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Ephesians

Ephesians 1:1

Section 1:1–2: Paul greeted the believers at Ephesus

Paul began his letter in the way that people usually began letters at that time. He gave his name first: “Paul.” Then he identified the people receiving the letter: “the saints in Ephesus.” Next, he gave a Christian greeting in 1:2.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Greetings from Paul (NLT)

Greetings to the church at Ephesus

1:1a Paul,

- ¶ I, Paul,
- ¶ I, Paul am writing this letter.
- ¶ This letter is from me, Paul.

Paul: The BSB follows the Greek text by beginning this letter with the name of the person who wrote it. In some languages it will be clearer to use a sentence here. For example:

This letter is from Paul (NLT)

In some languages it may be natural to use a word or form to indicate that Paul himself was addressing the believers. For example:

I, Paul, am writing this letter.

This letter is from me , Paul.

1:1b an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God,

- am an apostle of Christ Jesus because of God’s will.
- God chose me to be an apostle of Christ Jesus.
- I am a sent-one/messenger of Christ Jesus because that is what God wanted.

an apostle of Christ Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as apostle is literally “sent one.” It refers to a person whom someone sends with his authority to accomplish a mission or a particular purpose. Here, the word apostle refers to Paul whom

Jesus chose and to whom he gave authority. After Jesus returned to heaven, his apostles were the leaders of those who believed in him.

Some other ways to translate apostle include:

representative of Jesus Christ

(special) messenger of Jesus Christ

sent-person of Jesus Christ

If you have already translated the Gospels, you can probably use the same term for apostle as you used there. In some languages you may need to change it slightly for this context. See apostle in the Glossary for more information.

Christ Jesus: Notice that the word Christ comes before Jesus. The names Christ Jesus and Jesus Christ mean the same thing. In most English translations and other national language translations, “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” are translated literally, in the same order as they are in the Greek.

If the people who read your translation will be confused by the different order of the names, you may decide to translate Christ Jesus by the more familiar order: “Jesus Christ.” You should talk to many people about this matter and test it with many readers before you decide which order to use. In the Display the names “Christ Jesus,” “Jesus Christ,” and all other names, are translated literally and spelled according to normal English spelling. See Christ in the Glossary for more information.

by the will of God: The phrase by the will of God means that “God wanted Paul to be an apostle.” Paul himself did not decide to become an apostle.

Here is another way to translate by the will of God:

God chose Paul

1:1c To the saints in Ephesus,

- I am writing to you^(plur), God’s people in Ephesus,
- This letter is written to the people belonging to God in Ephesus.

To the saints: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints means “people set apart for God.” It does not refer to a special group of “holy people.” All Christians are saints.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

God's holy people (NLT)

the people belonging to God

See Holy, Meaning 1, special use, in the Glossary for more information.

in Ephesus: There is an issue with the Greek text here.

1. Some Greek manuscripts contain the words in Ephesus. English versions that follow these manuscripts are: (BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, NET, NASB, REB, KJV, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV, ESV)
2. Other Greek manuscripts do not contain the words in Ephesus. English versions that follow these manuscripts are: (RSV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) as it has more support among English versions.

1:1d

the faithful in Christ Jesus:

- who are faithful and who belong to Christ Jesus.
- You continue to follow Christ Jesus and are united with him.

the faithful: The Greek word that the BSB translates as faithful is ambiguous. It can mean:

1. people who are loyal or steadfast to Christ Jesus. The CEV follows this interpretation:

faithful followers of Christ Jesus (CEV) (NIV, BSB, RSV, GNT, NJB, NET, NASB, REB, KJV, CEV, GW, NLT, JBP, ESV)

1. people who have faith (or who believe) in Christ Jesus. For example:

believers in Christ Jesus (NCV) (NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as it has more support among English versions.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

those people who continue to follow Christ Jesus

those who faithfully obey Christ Jesus

in Christ Jesus: The phrase in Christ Jesus occurs many times in Paul's letters. It means "to be united

with Christ." The BSB always translates it literally, but the GNT usually translates it as "in union with Christ."

Here it has the usual meaning of "in union with Christ Jesus" or "to be related to Christ by faith." In many languages, it is difficult to translate this in a way that is clear and meaningful. Search for a good way to say this in your language, for example:

you who belong to Christ Jesus

you who have a close relationship with Christ Jesus

you who are joined to Christ Jesus

you who are one with Christ Jesus

Ephesians 1:2

Section 1:1-2: Paul greeted the believers at Ephesus

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Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Greetings from Paul (NLT)

Greetings to the church at Ephesus

1:2

Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

- May God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ show you grace and give you peace.
- I pray that God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ will be kind to you and cause you to have peace.

Grace and peace to you: The clause Grace and peace to you was a common greeting among Christians at that time. Here Paul used these words as a prayer to wish God's blessing on the Ephesians.

In the Greek, Grace and peace to you contains no verbs. In many languages, it may be more natural to add one or two verbs. For example:

May God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ give you grace and peace. (GNT)

May God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ show you grace and give you peace in your hearts.

In other languages, it may be better to translate Grace and peace as verbs, for example:

I pray that God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ will graciously help/bless you and help you to live well.

Grace: Grace here means that “God favors people” or that “he is kind to people even though they do not deserve it.” Paul used the word Grace to express his desire for God’s blessing on people and to wish them well. See grace, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

God’s favor

God’s gracious help

God’s generous help

peace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as peace refers to serenity and calm well-being. It often implies an absence of war or conflict. In the context of this Christian greeting, it probably implies the peace that comes from God for those who are in a relationship with him. Remember that the word peace has more than one meaning in the NT. You may need to translate it in different ways in different verses, according to the context.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

tranquility

untroubled relationships

calm life

God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ: Since the pronoun our occurs with Father, consider whether it is more natural in your language to also say “our Lord” rather than “the Lord.” For example:

God our Father and our Lord Jesus Christ. (NLT)

Ephesians 1:3

Section 1:3–14: God has done good things for us by means of Christ

Paul praised God for all the blessings that come to his people through Christ. Before God created the world, he chose us and then he redeemed us through Christ. God also revealed his plan to us. His plan is to unite everything in the world in the future with Christ as the Head. To show that we are his people, God gave us the Holy Spirit. The Spirit is the guarantee that God will give us all the good things he has promised us.

In Greek, 1:3–14 is all one long sentence. Most translations break this sentence into several shorter sentences. In your translation, you can use a few long sentences or many shorter sentences, whichever sounds best.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Spiritual blessings in Christ

God blesses us because we are joined to Christ

Paragraph 1:3–6

Paul praised God for all the blessings that come to us believers through Christ. Long ago before God created the world, he chose us to be his people, because he wanted to adopt us as his children. He did all this because he loved us, because he wanted to show us favor (help us), in order that we might become holy people.

1:3a

Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ,

- ¶ Let us praise/thank the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ.
- ¶ God is worthy of our praise. He is the God of our Lord Jesus Christ. He is also Christ’s Father.

Blessed be: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Blessed be is literally “blessed.” It was common for the Jews to use a phrase like this as a formal way to “bless” God. In such contexts, the word “bless” means “praise.” It indicates that people should praise God by telling others how wonderful and excellent he is.

In the Greek text there is no verb (be) after the word “blessed.” See the note on “blessed” in 1:3b below for more information. Most English versions have added a verb to make the phrase more natural.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- as an exhortation for the Ephesians to praise God. For example:

Praise (CEV)

Let us praise/thank

- as a statement about God. For example:

God is worthy of our praise/blessing

- As a blessing to God. For example:

May God be praised/blessed

See bless, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ: Paul was saying that God is both:

1. the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, and
2. the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ.

In order to make this meaning clear you may need to say something like:

Let us praise God. He is the God of our Lord Jesus Christ. He is also Christ's Father.

He is both the God and the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ

1:3b

who has blessed us in Christ with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly realms.

- Through our union with Christ, God has blessed us with all the spiritual blessings that are in the heavenly world.
- It is he who has given us all good things which come from the heavens to help our spirits. He did this by our union/identification with Christ.

who has blessed us: The word who refers to God. When Paul said God has blessed us, it means "God has done good things for us" or "God has given good things to us." See bless, Meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

in Christ: There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It tells us the means/way by which God gave us these blessings: he blessed us "by uniting us with Christ." For example:

Through Christ, God has blessed us with every spiritual blessing... (GW) (GNT, GW, JBP, CEV)

1. It tells us the reason he gave us these blessings. For example:

...who has blessed us with every spiritual blessing...because we are united with Christ. (NLT)

While many English versions leave the phrase in Christ ambiguous, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Also, see how you translated "in Christ Jesus" in 1:1d.

with every spiritual blessing: There are two ways to interpret the phrase spiritual blessing:

1. It may mean that the blessings are spiritual, not physical or material. In other words, Paul was not talking about things like food or money. Rather he was talking about things like eternal life and forgiveness, which he discussed in the next verses.
2. It may mean blessings from the Holy Spirit.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

- Translate it literally like most English versions.
- Translate it as:

with blessings that help our spirit

with blessings from heaven

God-given help

blessing: Here blessing refers to the good things that God does for his people. See bless, Meaning 3 in the Glossary.

in the heavenly realms: The phrase in the heavenly realms means "in the spiritual world." It is a general term, which includes all that exists in the invisible world. This includes heaven where God reigns, but it also includes the realms where all types of spirits live.

This expression occurs only five times in the New Testament, and all of them are in Ephesians (see also 1:20b, 2:6b, 3:10a-b, 6:12c).

In many languages, it will be best to follow the order of the Greek and put the phrase in the heavenly realms after the phrase "every spiritual blessing." For example:

...he has blessed us by giving us every spiritual blessing in the heavenly world. (GNT)

Ephesians 1:4

Section 1:3–14: God has done good things for us by means of Christ

Paul praised God for all the blessings that come to his people through Christ. Before God created the world, he chose us and then he redeemed us through Christ. God also revealed his plan to us. His plan is to unite everything in the world in the future with Christ as the Head. To show that we are his people, God gave us the Holy Spirit. The Spirit is the guarantee that God will give us all the good things he has promised us.

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Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Spiritual blessings in Christ

God blesses us because we are joined to Christ

Paragraph 1:3–6

Paul praised God for all the blessings that come to us believers through Christ. Long ago before God created the world, he chose us to be his people, because he wanted to adopt us as his children. He did all this because he loved us, because he wanted to show us favor (help us), in order that we might become holy people.

1:4a

For He chose us in Him before the foundation of the world

- Specifically, God chose us because of Christ before he created the world/universe
- Before God made the heavens and the earth, he chose us to be his people because of Christ.

For: There is an issue with the Greek word that the BSB translates as For. Scholars have various views about the way in which this Greek word connects 1:3 and 1:4. Here are the three main interpretations:

1. The Greek word introduces some of the specific blessings that God has given us. In 1:3, Paul made the general statement that God has blessed us with every blessing. Beginning with 1:4, he tells speci-

cally what some of these blessings are. An example of this interpretation is the NCV, which says:

^{3b}God has given us every spiritual blessing.... ⁴That is, in Christ, he chose us before the world was made.... (NCV) (NCV, NJB footnote)

1. The Greek word indicates the reason that God blessed us. All the blessings in 1:3 come to us because God chose us before he made the world. So according to this interpretation, the Greek word should be translated as “for” or “because.” For example:

For he chose us in Christ before the foundation of the world... (NET) (BSB, NIV, NET, JBP)

1. The Greek word indicates that the manner in which God has blessed us is the same as the manner in which he chose us. God has blessed us in Christ just as he chose us in Christ. According to this interpretation, the Greek word should be translated as “just as” or “even as.” For example:

...just as He chose us in Him before the foundation of the world... (NASB) (RSV, KJV, NASB, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Here are some other ways to translate following interpretation (1):

- Translate the Greek word with a word or a phrase to explicitly show the connection between 1:3 and 1:4. For example:

specifically

that is (NCV)

- Do not translate the Greek word and leave the connection implicit.

The Display gives an example of each.

He chose us in Him: The pronoun He refers to God. The pronoun Him refers to Christ.

In order to make the meaning of He chose us clear you may need to say:

he chose us to be his people.

in Him: Most commentators agree that the phrase in Him indicates the reason God chose us.

Here is one way to translate:

God chose us because of Christ.

before the foundation of the world: In some languages, the meaning of before the foundation of the world will be clearer if you change the noun foundation into a verb and add the agent, who is God. For example:

before God created the world

Also consider whether it would be more natural in your language to put this clause at the beginning rather than at the end of the sentence. For example:

Before God created the world, he chose us...

world: Here the word world refers to the entire universe. It includes both the heavens and the earth. See world, Meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

1:4b

to be holy and blameless in His presence.

- in order that we should be holy and innocent before him.
- He did this so that he could consider us to be pure and without any fault/blame.

to be holy and blameless in His presence: Because this sentence that began in 1:4a is already long, you could break it and start a new sentence here by saying:

He did this so that we should be holy and blameless in his presence.

to be: The verb to be indicates the purpose God chose us.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

He chose us in order that we should be holy and blameless.

He chose us so that we should be holy and blameless.

holy: Here holy “means pure, clean and without any sin.” See holy, Meaning 2 in the Glossary.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

without sin

pure spiritually

blameless: The word blameless means that there is nothing bad in a person’s behavior that God (or other people) could find fault with. Moore in his article “Doublets in the New Testament” rejects holy and blameless as a near-synonymous doublet.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

without blame (NCV)

without fault (GNT, NLT)

innocent (CEV)

in His presence: The pronoun His refers to God. This is literally “before him.”

Here are some other ways to translate 1:4b:

that he will consider us to be holy and innocent

holy and blameless when we stand before him

he will see us as holy and innocent

1:4c

In love

- Because God loves us,
- Because of his love,

In love: There are different views as to whether the phrase In love relates to what precedes or what follows:

1. In love goes with 1:5. According to this interpretation, In love gives the reason why God decided to adopt us. One way to translate this phrase is, “because of his love” or “because he loves us.” For example:

Because of his love he had already decided to adopt us... (GW) (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, NASB, NCV, GW, ESV)

1. In love goes with 1:4. According to this interpretation, In love further describes the life for which God has chosen us, that is, we should be full of love. The REB follows this interpretation:

he chose us in Christ to be his people, to be without blemish in his sight, to be full of love (REB) (NJB, NRSV, KJV, REB, CEV, NLT, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

love: The word love here refers to God's great affection and concern for his people. See love, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 1:5

Section 1:3–14: God has done good things for us by means of Christ

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Paragraph 1:3–6

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1:5a

He predestined us for adoption as His sons through Jesus Christ,

- he had decided before hand that he would adopt us as his children through Jesus Christ.
- he decided long ago that he would make us his children by means of what Jesus Christ has done.

He predestined us: The verb predestined means “to decide something beforehand” or “to determine

ahead of time what one plans to do.” The pronoun He refers to “God.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

God had already decided (GNT)

God decided in advance (NLT)

for adoption as His sons: This is a passive. If it would be more natural in your language to make this active, you can say:

God would adopt us as His children

In some languages, it is redundant or even confusing to include the phrase as His sons along with the noun adoption. If this is the case in your language, you can simply say:

God would adopt us

for adoption: The word adoption means “to make someone your child” or “to accept another child into your family as your own.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

to be his sons (RSV)

make us his children (GNT)

through Jesus Christ: The phrase through Jesus Christ tells how God made us his children. He did it by means of (or because of) what Jesus Christ has done. In some languages, there are special ways to express this, for example:

by the hand of Jesus Christ

because of what Jesus Christ did

1:5b

according to the good pleasure of His will,

- That was what God wanted and what pleased him,
- God did this because it delighted him, and he wanted to do it

according to the good pleasure of His will: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as according to the good pleasure of His will uses the word pleasure

emphasizes the delight God felt in making his decision in 1:5a.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

this was his pleasure and purpose (GNT)

that was what he wanted and what pleased him (NCV)

In some languages it is good to begin a new sentence here with some introduction, for example:

God did this according to the good pleasure of His will...

Also in many languages the translation will be clearer if you change the nouns pleasure and will into verbs, for example:

because it pleased him and this is what he wanted to do

Ephesians 1:6

Section 1:3–14: God has done good things for us by means of Christ

Paul praised God for all the blessings that come to his people through Christ. Before God created the world, he chose us and then he redeemed us through Christ. God also revealed his plan to us. His plan is to unite everything in the world in the future with Christ as the Head. To show that we are his people, God gave us the Holy Spirit. The Spirit is the guarantee that God will give us all the good things he has promised us.

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wanted to adopt us as his children. He did all this because he loved us, because he wanted to show us favor (help us), in order that we might become holy people.

1:6a

to the praise of His glorious grace,

- so that we should praise him for his great grace.
- So let us speak words of honour about him for the wonderful way he showed his kindness to us.

to the praise of His glorious grace: The phrase to the praise of His glorious grace tells us the purpose of all that God has done: he chose us and made us his children “in order that we should praise him for his grace.” Similar phrases are in 1:12b and 1:14c.

His glorious grace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as glorious means “wonderful” or “very great.” See also glory, Meaning 4, in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

his wonderful grace

the greatness of his grace

his important grace

grace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as grace means “showing kindness or generosity to someone who does not deserve it.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

kindness (GW)

gracious/generous help

See grace, Meaning 2, in the Glossary for more information.

1:6b

which He has freely given us in the Beloved One.

- He has given this great grace to us freely through his dearly loved Son.
- he has given/shown us this grace/kindness abundantly by means of what his dear son has done.

freely given: The phrase freely given is a single Greek verb meaning “to give generously.” In other words, God showed us a great amount of kindness, and he did not make us earn his kindness. Instead, he showed us his kindness generously, abundantly and freely.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he has poured out on us (NLT)

he has generously/abundantly given to us

in the Beloved One: The phrase in the Beloved One refers to Jesus whom God loves. It is through Jesus, by means of what he has done for us, that God gives us his grace. Be careful that the way you translate this does not imply that there are others whom he does not love.

Here are some other ways to translate in the Beloved One include:

his dearly loved Son (NLT)

in Christ, the One he loves (NCV)

Beloved: See how you translated “love” in 1:4c. See love, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

General Comment on 1:6a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of 1:6a–b. For example:

^{6b}God was very kind to us because of the Son he dearly loves, ^{6a}and so we should praise God. (CEV)

God has graciously helped us by means of his beloved Son’s actions, and so we should praise God for that help

Ephesians 1:7

Section 1:3–14: God has done good things for us by means of Christ

Paul praised God for all the blessings that come to his people through Christ. Before God created the world, he chose us and then he redeemed us through Christ. God also revealed his plan to us. His plan is to unite everything in the world in the future with Christ as the Head. To show that we are his people, God gave us the Holy Spirit. The Spirit is the guarantee that God will give us all the good things he has promised us.

In Greek, 1:3–14 is all one long sentence. Most translations break this sentence into several shorter sentences. In your translation, you can use a few long sentences or many shorter sentences, whichever sounds best.

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Spiritual blessings in Christ

God blesses us because we are joined to Christ

Paragraph 1:7–10

Paul continued to speak of the blessings that we have through Christ. God has redeemed us and revealed to us his plan to unite all things under the control of Christ.

1:7a

In Him we have redemption through His blood,

- ¶ Through Christ shedding his blood, we are redeemed
- ¶ God has freed/liberated us by means of Christ bleeding his blood when he died for us.

In Him: The pronoun Him refers to Christ. The phrase means “through Christ” or “by means of Christ” all these blessings come to us. (Compare 1:7a with Colossians 1:14 where Paul used the same expression.)

redemption: The word redemption means “to free a slave or a prisoner by paying a ransom.” Here Paul used this word in a figurative sense. It refers to our freedom from sin.

In many languages, it will be clearer to translate the noun redemption as a verb, for example:

God redeemed us

God freed us from the guilt and penalty of our sins

See redeem in the Glossary for more information.

through His blood: The phrase through His blood refers to the death of Jesus. That is the reason the GNT has translated it:

by the death of Christ (GNT)

If you decide to keep the word blood here in your translation, you may need to complete the idea by saying:

by shedding his blood when he died

the blood which he shed/bled when he died

Notice that the Display meaning lines combine the phrase “in him” and the phrase “through his blood” as some English versions do (GNT, GW).

1:7b

the forgiveness of our trespasses,

- and our sins are forgiven.
- God has taken away the guilt of our sins.

the forgiveness of our trespasses: In this context the phrase the forgiveness of our trespasses means “that God chooses not to punish a person for the evil things that he has done and thought.” God cancels his guilt and treats him as though he had never offended God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

release from sins

the taking away of sins

canceling sins/guilt

In some languages it may be necessary to translate the noun forgiveness with a verb. For example:

pardon sins

cancel sins

treat us as if we had not sinned

See forgive in the Glossary for more information.

To say that “God redeemed us (1:7a)” and that “he forgave our sins (1:7b)” are two ways to say almost the same thing. For example:

...we are set free, that is, our sins are forgiven.
(GNT)

1:7c

according to the riches of His grace

- God did this because of his abundant kindness
- In this way God shows us that his grace is very great,
- God’s grace is very great!

according to: The phrase according to introduces the reason why God redeemed us (1:7a) and forgave us (1:7b). He redeemed us and forgave us according to or because of his grace.

the riches of His grace: Paul used the word riches in a figurative sense to mean “abundant” or “great.” (Paul also used riches in a figurative sense in 1:18, 2:4, 2:7 and 3:16.) The word grace means “God is kind or generous to people even when they do not deserve it.” So the phrase the riches of His grace refers to the abundance of God’s grace/kindness.

Some other ways to translate the riches of His grace are:

- as an exclamation. For example:

How rich is God’s grace! (NCV)

God is so gracious and kind!

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Isn’t God’s grace great?

See how you translated “grace” in 1:6a. See grace, Meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

General Comment on 1:7

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder the parts of 1:7. One way to do this is:

^{7c}God’s grace/kindness is very great. ^{7a}That is why he redeemed us through Christ’s blood ^{7b}and forgave our sins.

Ephesians 1:8

Section 1:3–14: God has done good things for us by means of Christ

Paul praised God for all the blessings that come to his people through Christ. Before God created the world, he chose us and then he redeemed us through Christ. God also revealed his plan to us. His plan is to unite everything in the world in the future with Christ as the Head. To show that we are his people, God gave us the Holy Spirit. The Spirit is the guarantee that God will give us all the good things he has promised us.

In Greek, 1:3–14 is all one long sentence. Most translations break this sentence into several shorter sentences. In your translation, you can use a few long sentences or many shorter sentences, whichever sounds best.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Spiritual blessings in Christ

God blesses us because we are joined to Christ

Paragraph 1:7–10

Paul continued to speak of the blessings that we have through Christ. God has redeemed us and revealed to us his plan to unite all things under the control of Christ.

1:8a

that He lavished on us

- which he gave/showed us in great quantity
- And he has given/shown it to us abundantly.

that He lavished on us: The word lavished means, “gave in great quantity.” Paul used strong words to show how great is God’s grace towards us. Try to find strong expressions in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

He showed us his kindness to a very great extent.

he poured out his kindness (GW)

he gave to us in such large measure (GNT)

1:8b

with all wisdom and understanding.

- along with all wisdom and insight.
- He also causes us to be very wise and to know all kinds of things.

with all wisdom and understanding: There are different views about whether the phrase with all wisdom and understanding belongs to the words before it or the words after it. Furthermore, there are different views about whether Paul was talking about God’s wisdom and understanding or man’s wisdom and understanding. Some of these views are:

1. It refers to “lavished” in 1:8a and shows two further gifts that God gives to us. For example:

^{8a}He has showered his kindness on us, ^{8b}along with all wisdom and understanding. (NLT) (REB, NLT, GW, JBP)

1. It refers to “lavished” in 1:8a and to God’s wisdom; that is, in all his wisdom and understanding God lavished his grace on us. For example:

^{7c}...according to the riches of his grace ^{8a}that he lavished on us ^{8b}in all wisdom and insight (NET) (NET, NJB, KJV)

1. It refers to “made known” in 1:9 and to God, that is, in his wisdom God made known to us his plan. For example:

^{8b}God has great wisdom and understanding, ⁹and by what Christ has done, God has shown us his own mysterious ways. (CEV) (GNT, RSV, NASB, NCV, CEV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of commentaries support this interpretation.

all: The word all here means “all kinds of.” God has given us all kinds of wisdom and understanding.

wisdom: The word wisdom refers to the quality of being wise and acting wisely. Someone who has wisdom is someone who has good sense and can correctly decide which is the right way to think and act.

If your language would prefer an adjective here rather than the noun wisdom, you could say something like:

God makes us to be very wise...

understanding: The word that the BSB translates as understanding refers to the ability to understand or know something. It is slightly different from the word “wisdom.”

Here is another way to translate this word:

insight (GNT)

If your language would prefer a verb here rather than the noun understanding, you could say something like:

and to know all kinds of things

and to understand/comprehend all kinds of things

Ephesians 1:9

Section 1:3–14: God has done good things for us by means of Christ

Paul praised God for all the blessings that come to his people through Christ. Before God created the world, he chose us and then he redeemed us through Christ. God also revealed his plan to us. His plan is to unite

everything in the world in the future with Christ as the Head. To show that we are his people, God gave us the Holy Spirit. The Spirit is the guarantee that God will give us all the good things he has promised us.

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Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Spiritual blessings in Christ

God blesses us because we are joined to Christ

Paragraph 1:7-10

Paul continued to speak of the blessings that we have through Christ. God has redeemed us and revealed to us his plan to unite all things under the control of Christ.

1:9a

And He has made known to us the mystery of His will

- God revealed to us his plan that human beings previously did not know about,
- God has shown us the plan that he had hidden in the past.

He has made known to us: The Greek word that the BSB translates as made known means “revealed” or “showed.” Paul is saying here that God revealed to believers the “mystery of his will.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

revealed (NLT)

shown (CEV)

mystery of His will: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mystery means “something which was previously hidden from man that God has now revealed to him.” The next verse (1:10) tells us what this mystery is.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

God’s hidden plan

the plan that God had hidden in his heart

God’s purpose that no one knew about in the past

God’s plan that was previously not known to mankind/anybody

God’s plan that he has now made known to believers

1:9b

according to His good pleasure, which He purposed in Christ

- which he decided to accomplish through Christ, because it pleased him.
- And he was happy to accomplish this plan through Christ.

according to His good pleasure: This phrase is similar to the phrase, “according to the good pleasure of His will” in 1:5b. As in 1:5b, it may be easier to understand if you change the noun pleasure into a verb. For example:

it pleased God to reveal his plan to us

God delighted in revealing his plan to us

See how you translated the similar phrase in 1:5b.

which He purposed in Christ: There is an interpretation issue here. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in Christ is literally “in him.” Scholars are divided as to whom the “him” refers. These views are:

1. It refers to Christ. This means God decided to reveal his plan through or by means of Christ. For example:

and he planned to do it through Christ (NCV) (BSB, NCV, REB, NIV, RSV, ESV, CEV, GNT, GW, NET, JBP, NJB)

1. It refers to God himself. This means God decided to reveal his plan through or by means of himself or his own work. For example:

which he has purposed in himself (KJV)

The NASB leaves it ambiguous, using “in him.” The NLT says:

God has now revealed to us his mysterious plan regarding Christ. (NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of versions support this interpretation.

The phrase which He purposed in Christ means “God decided to reveal his plan through (or by means of) Christ.” That is, God decided to reveal his plan by means of what Christ would do.

Here are some other ways to translate which He purposed in Christ:

which he decided to accomplish through Christ

That he planned to do by means of Christ

That he planned to do through what Jesus would do

Ephesians 1:10

Section 1:3–14: God has done good things for us by means of Christ

Paul praised God for all the blessings that come to his people through Christ. Before God created the world, he chose us and then he redeemed us through Christ. God also revealed his plan to us. His plan is to unite everything in the world in the future with Christ as the Head. To show that we are his people, God gave us the Holy Spirit. The Spirit is the guarantee that God will give us all the good things he has promised us.

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Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Spiritual blessings in Christ

God blesses us because we are joined to Christ

Paragraph 1:7–10

Paul continued to speak of the blessings that we have through Christ. God has redeemed us and revealed to us his plan to unite all things under the control of Christ.

1:10

This verse tells us God’s plan. He plans to unite everything in the universe under one ruler; that is, under Christ.

1:10a

as a plan for the fullness of time,

- His plan is that when the right time comes,
- When the time is right, God/he will complete his plan by

as a plan: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as as a plan is literally “for (a) stewardship.” It refers to God completing his secret plan referred to in verse 9.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

carry out his plan (NCV)

do all that he had planned (CEV)

for the fullness of time: The clause for the fullness of time means “when everything is completed and the time that God chose comes.” This refers to the future, when Christ returns to earth and begins to rule as the chief/ruler over everything.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when the time is right (GNT)

when the right time comes

1:10b

to bring all things in heaven and on earth together in Christ.

- he will bring all things in heaven and those on the earth under one chief, that is Christ.
- uniting all things in heaven and on the earth and by making/causing Christ to be the chief/leader.

to bring...together: The clause bring...together is the translation of one Greek verb. The exact meaning of this Greek verb is unclear, because it occurs only here and in Romans 13:9. There are several interpretations for this verb, but the one presented here is the one followed by the majority of English versions. Also, Paul elaborates on the same idea in 1:20–22. The verb that the BSB translates as bring...together is literally, “to sum up.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he will bring everything together under the authority of Christ (NLT)

he would bring-together/unite all things...and cause Christ to rule over them (SSA)

God will unite everything and Christ will be the leader/chief

all things in heaven and on earth: The phrase all things in heaven and on earth here refers to everything and everyone that has been created. It includes things that are both physical and spiritual.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all creation

everything that has been created

in Christ: Here the phrase in Christ means that Christ is “ruler,” “chief” or “leader” of everything. Just as the head controls the body, even so Christ will control everything in heaven and earth.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

under the authority of Christ (NLT)

General Comment on 1:9–10

In some languages it may be better to combine 1:9 and 1:10, so that it will be clear to the reader at the beginning what God’s plan is. For example:

^{9b}God was pleased ^{9a}to reveal to us his plan, which previously was not known to mankind. ^{10b}His plan is this: he will unite all things in heaven and earth under one chief—Christ. ^{9b}From long ago God decided to accomplish this plan by means of Christ, ^{10a}and when the right time comes, he will carry out this plan.

Ephesians 1:11

Section 1:3–14: God has done good things for us by means of Christ

Paul praised God for all the blessings that come to his people through Christ. Before God created the world, he chose us and then he redeemed us through Christ. God also revealed his plan to us. His plan is to unite everything in the world in the future with Christ as the Head. To show that we are his people, God gave us the Holy Spirit. The Spirit is the guarantee that God will give us all the good things he has promised us.

In Greek, 1:3–14 is all one long sentence. Most translations break this sentence into several shorter sentences. In your translation, you can use a few long sentences or many shorter sentences, whichever sounds best.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Spiritual blessings in Christ

God blesses us because we are joined to Christ

Paragraph 1:11–14

God makes everything happen in the way in which he has decided. He chose the Jews to be the first to believe in Christ, so that they should bring him praise. But the Gentiles were also united with Christ when they believed the gospel and God gave them the Holy Spirit to show they were his people. So we should all praise God for his greatness.

1:11a

In Him we were also chosen as God’s own,

- ¶ In Christ we^(excl) were also chosen to be his people.
- ¶ God also chose us^(excl) Jews to be his people by uniting us to Christ.

In Him: The pronoun Him refers to Christ. This same expression occurs in 1:7a. You may be able to translate it in the same way.

we were also chosen: Here Paul used the pronoun we to refer to himself and other Jewish believers. Since the Ephesians were Gentiles, the pronoun we does not refer to the Ephesians.

also: The Greek word that the BSB translates as also is used to emphasize God’s action of choosing Paul and his fellow Jews through Christ.

chosen: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as chosen occurs only here in the New Testament. It is a passive verb. This verb includes the idea of casting lots either:

1. to determine who is appointed to a certain role,
2. to determine who obtains a portion of something such as an inheritance. There are several ways to interpret this verb:
3. It means that the Jews were appointed to be God’s inheritance. As such, the verb basically means “chosen.” For example:

God chose us to be his own people (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, GW, CEV, NCV)

1. It means that the Jews were chosen to obtain/ receive an inheritance, i.e. salvation. For example:

we have received an inheritance from God (NLT)
(NRSV, NASB, REB, KJV, NJB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as it better fits the context of this verse.

1:11b

having been predestined according to the plan of Him

- God did this because he had decided long ago to do it,
- He chose us because he had decided to do it beforehand. That was his plan,

having been predestined: The verb predestined means “to decide something beforehand” or “to determine ahead of time what one plans to do.” This is a passive verb. In some languages it may be necessary to make it an active verb by stating who did the predestinating. God predestined us long before.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

God determined long ago to do this for us

This was God’s decision for us from ages past

In many English versions, the relationship is ambiguous between the clause “we were chosen” in 1:11a and the clause “having been predestined” in 1:11b. The Display follows the model of the GNT, NLT and NCV. These versions state that God chose the Jews because he had predestined it (decided it beforehand).

according to the plan of Him: The phrase according to the plan of Him means that God’s plan was to decide to choose the Jews.

1:11c

who works out everything by the counsel of His will,

- and he makes all things happen just as he intends.
- and God causes everything to happen according to his plan.

who works out everything by the counsel of His will: The clause works out everything by the counsel of His will means: “God makes all things happen just as he determined/wanted.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he makes everything work out according to his plan (NLT)

which makes everything work the way he intends (GW)

General Comment on 1:11a–c

In some languages, this verse will be clearer if the parts are put in a different order. For example:

^{11c}God makes all things happen just as he wanted.

^{11b}From long ago he decided ^{11a}to choose us to be his people by uniting us with Christ.

Ephesians 1:12

Section 1:3–14: God has done good things for us by means of Christ

Paul praised God for all the blessings that come to his people through Christ. Before God created the world, he chose us and then he redeemed us through Christ. God also revealed his plan to us. His plan is to unite everything in the world in the future with Christ as the Head. To show that we are his people, God gave us the Holy Spirit. The Spirit is the guarantee that God will give us all the good things he has promised us.

In Greek, 1:3–14 is all one long sentence. Most translations break this sentence into several shorter sentences. In your translation, you can use a few long sentences or many shorter sentences, whichever sounds best.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Spiritual blessings in Christ

God blesses us because we are joined to Christ

Paragraph 1:11–14

God makes everything happen in the way in which he has decided. He chose the Jews to be the first to believe in Christ, so that they should bring him praise. But the Gentiles were also united with Christ when they believed the gospel and God gave them the Holy Spirit to show they were his people. So we should all praise God for his greatness.

1:12

in order that we...would be for the praise of His glory: This verse tells God’s purpose for choosing the Jews (1:11a). He chose them so that he would receive praise from them.

1:12a

in order that we, who were the first to hope in Christ,

- He did this so that we^(excl) Jews, who were the first people to hope/trust in Christ,
- We^(excl) Jews were the first people to hope/trust in Christ. He chose us so that we^(excl)

in order that we: The phrase in order that introduces the reason why the Jews were the first to hope in Christ.

we: Here Paul used the pronoun we to mean the Jews in contrast with “you, the Gentiles” in 1:13. The first people to believe in Christ were Jews. If your language has the exclusive pronoun, you should use it here.

Here is another way to translate this word:

I and my fellow Jews

were the first to hope in Christ: It was the Jews who were the first to hear that Jesus was the Messiah and some believed. Then the message went out to the Gentiles.

to hope in Christ: The phrase hope in Christ is similar in meaning to “trust in Christ.” See how you translated “in Christ Jesus” in 1:1d and in Christ in 1:3b and 1:9b.

1:12b

would be for the praise of His glory.

- would praise God for his glory.
- would speak highly of God for his greatness.

would be for the praise of His glory: The clause would be for the praise of His glory is the purpose for which God chose the Jews. It does not express uncertainty. He chose them so that they would praise God for his glory. This phrase is similar to the phrase “to the praise of his glorious grace” in 1:6a.

glory: Here glory means “God’s magnificence and greatness.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

greatness

wonderful power

majesty

See glory, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 1:13

Section 1:3–14: God has done good things for us by means of Christ

Paul praised God for all the blessings that come to his people through Christ. Before God created the world, he chose us and then he redeemed us through Christ. God also revealed his plan to us. His plan is to unite everything in the world in the future with Christ as the Head. To show that we are his people, God gave us the Holy Spirit. The Spirit is the guarantee that God will give us all the good things he has promised us.

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Paragraph 1:11–14

God makes everything happen in the way in which he has decided. He chose the Jews to be the first to believe in Christ, so that they should bring him praise. But the Gentiles were also united with Christ when they believed the gospel and God gave them the Holy Spirit to show they were his people. So we should all praise God for his greatness.

1:13a, c

And in Him, having heard and believed the word of truth—

- When you also heard and believed the true word
- And the same thing happened to you non-Jews also. You heard and believed the true message.

And ...you: The word And here indicates that the same thing that happened to the Jews also happened to the Gentiles. Just as the Jews became Christ’s people, the Gentiles also became Christ’s people.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

You as well

And you also (NIV)

And in Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as And in Him is literally “in whom.” This is the first

phrase in the verse and is repeated later in it. Scholars have different views about how these two occurrences of “in whom” are related to the other words in the context. See how you have translated the phrase “in him” or “in Christ” in other verses in this chapter (1:4a, 1:7a, 1:9b, 1:11a, 1:12a). Scholars have different views about how this phrase is connected to the rest of the sentence. The main views are: Some scholars have suggested other verbs that may be implied here, for example, “were chosen,” obtained an inheritance,” or “were made an inheritance.” See the Exegetical Summary of Ephesians.

1. The phrase in Him is connected to the main verb (literally “sealed”) in 1:13c. It is repeated twice in Greek because other clauses come between the subject “you” and the main verb. (Notice that the GW does not repeat “in him.”) For example:

you were sealed in Him (NASB) (BSB, RSV, NASB, REB, ESV, GW, NCV)

1. The phrase in Him is connected to an implied form of the verb “to be,” that is, “you also (are) in him.” English versions that follow this interpretation express it in different ways. For example:

were included in Christ (NIV)

became God’s people (GNT)

1. The phrase in Him is connected to the verb “believed/trusted” in 1:13a. For example:

In whom ye also [trusted] (KJV) (KJV, JBP, NET, NLT)

1. The phrase in Him is connected to the verb “heard.” For example:

Now you too, in him, have heard the message (NJB) (NJB, probably CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This fits the structure of the Greek text and does not require a translator to supply another verb. However, it may be more natural in many languages to translate the phrase “in him” only once.

If this is true in your language, you may be able to follow an example like the GW as you translate this verse:

^{13a-e}You heard and believed the message of truth, the Good News that he has saved you. In him you were sealed with the Holy Spirit whom he promised. (GW)

having heard and believed: In some languages it may be necessary to specify what the Gentiles had heard and believed. In this context there are two possibilities:

1. They heard and believed in the true message, the gospel of their salvation.
2. They heard and believed in Christ.

The meaning of (a) and (b) are almost the same, because the gospel is about Christ. Both options have good support. If you must make one of these options explicit, you may use whichever is more natural in your language in this context.

the word of truth: The phrase that the BSB translates as the word of truth is literally “message of truth.” It is the first part of a parallelism with “the gospel of your salvation in 1:13b. It means “the word that is true” or “the true message from God” and refers to the gospel or Good News. See the note below in 1:13b on “the gospel of your salvation” for examples of how the word of truth has been translated.

1:13b

the gospel of your salvation—

- which is the gospel about how God saves you,
- This true message is the good news that can save you.

the gospel of your salvation: The phrase the gospel of your salvation means “the good news that saved you.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase along with “word of truth” in 1:13a:

the true message, the Good News that brought you salvation (GNT)

the truth, the Good News that God saves you (NLT)

the truth, which is the good news about how you can be saved (CEV)

For more information, see gospel and save, Word 2, in the Glossary.

1:13c

you were sealed

- and in Christ, God put his seal/mark on you.

- and by means of your union with Christ, God gave you the Holy Spirit which he had promised/agreed to give to his people.

you were sealed: The phrase you were sealed is the translation of one Greek verb. This verb is passive. In some languages it may be necessary to make it active and supply the agent “God.” For example:

God marked you with a seal

In NT times a person used a special symbol to mark something that belonged to him. That was called his “seal.” Here Paul uses “seal” as a metaphor to describe the Holy Spirit: The Holy Spirit that God gives his people is the seal to show they belong to him.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Use a verb or noun in your language that means seal. For example:

tribal mark

mark (put on animals) to show ownership

- Use a simile. If a metaphor is not clear (“God sealed you with the Holy Spirit”), you can say:

When in Christ God gave you the Holy Spirit, it was like he put his seal/mark on you.

- If this figure of speech is confusing, you may have to translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example you could say:

In Christ God gave you the Holy Spirit to show that you belong to him.

you: Here, the pronoun you refers to the Gentiles. To make clear the contrast with the Jews in 1:12, you could say:

you non-Jews

you foreigners

1:13d

with the promised Holy Spirit,

- This seal/mark is the Holy Spirit which he gave to you as he promised.

- The Spirit is like a mark which shows that you belong to God.

the promised Holy Spirit: The phrase the promised Holy Spirit means “the Holy Spirit that God had promised to give to his people.” See Holy, Meaning 3 in the Glossary for more information.

General Comment on 1:13e

There is implied information here. The purpose of the believers being marked with the seal (the promised Holy Spirit) was to show themselves and/or other people that they belonged to God. If this purpose is not clear, you may want to make it explicit. For example:

were given the promised Holy Spirit to show that you belong to God (CEV)

Ephesians 1:14

Section 1:3–14: God has done good things for us by means of Christ

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1:14a

who is the pledge of our inheritance

- The Holy Spirit is also like a deposit which guarantees that God will give us the good things he has promised.
- Because God has given us the Holy Spirit, we may be certain that God will give us the other good things he has promised.

pledge: A pledge is a down payment. It is the first part of a payment for something that shows that the full price will be paid later. Paul used this as a metaphor for the Holy Spirit. Just as a person gives a deposit as a promise/pledge that he will pay the full price later, so God gave us the Holy Spirit as a pledge that he will one day give us our full inheritance.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

deposit (NIV)

down payment (NET)

inheritance: Here Paul used the word inheritance in a figurative sense. Inheritance literally refers to the money or property that someone receives when a relative dies. In its figurative sense, inheritance in this context refers to all the good things that God will give his people. It includes salvation and a future life in heaven with God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

what God has stored up for his people (CEV)

everything he promised (NLT)

promised blessing

1:14b

until the redemption of those who are God's possession,

- The Holy Spirit is our guarantee until God redeems/frees us who are his people.
- We will receive these things at the time that God will completely redeem us who are his people.

until the redemption: Here the word redemption refers to God completely freeing us from evil and giving us new bodies. This will happen when Christ comes back to earth.

In one sense, God has already redeemed us, as Paul said in 1:7. But God has not yet given us everything that he has promised. Now he has given us the Holy Spirit as a seal/sign that we belong to him (1:13) and as a

guarantee/pledge that in the future he will completely redeem us from this sinful world.

In some languages it may be necessary to translate the noun redemption with a verb. For example:

redeemed (REB)

purchased us (NLT)

set free (CEV, GW)

gives full freedom (NCV)

See redeem in the Glossary for more information.

of those who are God's possession: We who are God's children are called God's possession. We belong to him, that is, he possesses us.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

his own people (NLT)

those who are his (GNT, NCV)

to belong to him (GW)

1:14c

to the praise of His glory.

- This will cause people to praise God because he is very great.
- Let us and others praise him for his greatness!

to the praise of His glory: God will redeem his people so that they will praise him for his greatness and glory.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

Let us praise him for his greatness.

Praise him for his greatness.

So that we and others may praise him for his greatness

See how you translated similar phrases in 1:6a and 1:12a-b.

glory: Here glory means "God's magnificence or greatness." See glory, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 1:15

Section 1:15–23: Paul prayed for the believers at Ephesus

Paul started the next section by thanking God for the faith and love of the Christians in Ephesus. Then he prayed that they might know God better. Specifically, he prayed that they might know the good things that they can hope for in the future, the blessings that God has promised to his people and the greatness of God's power. This is the power that raised Jesus from death and put him in the place of highest honor in heaven.

In Greek this whole section is one very long sentence. You will probably need to break it into several shorter sentences in your translation.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's prayer (GNT, CEV, NCV)

Paul's prayer for spiritual wisdom (NLT)

Thanksgiving and prayer (NIV)

1:15a

For this reason,

- ¶ Because of everything that God has done for us,
- ¶ Because of all this, I thank God.

For this reason: The BSB translates the Greek phrase here as For this reason. It refers to everything that God has done for us in 1:3–14.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

That is why (NCV)

Because of all this

Because of everything that God has done

Therefore

The phrase For this reason is connected to 1:16a. The meaning is:

^{1:15a}Because of all this...^{1:16a}I have not stopped giving thanks for you.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

- Repeat some form of 1:16a after 1:15a. For example:

^{1:15a}Because of everything that God has done, I thank him. ^{1:15b–c}Ever since I heard that you believe in the Lord Jesus and love all the saints, ^{1:16a}I never stop giving thanks for you.

- Translate it literally. For example:

^{1:15a}Because of everything that God has done, ^{1:15b–c}and ever since I heard that you believe in the Lord Jesus and love all the saints, ^{1:16a}I never stop giving thanks for you.

- Move 1:15a to the end of verse 15. For example:

^{1:15b}I, too, have heard about your faith in the Lord Jesus ^{1:15c}and your love for all of God's people. ^{1:15a}For this reason... (GW)

- Move 1:15a to the beginning of verse 1:16. The CEV does this by translating For this reason as "So" at the beginning of 1:16:

^{1:15b}I have heard about your faith in the Lord Jesus ^{1:15c}and your love for all of God's people. ^{1:16a}So I never stop being grateful for you,... (CEV)

1:15b

ever since I heard about your faith in the Lord Jesus

- and ever since I heard that you believe in the Lord Jesus
- Ever since people told me that you trust in the Lord Jesus

your faith in the Lord Jesus: The word faith refers here to the action of trusting and believing in Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate the word faith in this context:

confidence

trust

In many languages, the noun faith will be clearer if you translate it as a verb. For example:

you trusted/believed in the Lord Jesus

See faith, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information.

Lord Jesus: The word Lord is a translation of the Greek word that means “lord, master or leader.” It is a term of respect. In this verse, it is a title associated with Jesus.

1:15c

and your love for all the saints,

- and that you love all God’s people, -or- and that you love God’s people everywhere,

your love for all the saints: The word love here is a noun in the Greek text. It refers to man’s affection and concern for other believers. If it is more natural in your language to translate love as a verb, you can say:

you love all of God’s people

See love, Meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

saints: The word saints means “people set apart for God.” It does not refer to a special group of “holy people.” All Christians are saints.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

God’s people

people who belong to God

See Holy, Meaning 1, special use, in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 1:16

Section 1:15–23: Paul prayed for the believers at Ephesus

Paul started the next section by thanking God for the faith and love of the Christians in Ephesus. Then he prayed that they might know God better. Specifically, he prayed that they might know the good things that they can hope for in the future, the blessings that God has promised to his people and the greatness of God’s power. This is the power that raised Jesus from death and put him in the place of highest honor in heaven.

In Greek this whole section is one very long sentence. You will probably need to break it into several shorter sentences in your translation.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul’s prayer (GNT, CEV, NCV)

Paul’s prayer for spiritual wisdom (NLT)

Thanksgiving and prayer (NIV)

1:16a

I have not stopped giving thanks for you,

- I have not stopped thanking God for you.
- I have been thanking God for you all the time.

I have not stopped giving thanks: The clause I have not stopped giving thanks contains a figure of speech. “Not stopped” is a litotes. Paul used the negative expression not stopped to emphasize a positive idea. The meaning is “I give thanks all the time.” If this figure of speech does not occur naturally in your language, translate the meaning directly. For example:

I thank God continually for you (JBP)

1:16b

remembering you in my prayers,

- When I pray, I mention you in my prayers,
- Whenever I pray to God, I pray for you.

remembering you in my prayers: The clause remembering you in my prayers means that when Paul prayed, he spoke to God about them. This does not mean that at other times Paul forgot about the Christians!

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

as I mention you in my prayers (CEV)

I pray for you constantly (NLT)

Ephesians 1:17

Section 1:15–23: Paul prayed for the believers at Ephesus

Paul started the next section by thanking God for the faith and love of the Christians in Ephesus. Then he prayed that they might know God better. Specifically, he prayed that they might know the good things that they can hope for in the future, the blessings that God has promised to his people and the greatness of God’s power. This is the power that raised Jesus from death and put him in the place of highest honor in heaven.

In Greek this whole section is one very long sentence. You will probably need to break it into several shorter sentences in your translation.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's prayer (GNT, CEV, NCV)

Paul's prayer for spiritual wisdom (NLT)

Thanksgiving and prayer (NIV)

1:17a

that the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the glorious Father,

- and I pray that the magnificent Father and God of our Lord Jesus Christ,
- I pray to the God of our Lord Jesus Christ. He is our Father and/he has great glory/magnificence.

that: The word that here introduces what Paul prayed for. Many English versions start a new sentence here and add the words “I ask” or “I pray” because they are implied from 1:16. For example:

I keep asking that (NIV)

the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the glorious Father: These two phrases form a parallelism. They both refer to God the Father. This should be clear in your translation. See the second meaning line of the Display for ways you can make this explicit.

the glorious Father: A literal English translation of the Greek is “Father of glory.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Father who has great glory

the Father who is very great

the Father who is wonderful/majestic

See how you translated “glorious grace” in 1:6a and “glory” in 1:12b and 1:14c. Also see glory, Meaning 4 in the Glossary for more information.

1:17b

may give you a spirit of wisdom and revelation

- will give you spiritual wisdom and reveal himself to you,

- I ask him to make you spiritually wise and reveal himself to you,

a spirit of wisdom: There are several ways to interpret the word spirit here. It may refer to:

1. the spirit of man. According to this interpretation, the phrase spirit of wisdom means “spiritual wisdom” or “thinking in a wise way.” For example:

I pray that the God of our Lord Jesus Christ... may give you spiritual wisdom.... (NET) (BSB, RSV, NASB, NET, KJV, GW, NCV, NJB, NLT, NCV, REB, JBP, ESV)

1. the Holy Spirit. For example:

I ask the glorious Father and God of our Lord Jesus Christ to give you his Spirit. The Spirit will make you wise and let you understand... (CEV) (NIV, GNT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English translations. In some languages, it will be more natural to translate spirit of wisdom as “spiritually wise.”

and revelation: The word revelation generally refers to something that has been made known. In this context it refers to God making himself known to people. In some languages, it will be more natural to translate the noun revelation as the verb “reveal.” Paul prayed that God would reveal himself to the Ephesian Christians. For example:

reveal God to you (GNT)

1:17c

in your knowledge of Him.

- in order that you will know him better.
- so that you will grow/increase in your knowledge of God.

in your knowledge of Him: In this context, the pronoun Him refers to God the Father. If this is not clear in your translation, you may want to make it explicit. You can say for example:

in your knowledge of God

as it regards the way that you know God

General Comment on 1:17

You may need to translate this verse as several sentences, as in the second meaning line of the Display.

Ephesians 1:18**Section 1:15–23: Paul prayed for the believers at Ephesus**

Paul started the next section by thanking God for the faith and love of the Christians in Ephesus. Then he prayed that they might know God better. Specifically, he prayed that they might know the good things that they can hope for in the future, the blessings that God has promised to his people and the greatness of God's power. This is the power that raised Jesus from death and put him in the place of highest honor in heaven.

In Greek this whole section is one very long sentence. You will probably need to break it into several shorter sentences in your translation.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's prayer (GNT, CEV, NCV)

Paul's prayer for spiritual wisdom (NLT)

Thanksgiving and prayer (NIV)

1:18a–19a

In 1:18–19a Paul prayed that the Christians in Ephesus would come to know three things. In the Display these are marked by repeating “I also pray that...”

1:18a

I ask that the eyes of your heart may be enlightened,

- I also pray that he will open your hearts/minds,
- I also pray that he will cause/help you to understand the truth,

that the eyes of your heart may be enlightened:

This is a figure of speech. In Jewish culture, the heart of a person represented his ability to think and understand. It also represented the person himself. The clause that the eyes of your heart may be enlightened means “that you may be enabled to understand.”

Here are some ways to translate figure of speech:

- Use a figure of speech that communicates this in your language:

I pray also that you will have greater understanding in your heart (NCV)

I pray that God will cause you to see his light

- Translate the meaning directly. For example:

that you may be enabled to understand

that the eyes of your heart may be enlightened is a passive clause. In some languages it may be more natural for you to use an active clause and supply God as the agent. For example:

that God will help you to understand

that God will give you special insight

In some languages a verb like “understand” may require an object. 1:18b indicates what God wanted them to know and understand. Consider how you can connect 1:18a and 1:18b in a natural way in your language. For example:

That God would help you understand the hope...

1:18b

so that you may know the hope of His calling,

- in order that you may understand the hope which he promised to you when he called you.
- so that you will know the good things he has for you. You can confidently expect to receive these good things because he has chosen you to be his people.

so that: The phrase so that introduces the reason why Paul prayed for the Ephesians to have greater understanding. It was so that they would understand “the hope to which he had called them.”

the hope of His calling: The phrase the hope of His calling refers to the blessings that God promised to give to us. We can hope to receive these blessings, which He promised to give us when he called us to be his people.

hope: The Greek word which the BSB translates as hope means “to confidently expect and wait for something that we know will happen.” Christian hope includes the ideas that God is actively working in the lives of all believers and that they will live forever with him in heaven. The Greek meaning of hope is different from the modern English meaning. In modern English,

hope means little more than “wish.” This is not the Greek meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

confidence (GW)

confidently expect

calling: The word calling here means that “God called (invited, summoned) us to be his people.” In some languages, it is clearer to make this explicit. For example:

he chose us to be his own people

1:18c

the riches of His glorious inheritance in the saints,

- And I pray that you will also know how great are the blessings that he promises to give to his people.
-or- I also pray that you will know how wonderful and glorious are the spiritual blessings God has promised to his holy people.

the riches of His glorious inheritance in the saints:

This is the second thing that Paul prayed that the Ephesians would know.

riches: Paul used the word riches in a figurative sense to mean “abundant” or “great.”

glorious inheritance: The words glorious inheritance refer to all the spiritual blessings that God will give to us.

One translation model to follow for 1:18c is the GNT, which says:

how rich are the wonderful blessings he promises his people (GNT)

See how you translated glorious in 1:17a and 1:14a for inheritance.

Also see glory, Meaning 4 in the Glossary for more information.

in the saints: The phrase in the saints means that God has given the glorious inheritance “to” or “for” the people set apart for God.” For example:

how rich are the wonderful blessings he promises his people (GNT)

For more information on the word “saints,” see the note on 1:15c and Holy, Meaning 1, special use, in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 1:19

Section 1:15–23: Paul prayed for the believers at Ephesus

Paul started the next section by thanking God for the faith and love of the Christians in Ephesus. Then he prayed that they might know God better. Specifically, he prayed that they might know the good things that they can hope for in the future, the blessings that God has promised to his people and the greatness of God’s power. This is the power that raised Jesus from death and put him in the place of highest honor in heaven.

In Greek this whole section is one very long sentence. You will probably need to break it into several shorter sentences in your translation.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul’s prayer (GNT, CEV, NCV)

Paul’s prayer for spiritual wisdom (NLT)

Thanksgiving and prayer (NIV)

1:19a

and the surpassing greatness of His power to us who believe.

- And I pray also that you will know his exceedingly great power. He uses this power on behalf of us who believe in him/Christ.
- And I pray also that you will know his power, which is above all powers. This power helps us who believe in him.

the surpassing greatness of His power to us who believe: This is the third thing that Paul prayed that the Ephesians would know.

the surpassing greatness of His power: The phrase surpassing greatness means that God’s power is so strong that no other power can compare with it. His power is greater than all other power.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

incredible greatness of God’s power (NLT)

unlimited greatness of his power (GW)

great and mighty power that God has (CEV)

to us: A literal English translation of the Greek is “toward us.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

power which helps us

power which he uses on our behalf

1:19b

These are in accordance with the working of His mighty strength,

- This is the same great power
- It is the same wonderful power

These are in accordance with the working of His mighty strength: Paul means that the power that God uses to help us is the same power that God used to raise Christ from death and to take him up to heaven (1:20a–b).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

This is the same mighty power (NLT)

This power working in us is the same as the mighty strength (GNT)

Ephesians 1:20

Section 1:15–23: Paul prayed for the believers at Ephesus

Paul started the next section by thanking God for the faith and love of the Christians in Ephesus. Then he prayed that they might know God better. Specifically, he prayed that they might know the good things that they can hope for in the future, the blessings that God has promised to his people and the greatness of God’s power. This is the power that raised Jesus from death and put him in the place of highest honor in heaven.

In Greek this whole section is one very long sentence. You will probably need to break it into several shorter sentences in your translation.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul’s prayer (GNT, CEV, NCV)

Paul’s prayer for spiritual wisdom (NLT)

Thanksgiving and prayer (NIV)

1:20a

which He exerted in Christ when He raised Him from the dead

- that God used when he caused Christ to come alive again,
- God used when he raised Christ from death

which He exerted in Christ: Paul is saying that God used this same power referred to in 1:19b when he raised Christ from death.

Here are some other ways to translate the word exerted:

used

showed

when He raised Him from the dead: Paul is reminding the Ephesians that it was God’s power that made Christ live again.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

when he raised Christ from death (GNT)

when he brought him back to life (GW)

General Comment on 1:19b–20a

Here is another way to translate 1:19b–20a:

This is the same mighty power that raised Christ from the dead (NLT)

1:20b

and seated Him at His right hand in the heavenly realms,

- and when he caused Christ to sit at his right side in the place of honour in heaven,
- and placed him in heaven at his right side.

seated Him at His right hand: The clause seated Him at His right hand is a figure of speech. In Jewish culture, the seat at the right-hand side of a ruler is the place of greatest honor and authority. This same figure occurs frequently in the Bible. The idea that God will cause the Messiah to sit at his right side is first found in Psalm 110:1. This verse from Psalm 110 is also quoted or referred to in several other places in the NT. See Matthew 22:44, 26:64; Mark 12:36, 14:62, 16:19; Luke 20:42, 22:69; Acts 2:33–35, 5:31, 7:55–56, Romans 8:34,

Colossians 3:1; Hebrews 1:3, 1:13, 8:1, 10:12, and 12:2. So you should keep this figure in your translation.

If it is not clear in your translation that this is the place of honor, you may want to make this clearer in your translation. For example:

and seated him in the place of honor at God's right hand (NLT)

in the heavenly realms: This is the same expression as in 1:3b. Here, however, it refers specifically to heaven where God reigns.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

in heaven (CEV)

in the heavenly world (GNT)

Ephesians 1:21

Section 1:15–23: Paul prayed for the believers at Ephesus

Paul started the next section by thanking God for the faith and love of the Christians in Ephesus. Then he prayed that they might know God better. Specifically, he prayed that they might know the good things that they can hope for in the future, the blessings that God has promised to his people and the greatness of God's power. This is the power that raised Jesus from death and put him in the place of highest honor in heaven.

In Greek this whole section is one very long sentence. You will probably need to break it into several shorter sentences in your translation.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's prayer (GNT, CEV, NCV)

Paul's prayer for spiritual wisdom (NLT)

Thanksgiving and prayer (NIV)

1:21a

far above all rule and authority, power and dominion,

- far above all good angels and evil spirits.
- Christ rules there above all types of supernatural beings.

far above: The phrase far above means that Christ is higher in rank than all other rulers. He is superior to them.

If you wish to begin a new sentence here, you can say:

He is far above (GW)

Christ rules there above (GNT)

all rule and authority, power and dominion: This list refers to all ranks of supernatural, spiritual beings. The list does not refer to earthly rulers. The meaning is that Christ is superior to all good angels and evil spirits however great they are.

dominion: The word dominion refers to the ruling power of angels. It is similar in meaning to "authority" and "power."

Here are some other ways to translate this list of terms:

all heavenly rulers, authorities, powers, and lords (GNT)

any ruler or authority or power or leader or anything else (NLT)

It is possible to translate these four terms by one, two or three terms. See the Display for some examples.

1:21b

and every name that is named,

- His title is more important than any other title that man can give to someone
- His authority is more important than the authority of all the chiefs who rule

every name: The word name here means "title." It refers to a word that is attached to a person's name to show their rank or profession, or to give them honor. Some common titles in English are "Doctor," "Captain," and "Mayor." God gave Jesus a title for his task that is more important than any other title/name. This means that Jesus' authority is superior to that of any other person.

that is named: This is a passive. The "names" referred to in this verse are given by man. If it is not clear in your translation who is giving these names, you can add:

given by man

Some ways to translate this verb are:

- As a passive verb. For example:

and all other names that can be named (GW)
- As an active verb. For example:

his name is greater than all other names that people can give

he has a title superior to all titles (GNT)

1:21c

not only in the present age but also in the one to come.

- that exists now or in the future.
- now and who will rule in the future.

not only in the present age but also in the one to come: This long clause means that Jesus' authority is greater than the authority of anyone or anything that exists today or that will come in the future. For example:

He rules over all beings in this world and will rule in the future world as well. (CEV)

Ephesians 1:22

Section 1:15–23: Paul prayed for the believers at Ephesus

Paul started the next section by thanking God for the faith and love of the Christians in Ephesus. Then he prayed that they might know God better. Specifically, he prayed that they might know the good things that they can hope for in the future, the blessings that God has promised to his people and the greatness of God's power. This is the power that raised Jesus from death and put him in the place of highest honor in heaven.

In Greek this whole section is one very long sentence. You will probably need to break it into several shorter sentences in your translation.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's prayer (GNT, CEV, NCV)

Paul's prayer for spiritual wisdom (NLT)

Thanksgiving and prayer (NIV)

1:22a

And God put everything under His feet

- And God gave Christ authority to rule over all things, -or- And God has given Christ control of everything.

God put everything under His feet: The clause God put everything under His feet is a figure of speech which comes from Psalm 8:6. It means that God has given Christ control of all things, and all things are in his power.

In many languages this figure of speech will not be clear if it is translated literally. If this is true for your language, it may be better to say something like this:

God has put all things under the power of Christ (CEV)

God caused all things to be under Christ's authority

1:22b

and made Him head over everything for the church,

- and made him head/leader over everything for the benefit/good of the church. -or- He also made Christ the chief over everything for the benefit of his people, the church.

made Him head over everything for the church:

There are several ways to understand this clause:

1. God made Christ head/leader of everything for the benefit of the church (God's people). For example:

He has made Christ the head of everything for the good of the church. (GW) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NLT, GW, CEV, NCV)

1. God gave Christ to the church (his people). For example:

...he gave him to the church as head over all things. (NET) (NET, GNT, NASB, REB, KJV)

1. God made Christ the head/leader of the church (his people). For example:

He...made him, as he is above all things, the head of the Church. (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

head: Here, Paul used the word head in a metaphorical sense. It means that Christ is the “leader,” “ruler,” or “chief” over everything.

Paul also used the word head in a metaphorical sense in 1:10b, 4:15b, 5:23a and 5:23b. You should translate it in a similar way in all these places.

church: The word church refers to all believers in Christ throughout the world. Be careful to avoid any translation that would mean a church building. You can say:

his people/group

all his followers

See church in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 1:23

Section 1:15–23: Paul prayed for the believers at Ephesus

Paul started the next section by thanking God for the faith and love of the Christians in Ephesus. Then he prayed that they might know God better. Specifically, he prayed that they might know the good things that they can hope for in the future, the blessings that God has promised to his people and the greatness of God’s power. This is the power that raised Jesus from death and put him in the place of highest honor in heaven.

In Greek this whole section is one very long sentence. You will probably need to break it into several shorter sentences in your translation.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul’s prayer (GNT, CEV, NCV)

Paul’s prayer for spiritual wisdom (NLT)

Thanksgiving and prayer (NIV)

1:23a which is His body,

- The church is like Christ’s body.
- The church belongs to him.

which is His body: The clause which is His body is a metaphor. The church is like the body of Christ, and Christ is the head/leader. Paul often used this figure

of speech to describe the close relationship between Christ and the church (see 4:15–16, 5:23).

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Use a figure of speech that communicates this in your language:

And the church is his body (NLT)

- Use a simile:

which is like his body

Translate the meaning directly. For example:

The church belongs to him

1:23b the fullness of Him

- It is filled with the life of Christ,
- Christ fills the assembly/group of believers with all of his life/power,
- Christ gives the church all of its life/power,

the fullness of Him: There are several ways to understand the word fullness in this context:

1. It indicates that the church is filled with/by Christ. This means that Christ fills the church with his life and power. For example:

The church is filled with Christ (NCV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NET, NASB, REB, KJV, NLT, CEV, NCV, NJB)

1. It indicates that the church fulfils Christ in the sense that the church completes Christ. For example:

The church is Christ’s body and completes him (GW) (GNT, GW, UBS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English versions.

fullness: In many languages, it will not make sense to literally translate “the church is filled by Christ” or “Christ fills the church.” You will need to supply a complement to the verb “fill,” or you will need to choose a different verb.

Commentators say that Christ fills the church with his presence, power, life, directions, gifts, graces and

blessings. So some ways you can translate this part of the verse are:

Christ fills the church with his power/life/presence

Christ gives power/life to the church

Christ sustains the church

1:23c

who fills all in all.

- who completely fills all things.
- and he/Christ is the one who controls everything in every way.

who fills all: There are at least two ways to understand the word fills in this part of the verse:

1. fills has an active meaning. It means that Christ fills (controls, empowers) everything. For example:

Christ fills everything in every way (NCV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, NET, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV, JBP)

1. fills has a passive meaning. It means that Christ is filled with everything, that is, Christ is filled with all the fulness of God. For example:

the fullness of him who is filled (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English versions.

all: The word all here refers to everything in the whole world or universe.

in all: The phrase in all means “completely” or “in every respect.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

who himself completes all things everywhere (GNT)

who fills all things everywhere with himself (NLT)

Ephesians 2:1

Section 2:1–10: God saved us by his grace

In this section Paul explained how the power of God, which he described in 1:19–20, changed the lives of

the Ephesians. 2:1–3 describes their condition before they became believers. 2:4–10 describes the new life that God gave to them. Paul stressed that God has done many things for them because he is kind, so they should not be proud.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Made alive in Christ (NLT)

From Death to life (GNT, CEV)

God Saved Us Because of His Great Love for Us (GW)

Because God is loving and kind he saved us^(incl)

Paragraph 2:1–3

In this paragraph, Paul described the condition of the Ephesians before they became Christians. They were spiritually “dead” because of their sins, Satan controlled them, and God was angry with them.

To begin this paragraph, a good model to follow is the GNT. The GNT starts this paragraph with the phrase “in the past” to show that Paul was talking about the former condition of the Ephesians. The CEV and NCV also begin this paragraph in the same way. Some other ways you can make this implied information clear are:

As for you, formerly you were dead

As for you, before you believed you were dead

2:1–2

The BSB and some other English versions translate 2:1–2 as one long sentence. Other versions such as the NLT and the CEV divide these verses into three sentences. You may want to divide 2:1–2 into two or three sentences as well.

2:1

And you were dead in your trespasses and sins,

- ¶ You^(plur) were like dead people because you disobeyed God and sinned.
- ¶ Because you often sinned. you^(plur) were spiritually dead.

And you were dead in your trespasses and sins: In the Greek text, the pronoun you is emphatic. It refers to the Ephesian Christians. Try to show this emphasis in your language in a way that is natural. This sentence

means “you^(plur) were dead because of your transgressions and sins.”

dead: Here the word dead refers to spiritual death, not physical death. Because of their sins, they were like dead people as far as the things of God were concerned. They could not respond to God at all. In many languages, it is better to translate this as a simile. For example:

you were like dead people

it was as if you were dead

In some languages, it may be necessary to make the point of comparison explicit. For example:

you were as unable to please God as a dead person is

trespasses and sins: These two words are similar in meaning and are a doublet. In translating these words, you have at least the following choices:

- Find synonyms to translate both trespasses and sins. One way to translate trespasses is “disobedience.” For example:

because of your disobedience and sins (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate these two words:

you sinned and fought against God (CEV)

your sins and the things you did against God (NCV)

- If your language would not use doublets in this case or does not have synonyms for trespasses and sins, you can translate these two words as one concept. For example:

because of your many sins (NLT96)

Ephesians 2:2

Section 2:1-10: God saved us by his grace

In this section Paul explained how the power of God, which he described in 1:19-20, changed the lives of the Ephesians. 2:1-3 describes their condition before they became believers. 2:4-10 describes the new life

that God gave to them. Paul stressed that God has done many things for them because he is kind, so they should not be proud.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Made alive in Christ (NLT)

From Death to life (GNT, CEV)

God Saved Us Because of His Great Love for Us (GW)

Because God is loving and kind he saved us^(incl)

Paragraph 2:1-3

In this paragraph, Paul described the condition of the Ephesians before they became Christians. They were spiritually “dead” because of their sins, Satan controlled them, and God was angry with them.

To begin this paragraph, a good model to follow is the GNT. The GNT starts this paragraph with the phrase “in the past” to show that Paul was talking about the former condition of the Ephesians. The CEV and NCV also begin this paragraph in the same way. Some other ways you can make this implied information clear are:

As for you, formerly you were dead

As for you, before you believed you were dead

2:2a

in which you used to walk when you conformed to the ways of this world

- At that time you followed the ways of the people of this world
- You formerly behaved badly like the rest of the people who do not know God.

in which you used to walk when you conformed to the ways of this world: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as walk refers to the way the Ephesians behaved in the past before they became Christians. It does not mean to be alive which is the opposite of being dead.

in which you used to walk: This phrase refers to the sinning behavior which the Ephesians used to do but no longer did at the time that Paul wrote them.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

You used to live in sin (NLT)

when you conformed to the ways of this world: The clause conformed to the ways of this world refers to living in a way that disregards God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You^(plur) lived in an evil way like the other people of this world

You behaved in evil ways like other people who do not know God

You did bad behavior like the people of this world do

For more discussion on the meaning of world, see world, Meaning 2 in the Glossary.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

world of evil people

ungodly people of this world

people who do not know God

2:2b

and of the ruler of the power of the air,

- and you followed the ruler/chief of the spirits in the air/sky.
- You followed/obeyed Satan, the chief who rules the evil spirits who are in the sky.

(REB:) the commander of the spiritual powers of the air: In 2:2a Paul said that the Ephesian Christians used to follow “the ways of this world.” In 2:2b he added that they also followed the commander of the spiritual powers of the air. It may be clearer in your translation to begin a new sentence here at 2:2b, or at least to repeat the verb from 2:2a, for example:

^{2a}At that time you followed the ways of the unbelieving people in this world, ^{2b}and you followed the evil ruler who is the chief of the spirits in the air.

(REB:) commander: The commander that Paul referred to is the devil Satan. For example:

You followed the ways of this world and obeyed the devil. (CEV)

Satan is the commander (chief, boss), the one who rules over the evil spirits. If your key term for Satan is something like “the king of evil spirits,” you may want to use it here. The important thing is that it is clear in your translation that Paul is talking about an evil ruler. See devil in the Glossary for more information.

(REB:) spiritual powers of the air: The Greek word that the REB translates as spiritual powers means “authorities.” There are two ways to understand this word.

1. It refers to the spiritual powers that Satan rules, that is, the evil spirits. For example:

you obeyed the ruler of the spiritual powers in space (GNT) (REB, GNT, REB, NCV)

1. It refers to the area where Satan has his power, that is, the kingdom of the air. For example:

according to the ruler of the kingdom of the air (NET) (BSB, NIV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) because it fits the context better.

General Comment on 2:2b

You could translate the phrase “the commander of the spiritual powers of the air” as:

the evil ruler who is the king of the spirits in the sky

Satan who is the chief of the spirits who are as near as the sky

See kingdom in the Glossary for more information.

2:2c

the spirit who is now at work in the sons of disobedience.

- This evil spirit is now working in the hearts of those people who disobey God.
- He—Satan—is the spirit who is still trying to control those people who do not obey God.

the spirit: Here the word spirit refers to Satan. Paul called Satan a spirit because Satan is a supernatural being that people cannot see.

at work: The phrase at work means that Satan tries to control and affect the thinking and behavior of people who do not believe in Christ.

Here are some other ways the phrase has been translated:

has power over (CEV)

rules over

in the sons of disobedience: The phrase in the sons of disobedience means those people who disobey God. It refers to the people who refuse to submit to God, who do not want to listen to and obey God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the people who disobey God (GNT)

of those who refuse to obey God (NLT)

Ephesians 2:3

Section 2:1-10: God saved us by his grace

In this section Paul explained how the power of God, which he described in 1:19-20, changed the lives of the Ephesians. 2:1-3 describes their condition before they became believers. 2:4-10 describes the new life that God gave to them. Paul stressed that God has done many things for them because he is kind, so they should not be proud.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Made alive in Christ (NLT)

From Death to life (GNT, CEV)

God Saved Us Because of His Great Love for Us (GW)

Because God is loving and kind he saved us^(incl)

Paragraph 2:1-3

In this paragraph, Paul described the condition of the Ephesians before they became Christians. They were spiritually “dead” because of their sins, Satan controlled them, and God was angry with them.

To begin this paragraph, a good model to follow is the GNT. The GNT starts this paragraph with the phrase

“in the past” to show that Paul was talking about the former condition of the Ephesians. The CEV and NCV also begin this paragraph in the same way. Some other ways you can make this implied information clear are:

As for you, formerly you were dead

As for you, before you believed you were dead

2:3a

All of us also lived among them at one time,

- We^(incl) all also behaved like them in the past.
- Before/earlier we^(incl) believed in Christ, we^(incl) all behaved/acted like them.

All of us: In 2:1-2, Paul was talking about the Ephesian Christians, who were not Jews. But in this verse he includes himself also. So the phrase All of us refers to both Jews and non-Jews.

lived among them: The pronoun them refers to those people who are disobedient in 2:2c.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

were like them (GNT)

behaved like them

as they did so we^(incl) also did

at one time: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as at one time is one word in Greek and it means “in the past.” It refers to a time before they believed in Christ.

This time word can also be put earlier in the clause. For example:

In the past all of us lived like them (CEV)

All of us once lived among them in the passions of our flesh (RSV)

2:3b

fulfilling the cravings of our flesh

- We satisfied the desires of our bodies.
- We did whatever evil/selfish things we wanted to do.
- We did the things that our selfish nature pushed us to do.

fulfilling the cravings of our flesh: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fulfilling literally means “doing” or “making.” In this context it means to do the sinful things we desire to do.

cravings: The word cravings refers to very strong desires. In this context, it refers to lusts or selfish desires.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

desires to sin

ungodly wants

flesh: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as flesh refers to the evil/selfish character of humans. See flesh, Meaning 6 in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

doing whatever suited the wishes of our own bodies and minds (GNT)

following the passions and desires of our evil nature (NLT96)

trying to please our sinful selves (NCV)

2:3c

and indulging its desires and thoughts.

- We followed/did whatever our evil desires and thoughts told/wanted us to do.
- We behaved according to the evil/selfish desires of our bodies and our evil/selfish thoughts.

This verse part restates the same idea that is found in 2:3b.

indulging its desires and thoughts: The pronoun its refers to the sinful nature in 2:3b.

indulging: The Greek participle that the BSB translates as indulging is literally “doing.” It is another way of expressing “fulfilling” in 2:3b. People did whatever their sinful nature caused them to want to do.

desires and thoughts: The phrase desires and thoughts is similar in meaning to “cravings” in 2:3b.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

doing the evil we want to do and think about

2:3d

Like the rest, we were by nature children of wrath.

- We were naturally evil, just like everyone else, so God was angry with us.
- Because we were naturally sinful, we were people at whom God was angry and would punish, like everyone else.

Like the rest: The phrase Like the rest means that the Ephesians and Jews were just like all the other people in the world.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

just like everyone else (NLT)

We were the same as all other people (NCV)

as they did so have all of us^(incl) done

by nature: The phrase by nature refers to the condition that believers were in before God showed them mercy. They were naturally sinful.

Here are some other ways this phrase has been translated:

We were born with an evil nature (NLT96)

In our natural condition (GNT)

children of wrath: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as children of wrath is a Jewish figure of speech that means “deserving of or subject to God’s wrath.” The word wrath means “anger.” In the New Testament, the word translated as wrath often represents the idea of punishment. So the idea of punishment is also implied in this phrase. See the second meaning line of the display for an example of including this implied information.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

subject to God’s anger (NLT)

destined to suffer God’s anger (GNT)

people whom God would punish

Ephesians 2:4

Section 2:1–10: God saved us by his grace

In this section Paul explained how the power of God, which he described in 1:19–20, changed the lives of the Ephesians. 2:1–3 describes their condition before they became believers. 2:4–10 describes the new life that God gave to them. Paul stressed that God has done many things for them because he is kind, so they should not be proud.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Made alive in Christ (NLT)

From Death to life (GNT, CEV)

God Saved Us Because of His Great Love for Us (GW)

Because God is loving and kind he saved us^(incl)

Paragraph 2:4–10

Remember that in 2:1–3, Paul was talking about the way people were before they trusted in Jesus. Now that they are believers, these things are no longer true. Make sure that this is clear in your translation.

2:4

But because of His great love for us, God, who is rich in mercy,

- ¶ But God loves us very much, and his mercy is abundant. Because of this,
- ¶ But God is very kind/compassionate and he loves us very much in spite of what we have done. Because of this,

But: The conjunction But introduces a contrast with 2:1–3. One contrast is that we believers were dead in sins (2:1), but God made us alive (2:5a). Another contrast is that we deserved God’s anger and punishment (2:3d), but instead God shows us mercy and grace (2:5a–b). Translate this conjunction in a way that naturally introduces these contrasts in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Nevertheless

In spite of this

However

because of His great love for us: The word love here refers to God’s affection and concern for his people. See how you translated love in 1:4c. Also see love, meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

God, who is rich in mercy: As in 1:7c, Paul here used the word rich in a figurative sense to mean “abundant” or “great.”

mercy: The word mercy here refers to God being kind or compassionate to people in serious need. So the phrase “rich in mercy” means that God shows great mercy or compassion to people. See mercy in the Glossary for more information.

General Comment on 2:4

Some English versions change the order of the verses parts for this verse. For example:

But God’s mercy is so abundant, and his love for us is so great, (GNT)

But God’s mercy is great, and he loved us very much. (NCV)

But God was very merciful to us

Translate the order of this verse in a way that is natural for your language.

Ephesians 2:5

Section 2:1–10: God saved us by his grace

In this section Paul explained how the power of God, which he described in 1:19–20, changed the lives of the Ephesians. 2:1–3 describes their condition before they became believers. 2:4–10 describes the new life that God gave to them. Paul stressed that God has done many things for them because he is kind, so they should not be proud.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Made alive in Christ (NLT)

From Death to life (GNT, CEV)

God Saved Us Because of His Great Love for Us (GW)

Because God is loving and kind he saved us^(incl)

Paragraph 2:4-10

Remember that in 2:1-3, Paul was talking about the way people were before they trusted in Jesus. Now that they are believers, these things are no longer true. Make sure that this is clear in your translation.

2:5-6

In 2:5-6, Paul used three Greek verbs. These verbs describe three events that happen to us as we are “together with Christ”:

1. God made us alive together with Christ,
2. God raised us up together with Christ,
3. God caused us to sit/rule together with Christ in heaven.

There are at least two ways to interpret these events:

1. Paul was speaking metaphorically. He compared what God does for us believers spiritually with what he did to Christ physically. These events happen when people trust in Christ.
2. Paul was speaking literally. God will one day resurrect believers just as he resurrected Christ. These events are in the future and will happen when Christ returns, but Paul speaks of them as already having happened.

The discussion below follows interpretation (1).

2:5a

made us alive with Christ even when we were dead in our trespasses.

- he made us alive with Christ. He did this when we were dead to God because we had disobeyed God.
- when we were like dead people because of our sins, God gave us a new/spiritual life just as he gave Christ a new life.

made us alive with Christ: The clause made us alive with Christ is a metaphor. It refers to a Christian’s spiritual life. When we believe in Christ, God gives us a new, spiritual life just as he gave Christ a new life.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

brought us to life with Christ (GNT)

gave us life when he raised Christ from the dead (NLT)

God gave us Christ and we live through/because of him

when we were dead in our trespasses: As in 2:1, the word dead is a metaphor and refers to spiritual death. The word trespasses is a synonym of “sin.” So the phrase means that “because of our sins, we were like dead people.”

In many languages, it is better to translate this as a simile. For example:

we were like dead people

it was as if we were dead

In some languages, it may be necessary to make the point of comparison explicit. For example:

we were as unable to please God as a dead person is unable to please God

trespasses: As stated above, the word trespasses means “sins.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

sins (NLT)

disobedience (GNT)

the things we did against God (NCV)

2:5b

It is by grace you have been saved!

- It is because of God’s grace that you^(plur) have been saved.
- God saved you^(plur) from being punished because he is kind/generous.

It is by grace: The BSB has supplied the words It is to emphasize the word grace here. Try to keep this emphasis in your translation.

grace: Here grace means “showing kindness or generosity to someone.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

special favor (NLT96)

wonderful kindness (CEV)

See how you translated grace in 1:2, 1:6a, and 1:7c. Also see grace, Meaning 2 in the Glossary.

you have been saved!: This is a passive form. If your language would not use a passive verb here, you may need to say:

God saved you^(plur)

saved!: To be saved means to be rescued from danger. In this case, God is rescuing believers from the spiritual danger of being punished for their sins. See save, Word 1, in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 2:6

Section 2:1–10: God saved us by his grace

In this section Paul explained how the power of God, which he described in 1:19–20, changed the lives of the Ephesians. 2:1–3 describes their condition before they became believers. 2:4–10 describes the new life that God gave to them. Paul stressed that God has done many things for them because he is kind, so they should not be proud.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Made alive in Christ (NLT)

From Death to life (GNT, CEV)

God Saved Us Because of His Great Love for Us (GW)

Because God is loving and kind he saved us^(incl)

Paragraph 2:4–10

Remember that in 2:1–3, Paul was talking about the way people were before they trusted in Jesus. Now that they are believers, these things are no longer true. Make sure that this is clear in your translation.

2:6a

And God raised us up with Christ

- God raised us up from death with Christ,
- God raised us up from spiritual death like he raised Christ up from death.

And God raised us up with Christ: Here Paul continued the metaphor which he began in 2:5a. The clause God raised us up with Christ means the same thing as “made us^(incl) alive with Christ” in 2:5a. When we trusted in Christ, God raised us up in a spiritual sense. He raised us up from spiritual death and gave us spir-

itual life. He raised us up like he raised Christ up from the dead.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God raised us from death to life with Christ Jesus (CEV)

God has brought us back to life together with Christ Jesus (GW)

2:6b

and seated us with Him in the heavenly realms in Christ Jesus,

- and he caused us to sit and rule the spiritual world with Christ. God did this by uniting us with Christ Jesus.
- And because he united us with Christ, he placed us on thrones in the heavenly/unseen world.

seated us with Him: This phrase is a figure of speech. It normally refers to a king or leader sitting on his throne to rule with power and authority.

In this verse, Paul again used a metaphor to compare us with Christ. When Christ ascended to heaven, he sat at the right hand of God to rule (a position of authority). When people trust in Christ, they receive the Holy Spirit, who gives them the power to rule in a spiritual sense. It is in this sense that believers are seated with Christ.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he has given us a place beside Christ (CEV)

has given us a position in heaven with him (GW)

in the heavenly realms: The phrase in the heavenly realms means “in the spiritual places” or “the supernatural world.” It is a general term that describes the invisible spirit world. This includes heaven, but it also includes the areas where all types of spirits use their power. In this context it refers to heaven.

This phrase occurs only five times in the New Testament, and all of them are in Ephesians (see also 1:3b, 1:20b, 3:10a–b, 6:12b).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the spiritual realm/world

in the world of unseen beings/spirits

In the unseen world of spiritual beings

in Christ Jesus: The phrase in Christ Jesus means God “united believers with Christ Jesus.” The phrase repeats how God raised up us believers with Christ and made us sit with him in heaven. He did it “by uniting us with Christ Jesus.” See how you translated in Christ Jesus in 1:1d and in Christ in 1:3b, 1:9b, and 1:12a.

Ephesians 2:7

Section 2:1–10: God saved us by his grace

In this section Paul explained how the power of God, which he described in 1:19–20, changed the lives of the Ephesians. 2:1–3 describes their condition before they became believers. 2:4–10 describes the new life that God gave to them. Paul stressed that God has done many things for them because he is kind, so they should not be proud.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Made alive in Christ (NLT)

From Death to life (GNT, CEV)

God Saved Us Because of His Great Love for Us (GW)

Because God is loving and kind he saved us^(incl)

Paragraph 2:4–10

Remember that in 2:1–3, Paul was talking about the way people were before they trusted in Jesus. Now that they are believers, these things are no longer true. Make sure that this is clear in your translation.

2:7a

in order that in the coming ages

- God did this so that in the future
- so that in future years

in order that: The conjunction that the BSB translates as in order that introduces the purpose for which God saved people (2:4–6). God saved people in order to show how great his grace is.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

so (NLT)

for the purpose that

God did that so

You should translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

in the coming ages: The phrase in the coming ages refers to the future. It may refer to the present church age, or it may refer to the time after Christ’s second coming, or both. The exact time period should not be made explicit.

Here are some other ways this phrase has been translated:

for all time to come (GNT)

for all future time (NCV)

in all future ages (NLT)

in future years

2:7b

He might display the surpassing riches of His grace,

- he can show the world how very great his grace/kindness is. It is greater than anything.
- people will see how his grace/kindness is great. It surpasses everything.

He might display: The Greek text does not indicate to whom God would show his great grace. Some commentators say he will show it to people. Other commentators say God will show his grace to both people and angels. If you must make it explicit, you can translate in a general way such as:

to the world

to people

might display: The phrase might display expresses potential and means “would be able to show.” It does not express doubt.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

could show (NCV)

would exhibit/manifest

will make clear

will make known

the surpassing riches of His grace: As in 1:7c and 2:4, Paul here used the word riches in a figurative sense to mean “abundant” or “great.” This means that God’s grace/kindness to us is so great that nothing can be compared with it. His grace/kindness is greater than anything else.

grace: Here, grace means that God shows his generous kindness to people. See how you translated grace in 2:5b. Also, see grace, Meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

extraordinary greatness of his grace (GNT)

incredible wealth of his grace (NLT)

He is very generous to us

2:7c

demonstrated by His kindness to us in Christ Jesus.

- He shows how great his grace is by the kind way he helped us, by what Christ Jesus did for us.
- Through what Christ Jesus did for us, people will see how God’s grace/kindness is great.

demonstrated by His kindness to us in Christ Jesus:

The clause demonstrated by His kindness to us means that God shows his great grace through his kindness to us.

kindness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as kindness also means “goodness.” It is used only here and in Romans 11:22 and 2 Corinthians 6:6. It is a different Greek word than the word for “love” or “grace.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

kindly acts toward us

kind way of helping us

being good to us

in Christ Jesus: The phrase in Christ Jesus represents the means by which God would show his love for us.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because of what Christ Jesus has done (CEV)

By what Christ Jesus has done for us.

General Comment on 2:7a–c

In some languages, it may be helpful to reorder verse parts 7a, 7b, and 7c. The example below has the verse parts in the following order: 7c, 7a, 7b. For example:

^{7c}He showed us his kindness through Christ Jesus,
^{7a}so that for all time to come ^{7b}people will be able
 to see the greatness of his grace.

The second meaning line in the display shows another example of reordering 2:7a–c.

Ephesians 2:8

Section 2:1–10: God saved us by his grace

In this section Paul explained how the power of God, which he described in 1:19–20, changed the lives of the Ephesians. 2:1–3 describes their condition before they became believers. 2:4–10 describes the new life that God gave to them. Paul stressed that God has done many things for them because he is kind, so they should not be proud.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Made alive in Christ (NLT)

From Death to life (GNT, CEV)

God Saved Us Because of His Great Love for Us (GW)

Because God is loving and kind he saved us^(incl)

Paragraph 2:4–10

Remember that in 2:1–3, Paul was talking about the way people were before they trusted in Jesus. Now that they are believers, these things are no longer true. Make sure that this is clear in your translation.

2:8a

For it is by grace you have been saved through faith,

- It is because of the grace that God showed you that he saved you, because you believed in Christ.
- God saved you because he is kind. This happened because you believed in him.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces a repetition and expansion of what Paul has already said and specifically concerning what he said in 5b and 7b concerning God's grace.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

As I said before

My point again is that

I mean that (NCV)

it is by grace you have been saved: This clause means that God saves us because of his grace/kindness. The phrase by grace is emphasized in Greek. The BSB shows this emphasis by adding it is to by grace. This clause is almost identical to 2:5b.

grace: Here, grace means "showing kindness or generosity to someone. See how you translated grace in 2:5b Also, see grace, Meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

saved: To be saved means to be rescued from danger. See how you translated saved in 2:5b. Also, see save, Word 1 in the Glossary for more information.

through faith: The word faith refers here to the action of trusting and believing in someone. God saves us because we believe in Christ.

See how you translated faith in 1:15b. Also see faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some ways of translating this phrase:

by means of believing in Jesus Christ

Because you trust in Jesus Christ

2:8b

and this not from yourselves;

- He did not save you because of anything you have done.
- He did not save you because of any good works you did.

and this not from yourselves: The word this refers to the clause "you have been saved" in 2:8a. The clause and this not from yourselves means that God does not save you because of anything good that you have done.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and this is not your own doing (RSV)

And you can't take credit for this (NLT)

and not anything you have done on your own (CEV)

General Comment on 2:8b -c

Some English versions, like the NIV, have a "—" at the beginning of 2:8b and another at the end of 2:8c. This is to show the reader that 2:8b-c is a comment inserted here by Paul. Other English versions, like the BSB, do not do this, so it is recommended that you do not place a "—" at the beginning of 2:8b and another at the end of 2:8c.

2:8c

it is the gift of God,

- He saved you freely.
- He did this for you because he wanted to.

it is the gift of God: The word it refers to being saved by God. Salvation is God's gift to everyone. The GW makes this explicit:

Being saved is a gift from God (GW)

Ephesians 2:9

Section 2:1-10: God saved us by his grace

In this section Paul explained how the power of God, which he described in 1:19-20, changed the lives of the Ephesians. 2:1-3 describes their condition before they became believers. 2:4-10 describes the new life that God gave to them. Paul stressed that God has done many things for them because he is kind, so they should not be proud.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Made alive in Christ (NLT)

From Death to life (GNT, CEV)

God Saved Us Because of His Great Love for Us (GW)

Because God is loving and kind he saved us^(incl)

Paragraph 2:4–10

Remember that in 2:1–3, Paul was talking about the way people were before they trusted in Jesus. Now that they are believers, these things are no longer true. Make sure that this is clear in your translation.

2:9**not by works, so that no one can boast.**

- It is not the result of anyone's own efforts, so no one can brag.
- God did not save you because of any good thing you have done, so there is no reason for anyone to praise himself.
- It is not the result of your own efforts, so no one can say, "God saved me because of my good works."

not by works: The phrase not by works means almost the same thing as "this not from yourselves" (2:8b). Here, Paul is more specific and mentions works. God does not save you because of any good deeds or behavior you have done.

Here are some other ways this phrase has been translated:

your own efforts (GNT)

anything you've done (GW)

the good things we have done (NLT)

so that no one can boast: The word boast means "to talk or to brag about what you have done."

Here is another way to translate this clause:

It's not the result of anything you've done, so no one can brag about it. (GW)

General Comment on 2:9

In some languages, 2:9 may be more clearly expressed as a direct quote. For example:

So no one can boast and say, "God saved me because of my good behavior."

Ephesians 2:10**Section 2:1–10: God saved us by his grace**

In this section Paul explained how the power of God, which he described in 1:19–20, changed the lives of the Ephesians. 2:1–3 describes their condition before they became believers. 2:4–10 describes the new life that God gave to them. Paul stressed that God has

done many things for them because he is kind, so they should not be proud.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Made alive in Christ (NLT)

From Death to life (GNT, CEV)

God Saved Us Because of His Great Love for Us (GW)

Because God is loving and kind he saved us^(incl)

Paragraph 2:4–10

Remember that in 2:1–3, Paul was talking about the way people were before they trusted in Jesus. Now that they are believers, these things are no longer true. Make sure that this is clear in your translation.

2:10a**For we are God's workmanship,**

- For our being made new is God's work.
- Because it is God who has made us what we now are.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces the basis or reason for the previous statement in 2:9. Paul clearly states again that this grace and salvation are not from us or out of any good thing we have done.

Here is another way to translate this word:

Because,

we are God's workmanship: The expression we are God's workmanship means that God made us what we now are. This refers to God spiritually remaking us when we became Christians. By saying this Paul again emphasizes that our salvation is all God's work, and not ours.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

God has made us what we are (GNT)

we are God's masterpiece (NLT)

2:10b**created in Christ Jesus to do good works,**

- He created us in Christ Jesus to do good deeds,

- Through our union with Christ Jesus, he has remade us into new beings, so that we should habitually do good behaviors.

created in Christ Jesus: When God saved us, he remade or recreated us. We are a new creation. See translation advice in the following note.

in Christ Jesus: God gave us this new life by uniting us with Christ Jesus. See how you translated in Christ Jesus in 1:1d and 2:6b and in Christ in 1:3b, 1:9b, and 1:12a.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

In Christ Jesus, God made us... (NCV)

God made us new people through Christ Jesus

God made us new people because we are in Christ Jesus

to do good works: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to do good works is literally “walk in good works.” Here the word works means deeds. So the phrase to do good works means that believers should be doing good behaviors or doing good deeds as a normal part of their lives.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for a life of good deeds (GNT)

so we can do the good things (NLT)

in order that we would behave in good ways

2:10c

which God prepared in advance as our way of life.

- which is the way he had already planned for us to live/behave.
- Even before he saved us God had already planned for us to do these good works/deeds.

which God prepared in advance as our way of life: This clause means that before God recreated us, he had already planned what good deeds he wanted us to do.

in advance: The phrase in advance refers to the time before God saved us. If it is not clear in your translation what this refers to, you can supply this information. For example:

Even before he saved us, God had already planned for us to do these good works.

as our way of life: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as as our way of life is literally “that we should walk in them” (as in the RSV). The Greek word for “walk” is a figure of speech that refers to our daily actions and our behavior.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for us to live doing good deeds

for us to behave in good ways

For another reference to “walk,” see the note on 2:2a.

Ephesians 2:11

Section 2:11–22: God has united Jews and non-Jews through Christ

In 2:11–22, Paul described another aspect of God’s salvation. Previously Jews and Gentiles were enemies. But Christ, by his death on the cross, has made peace between both groups of people and God. Because of this, there is peace between the two groups also. So the Gentile Christians now belong to the family of God just like Jewish Christians do.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Christ has united all people

All people are one in Christ

Paragraph 2:11–13

Paul again describes the former condition of the Ephesians: they did not share in any of the privileges of the Jews. They were far from God and had no hope. But now they have been brought close to God because Christ died in their place for their sins.

2:11–12

Verses 2:11–12 are one complex sentence in Greek and in the BSB. The main verb of this sentence is “remember,” which occurs at the beginning of 2:11. However, the main things that Paul wants the Ephesians to remember are listed in 2:12. To show this relationship, some good translation models to follow are the NCV and GNT. The NCV places “remember” in 2:12. The GNT places “remember” at the end of 2:11.

¹¹You were not born Jewish. You are the people the Jews call “uncircumcised.” Those who call you “uncircumcised” call themselves “circumcised.” (Their circumcision is only something they themselves do on their bodies.) ^{12a}Remember that in the past you were without Christ... (NCV)

¹¹You Gentiles by birth—called “the uncircumcised” by the Jews, who call themselves the circumcised (which refers to what men do to their bodies)—remember what you were in the past. (GNT)

Although the BSB does not break this into shorter sentences, it does repeat the verb “remember” in 2:12a.

2:11

This verse refers to a particular Jewish custom called “circumcision.”

Circumcision is the cutting off of a band of skin, called the foreskin, from around the end of the penis.

You may want to use a euphemism to describe this event. Some examples are:

mark

receive the mark

Circumcision was the special mark or sign God gave to the Jews which showed they were his chosen people. Since the Gentiles did not practice circumcision, this showed that they did not belong to God’s chosen people.

2:11a

Therefore remember that formerly you who are Gentiles in the flesh

- ¶ Therefore, you who were born Gentiles, remember how you were in the past.
- ¶ Do not forget that you were not born Jewish.

Therefore: The conjunction Therefore refers back to 2:1–10. Paul is reminding the Ephesians again of what they were like before they became Christians.

Here is another way to translate this word:

So then (NRSV)

remember that formerly you who are Gentiles in the flesh: The word that the BSB translates as remember is a command. It means “keep in mind” or “think of.” Most English versions translate it positively, re-

member. A few versions translate it using a negative, for example:

do not forget (NLT)

formerly: The word formerly means “in the past” or “previously.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

before you believed in Christ

prior to becoming a Christian

Gentiles: This word Gentiles refers to all people who are not Jews. See Gentiles, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

non-Jews

people who are not Jews

in the flesh: The Greek phrase which the BSB literally translates as in the flesh refers to the fact that the Ephesians were not circumcised physically (in the flesh) like the Jews were. They were born Gentiles. See flesh, Meaning 5, in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Don’t forget that you Gentiles used to be outsiders. (NLT)

Remember that once you were not Jewish physically. (GW)

2:11b

and called uncircumcised by the so-called circumcision

- You were called “uncircumcised” by the Jews, who call themselves “the circumcised.”
- The Jews insultingly say to you, “you are uncircumcised people.” They say this because they proudly consider themselves to be the people of God because they are circumcised.

called uncircumcised: When a Jew called someone uncircumcised, he was insulting him. To a Jew, anyone who was uncircumcised was a pagan, which is an unbeliever. If the verb for called in your language has

only a positive meaning, you may need to choose another verb or add a word such as “insult” to give the proper meaning of this clause.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

uncircumcised heathen

despicable people without the mark of God

by the so-called circumcision: The phrase by the so-called circumcision refers to the Jewish people. They called themselves the circumcision because their men were circumcised. You may need to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

the Jews, who call themselves the circumcised (GNT)

Jewish people who say, “we are circumcised people.”

This context implies that the Jews were proud of this sign that they were God’s chosen people. In some languages it may be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

the Jews, who were proud of their circumcision (NLT)

marked as God’s chosen people

2:11c (that done in the body by human hands)—

- (which refers to what men do to their bodies.) (GNT)
- But circumcision is only a ceremony which men do to their bodies.

In 2:11c, Paul says two things about circumcision. These are discussed in the following two notes.

that done in the body: The first thing that Paul said about circumcision is that it is done in the body. This means it is a ritual that someone does to a man’s body. Paul implied that circumcision affects a man’s outward appearance, but does not change his heart or change his behavior.

body: This is literally “flesh.” See flesh, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

by human hands: The second thing that Paul said about circumcision is that it is done by human hands.

This means it is something people do, not something God does.

In other words, circumcision is only an outward, physical ceremony. A person may be circumcised following the Jewish religion, but that does not mean that the person has allowed God to change his inner being. (See Romans 2:28–29 and Colossians 2:11.)

General Comment on 2:11c

2:11c is background information Paul gives explaining about circumcision. The BSB has used parentheses to indicate this. Try to indicate it in a natural way in your language.

Ephesians 2:12

Section 2:11–22: God has united Jews and non-Jews through Christ

In 2:11–22, Paul described another aspect of God’s salvation. Previously Jews and Gentiles were enemies. But Christ, by his death on the cross, has made peace between both groups of people and God. Because of this, there is peace between the two groups also. So the Gentile Christians now belong to the family of God just like Jewish Christians do.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Christ has united all people

All people are one in Christ

Paragraph 2:11–13

Paul again describes the former condition of the Ephesians: they did not share in any of the privileges of the Jews. They were far from God and had no hope. But now they have been brought close to God because Christ died in their place for their sins.

2:12a remember that at that time you were separate from Christ,

- Remember that you were without Christ at that time.
- Therefore remember that at that time you did not know Christ,

remember: The BSB has supplied the word remember here. It occurred in 2:11a. It is repeated here to emphasize what Paul said in 2:12. He told the Ephesians to remember. Translate remember in a way that is natural in your language.

at that time: The phrase at that time refers to the word “formerly” in 2:11a. This was before the Ephesians had become Christians.

separate from Christ: The phrase separate from Christ means that they did not know him, and they had no relationship with him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

without Christ (GW)

did not know about Christ (CEV)

2:12b

alienated from the commonwealth of Israel,

- You did not belong to the nation of Israel, the people God had chosen to be his special people.
- you were not included as citizens of God’s chosen people Israel.

alienated from the commonwealth of Israel: The clause alienated from the commonwealth of Israel means they were foreigners/aliens and were not part of God’s chosen people.

alienated: The Greek word that the BSB translates as alienated means “kept from” or “not a part of.” It occurs only three places in the New Testament: here, in 4:18b and in Colossians 1:21.

2:12c

and strangers to the covenants of the promise,

- You were not included in the agreements/oaths God made with them, in which he made them a promise.
- You were foreigners, you had no share in the agreements that God made with the Jews. In those agreements, God made them a promise.

strangers to the covenants of the promise: The word strangers here means the same as “excluded” in 2:12b. Those people who were not Jews were not included in the agreements between God and his chosen people.

covenants of the promise: The phrase covenants of the promise means the agreements/oaths that God made with all the people, in which he made a promise to them. See covenant in the Glossary for more information.

covenants: A “covenant” is an agreement or contract that binds two people or two groups.

Here the word covenants refers to the agreements that God made with Abraham and the agreements he made with the Jews. The Gentiles were excluded from these covenants that God had made with the Jews. The

Gentiles were foreigners in the sense that they were on the outside. They were not part of the group with which God had made these covenants.

Here are some other ways to translate the word covenants:

binding agreements

pacts

promises

the promise: There is an interpretation issue here:

- Most commentators believe that the promise refers to the salvation provided to mankind through God’s Messiah, Jesus Christ and the blessings associated with his kingdom.
- Others believe it refers to God’s blessings in general, or to the promise that God made to Abraham, to make him a great nation.

Each of these interpretations is possible. So it is recommended that your translation be general to allow for these different interpretations as the English versions do.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

binding agreements in which God gave a promise

pacts made by God with an oath that he would do something

2:12d

without hope and without God in the world.

- You lived in this evil/sinful world but you had nothing to hope for, and you did not know God.
- You were in this world without knowing God, and without expecting to live forever with him.

without hope: The phrase without hope indicates that the Ephesians had no hope of being saved from their sins, and they had no hope of eternal life. In other words, they did not expect to live forever with God in heaven.

hope: As in 1:18b, the Greek word that the BSB translates as hope means “to confidently expect and wait for something wonderful to happen that we know will happen.” Christian hope includes the ideas that God is actively working in the lives of all believers and that

they will live forever with him in heaven. See how you translated hope in 1:18b.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

confident expectation

assurance that God will do what he says

and without God: The phrase without God means that the Ephesians did not know about God, and they had no relationship with God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and you did not know God (NCV)

and you were ignorant of who God was

in the world: Here the word world refers to this world where sin and evil are present. See world, Meaning 3 in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 2:13

Section 2:11–22: God has united Jews and non-Jews through Christ

In 2:11–22, Paul described another aspect of God's salvation. Previously Jews and Gentiles were enemies. But Christ, by his death on the cross, has made peace between both groups of people and God. Because of this, there is peace between the two groups also. So the Gentile Christians now belong to the family of God just like Jewish Christians do.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Christ has united all people

All people are one in Christ

Paragraph 2:11–13

Paul again describes the former condition of the Ephesians: they did not share in any of the privileges of the Jews. They were far from God and had no hope. But now they have been brought close to God because Christ died in their place for their sins.

2:13a–b

you who once were far away have been brought near: There is implied information here. In many languages it will be clearer to translate “far away from God” and “near to God.”

Paul used far and near as a figure of speech here. This means that previously, they had no relationship with God (they were far away from God), but when they believed, they did have a relationship with God (they were near to God). If this figure of speech is not clear in your language, you may want to use different words, such as:

In the past you had no relationship with God, but now you have a good/close relationship with him...

In the past you were spiritually separated from God, but now you are joined/united with him...

2:13a

But now in Christ Jesus you who once were far away

- Before, you were far away from God. But now that you are in Christ Jesus,
- In the past you had no relationship with God. But now that you have been united with Christ Jesus,

But now: The phrase But now marks a strong contrast, as in 2:4. The contrast is between how the Ephesians were before they knew God and how they were as believers in Christ Jesus. Show this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

In contrast, now

However, at this time

in Christ Jesus: See how you translated in Christ Jesus in 1:1d and 2:6b and in Christ in 1:3b, 1:9b, and 1:12a.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you have been united with Christ Jesus (NLT)

in union with Christ Jesus (GNB)

through Christ Jesus (GW)

2:13b

have been brought near through the blood of Christ.

- God has brought you close to himself by means of the blood which Christ shed for you.

- God has brought you close to himself by your trusting in what Christ accomplished for us when he shed his blood when he died.

brought near: The phrase brought near is a passive. It means that God has brought the Ephesians near to himself. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this explicit. For example:

God has brought you near

Christ...brought you near God (CEV)

blood of Christ: The phrase blood of Christ refers to the death of Jesus. For example:

But Christ offered his life's blood as a sacrifice and brought you near God. (CEV)

You may need to add more information to complete the idea of Jesus' blood referring to his death.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

...you have been brought near to God through the blood which Christ shed/poured out when he died.

...you have been brought near to God by trusting in what Christ accomplished for us when he shed his blood when he died.

...God has brought you near to himself through the blood which Christ bled when he died.

Ephesians 2:14

Section 2:11–22: God has united Jews and non-Jews through Christ

In 2:11–22, Paul described another aspect of God's salvation. Previously Jews and Gentiles were enemies. But Christ, by his death on the cross, has made peace between both groups of people and God. Because of this, there is peace between the two groups also. So the Gentile Christians now belong to the family of God just like Jewish Christians do.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Christ has united all people

All people are one in Christ

Paragraph 2:14–18

In order to unite Jews and Gentiles, Christ had to remove two things: the hatred between them and the Jewish law. He did this through his death on the cross. He died for both groups. So he united them and made peace between them. So now all believers of whatever race can come near to God.

2:14a

For He Himself is our peace,

- ¶ For Christ himself has made peace between us^(incl).
- ¶ Christ himself has made/brought peace between the Jews and Gentiles.

He Himself is our peace: The pronoun He refers to Christ. In Greek, this pronoun is emphatic. So the BSB has translated it as He Himself.

our peace: In these verses the word peace refers to a good relationship or understanding between people. Christ has made peace between the Jews and non-Jews.

Some commentators think that Paul was also talking about the fact that Christ has made peace between God and mankind. But in 2:11–15 Paul is specifically talking about how Christ united the Jews and non-Jews.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

For Christ himself has brought us peace (GNT)

Christ has made peace between Jews and Gentiles (CEV)

Because Christ has made it possible for the Jews and Gentiles to live in harmony

See how you translated peace in 1:2.

2:14b–2:15a

The Greek grammar in this passage is difficult, and commentators and versions differ as to the exact meaning. However, the general meaning is clear: Christ has destroyed that which separated the Jews and Gentiles.

As you study this passage in different English versions, focus on the following seven elements and how they are connected. These elements are listed in the order in which they appear in Greek.

1. made the two one
2. the dividing wall
3. destroyed
4. hostility

5. in his flesh
6. the law
7. having abolished

All English versions agree that:

1. the dividing wall and (c) destroyed go together.

All English versions also agree that:

1. the law and (g) having abolished go together.

The main difference in English versions is to which part of the verse (d) “hostility” and (e) “in his flesh” are connected. Different options for each of these clauses are discussed below.

2:14b

who has made the two one and has torn down the dividing wall of hostility

- Formerly the hatred between Jews and Gentiles was like a barrier. He has removed this hatred/barrier and made the two groups into one people.
- In the past, it was as if a wall separated the Jews and Gentiles. They hated each other. But now Christ has broken down that wall and caused the two groups to become one.

the two: The phrase the two refers to the two groups of people in this passage: the Jews and Gentiles.

one: The word one here refers to one group of people, the church. Some translations make this explicit. For example:

one people (GNT)

the dividing wall: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the dividing wall is literally “the wall of separation.” See the General Comment note below for more information.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the wall which separated them (GNT)

hostility: The word hostility means “hatred.” There are two views regarding to which part of the text it is connected:

1. It is connected to the word wall. For example:

...he broke down the wall of hostility that separated us. (NLT) (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, NET, REB, NLT, GW, CEV, NCV)

1. It is connected to the word law in 2:15a. For example:

^{14b}by destroying in his own person the hostility,
^{15a}that is, the Law of commandments (NJB) (NJB, NASB, KJV, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English versions.

General Comment on the phrase the dividing wall of hostility

Paul used these words as a metaphor. The hatred between Jews and Gentiles was like a barrier between them. You could translate the phrase “the dividing wall of hostility” something like this:

The Jews and non-Jews were hostile towards each other. It was as if there was a wall that kept them apart.

The Jews and Gentiles hated each other. It was as if there was a wall that separated them.

Ephesians 2:15

Section 2:11–22: God has united Jews and non-Jews through Christ

In 2:11–22, Paul described another aspect of God’s salvation. Previously Jews and Gentiles were enemies. But Christ, by his death on the cross, has made peace between both groups of people and God. Because of this, there is peace between the two groups also. So the Gentile Christians now belong to the family of God just like Jewish Christians do.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Christ has united all people

All people are one in Christ

Paragraph 2:14–18

In order to unite Jews and Gentiles, Christ had to remove two things: the hatred between them and the Jewish law. He did this through his death on the cross. He died for both groups. So he united them and made peace between them. So now all believers of whatever race can come near to God.

2:15a**by abolishing in His flesh the law of commandments and decrees.**

- The law of the Jews had many rules, but Christ cancelled the rules by his death,
- He did this by dying and ending the rules and regulations in the law.

by abolishing: The word that the BSB translates as abolishing means to “destroy, cancel, or end.” In this context, Christ abolished the law in the sense that he removed the law as the way to achieve salvation. This means that people do not have to follow the law in order to be saved.

Here are some other ways this word has been translated:

ending (NLT)

brought an end to (GW)

The law Paul referred to includes the ceremonial laws concerning sacrifices and festivals. These ceremonial laws separated the Jews and the Gentiles, because the Gentiles did not follow these ceremonies. The law was a barrier between Jews and Gentiles. Christ, by his death, removed this barrier. One possible way to translate this is:

he made it so that we do not have to follow all the rules and commands of the Jewish religion in order to be acceptable to God

in His flesh: The phrase in His flesh refers to Christ’s death. However, there are different views regarding which part of the verse in His flesh is connected.

The three main views are:

1. It is connected to the verb abolished/ended in 2:15a. For example:

^{15a}By his death he ended the whole system of Jewish law... (NLT96) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NASB, KJV, CEV, NLT96, JBP, NJB)

1. It is connected to the clause destroyed/broke the wall in 2:14b. For example:

^{14b}With his own body he broke down the wall that separated them and kept them enemies. (GNT) (GNT, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It is connected to the clause made the two one in 2:14b. For example:

^{14b}in his flesh he has made both groups into one (NRSV) (NRSV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English versions.

flesh: Here flesh means Christ’s body. Most commentators believe that it refers to Christ’s crucified body.

Here are some other ways this phrase has been translated:

by his death (NLT96)

Christ gave his own body (CEV)

See flesh, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

the law of commandments and decrees: The two words commandments and decrees are a doublet. They refer to the Jewish religious laws found in the law of Moses. Some ways of translating this entire phrase are:

the whole system of Jewish law (NLT)

the Jewish law with all its rules

the law containing rules about things which people must do and rules about things which they must not do

You should translate this phrase in a way that is natural in your language.

2:15b**He did this to create in Himself one new man out of the two,**

- so that he might join Jews and Gentiles to himself and so make one new person/group.
- His/Christ’s purpose in doing that was so that he could cause the two separate groups to become one new group that is joined to him.

to create in Himself one new man out of the two:

One reason Christ abolished the law was so that he could unite both Jews and Gentiles to himself and, in this way, make one new group. This new group is the group of Christians, or the church.

one new man: The phrase one new man means “one new group.” It refers to the “one” in 2:14b.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

one new group of people

one new community

out of the two: The phrase the two refers to the Jews and Gentiles. See how you translated the two in 2:14b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

from the two opposing groups

out from among the Jews and Gentiles/non-Jews

2:15c thus making peace

- In doing this, he made peace between them.
- This is the way he made the Jews and non-Jews to no longer be hostile/hateful towards each other.

thus making peace: Christ united the Jews and Gentiles, and this made peace between them.

Here are some other ways this phrase has been translated:

so they are no longer hostile/hateful towards each other

so they now relate to each other in peaceful ways

Ephesians 2:16

Section 2:11–22: God has united Jews and non-Jews through Christ

In 2:11–22, Paul described another aspect of God’s salvation. Previously Jews and Gentiles were enemies. But Christ, by his death on the cross, has made peace between both groups of people and God. Because of this, there is peace between the two groups also. So the Gentile Christians now belong to the family of God just like Jewish Christians do.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Christ has united all people

All people are one in Christ

Paragraph 2:14–18

In order to unite Jews and Gentiles, Christ had to remove two things: the hatred between them and the Jewish law. He did this through his death on the cross. He died for both groups. So he united them and made peace between them. So now all believers of whatever race can come near to God.

2:16a and reconciling both of them to God in one body through the cross,

- Through his death on the cross, he/Christ united the two groups into one and reconciled them to God.
- Christ united both groups into one body and made them all God’s friends by dying on the cross.

reconciling both of them to God: The word reconciling means “making those who are enemies into friends.” By his death on the cross, Christ made the Jews and the Gentiles into friends of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

brought them back to God (GNT)

made peace between us and God (CEV)

See reconcile in the Glossary for more information.

in one body: The phrase in one body means the same thing as the phrase “one new man” in 2:15b. It means that the Jews and Gentiles are now “one (new) group.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

as one united people

like one harmonious group of people

through the cross: The phrase through the cross means “through Christ’s death on the cross” or “by Christ’s dying on the cross.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

his death on the cross (GNT)

2:16b by which He extinguished their hostility.

- By dying on the cross, Christ ended the hostility between Jews and Gentiles.
- Because of this they did not hate each other any longer.

by which: The word which refers to “the cross” in 2:16a. By dying on the cross, Christ ended the hatred between Jews and Gentiles.

He extinguished their hostility: The phrase He extinguished their hostility is a figure of speech. It means that what Christ did caused the Jews and Gentiles to stop hating each other.

Here are some other ways this phrase has been translated:

Christ did away with our hatred for each other (CEV)

Christ’s purpose (was) to end the hatred between the two groups (NCV)

Ephesians 2:17

Section 2:11–22: God has united Jews and non-Jews through Christ

In 2:11–22, Paul described another aspect of God’s salvation. Previously Jews and Gentiles were enemies. But Christ, by his death on the cross, has made peace between both groups of people and God. Because of this, there is peace between the two groups also. So the Gentile Christians now belong to the family of God just like Jewish Christians do.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Christ has united all people

All people are one in Christ

Paragraph 2:14–18

In order to unite Jews and Gentiles, Christ had to remove two things: the hatred between them and the Jewish law. He did this through his death on the cross. He died for both groups. So he united them and made peace between them. So now all believers of whatever race can come near to God.

2:17a

He came and preached peace to you who were far away

- Christ came and preached a message of peace to you who were far away from God
- Christ came into the world and preached the good news which tells of peace to you Gentiles who were spiritually separated from God.

preached peace: The word preached means publicly told or announced a message.

peace: The word peace here has a more general meaning than in 2:14–15. In this context it refers to the message of salvation. Christ came into the world and preached that there is now peace between man and God. Some English versions make this association with the message of salvation explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase “preached peace”:

So Christ came and preached the Good News of peace to all (GNT)

He brought this Good News of peace to you (NLT)

He announced that his death would do away with that hostility/hatred between the two

you who were far away: The pronoun you refers to the Ephesians who were Gentiles. This is stating their condition before they believed in Christ.

far away: As in 2:13a–b, the phrase far away is a figure of speech that means that they were “far away from God.” They did not have a close relationship with God.

If this figure of speech is not clear in your language, you may want to use different words, such as:

you who had no relationship with God

you who were spiritually separated from God

See how you translated far away in 2:13a–b.

2:17b

and peace to those who were near.

- and to us^(excl) Jews who were near to God.
- He also preached to us Jews who had a close relationship to God, saying that there is now peace between man and God.

peace: The Greek text repeats the word peace in 2:17a and 2:17b. If it is not natural to repeat this word in your language, here is a way you can translate this:

Christ came and preached peace to you who were far away from God, and to those who were near to God. (NCV)

to those who were near: The phrase those who were near refers to the Jews. Since Paul was also a Jew, it is possible to translate this clause using a first person plural pronoun (us). For example:

to us Jews who were near

near: The word near (like the expression “far away” in 2:17a) is a figure of speech here. The Jews were near to God because they had a special relationship with him. He had chosen them to be his special people. It does not mean that they were physically near or close to God.

If this figure of speech is not clear in your language, you may want to use different words, such as:

those people who had a close relationship with him

the Jews who are his chosen/special people

Here is another way to translate 2:17:

To you non-Jews who are far and to you Jews who are near, he came and said this, “Live in peace together.”

Ephesians 2:18

Section 2:11–22: God has united Jews and non-Jews through Christ

In 2:11–22, Paul described another aspect of God’s salvation. Previously Jews and Gentiles were enemies. But Christ, by his death on the cross, has made peace between both groups of people and God. Because of this, there is peace between the two groups also. So the Gentile Christians now belong to the family of God just like Jewish Christians do.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Christ has united all people

All people are one in Christ

Paragraph 2:14–18

In order to unite Jews and Gentiles, Christ had to remove two things: the hatred between them and the Jewish law. He did this through his death on the cross. He died for both groups. So he united them and made

peace between them. So now all believers of whatever race can come near to God.

2:18

For through Him we both have access to the Father by one Spirit.

- Because of Christ, we both —Jews and Gentiles— are able to approach God our Father by way/means of the same Holy Spirit.
- Because of what Christ has done for us, the Holy Spirit helps both Jews and Gentiles to approach God our Father.

For through Him: The phrase For through Him refers to Christ dying on the cross for people. The NLT makes this explicit:

because of what Christ has done for us (NLT)

we both: The phrase we both refers to the Jews and the Gentiles. If it is not clear to whom this phrase refers you may want to make it clearer in the translation.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

both we Jews and you Gentiles

we who are Jews and you who are not Jews

we^(incl) all, both Jews and Gentiles

have access to the Father: The word access means we have the right to enter God’s presence here on earth. Paul meant that believers can talk with God in this life because they have a good relationship with him. Paul was not talking here about believers going to heaven after they died.

If there is a special word in your language that indicates entering the presence of a chief/ruler, you may want to use it here.

It is possible to translate the word access as a verb. For example:

all of us can come to the Father (CEV)

all of us...are able to come...into the presence of the Father (GNT)

Jewish and non-Jewish people can go to the Father (GW)

by one Spirit: The phrase by one Spirit in this context means “the same Holy Spirit.” It is the same Holy Spirit who leads both Jews and Gentiles to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

we all can approach God by the power of the same Holy Spirit

both Jews and Gentiles can approach God our Father with the help of the same Holy Spirit

Ephesians 2:19

Section 2:11–22: God has united Jews and non-Jews through Christ

In 2:11–22, Paul described another aspect of God’s salvation. Previously Jews and Gentiles were enemies. But Christ, by his death on the cross, has made peace between both groups of people and God. Because of this, there is peace between the two groups also. So the Gentile Christians now belong to the family of God just like Jewish Christians do.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Christ has united all people

All people are one in Christ

Paragraph 2:19–22

In this next paragraph, Paul used three comparisons to describe the unity of Jewish and Gentile believers in Christ. He said that they are like:

1. citizens of the same country (19a–b)
2. members of the same family (19c)
3. bricks of one building (20–21)

2:19a

Therefore you are no longer strangers and foreigners,

- ¶ Therefore, you Gentiles are no longer foreigners or strangers.
- ¶ So then, you Gentiles are no longer outsiders to God.

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB here translates as Therefore means that Paul is concluding and summarizing what he has said in 2:11–18.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

So then (GNT)

That is why (GW)

And so because of this

strangers and foreigners: The word strangers refers to people who visit a country, but do not live there. The word foreigners refers to those who have come to live in a country, though they are not full citizens of it.

Before the Gentiles became Christians, they were like foreigners to God’s people. They were excluded from God’s people the same way foreigners and aliens are excluded from the people they are living among. (Paul used the word strangers in 2:12 also.)

If your language has only one word for both of these, do not try to distinguish them, but use the one word. For example:

outsiders

Some languages translate foreigners as a phrase, such as “not part of God’s people.” So to say, “no longer strangers and foreigners” makes a complicated sentence with two negatives, such as “You are no longer not a part of God’s people.” To avoid this you can make two sentences, for example:

In the past it was like you were on the outside, you were not part of God’s people. But now you are no longer like that.

2:19b

but fellow citizens with the saints

- Instead, you have become like people of the same country together with the other people of God.
- but rather, you are one group with God’s people.

but fellow citizens with the saints: This clause contrasts with 2:19a. To be fellow citizens means to be members of the same country. This is another comparison. They are now members of God’s people.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

It is like you are from the same tribe as all the rest of God’s people.

You are one group with God’s people.

But rather you and God’s people are in the same group

the saints: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as the saints means “people set apart for God.” This Greek word refers to every believer.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

God’s people (NIV)

people who belong to God

See Holy, Meaning 1, special use in the Glossary for more information.

2:19c

and members of God’s household,

- You are members of God’s house/family.
- You belong to God’s family.

members of God’s household: The phrase members of God’s household is also a comparison. The meaning is the same as the comparison in 2:19b. The Gentiles who believe in Christ are no longer foreigners or outsiders. They are God’s children, just the same as Jews who believe in Christ. Jews and Gentiles are all brothers and sisters, part of the same family.

Here is another way this phrase can be translated:

members of God’s family (NLT)

Ephesians 2:20

Section 2:11–22: God has united Jews and non-Jews through Christ

In 2:11–22, Paul described another aspect of God’s salvation. Previously Jews and Gentiles were enemies. But Christ, by his death on the cross, has made peace between both groups of people and God. Because of this, there is peace between the two groups also. So the Gentile Christians now belong to the family of God just like Jewish Christians do.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Christ has united all people

All people are one in Christ

Paragraph 2:19–22

In this next paragraph, Paul used three comparisons to describe the unity of Jewish and Gentile believers in Christ. He said that they are like:

1. citizens of the same country (19a–b)

2. members of the same family (19c)
3. bricks of one building (20–21)

2:20–22

In 2:20–22, Paul used the idea of a house or building as a metaphor for the Church/believers. There are three parts of this metaphor:

1. Believers are the bricks (or boards or sticks) of the house.
2. The apostles and prophets are the foundation.
3. Christ is the cornerstone.

You should keep this figure of speech in your translation. You may want to change it to a simile, for example, “Christ is like a cornerstone.”

Also, think about what houses are like in your area. You may want to adapt Paul’s figure of speech so that it will communicate clearly in your language. Perhaps you can say that Christ is like the rock on which the house posts stand and the apostles and prophets are like the house posts. Or perhaps you can say that Christ is the big central post, and the apostles and prophets are the main horizontal beams.

2:20a

built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets,

- You are built on the foundation composed/made of the apostles and prophets.
- You are also like a house. The apostles and prophets are like the foundation/solid footing on which that house is built,
- You are like the bricks/stones of a house. The apostles and the prophets are like the solid base/footing of that house,

foundation of the apostles and prophets: There are different views about the meaning of this phrase. This phrase could mean that:

1. the foundation is composed of the apostles and prophets. For example:

You are like a building with the apostles and prophets as the foundation (CEV) (CEV, JBP)

1. the foundation has been laid by the apostles and prophets. This means that the work that the apostles and prophets did is the foundation. For example:

You, too, are built upon the foundation laid by the apostles and prophets (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most English versions translate the Greek literally, and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. In some languages, a literal translation would mean that the apostles and prophets owned the foundations, so be careful to avoid such a meaning.

foundation: In New Testament times the houses were built on rocks to make them solid. These rocks were called the foundation. If your language has no word for foundation, you may need to say something like this:

rocks that they build the house on

apostles: The apostles are the twelve disciples plus Paul and perhaps a few other men. See how you translated “apostle” in 1:1b. See apostle in the Glossary if you want more information.

prophets: In this context, prophets were people in the church to whom God gave a spiritual gift. This gift enabled the person to speak a message from God. Most commentators think that the prophets Paul was talking about were New Testament prophets rather than Old Testament prophets. (See Acts 13:1, Ephesians 3:5, Ephesians 4:11.)

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

spokesmen for God

men who speak God’s words

God’s message-speakers

See prophet in the Glossary for more information.

2:20b

with Christ Jesus Himself as the cornerstone.

- And Christ Jesus himself is the most important stone.
- And Christ Jesus himself is like the main stone support for the house.

cornerstone: The Greek word the BSB translates as cornerstone was the largest and most important stone in the building. It was a large stone placed in the corner of the foundation. It made the building solid and helped hold the foundation and walls together.

If your readers will not understand a word like cornerstone, you may need to use a word for the most important part of your buildings. For example:

the most important stone (CEV)

the central post of the house

Ephesians 2:21

Section 2:11–22: God has united Jews and non-Jews through Christ

In 2:11–22, Paul described another aspect of God’s salvation. Previously Jews and Gentiles were enemies. But Christ, by his death on the cross, has made peace between both groups of people and God. Because of this, there is peace between the two groups also. So the Gentile Christians now belong to the family of God just like Jewish Christians do.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Christ has united all people

All people are one in Christ

Paragraph 2:19–22

In this next paragraph, Paul used three comparisons to describe the unity of Jewish and Gentile believers in Christ. He said that they are like:

1. citizens of the same country (19a–b)
2. members of the same family (19c)
3. bricks of one building (20–21)

2:21a

In Him the whole building is fitted together

- Because of him, all the stones of the house fit/hold together;
- He is the one who holds the whole building together; (GNT)

In Him: Here the phrase In Him means “because of Christ.” It has the same meaning as “through him” in 2:18. It first occurred in 1:7a. It means that Christ is doing the work of joining and building the building.

whole building: The phrase whole building is part of the apostle Paul’s metaphor comparing the church to a building or house. See the above note on 2:20–22 for more information.

fitted together: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as fitted together is a technical building term. It refers to cutting or shaping stones so that they fit exactly together in the building, then fastening together the cut stones with metal pegs. (This verb occurs only here and in 4:16.) This metaphor refers to the Jews and Gentiles being joined or united together in the church.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

He is the one who holds the whole building together (GNT)

In him all the parts of the building fit together (GW)

2:21b

and grows into a holy temple in the Lord.

- and because of him, the house becomes bigger, so that it becomes a holy temple for the Lord.
- and he causes/makes the house to become larger, so in that way it becomes a house dedicated to the Lord.

grows into a holy temple in the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as grows means “to get larger.” In some languages the word “grow” may not be appropriate to describe a building becoming larger. Use a natural way to describe this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

becoming a holy temple (NLT)

He builds a holy temple

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate what causes the building to become larger. If this is true in your language you may indicate that Christ is the one who causes the temple to get larger.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

makes it grow into a holy temple for the Lord (CEV)

Christ builds it into a holy temple for the Lord

holy temple: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as temple specifically refers to the Holy of Holies. It was the room in the temple where God’s presence lived. The word holy means that this temple is dedicated/set apart for God. In some languages, there is no special word for temple or sanctuary. Instead a phrase like “worship place” or “God’s house” is used. See holy, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a place set apart for God where God resides

like a temple, wholly dedicated to God and filled with his presence

God’s big holy house

in the Lord: By using the word Lord, Paul probably meant the Lord Jesus, but some commentators think Paul means Lord God. If possible, leave this ambiguous in your translation. If this is impossible then choose “the Lord Jesus” as the majority of the commentaries consulted favor this view.

The phrase in the Lord means that the temple is “for the Lord” (see the NLT) or “dedicated to the Lord” (see GNT).

Ephesians 2:22

Section 2:11–22: God has united Jews and non-Jews through Christ

In 2:11–22, Paul described another aspect of God’s salvation. Previously Jews and Gentiles were enemies. But Christ, by his death on the cross, has made peace between both groups of people and God. Because of this, there is peace between the two groups also. So the Gentile Christians now belong to the family of God just like Jewish Christians do.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Christ has united all people

All people are one in Christ

Paragraph 2:19–22

In this next paragraph, Paul used three comparisons to describe the unity of Jewish and Gentile believers in Christ. He said that they are like:

1. citizens of the same country (19a–b)
2. members of the same family (19c)
3. bricks of one building (20–21)

2:22a

And in Him you too are being built together

- Because you are united with/in Christ, Christ is also building/joining you together with other Christians,
- And in Christ, he is building/transforming you Gentiles together with Jews.

in Him: The phrase in Him means “because you are united in/with Christ.” See how you translated it in 2:21a.

you too are being built together: This is a passive. If it would be more natural in your language to make this active, you can supply the word “Christ” as the agent and say this:

Christ is building you together

you too: The pronoun you refers to “you Gentiles.” The Gentiles are also being built and joined into the temple along with the Jews.

built together: The phrase built together is a figure of speech. It is part of the metaphor Paul used. See the above note for 2:20–22 for more information. Here, it means that the Gentiles who believe in Christ are being joined together in one group with Jews who believe in Christ.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

And you Gentile believers are also being joined together with all of God’s other people.

And Christ is also joining you Gentile believers together with all of God’s other people.

2:22b

into a dwelling place for God in His Spirit.

- so that you become a house where God lives by/ through the power of the Holy Spirit.
- You are together becoming like a house where God’s Spirit lives.

a dwelling place for God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a dwelling place for God is literally “dwelling-place of God.” This is another way of saying “holy temple in the Lord” in 2:21. But here, it is a figure of speech. Paul is saying that the believers together are like a building that can be compared to the temple.

in His Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in His Spirit is literally “in spirit.” This phrase tells how God lives in this house—that is, in us. He lives in us by the power and presence of the Holy Spirit. In other words, because the Holy Spirit dwells in us, we can say that God dwells in us.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

And you are part of that building Christ has built as a place for God’s own Spirit to live (CEV)

Through him you Gentiles are also being made part of this dwelling where God lives by his Spirit (NLT)

Because you are in Christ, God will come and take both of you Jews and Gentiles and build you together into one house where the Spirit will live with you.

Ephesians 3:1

Section 3:1–13: God sent Paul to preach the good news to the non-Jews

In 3:1, Paul was about to pray for the Christians. Instead, in 3:2 he stopped his sentence and began to write about the special work that God had given him. It was not until 3:14 that Paul resumed his prayer.

The special work that God had given Paul was to preach God’s message to the Gentiles. The blessings of God are for the Gentiles as well as for the Jews, but God had hidden this great truth for a long time. Then God gave Paul the task of telling people about this truth. In this way, everyone would know that God was very wise and loving because he saved both Jews and Gentiles and united them into one church.

Here are some other titles for this section:

God’s mysterious plan revealed (NLT)

Paul’s work in telling the Good News (NCV)

God’s plan to unite Jews and Gentiles in Christ is revealed to Paul

3:1

In the Greek, 3:1 is an incomplete sentence. The BSB shows this with an ellipsis at the end of the verse. Paul’s intention in 3:1 was probably to say something like:

For this reason I, Paul...pray for you.

Paul did not complete the sentence here. Instead, he inserted 3:2–13 where he described his ministry. In 3:14 Paul continued the prayer he started in 3:1.

It is recommended that you make this a complete sentence by adding the words “pray to God.”

Here is a way to translate this:

For this reason I, Paul, the prisoner of Christ Jesus for the sake of you Gentiles, pray to God. (GNT)

3:1a**For this reason I, Paul,**

- ¶ Therefore I, Paul, am praying to God for you.
- ¶ So I, Paul, pray for you.

For this reason: The phrase For this reason refers back to God's grace towards the Gentiles in 2:11–22. Since God had blessed them so much, Paul began to pray that they would appreciate his grace.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

This is the reason... (GW)

So... (NCV)

This phrase also occurred in 1:15a.

I, Paul: The words I, Paul are emphatic in the Greek. Paul began to talk about himself. Look for an expression in your language to show this emphasis.

3:1b**the prisoner of Christ Jesus**

- I am in prison because of the work Christ Jesus gave me to do,
- I am in prison because I serve/follow Christ Jesus.

the prisoner of Christ Jesus: When Paul said that he was a prisoner of Christ Jesus, he meant that he was in prison “because he belonged to or served Jesus.” People who did not like him preaching about Jesus had put him in prison.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

who am imprisoned on account of my serving Christ Jesus

a prisoner because of my following Jesus Christ

Avoid translating in a way that could give the impression that Jesus had put him in prison, or that Jesus was keeping Paul in prison.

3:1c**for the sake of you Gentiles...**

- proclaiming the good news to you Gentiles.
- I am also in prison because I preach the gospel to you non-Jews.

for the sake of you Gentiles: Another reason Paul was in prison was because he had been preaching the gospel to the Gentiles.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

so that I could help you Gentiles (CEV)

so that you Gentiles will believe in Christ Jesus

Gentiles: Here the word Gentiles refers to people who were not Jews.

See how you translated Gentiles in 2:11a. See Gentiles, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 3:2**Section 3:1–13: God sent Paul to preach the good news to the non-Jews**

In 3:1, Paul was about to pray for the Christians. Instead, in 3:2 he stopped his sentence and began to write about the special work that God had given him. It was not until 3:14 that Paul resumed his prayer.

The special work that God had given Paul was to preach God's message to the Gentiles. The blessings of God are for the Gentiles as well as for the Jews, but God had hidden this great truth for a long time. Then God gave Paul the task of telling people about this truth. In this way, everyone would know that God was very wise and loving because he saved both Jews and Gentiles and united them into one church.

Here are some other titles for this section:

God's mysterious plan revealed (NLT)

Paul's work in telling the Good News (NCV)

God's plan to unite Jews and Gentiles in Christ is revealed to Paul

3:2a**Surely you have heard about**

- I am sure that you have heard about
- You have certainly heard that
- Assuredly someone has told you that

Surely you have heard: This phrase expresses a strong assumption or a certainty. Paul was saying that he was sure that the Ephesian believers knew of his ministry of preaching the gospel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Certainly you have heard (GW)

Since you have heard

I am sure that you have heard Paul had lived and preached the gospel in Ephesus for about three years, and he had been gone for only a few years when he wrote this letter. So most of the Christians in Ephesus probably knew Paul personally. But when we read Ephesians 3:2, it sounds as if Paul is writing to people who had only heard about him. This is one reason that some scholars believe that Paul sent this letter not only to the church in Ephesus, but also to other churches in nearby towns. This may also explain why some ancient manuscripts of this letter do not have the words “in Ephesus” in 1:1.

3:2b

the stewardship of God’s grace that was given to me for you,

- this responsibility which God has given me to offer his Gospel of grace to you.
- God entrusted to me this work which is to make known to you his mercy/grace.

stewardship of God’s grace that was given to me for you: The Greek word which the BSB translates as stewardship refers to how something is put into effect, accomplished, administered or caused to be done. Paul was talking about his job of being an apostle and preaching the gospel.

Here is another way to translate this word:

special responsibility (NLT)

God sent me to preach

of God’s grace that was given to me for you: The phrase of God’s grace that was given to me for you can be interpreted in a number of ways:

1. It refers to the Good News of God’s saving grace. For example:

God gave me the special responsibility of extending his grace to you Gentiles. (NLT) (NLT, GW)

1. It refers to Paul’s commission to evangelize the Gentiles. For example:

God in his grace has given me this work to do for your good. (GNT) (GNT, NCV, CEV)

1. It refers to Paul’s knowledge of the mystery given to him. For example:

You have heard of the knowledge of the mystery God so graciously gave me to proclaim to you.

While both interpretations (1) and (2) have good support among English translations and commentators, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Ephesians 3:3

Section 3:1–13: God sent Paul to preach the good news to the non-Jews

In 3:1, Paul was about to pray for the Christians. Instead, in 3:2 he stopped his sentence and began to write about the special work that God had given him. It was not until 3:14 that Paul resumed his prayer.

The special work that God had given Paul was to preach God’s message to the Gentiles. The blessings of God are for the Gentiles as well as for the Jews, but God had hidden this great truth for a long time. Then God gave Paul the task of telling people about this truth. In this way, everyone would know that God was very wise and loving because he saved both Jews and Gentiles and united them into one church.

Here are some other titles for this section:

God’s mysterious plan revealed (NLT)

Paul’s work in telling the Good News (NCV)

God’s plan to unite Jews and Gentiles in Christ is revealed to Paul

3:3a

that is, the mystery made known to me by revelation,

- God revealed his secret plan to me
- God showed me that which he had not yet explained.

that is: The Greek word that the BSB translates as that is is literally “that.” It is used to introduce the content of the “grace” given to Paul. Some versions do not translate it. Here is another way to translate this:

how (RSV)

Translate this word in a way that is natural in your language.

the mystery: The word mystery here refers to God’s plan that was unknown to mankind in the past. God had not yet explained his plan to man. Another way to say mystery is “hidden matter.” Paul also used this word in 1:9a.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

mysterious plan (NLT)

secret plan (GNT)

Paul wrote about God's plan in 3:3–5, but he did not clearly state what God's plan is until 3:6.

made known to me by revelation: Paul knew God's plan only because God revealed it to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

God revealed his secret plan to me

God explained his hidden course of action to me

3:3b

as I have already written briefly.

- as I have already briefly written to you.
- I have already written to you a little about this.

as I have already written briefly: There is an interpretation issue here. We do not know exactly which passage in his letters Paul was referring to:

- Most commentators think that he was referring to what he wrote in this letter, specifically to 2:11–22 and perhaps also to 1:9–10.
- A few commentators think that he was referring to something he wrote in another letter.

Some languages distinguish between events that just happened a short time ago and events that happened a long time ago. If this is true in your language, you should use terms for something that happened a short time ago.

General Comment on 3:a-b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reverse the order of 3a and 3b. For example:

^{3b}As I briefly wrote earlier, ^{3a}God himself revealed his mysterious plan to me. (NLT)

Ephesians 3:4

Section 3:1–13: God sent Paul to preach the good news to the non-Jews

In 3:1, Paul was about to pray for the Christians. Instead, in 3:2 he stopped his sentence and began to write about the special work that God had given him. It was not until 3:14 that Paul resumed his prayer.

The special work that God had given Paul was to preach God's message to the Gentiles. The blessings of God are for the Gentiles as well as for the Jews, but God had hidden this great truth for a long time. Then God gave Paul the task of telling people about this truth. In this way, everyone would know that God was very wise and loving because he saved both Jews and Gentiles and united them into one church.

Here are some other titles for this section:

God's mysterious plan revealed (NLT)

Paul's work in telling the Good News (NCV)

God's plan to unite Jews and Gentiles in Christ is revealed to Paul

3:4a

In reading this, then,

- When you read this,
- As you read this earlier passage,

In reading this, then: The word this refers to the writing Paul referred to in 3:3b.

then: The BSB has supplied the word then because it is good English style. It should only be translated if it would be natural to do so in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

When/if you read this...

As you read this earlier passage...

3:4b

you will be able to understand my insight into the mystery of Christ,

- you will realise that I understand the secret plan concerning Christ.
- you will see that I understand God's hidden plan which will be fulfilled through Christ.

you will be able to understand my insight: In the Greek text, the phrase you will be able to understand my insight is in the present tense.

So here is another way to translate this phrase:

you can understand my insight

my insight: The phrase my insight refers to Paul's ability to see and understand God's formerly unknown plan concerning Christ.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you can perceive my insight (RSV)

you can see that I truly understand (NCV)

mystery of Christ: The word mystery means “something that has not been explained.” In this context, mystery of Christ can mean “the secret (plan) put into effect by Christ.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the secret purpose of Christ (REB)

God’s secret plan carried out by Christ,

the hidden plan concerning Christ

the secret plan that tells about Christ

Also, see how you translated “the mystery of his will” in 1:9a and “the mystery” in 3:3a.

Ephesians 3:5

Section 3:1–13: God sent Paul to preach the good news to the non-Jews

In 3:1, Paul was about to pray for the Christians. Instead, in 3:2 he stopped his sentence and began to write about the special work that God had given him. It was not until 3:14 that Paul resumed his prayer.

The special work that God had given Paul was to preach God’s message to the Gentiles. The blessings of God are for the Gentiles as well as for the Jews, but God had hidden this great truth for a long time. Then God gave Paul the task of telling people about this truth. In this way, everyone would know that God was very wise and loving because he saved both Jews and Gentiles and united them into one church.

Here are some other titles for this section:

God’s mysterious plan revealed (NLT)

Paul’s work in telling the Good News (NCV)

God’s plan to unite Jews and Gentiles in Christ is revealed to Paul

3:5a

which was not made known to men in other generations

- This hidden plan had not been made known to people of previous generations,
- In the past God did not reveal this plan to people.

which: The Greek word which the BSB translates as which refers back to the “mystery” or “hidden plan” mentioned in the previous verse.

If you need to make this word more clear, here are some ways to translate this word:

that secret (NCV)

this mystery (GW)

this plan

was not made known: This is a passive clause. If it would be more natural in your language to use an active phrase in this case, here are some ways you can translate this phrase:

God did not reveal it (NLT)

God did not announce it

to men: The word men refers here to people in general, not just males.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

people (GW)

human beings (GNT)

in other generations: The phrase in other generations is a way of referring to the past in a general way.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

previous generations (NLT)

in past times (GNT)

in the time before Jesus came

3:5b

as it has now been revealed by the Spirit

- but now God has revealed it by/through the Holy Spirit.
- But now he has caused his Holy Spirit to reveal this plan

now: The word now refers to the time when Paul lived.

been revealed by the Spirit: This is a passive clause. If it would be more natural in your language to make this an active clause, you can translate like this:

God revealed it through/by the Holy Spirit... (similar to GNT)

God caused the Holy Spirit to reveal...

The Spirit revealed... (similar to GW)

revealed: The verb revealed means the same thing as the verb “made known” in 3:5a. They are synonyms.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

told (CEV)

shown (NCV)

the Spirit: The word Spirit here refers to the Holy Spirit. God revealed his plan to the apostles and prophets by causing the Holy Spirit to reveal it to them. He did it “by the work/power/hand of the Holy Spirit.”

3:5c

to God’s holy apostles and prophets.

- He has shown this to his holy apostles and prophets. -or- to people whom he chose to be Jesus’ sent ones and his spokesmen.

God’s holy apostles and prophets: The word holy modifies both apostles and prophets, not just apostles. It means they were consecrated, set apart and specially chosen for a task. It does not mean that they were pure or sinless. See Holy, Meaning 3 in the Glossary for more information.

God chose certain people to be apostles and prophets, and in this way he set them apart. You could translate this:

the people God especially chose/appointed to be apostles and prophets

In some languages, a translation of this phrase may exclude Paul from the group of apostles and prophets. However, since Paul was an apostle, you should translate this phrase in a way that makes it clear that Paul was part of that group. For example:

us^(excl) who are God’s holy apostles and prophets

apostles: The Greek word that the BSB translates as apostles is literally “sent ones.” See how you translated apostles in 2:20a. For more information see apostle in the Glossary.

prophets: In this context, prophets refer to people in the church who had the ability to speak messages directly from God. See how you translated prophets in 2:20a. See prophet in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 3:6

Section 3:1–13: God sent Paul to preach the good news to the non-Jews

In 3:1, Paul was about to pray for the Christians. Instead, in 3:2 he stopped his sentence and began to write about the special work that God had given him. It was not until 3:14 that Paul resumed his prayer.

The special work that God had given Paul was to preach God’s message to the Gentiles. The blessings of God are for the Gentiles as well as for the Jews, but God had hidden this great truth for a long time. Then God gave Paul the task of telling people about this truth. In this way, everyone would know that God was very wise and loving because he saved both Jews and Gentiles and united them into one church.

Here are some other titles for this section:

God’s mysterious plan revealed (NLT)

Paul’s work in telling the Good News (NCV)

God’s plan to unite Jews and Gentiles in Christ is revealed to Paul

3:6

In this verse, Paul finally explained what God’s mystery/plan is. God’s plan is to call both Gentiles and Jews to be his people and to make them equal partners in the church.

Paul described the relationship between Gentile and Jewish believers by three nouns, all of which have the same prefix “joint,” meaning “together”:

1. joint-heirs: The Gentiles now receive the same blessings from God that the Jews receive. (3:6c)
2. joint-body: Gentiles and Jews are now united in one body, the church. (3:6d)
3. joint-sharers: The promise of salvation God made to the Jews he also made to the Gentiles. (3:6e)

In some languages it may be possible to use similar wording for all three of these. This may help your readers to see the similarity between these terms. For example:

heirs together...members together...sharers together (NIV)

fellow heirs...fellow members...fellow partakers (NET)

have the same inheritance...belong to the same body...share the same promise (GW)

3:6a

This mystery is that

- God's secret plan is this:
- Here is God's hidden plan:

This mystery is that: In order to show that Paul has arrived at his main point, the BSB begins 3:6 with the clause This mystery is that...This is a good model to follow. Other English versions do similar things. For example:

And this is the secret plan... (NLT96)

And the meaning of that hidden/secret talk is this

mystery: The word mystery means "something that has not been explained." This refers to God's plan that was unknown to man in the past. It also occurred in 3:3a and 3:4b.

3:6b

through the gospel

- Because of the gospel,
- By means of your believing the gospel,

through the gospel: The phrase through the gospel is connected to the three clauses:

1. Gentiles and Jews have become joint-heirs,
2. members of the same body and
3. joint-sharers through the gospel.

Some ways to translate through the gospel are:

by means of your believing the gospel

because you believed the gospel

the good news has given (CEV)

See gospel in the Glossary for more information.

General Comment on 3:6b

The BSB has the phrase "through the gospel" at the beginning of 3:6b. However, in the Greek text, the phrase "through the gospel" occurs at the end of 3:6. For example:

This mystery is that the Gentiles are fellow heirs, members of the same body, and partakers of the promise in Christ Jesus through the gospel. (ESV)

Insert this phrase in 3:6 where it would be natural to do so in your language.

3:6c

the Gentiles are fellow heirs,

- the Gentiles will have/receive the same inheritance as the Jews.
- you Gentiles will inherit all God's good things just like the Jews will inherit all God's good things.
- you Gentile believers and the Jewish believers will share all the blessings that God gives as joint heirs.

the Gentiles: Here the word Gentiles refers to people who are not Jews. See how you translated "Gentiles" in 2:11a and 3:1c. Also, see Gentiles, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

are fellow heirs: An "heir" is a person who has the right to inherit things from his parents or other relatives. The phrase fellow heirs is just one word in Greek: "joint-heirs." Some English versions add the implied words "with Israel." Other versions such as GNT say:

with the Jews (GNT)

When Paul says that the Gentiles are joint-heirs, he means that Gentiles believers will have an equal share with Jewish believers in all the good things God has for his children.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

have the same inheritance as Jewish people do (GW)

have a part with the Jews in God's blessings (GNT)

3:6d

fellow members of the body,

- Gentiles and Jews will become like one body,
- You Gentiles and the Jews will become one people,

fellow members of the body: A literal English translation of the Greek is "joint-body." This is a figure of speech. Gentile and Jewish believers are like part of the same body. This implies that they are members of the same group. They are united as one new people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Both are part of the same body (NLT)

They belong to the same body (GW, NCV)

They both are now united as one people

3:6e

and fellow partakers of the promise in Christ Jesus.

- and you Gentiles also share with the Jews that which God promised through Christ Jesus to his people.
- and you share with the Jews the promise of blessings because you belong to Christ Jesus.

fellow partakers of the promise: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as fellow partakers of the promise is literally "joint-sharers of the promise." This means almost the same thing as "fellow heirs" which was used earlier in 3:6c. Both Gentiles and Jews equally share all that God promises and gives to his children. The word promise is singular, and it sums up all that God has promised his people. For example:

promise of blessings (NLT)

in Christ Jesus: The phrase in Christ Jesus means "through Christ Jesus" For example:

the promise that God made through Christ Jesus (GNT)

Through our union with Christ, God's plan has been fulfilled. These words are connected to the preceding words "the promise": God made the promise through Christ Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and share the same promise that God made in Christ Jesus (GW)

both enjoy the promise of blessings because they belong to Christ (NLT)

and share the same promise that God made to us^(incl) because we are united with Christ Jesus

General Comment on 3:6a–e

Here is another way to translate 3:6a–e:

^{6a}That hidden talk is like this: ^{6e}That which God promised to give us^(incl) ^{6b}through the good news of Christ Jesus, ^{6c,e}he didn't just promise us^(excl) Israel people alone, no, he also promised it to you Gentiles, ^{6d}thereby making us^(incl) all into one body.

Ephesians 3:7

Section 3:1–13: God sent Paul to preach the good news to the non-Jews

In 3:1, Paul was about to pray for the Christians. Instead, in 3:2 he stopped his sentence and began to write about the special work that God had given him. It was not until 3:14 that Paul resumed his prayer.

The special work that God had given Paul was to preach God's message to the Gentiles. The blessings of God are for the Gentiles as well as for the Jews, but God had hidden this great truth for a long time. Then God gave Paul the task of telling people about this truth. In this way, everyone would know that God was very wise and loving because he saved both Jews and Gentiles and united them into one church.

Here are some other titles for this section:

God's mysterious plan revealed (NLT)

Paul's work in telling the Good News (NCV)

God's plan to unite Jews and Gentiles in Christ is revealed to Paul

Paragraph 3:7–13

In the previous verses 3:3–6, Paul talked about God's mystery/plan. However, beginning in 3:7, he changed topics. Here he talked about his work preaching the gospel to the Gentiles.

Even though Paul was not one of the twelve apostles, God gave him the work of preaching the gospel to the Gentiles. God intended that through the church, made

up of Jews and Gentiles, all the angels and evil spirits would see his wisdom. So Paul urged the Christians not to be discouraged by the fact that he was suffering in prison. He reminded them that it was for their honor that he was suffering in prison.

3:7a

I became a servant of this gospel by the gift of God's grace, given me

- ¶ God very kindly gave me the work of preaching this gospel,
- ¶ Because God is gracious/kind, he gave me this job of proclaiming the good news.

I became a servant of this gospel: This sentence means that Paul's work was to preach the gospel. In many languages it will not be clear if you translate servant of this gospel literally. You may want to translate it something like this:

Of this gospel I was made a minister (ESV)

My work is to preach the gospel

God gave me the task/responsibility of preaching this gospel

See gospel in the Glossary for more information.

by the gift of God's grace: The gift that Paul was talking about here was the work of an apostle. It was the work of being one of God's servants who proclaimed the gospel. Paul considered it a gift/privilege that God had given him this work. God gave this gift to Paul because of his grace/kindness. See grace, Meaning 2 in the Glossary.

In some languages it is better to use the verb "give" rather than the noun gift, for example:

God in his grace gave me the job of preaching this gospel

God was kind to me and gave me the work of spreading the gospel

God very kindly gave me the task of preaching the Good News

God's grace: God gave this gift to Paul because of his grace/kindness/generosity. See how you translated God's grace in 3:2b.

3:7b

through the working of His power.

- by causing his power to work in me.
- He did this by powerfully working in me.

through the working of His power: Paul had become a preacher of the gospel because God worked in his life and changed him. He changed from being an enemy of Christ's to being a follower of Christ.

Ephesians 3:8

Section 3:1-13: God sent Paul to preach the good news to the non-Jews

In 3:1, Paul was about to pray for the Christians. Instead, in 3:2 he stopped his sentence and began to write about the special work that God had given him. It was not until 3:14 that Paul resumed his prayer.

The special work that God had given Paul was to preach God's message to the Gentiles. The blessings of God are for the Gentiles as well as for the Jews, but God had hidden this great truth for a long time. Then God gave Paul the task of telling people about this truth. In this way, everyone would know that God was very wise and loving because he saved both Jews and Gentiles and united them into one church.

Here are some other titles for this section:

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Paul's work in telling the Good News (NCV)

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Paragraph 3:7-13

In the previous verses 3:3-6, Paul talked about God's mystery/plan. However, beginning in 3:7, he changed topics. Here he talked about his work preaching the gospel to the Gentiles.

Even though Paul was not one of the twelve apostles, God gave him the work of preaching the gospel to the Gentiles. God intended that through the church, made up of Jews and Gentiles, all the angels and evil spirits would see his wisdom. So Paul urged the Christians not to be discouraged by the fact that he was suffering in prison. He reminded them that it was for their honor that he was suffering in prison.

3:8a

Though I am less than the least of all the saints,

- To me, the least deserving of all God's people,
- I am the least important of all God's people.

Though: The BSB has supplied the word *Though* in order to emphasize Paul's amazement that God would choose him to do this task. The Greek text begins 3:8a with an emphatic "To me," as in the RSV. Try to find a natural way in the language to show this emphasis. Some other versions do this by adding "but" or "yet" at the beginning of 3:8b. For example:

I am the least of all God's people. Yet, God showed me his kindness... (GW)

I am the least important of all God's people. But God was kind... (CEV)

I am less than the least: The phrase *less than the least* is a strong statement that means "the very least" or "the most unimportant."

Paul humbly said that he was not important. Try to find a strong expression in your language. Be careful that your translation does not mean that Paul was physically smaller or weaker than other believers. In some languages the correct idea can be expressed by an idiom, such as:

I am behind all God's people

I am lower than all God's people

If your language makes comparisons by contrasting one phrase with another, you may need to translate this phrase in a different way. For example:

All of God's people might have a name, but I have no name, I am underneath everyone.

all the saints: A literal English translation of the Greek is "holy ones." It means "people set apart for God." This Greek word refers to every believer. See how you translated this same expression in 2:19b.

See *Holy*, Meaning 1, special use in the Glossary for more information.

3:8b

this grace was given me:

- this special work was given.
- Nevertheless, God gave me this special job/responsibility

this grace was given me: This clause is a passive. God gave this grace to Paul.

this grace: The meaning of *grace* here is "privilege, special work." Here it refers to Paul's work as an apostle and preacher of the gospel.

The phrase *this grace* is a short way of saying the same thing Paul just said in 3:7a: "This work of preaching the gospel that God in his grace gave me."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he graciously gave me the privilege (NLT)

God showed me his kindness by allowing me (GW)

See *grace*, Meaning 4 in the Glossary for more information.

3:8c

to preach to the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ,

- This special work is to announce to the Gentiles about the riches of Christ which are too great to understand.
- of preaching to the Gentiles about the good things which Christ gives. These good things are greater than people can understand.

to preach: The word *preach* means to publicly tell or announce a message. See how you translated "preached" in 2:17a.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

to announce

to declare publicly

to the Gentiles: Here the word *Gentiles* refers to people who are not Jews. See how you translated *Gentiles* in 3:6c.

unsearchable riches of Christ: The word *unsearchable* means "too great/big to be understood or imagined."

riches of Christ: The phrase *riches of Christ* refers to the spiritual blessings of Christ, not just to material wealth. These spiritual riches may refer to:

1. riches which Christ gives. For example:

endless treasures available to them in Christ (NLT)

1. riches which Christ possesses, that is, his divine glory and perfection.

Most versions use words that could be understood either way. If you must choose, follow interpretation (1).

In your translation, avoid any word that refers only to material wealth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

immeasurable wealth of Christ (GW)

because of Christ there are blessings that cannot be measured (CEV)

the riches of Christ, which are too great to understand fully (NCV)

The unimaginable blessings of Christ

Also, see how you translated riches in 1:7c and 1:18c.

Ephesians 3:9

Section 3:1–13: God sent Paul to preach the good news to the non-Jews

In 3:1, Paul was about to pray for the Christians. Instead, in 3:2 he stopped his sentence and began to write about the special work that God had given him. It was not until 3:14 that Paul resumed his prayer.

The special work that God had given Paul was to preach God's message to the Gentiles. The blessings of God are for the Gentiles as well as for the Jews, but God had hidden this great truth for a long time. Then God gave Paul the task of telling people about this truth. In this way, everyone would know that God was very wise and loving because he saved both Jews and Gentiles and united them into one church.

Here are some other titles for this section:

God's mysterious plan revealed (NLT)

Paul's work in telling the Good News (NCV)

God's plan to unite Jews and Gentiles in Christ is revealed to Paul

Paragraph 3:7–13

In the previous verses 3:3–6, Paul talked about God's mystery/plan. However, beginning in 3:7, he changed topics. Here he talked about his work preaching the gospel to the Gentiles.

Even though Paul was not one of the twelve apostles, God gave him the work of preaching the gospel to the Gentiles. God intended that through the church, made up of Jews and Gentiles, all the angels and evil spirits would see his wisdom. So Paul urged the Christians not to be discouraged by the fact that he was suffering in prison. He reminded them that it was for their honor that he was suffering in prison.

3:9a

and to illuminate for everyone the stewardship of this mystery,

- He also gave me the work of explaining to all people how he would accomplish his plan.
- And God chose me to explain to all people how he will accomplish his secret plan.

and: Notice the word and at the beginning of 3:9. God gave Paul two things to do:

1. preach the gospel to the Gentiles (3:8b) and
2. explain how God will accomplish his plan (3:9a).

to illuminate: Some other ways to say to illuminate are:

explain (as in GW and NLT)

help everyone understand (CEV)

the stewardship of this mystery: The Greek word which the BSB translates as stewardship refers to how something is put into effect, accomplished, administered or caused to be done. For example:

how God's secret plan is to be put into effect (GNT)

the way people/someone will accomplish God's hidden plan

See how you translated "administration of God's grace" in 3:2b.

mystery: The word mystery in this context means "something that was formerly unknown to people but has recently been revealed or explained." See how you translated it in 3:3a, 3:4b, and 3:6a.

3:9b

which for ages past was kept hidden in God, who created all things.

- God, who created all things, kept this plan hidden from the eyes of men formerly.

- From the very beginning when God created everything until now, he had not revealed this plan to anyone.

which: The word which refers back to “the mystery” that Paul just mentioned.

for ages past: The phrase for ages past refers to all of past time, including all the time before God created the world. In all that time, God had not revealed his plan to anyone. But now he had revealed it clearly to Paul and the other apostles and prophets.

Some other ways this phrase has been translated include:

through all the past ages (GNT)

from the beginning (NLT)

since the beginning of time (NCV)

was kept hidden in God: The phrase was kept hidden in God is a figure of speech. Its meaning here is “God kept it hidden from people”

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

was kept secret by God

God never revealed it to anyone before

It is also passive. Some ways to make this active are:

God kept his plan hidden from people

He kept his plan to himself, in his own heart

He did not tell anyone about it.

who created all things: Consider what is the best way to translate this clause in your language:

- literally, as a relative clause (“God who created...”) This is how the BSB and many other English versions have translated it.
- as an independent clause (“God created...”). For example:

God created everything

If you translate it as a relative clause, the reader must not think that it means that there is more than one God. It does not mean that there are two Gods: one God who created all things, and another God who did not create all things.

General Comment on 3:9b

In Greek the phrase “who created all things” occurs at the end of 3:9b, however many English versions have moved this clause to the beginning of 3:9b. For example:

God, who is the Creator of all things, kept his secret hidden through all the past ages (GNT)

God, the Creator of all things, had kept secret from the beginning (NLT)

God, the one who created everything

Place this phrase in 3:9 where it would be most natural to occur.

Ephesians 3:10

Section 3:1–13: God sent Paul to preach the good news to the non-Jews

In 3:1, Paul was about to pray for the Christians. Instead, in 3:2 he stopped his sentence and began to write about the special work that God had given him. It was not until 3:14 that Paul resumed his prayer.

The special work that God had given Paul was to preach God’s message to the Gentiles. The blessings of God are for the Gentiles as well as for the Jews, but God had hidden this great truth for a long time. Then God gave Paul the task of telling people about this truth. In this way, everyone would know that God was very wise and loving because he saved both Jews and Gentiles and united them into one church.

Here are some other titles for this section:

God’s mysterious plan revealed (NLT)

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Paragraph 3:7–13

In the previous verses 3:3–6, Paul talked about God’s mystery/plan. However, beginning in 3:7, he changed

topics. Here he talked about his work preaching the gospel to the Gentiles.

Even though Paul was not one of the twelve apostles, God gave him the work of preaching the gospel to the Gentiles. God intended that through the church, made up of Jews and Gentiles, all the angels and evil spirits would see his wisdom. So Paul urged the Christians not to be discouraged by the fact that he was suffering in prison. He reminded them that it was for their honor that he was suffering in prison.

3:10a

His purpose was that now, through the church,

- His purpose was to now use the church
- God's purpose was to now show all the angels and evil spirits

His purpose was that now: In the Greek text, 3:10 begins with a conjunction often translated as “so that” or “in order that.” It is the Greek conjunction “hina.” This conjunction shows that 3:10 is the purpose of 3:8–9. For example:

3:8b this grace was given me: 3:8c to preach to the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ, 3:9a and to illuminate for everyone the stewardship of this mystery...

3:10 in order that...the manifold wisdom of God should be made known to the rulers and authorities...

English versions frequently translate this conjunction as “in order that” or “so that.” For example:

in order that at the present time (GNT)

The BSB and other versions have tried to make the connection clearer by translating this conjunction with a clause. Some other ways that English versions translate this conjunction are:

God's purpose in all this was... (NLT)

He did this so that now... (GW)

through the church: The phrase through the church refers to the church as the means by which the rulers and authorities would come to know God's wisdom. For example:

God's purpose in all this was to use the church to display his wisdom in its rich variety to all the unseen rulers and authorities in the heavenly places. (NLT)

church: The word church refers to all believers in Christ throughout the world. In the New Testament, the word church never refers to a building. See how you translated church in 1:22b. See church in the Glossary for more information.

3:10b

the manifold wisdom of God should be made known to the rulers and authorities in the heavenly realms,

- to make known his many kinds of wisdom to all the spirit beings who rule and have authority in the unseen world.
- how wise he is in everything. God uses the church as an example of this,

the manifold wisdom of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as manifold literally means “many-sided,” or “very varied.” So the phrase manifold wisdom means that God is “wise in all ways.” He is not just wise in one area.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

his infinite wisdom (GW)

he has many different kinds of wisdom (CEV)

God's wisdom, which has so many forms (NCV)

God is very wise in everything he does

should be made known: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as should be made known is a passive. If it would be more natural in your language to make this active, you can:

- supply God as the agent. For example:

God/he should make known

- supply God as the agent and translate the verb as “show.” For example:

God's purpose was to show his wisdom (NLT96)

- make rulers and authorities the subject. For example:

the rulers and powers in the heavenly world will now know God's wisdom (NCV)

to the rulers and authorities: The words rulers and authorities can refer to either:

1. human beings who rule on earth or
2. spirit beings who rule in the heavens

In this context with the phrase "in the heavenly realms" that follows, these words refer to spirit beings. These beings are good angels and evil spirits. These are probably the same spiritual powers Paul talked about in 1:21a.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

angelic rulers and powers (GNT)

unseen rulers and authorities (NLT)

in the heavenly realms: The phrase the heavenly realms refers to the area above the earth where the spirits were thought to live. This does not refer to heaven where God is.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the heavenly world (GNT)

in the heavenly places (NLT)

in the spiritual world (CEV)

General Comment on 3:10a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to put the phrase "through the church" in 3:10a at the end of 3:10b. See the second meaning line for these verses for an example.

Ephesians 3:11

Section 3:1–13: God sent Paul to preach the good news to the non-Jews

In 3:1, Paul was about to pray for the Christians. Instead, in 3:2 he stopped his sentence and began to write about the special work that God had given him. It was not until 3:14 that Paul resumed his prayer.

The special work that God had given Paul was to preach God's message to the Gentiles. The blessings of God are for the Gentiles as well as for the Jews, but God had hidden this great truth for a long time. Then God gave Paul the task of telling people about this truth. In this way, everyone would know that God

was very wise and loving because he saved both Jews and Gentiles and united them into one church.

Here are some other titles for this section:

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God's plan to unite Jews and Gentiles in Christ is revealed to Paul

Paragraph 3:7–13

In the previous verses 3:3–6, Paul talked about God's mystery/plan. However, beginning in 3:7, he changed topics. Here he talked about his work preaching the gospel to the Gentiles.

Even though Paul was not one of the twelve apostles, God gave him the work of preaching the gospel to the Gentiles. God intended that through the church, made up of Jews and Gentiles, all the angels and evil spirits would see his wisdom. So Paul urged the Christians not to be discouraged by the fact that he was suffering in prison. He reminded them that it was for their honor that he was suffering in prison.

3:11a

according to the eternal purpose

- God planned/decided to do this before he made the world,
- just as he always planned to do.

It may be better to begin a new sentence here. For example:

God did this according to his eternal purpose.
(GNT)

The word "this" in the GNT (and in the Display of 3:11a) refers to 3:9b–10b. That is, it refers to God's plan to save mankind, both Gentiles and Jews.

according to the eternal purpose: Here the word eternal refers primarily to the past not the future. So the phrase eternal purpose means that God had planned (to save Gentiles and Jews) from eternity past or from the beginning. He planned it before he created the world.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

eternal plan (NLT)

God's plan for all of history (GW)

the purpose God had since the beginning of time
(NCV)

3:11b

that He accomplished in Christ Jesus our Lord.

- and he did/achieved it through Christ Jesus our Lord.
- Now he has caused it to happen by means of what Christ Jesus our supreme Master has done.

that He accomplished in Christ Jesus our Lord: The word accomplished means “to get something done.” God accomplished or achieved his plan through Christ Jesus.

in Christ Jesus our Lord: Another way to express this is that God accomplished his plan by means of what Christ has done.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because of all that Christ Jesus our Lord had done
(CEV)

which he carried out through Christ Jesus our Lord
(NLT)

Ephesians 3:12

Section 3:1–13: God sent Paul to preach the good news to the non-Jews

In 3:1, Paul was about to pray for the Christians. Instead, in 3:2 he stopped his sentence and began to write about the special work that God had given him. It was not until 3:14 that Paul resumed his prayer.

The special work that God had given Paul was to preach God’s message to the Gentiles. The blessings of God are for the Gentiles as well as for the Jews, but God had hidden this great truth for a long time. Then God gave Paul the task of telling people about this truth. In this way, everyone would know that God was very wise and loving because he saved both Jews and Gentiles and united them into one church.

Here are some other titles for this section:

God’s mysterious plan revealed (NLT)

Paul’s work in telling the Good News (NCV)

God’s plan to unite Jews and Gentiles in Christ is revealed to Paul

Paragraph 3:7–13

In the previous verses 3:3–6, Paul talked about God’s mystery/plan. However, beginning in 3:7, he changed topics. Here he talked about his work preaching the gospel to the Gentiles.

Even though Paul was not one of the twelve apostles, God gave him the work of preaching the gospel to the Gentiles. God intended that through the church, made up of Jews and Gentiles, all the angels and evil spirits would see his wisdom. So Paul urged the Christians not to be discouraged by the fact that he was suffering in prison. He reminded them that it was for their honor that he was suffering in prison.

3:12a

In Him and through faith in Him

- In union with Christ and through faith in him
- Because we believe in Christ and are united with him,

In Him and through faith in Him: The pronoun Him refers to Christ. See how you translated in Him at 2:22a.

One way to show how this phrase is connected to the rest of the verse is with the word “because.” For example:

Because we are united with Christ and because we believe in him

Because of our close relationship with Christ and because we believe in him

faith: The word faith refers here to the action of people trusting and believing in Jesus. See how you translated faith in 1:15b and 2:8a. See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

3:12b

we may enter God’s presence with boldness and confidence.

- we may be bold and approach God with confidence.
- we can go to God confidently and without fear.

we may enter God’s presence: The clause we may enter God’s presence refers to believers praying to God and worshipping him; they approach him or “enter into his presence.” (Paul was not talking here about entering into God’s presence in heaven after we die.)

enter: The Greek word which the BSB translates as the verb enter is literally “we have...access.” This same Greek word was translated as “access” in 2:18. It means that we have the ability and right to enter

God's presence. As in 2:18, it is best in many languages to translate this phrase as a verb. For example:

go into God's presence (GNT)

we can come before God (NCV)

with boldness and confidence: The words the BSB has translated as boldness and confidence have a similar meaning. Moore in his book "Doublets in the New Testament" classifies "freedom" (boldness) and "confidence" as near synonymous doublets. In this context, they are so close in meaning that they may be translated as a single noun with an adjective to strengthen it. For example:

bold confidence (GW)

boldness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as boldness is literally "boldness." It means that believers do not have to be afraid when they pray to God or worship him.

confidence: The word confidence means to have "complete trust; belief in one's own or another's ability." In this context, it is similar in meaning to "boldness" and strengthens it.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

without fear (NCV)

trust

General Comment on 3:12a–b

In some languages, it will be more natural to reverse the order of 3:12a and 3:12b. For example:

^{12b}We can go to God confidently and without fear

^{12a}because we believe in Christ and are united with him.

In some languages, it might be more natural to make separate clauses out of the phrases "In Him" and "through faith in him." For example:

Through the work of Christ we^(incl) can go close to God. Because we have believed in Jesus he has opened the way so we do not fear, we can go close to God.

Ephesians 3:13

Section 3:1–13: God sent Paul to preach the good news to the non-Jews

In 3:1, Paul was about to pray for the Christians. Instead, in 3:2 he stopped his sentence and began to write about the special work that God had given him. It was not until 3:14 that Paul resumed his prayer.

The special work that God had given Paul was to preach God's message to the Gentiles. The blessings of God are for the Gentiles as well as for the Jews, but God had hidden this great truth for a long time. Then God gave Paul the task of telling people about this truth. In this way, everyone would know that God was very wise and loving because he saved both Jews and Gentiles and united them into one church.

Here are some other titles for this section:

God's mysterious plan revealed (NLT)

Paul's work in telling the Good News (NCV)

God's plan to unite Jews and Gentiles in Christ is revealed to Paul

Paragraph 3:7–13

In the previous verses 3:3–6, Paul talked about God's mystery/plan. However, beginning in 3:7, he changed topics. Here he talked about his work preaching the gospel to the Gentiles.

Even though Paul was not one of the twelve apostles, God gave him the work of preaching the gospel to the Gentiles. God intended that through the church, made up of Jews and Gentiles, all the angels and evil spirits would see his wisdom. So Paul urged the Christians not to be discouraged by the fact that he was suffering in prison. He reminded them that it was for their honor that he was suffering in prison.

3:13a

So I ask you not to be discouraged because of my sufferings for you,

- Because of this, I ask you not to be discouraged that I am suffering for you.
- And so, I request that you not feel discouraged when you hear how I am suffering for preaching the gospel to you Gentiles.

So I ask you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a So is the conjunction that is often translated as "therefore." Some other versions place this conjunction after I ask you because it is good English style.

You should place it in this sentence where it is most natural in your language.

So: The conjunction So refers back to what Paul has said in 3:2–12. So, Paul made his request here based on what he had said in 3:2–12: “So since God has given me this wonderful job of preaching to you Gentiles, and since you Gentiles who believe have many blessings, I request...”

Some English versions do not translate this word So. However, here are some other ways to translate this word:

then (GNT)

therefore (NIV)

For this reason (NET)

You should translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

I ask you: Some other ways to say I ask you are:

I request...

I urge that you please...

I want you to

not to be discouraged: To be discouraged means “to cause to lose heart” or “to give up.” For example:

do not lose heart (NLT)

do not give up

If your language has an idiom that means to be discouraged, you should consider using it here.

because of my sufferings for you: Paul was in prison and was suffering for preaching the gospel to the Ephesians and other Gentiles. The Ephesian Christians might have become discouraged when they heard this, so Paul asked them not to be discouraged.

Just how Paul was suffering was not made explicit. It was probably physical and spiritual. Your translation should be in a general sense that includes all kinds of suffering.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

when I suffer for you (CEV)

by the troubles I suffer for you (GW)

3:13b

which are your glory.

- Instead, you should be proud of this.
- After all, it will bring honor to you. (CEV)

which are your glory: There are two ways to interpret the clause which are your glory here:

1. It gives a reason for the Ephesians to feel proud. They should be proud that Paul was willing to be imprisoned for the gospel, For example:

you should feel honored (NLT)

1. It is for the benefit or good of the Ephesians. For example,

it is all for your benefit (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

glory: Here glory refers to “honor.” Honor came to the Ephesians because Paul was willing to suffer imprisonment for preaching to them and other Gentiles. See how you translated glory in 1:12b and 1:14c. See glory, Meaning 3 in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 3:14

Section 3:14–21: Paul prayed again for the believers at Ephesus

In this section, Paul resumed his prayer for the Ephesian Christians. He asked God to strengthen them by the Holy Spirit so that Christ could live in them. He prayed that they would love each other, and that they would know how much Christ loved them, even though he loved them more than people could understand. Paul finished his prayer by praising God for his great power.

Here are some other titles for this section:

Paul prayed that God would strengthen the Ephesians

Paul’s prayer for spiritual strength and love for the Ephesians

Paragraph 3:14–19

In this paragraph Paul prayed the prayer he almost began in 3:1. (See the note at 3:1.) He began this paragraph with the words “for this reason” which are the same words he used at the beginning of 3:1. The BSB indicates this connection by using ellipses here (as it did in 3:1).

3:14

...for this reason I bow my knees before the Father,

- ¶ This is the reason I kneel before God the/our Father.
- ¶ Because God the Father has done all this for you, I kneel before him to/and pray for you.

for this reason: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for this reason introduces Paul’s response to all that he had said in chapter 2 and his expansion on part of chapter 2 in 3:1–13. The idea is this:

As I think of God’s great plan, this is the reason

When I think of all that God has done, this is the reason

When I think of the wisdom and scope of God’s plan, I fall to my knees... (NLT96)

See how you translated this phrase in 3:1a.

I bow my knees before the Father: The phrase bow my knees refers to the way Jewish people prayed to God. They bowed down on their knees instead of standing up. So in this context, bow my knees represents the act of praying. You may need to complete the thought. For example:

I kneel...and pray for you before the Father.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I fall to my knees and pray to the Father (NLT)

I bow in prayer before the Father (NCV)

I pray to the Father

the Father: It should be clear in your translation that this is a reference to God, the Father. One way to make this clear in the translation is:

I pray to our^(incl) heavenly Father

Ephesians 3:15**Section 3:14–21: Paul prayed again for the believers at Ephesus**

In this section, Paul resumed his prayer for the Ephesian Christians. He asked God to strengthen them by the Holy Spirit so that Christ could live in them. He prayed that they would love each other, and that they would know how much Christ loved them, even though he loved them more than people could understand. Paul finished his prayer by praising God for his great power.

Here are some other titles for this section:

Paul prayed that God would strengthen the Ephesians

Paul’s prayer for spiritual strength and love for the Ephesians

Paragraph 3:14–19

In this paragraph Paul prayed the prayer he almost began in 3:1. (See the note at 3:1.) He began this paragraph with the words “for this reason” which are the same words he used at the beginning of 3:1. The BSB indicates this connection by using ellipses here (as it did in 3:1).

3:15

from whom every family in heaven and on earth derives its name.

- He is the one who causes all families to exist, both those in heaven and also those on earth.
- He created all nations/clans/orders of beings in heaven and on earth.

from whom every family in heaven and on earth derives its name: The phrase from whom refers back to God the Father in 3:14. God is the one from whom each family in heaven and on earth derives its name.

whom: In the BSB, whom refers to God. (See the discussion on “whole family” below.)

every family: The Greek word that the BSB translates as every generally means “all.” So there is an interpretation issue here. This phrase can mean:

1. each or every family. For example:

...from whom every family in heaven and on the earth is named. (NET) (BSB, GNT, RSV, NET, NASB, REB, NCV, ESV) According to this interpretation,

the phrase translated as every family refers to human beings as well as angels.

1. every family. For example:

Of whom the whole family in heaven and earth is named. (KJV) (NIV, KJV, GW) According to this interpretation, the phrase translated as every family refers to the whole family of believers: both those in heaven and those on earth.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of versions.

family in heaven and on earth: The phrase family in heaven and on earth is a figure of speech. The phrase in heaven refers to angels (beings who are spiritual or in heaven). The phrase on earth refers to humans (beings who are on earth).

The angels and humans are referred to as belonging to families. Here the word family refers to extended families like “clans” or “races,” or even “nations” of people. (It does not refer to the more common meaning of family consisting of a father, mother and their children.)

Since angels are not normally considered to be in families, the word family may cause some problems. For examples of ways to translate the phrase family in heaven and on earth, see below.

derives its name: The phrase derives its name is a figurative way to say that God gives every heavenly being and every human being its life and character. He is the Creator of everything in heaven and earth. He causes every group to exist.

Be careful to avoid a translation that gives the impression that God has given every family its surname.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

the Creator of everything in heaven and on earth (NLT)

All beings in heaven and on earth receive their life from him. (CEV)

Ephesians 3:16

Section 3:14–21: Paul prayed again for the believers at Ephesus

In this section, Paul resumed his prayer for the Ephesian Christians. He asked God to strengthen them by the Holy Spirit so that Christ could live in them. He

prayed that they would love each other, and that they would know how much Christ loved them, even though he loved them more than people could understand. Paul finished his prayer by praising God for his great power.

Here are some other titles for this section:

Paul prayed that God would strengthen the Ephesians

Paul’s prayer for spiritual strength and love for the Ephesians

Paragraph 3:14–19

In this paragraph Paul prayed the prayer he almost began in 3:1. (See the note at 3:1.) He began this paragraph with the words “for this reason” which are the same words he used at the beginning of 3:1. The BSB indicates this connection by using ellipses here (as it did in 3:1).

3:16

Verses 3:16–19 are the contents of Paul’s prayer. Be sure that this is clear in your translation. Another way to introduce the contents of this prayer is:

I ask God... (GNT)

3:16a

I ask that out of the riches of His glory

- I pray that from the unlimited resources of his glory,
- I ask God that he will help you out of the wealth of what he has in glory

I ask that: The words I ask are not in the original Greek. The BSB (and many other English versions) has added them here, and in 3:17c, to make the translation clearer.

out of the riches of His glory: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as out of the riches of His glory is literally “according to the wealth of the glory of him.” Both “wealth” and “glory” refer here to God’s unlimited resources, to everything he has and is. He is infinite in his goodness, power, and love. See glory, Meaning 4 in the Glossary.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

from his glorious, unlimited resources (NLT)

from the wealth of his glory (GNT)

Because this is Paul's prayer to God, it may be more natural to use direct speech here. For example:

I pray to God for you like this, "God, from out of the many many things you^(sg) have"...

3:16b

He may strengthen you with power through His Spirit in your inner being,

- his Spirit may give you power, so your hearts may be strong,
- so that by his Spirit you will have great inward strength.

He may strengthen you with power: The phrase He may expresses Paul's wish for the Ephesians. It is what he wanted for the Ephesians. It does not express doubt in his thinking.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he will (NLT)

he would (GW)

strengthen you with power: The words strengthen and power are a doublet. The Greek language uses doublets to emphasize an idea.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

I pray that he will mightily empower you

I pray that he will give you power so you will be spiritually strong

through His Spirit: It should be clear in your translation that this is a reference to the Holy Spirit. Some other ways to translate this are:

by means of His Holy Spirit

his Spirit will make you (CEV)

inner being: The inner being includes the heart, mind, will and spirit of a person. It is similar to "heart" in 3:17.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your inner selves (GNT)

the inner person (NET)

inwardly (NCV)

inner minds

General Comment on 3:16

Here is how to translate 3:16 using direct speech:

God, I pray, "Take the many many things you have and send them through your Spirit so that the peoples' inside minds might be strengthened and made strong."

Ephesians 3:17

Section 3:14–21: Paul prayed again for the believers at Ephesus

In this section, Paul resumed his prayer for the Ephesian Christians. He asked God to strengthen them by the Holy Spirit so that Christ could live in them. He prayed that they would love each other, and that they would know how much Christ loved them, even though he loved them more than people could understand. Paul finished his prayer by praising God for his great power.

Here are some other titles for this section:

Paul prayed that God would strengthen the Ephesians

Paul's prayer for spiritual strength and love for the Ephesians

Paragraph 3:14–19

In this paragraph Paul prayed the prayer he almost began in 3:1. (See the note at 3:1.) He began this paragraph with the words "for this reason" which are the same words he used at the beginning of 3:1. The BSB indicates this connection by using ellipses here (as it did in 3:1).

3:17a

so that Christ may dwell in your hearts

- and that Christ may live/dwell permanently in your hearts
- And I pray that Christ will live in your hearts

so that Christ may dwell in your hearts: There are different views about how this clause is related to 3:16.

1. It is a second request that Paul prays for. So dwell is parallel with "strengthen," that is, "I pray that God will strengthen you...and I pray that Christ may dwell...." For example,

I pray that Christ will live in your hearts (NCV)
(GNT, NCV, NLT, CEV)

1. It is the purpose or result of what Paul prays in 3:16:
“I pray that God will strengthen you...so that Christ will dwell....” For example,

so that Christ may live in your hearts (BSB, NIV,
NJB, NET, NASB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), though both interpretations have strong support.

dwell in your hearts: The verb dwell has the meaning of “live permanently,” “settle down.”

in your hearts: In the New Testament, the word “heart” refers figuratively to the whole inner life of a person. It includes the mind, will, and emotions. You should use the expression in your language that refers to the inner part of man. In some languages people say ‘mind,’ ‘throat,’ ‘liver,’ or ‘stomach.’

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Christ will make his home in your hearts (NLT)

and I pray that Christ will make his home in your hearts (GNT)

I also pray that Christ may control your whole/
inner being

3:17b through faith.

- through your^(plur) faith in him.
- as you^(plur) trust in him. (NLT)
- because you^(plur) believe in him.

through faith: The phrase through faith means “because you believe in Christ.” See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

as you trust in him (NLT)

because you believe in him

because of your faith (CEV)

General Comment on 3:17a–b

In some languages, it may be natural to change the order of 17a–b. For example:

I pray that ^{17b}through your believing, ^{17a}Christ would come and live in your inside stomachs.

3:17c

Then you, being rooted and grounded in love,

- The way you love God and each other will make you firm and keep you from falling. So I pray that you
- When you love God and each other you are strong like a tree whose roots go into the earth, and like a house built on a strong foundation. So I pray that you

Some English versions add the words “And I pray that” here, and in 3:16a, to make the translation clearer. See how you translated this clause in 3:16a and then decide if it would be natural in your language to translate it here.

being rooted and grounded in love: The words rooted and grounded are both metaphors referring to “strength.” The word rooted refers to the roots of a tree holding the tree steady. The word grounded refers to the foundation of a house making the house firm. The roots of a tree hold the tree steady, and the foundation of a house makes the house established/firm. In the same way, love makes Christians strong.

When you translate these words you may need to:

- translate the meaning directly. For example:

love will make you strong and keep you from falling

- translate the metaphors as similes. For example:

love is like the roots which make a tree stand firm
or like the foundation on which a house stands

Both possibilities are shown in the Display. You should choose the option that is most natural in your language.

in love: There is an interpretation issue here. Scholars do not agree about what Paul meant here. There are two possibilities:

1. Paul wrote about both our love for God and our love for other people.
2. Paul wrote about God’s love for us (as in 3:18–19b). (CEV, NLT)

Both interpretations make sense. As we come to love God and others, and as we learn how much God loves us, that love makes our hearts strong. You may want to follow your national translation in deciding which interpretation to choose.

The Display follows interpretation (a). If you want to follow interpretation (b), you could say:

I pray that you will come to really know how much God loves you, so this will make you firm and keep you from falling.

Ephesians 3:18

Section 3:14–21: Paul prayed again for the believers at Ephesus

In this section, Paul resumed his prayer for the Ephesian Christians. He asked God to strengthen them by the Holy Spirit so that Christ could live in them. He prayed that they would love each other, and that they would know how much Christ loved them, even though he loved them more than people could understand. Paul finished his prayer by praising God for his great power.

Here are some other titles for this section:

Paul prayed that God would strengthen the Ephesians

Paul's prayer for spiritual strength and love for the Ephesians

Paragraph 3:14–19

In this paragraph Paul prayed the prayer he almost began in 3:1. (See the note at 3:1.) He began this paragraph with the words “for this reason” which are the same words he used at the beginning of 3:1. The BSB indicates this connection by using ellipses here (as it did in 3:1).

3:18–19a

In 3:18–19a, Paul prayed about two things regarding God's love.

He prayed that:

1. the Ephesians would be able to understand that Christ's love is very, very great (3:18),

and he prayed that:

1. the Ephesians would know Christ's love (3:19b).

3:18a–b

will have power...to comprehend: The clause will have power...to comprehend means “that you may

have the ability to understand/know” or “that you may be able to understand.”

3:18a

will have power, together with all the saints,

- and all God's people will be able to know how much Christ loves us.
- and all God's people will be able to understand

together with all the saints: The word saints means “people set apart for God.” See the note on 1:15c for more information and Holy, Meaning 1, special use in the Glossary.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

so that you, together with all God's people, may have the power to understand (GNT)

This way, with all of God's people you will be able to understand (GW)

So that all of you believers will strongly recognize/realize

3:18b

to comprehend the length and width and height and depth

- He loves us very greatly, without limit.
- that Christ loves us more than we can describe.

the length and width and height and depth: The phrase length and width and height and depth is a figure of speech that compares love to an object that we can see and measure. It means that Christ's love is “very, very great.”

It may be difficult in your language to speak of love being wide and long. So, in that case, think how you would describe love that is extremely great. For example:

love which has no end/limits

love which we can never measure

we can never finish describing how much he loves us

Ephesians 3:19

Section 3:14–21: Paul prayed again for the believers at Ephesus

In this section, Paul resumed his prayer for the Ephesian Christians. He asked God to strengthen them by the Holy Spirit so that Christ could live in them. He prayed that they would love each other, and that they would know how much Christ loved them, even though he loved them more than people could understand. Paul finished his prayer by praising God for his great power.

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3:19a

of the love of Christ, and to know this love that surpasses knowledge,

- I pray that you will know this love which is beyond human comprehension,
- Even though no one can completely know how much Christ loves us, I pray that you will know/experience it.

As mentioned above, verse 3:19a is the second part of Paul's prayer about love.

love of Christ: Here, the phrase love of Christ means “Christ's love for believers.” See love, meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

and to know this love that surpasses knowledge:

The clause and to know this love that surpasses knowledge may seem to contradict itself. Generally, people cannot know something that surpasses knowledge. People cannot know something that is beyond knowing. But that is Paul's prayer here. Paul used this statement to emphasize that human beings can never completely know or understand how much Christ loves them but they can experience that love.

know this love: The phrase know this love refers to experiencing Christ's love. It is more than simply knowing about Christ's love. It means that believers have experienced or seen how much Christ loves them.

surpasses knowledge: The phrase surpasses knowledge means “beyond knowing.” Christ's love is so great that people cannot completely know or understand it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

May you experience the love of Christ, though it is so great you will never fully understand it. (NLT96)

I want you to know all about Christ's love, although it is too wonderful to be measured. (CEV)

General Comment on 3:18b–19a

In the BSB, the phrase “of the love of Christ” is placed at the beginning of verse 19. However, in some other English translations, such as the NIV, this phrase is placed at the end of verse 18b. In some languages, it may be helpful to combine or reorder 3:18b–19a to create simpler sentences. See the meaning lines in 3:18b–19a for different ideas of how to translate these verse parts.

General Comment on 3:19a

Some English versions have a “—” at the end of 3:19a. This is to show the reader that what follows, 3:19b, is a comment inserted here by Paul. Other English versions, like the BSB, do not do this, so it is recommended that you do not use a “—” at the end of this verse part.

3:19b

that you may be filled with all the fullness of God.

- so that God may fill you with his nature/character.
- I pray this so that your character may become like God's character.
- I pray this, so that you will become complete/mature in every way, just as God is.

that you may be filled with all the fullness of God:

3:19b is the purpose of Paul's prayer in 3:17 and 18. Here is a summary of these verses:

(3:17a) I pray that Christ will live in your hearts...
and

(3:18–19a) I pray that you will know Christ's love

(3:19b) so that you may be completely filled with God's character

filled with all the fullness of God: The clause filled with all the fullness of God means:

completely filled with the very nature of God (GNT)

The words filled and fullness are figures of speech. To be full of God's fullness means to have character qualities that are completely like his. Paul prayed that the Ephesians would be the kind of people God wants them to be. He prayed that they would be mature, loving and wise, with strong faith, peace, joy and all the other characteristics God wants to give them.

In some languages it is not natural to use the verb "fill" when referring to "character." If that is the case in your language, you can leave out the figure of being filled and translate the meaning directly. For example:

I pray this so that you may become completely like God in your character.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and so be completely filled with the very nature of God (GNT)

Then you will be made complete with all the fullness of life and power that comes from God (NLT)

Ephesians 3:20

Section 3:14–21: Paul prayed again for the believers at Ephesus

In this section, Paul resumed his prayer for the Ephesian Christians. He asked God to strengthen them by the Holy Spirit so that Christ could live in them. He prayed that they would love each other, and that they would know how much Christ loved them, even though he loved them more than people could understand. Paul finished his prayer by praising God for his great power.

Here are some other titles for this section:

Paul prayed that God would strengthen the Ephesians

Paul's prayer for spiritual strength and love for the Ephesians

Paragraph 3:20–21

This paragraph is a "doxology" or song of praise to God. Paul was expressing his praise for God in a very strong way.

It may be necessary to begin this paragraph with a phrase taken from 3:21. For example:

Let us glorify/praise God

May God be praised

Praise God

That God's name would be huge

3:20a

Now to Him

- ¶ Let us glorify/praise God
- ¶ Praise God.

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now simply connects 3:20 to the preceding verses. It is not a time word. Some of the more modern English versions do not translate it.

to Him: The pronoun Him refers to God. Even though Paul did not mention God by name, you may want to say "God" explicitly in your translation. For example:

Glory belongs to God (GW)

3:20b

who is able to do so much more

- who is able to do so much more than all the things
- He has power to do things which are very much greater

who is able to do so much more: The Greek word that the BSB translated as so much more literally means "super-abundantly above." So, the clause who is able to do so much more means that God has power to do much, much more than we can ever ask of him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

who can do far more

He has power to do immeasurably more

3:20c

than all we ask or imagine,

- that we ask him to do, or think that he can do.
- than anything we request from him or we can ever even imagine is possible.

than all we ask or imagine: Paul is saying that God is able to do infinitely more than he or the Ephesians could ask or think to ask.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

than we could possibly think of to ask

than is even possible to request or even think of

General Comment on 3:20

Commentators are divided over whether Paul was referring to his requests in 3:16–19 or to requests in general.

Translations leave the reference here ambiguous and it is recommended that you translate this verse the same way.

3:20d

according to His power that is at work within us,

- He does all this by his power which is working/acting in our hearts.
- He can do this because he is working powerfully/mightily in us.

according to His power that is at work within us:

God does more than people can ask or think. He does this according to or by the power of his Holy Spirit who works in the hearts of his people.

In some languages it may not be possible to say that God's power "works" in us. You may have to say that God's power "acts" or "moves" in us. Use whichever verb goes with power. Or you may have to say that God is working powerfully/mightily in us.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Now all glory to God, who is able, through his mighty power at work within us, to accomplish infinitely more than we might ask or think. (NLT)

To him who by means of his power working in us is able to do so much more than we can ever ask for, or even think of: (GNT)

General Comment on 3:20a–d

It may be more natural in your language to change the order of 3:20a–d. For example:

^{20a}Glory belongs to God, ^{20d}whose power is at work in us. ^{20b–c}By this power he can do infinitely more than we can ask or imagine (GW)

Ephesians 3:21

Section 3:14–21: Paul prayed again for the believers at Ephesus

In this section, Paul resumed his prayer for the Ephesian Christians. He asked God to strengthen them by the Holy Spirit so that Christ could live in them. He prayed that they would love each other, and that they would know how much Christ loved them, even though he loved them more than people could understand. Paul finished his prayer by praising God for his great power.

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Paragraph 3:20–21

This paragraph is a "doxology" or song of praise to God. Paul was expressing his praise for God in a very strong way.

It may be necessary to begin this paragraph with a phrase taken from 3:21. For example:

Let us glorify/praise God

May God be praised

Praise God

That God's name would be huge

3:21a

to Him be the glory

- Praise God because of his greatness
- God deserves praise
- May he/God be honored

to Him be the glory: A literal English translation of the Greek is "to him the glory." There is no explicit verb in Greek, so you may need to supply one.

Here are some examples of how to translate this phrase:

- Using the form of a blessing. For example:

That God's name be big

May he be honored through Christ

- Using the form of a command. For example:

Give to God the glory...

- Using the form of a statement. For example:

God deserves glory...

Glory belongs to God (GW)

glory: There are two aspects to the word glory in this verse:

1. praise,
2. the manifestation of God's divine perfection and power.

Paul probably had both of these things in mind. When Paul said, "to him [be] glory" he meant "God should be praised because of his greatness." Some ways to translate this are:

May God be praised for his greatness

Praise God because of his greatness which is seen

May people speak very highly about God's goodness/majesty/bigness

He did not mean that God must be given some glory because he does not have any.

See glory, Meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information. To "give God glory" is a common Hebrew expression for praising God. See, for example Isaiah 24:15, Psalm 96:7-8, 115:1, and also Luke 2:12. We do not actually give God glory in the sense that we give him something he did not have. He already has glory. To give him glory means to say that he has glory, to praise him because of his glory. The expression "glorify God" means the same thing: to praise him. See, for example, Psalm 34:3, Daniel 4:34, Luke 2:20, Romans 1:21, 15:6.

3:21b

in the church and in Christ Jesus

- in his people and in Christ Jesus.

- through those who believe in Christ and through/ Christ Jesus himself

in the church: The word church here means "God's people" or "the people who believe in Christ." It does not refer to a building.

So the phrase "To God be glory in the church" means that God's people should glorify God through what they do. People should see God's glory in his people.

Here are some other ways to translate 3:21a-b:

Praise God because of his greatness which is seen/shown in his people

God deserves/merits praise because of his power which others can see in his people

Let us praise God for his greatness which his people display/show

Also, see how you translated church in 3:10a. And see church in the Glossary for more information.

in Christ Jesus: The phrase in Christ Jesus is parallel grammatically to the phrase "in the church." We should also praise God because of his greatness that is seen in the church and in Christ Jesus. It may be helpful to translate 3:21a-b as:

To him be praise for his glory which is seen both in the church and in Christ Jesus

In some languages, it may be necessary to translate these two phrases in Christ Jesus and "in the church" as two different clauses. For example:

May God's name be truly high among God's people, and through the work of Christ Jesus, may God's name always be high with no end.

3:21c

throughout all generations, forever and ever. Amen.

- Praise him throughout the ages for ever and ever. Amen.
- God deserves/merits praise forever. Amen.
- may he be praised forever. So be it.

throughout all generations, forever and ever: The phrase throughout all generations and the phrase forever and ever both refer to very long periods of time.

Paul used both statements to emphasize that people should never stop praising God.

When you translate these phrases, you will need to decide:

1. whether it is more natural to combine these two phrases into one. An example of combining them is:

for all time/eternity

1. where to put them in the sentence. Some possibilities are:

- keep them at the end of the verse and begin a new sentence here. For example:

^{21a}Praise God because of his greatness which is seen ^{21b}in his people and in Christ Jesus. ^{21c}Praise him throughout all time and forever and ever!

- move these phrases to the beginning of the verse after “to him be glory.” For example:

^{21a,c}Praise God forever and ever because of his greatness which is seen ^{21b}in his people and in Christ Jesus.

Amen: The meaning of the word Amen is “Indeed it is true” or “May it be so.” Since people most frequently use this word at the end of a prayer, many people think this Greek word means “the end.” But this is not its true meaning.

Translations in many languages simply transliterate this word rather than translating the meaning. You may do the same.

Ephesians 4:1

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

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Paul urges the Ephesians to live a life of unity in Christ

Believers in Christ should live in unity, strengthening each other

4:1a

As a prisoner in the Lord, then,

- ¶ Because of all this, therefore, I, who am a prisoner for serving the Lord,
- ¶ Because of all that God has done for you, now I, who am in prison because I serve the Lord Jesus,

prisoner in the Lord: The phrase prisoner in the Lord means that Paul was in prison for serving the Lord.

This phrase is the same as the phrase “prisoner of Christ Jesus” in 3:1b, though the Greek is not exactly the same. Here are some other ways to translate this:

I am imprisoned because I serve the Lord

People put me in prison for serving my Master Jesus

the Lord: Here the phrase the Lord refers to Jesus. The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master” or “one who has authority over others.” People used this word as a polite title when they spoke to an elder or someone in authority. However, the Jews also used this same title to refer to God. Paul here recognizes Jesus as his sovereign Master who had authority from God and is the Son of God. Use a term in your language that could also be used in this way.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Master

Chief

Owner

Sovereign God

In some languages it may be necessary to add a word like “my” before such a term of address. For example:

my Chief/Sovereign

then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then connects all that Paul had taught in chapters 1–3 to the advice that he gave in chapters 4–6. This is not a time word. Paul began his advice by urging the Ephesians to behave like Christians should because of all that God had done for them.

Here are some other ways to translate the main idea here:

Because of all this therefore...

Because of all that God has done for you, I urge you...

The BSB has placed the conjunction then after the phrase “prisoner for the Lord” because it is good English style. In Greek, this conjunction occurs before the phrase “prisoner for the Lord.” For example:

Therefore I, a prisoner for serving the Lord... (NLT)

In some languages, it may not be necessary to explicitly show a connection here. In such cases, you may leave this conjunction untranslated.

General Comment on 4:1a–b

The Greek text of 4:1a–b is literally “I encourage therefore you, I, the prisoner of the Lord...” Paul repeats the pronoun “I” when he adds that he is a prisoner in the Lord. He does this to emphasize that he is in prison for the Lord, and this gives added authority to the advice he is going to give to the Ephesians in the following sections. As you translate 4:1a–c, try to include this emphasis in your translation in a natural way.

4:1b

I urge you to walk in a manner worthy

- I encourage you to live/behave in a way that is worthy
- I beg you to live in a way that is fitting for believers. Your life should demonstrate

I urge you to walk in a manner worthy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as urge can also mean “beg,” “plead,” “request” and “encourage.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

encourage (GW)

beg (RSV)

to walk in a manner worthy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to walk refers to our daily actions and our behavior.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

to live

to behave

(For other references to “walk,” see notes on 2:2a, 2:10c.)

worthy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worthy also means “fitting,” or “proper.”

Here are some other ways to translate “to walk in a manner worthy”:

to live the kind of life which proves that God has called you (GW)

behave in a way that is proper for God’s people to behave

to live in a way which agrees/conforms to the way God wants his people to live

When God called the Ephesians to be his people, he expected them to behave in a way that pleased him.

4:1c

of the calling you have received:

- of the way God called you to live/behave.
- the fact that God called you to be his people.

of the calling you have received: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as of the calling you have received is literally “of the calling to which you were called” (as in the RSV). This is a passive construction. God is the one who calls us. He calls us to be his people.

received: Some other ways to translate the word received are “invited” and “chosen.”

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase “of the calling you have received”:

(worthy) of the fact that God called you to be his people

of the invitation that God gave you to belong to him

The word “calling” is the same as the word “called” in 1:18b. See how you translated this word there.

Ephesians 4:2

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

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Paul urges the Ephesians to live a life of unity in Christ

Believers in Christ should live in unity, strengthening each other

4:2–4

In 4:1 Paul urged the Ephesians to behave in a way that pleased God. In 4:2–4 he listed some specific types of behavior that please God.

4:2a

with all humility and gentleness,

- In all you do, be humble and gentle.
- Always be unassuming and treat other people in a considerate way.

with all: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as with all means “in every situation” or “at all times.” It is connected to both “humble” and “gentle.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in everything/all you do

Always (CEV)

humility: The word humility means to be unassuming, without arrogance. It could also be translated as “without pride.” Some languages have idioms for this. For example:

have a low heart/head

bring yourself down

gentleness: The word gentleness means “without harshness, not easily irritated, with courtesy.” Acting with gentleness is the opposite of taking revenge, getting even or demanding your own rights.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

considerate

not demanding

not harsh

4:2b

with patience, bearing with one another in love,

- Be patient and tolerate one another in a loving manner.
- Be calm/uncomplaining and endure the behaviour of each other because you love one another.

with patience: The word patience means “being slow to get angry or complain” or “being long-suffering.” There may be an idiom in your language to express this, for example:

having a long heart

bearing with one another in love: The phrase bearing with one another means “be tolerant or patient with one another.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

accepting each other (NCV)

be tolerant of others

endure the wrongs of others

Some languages have idioms for this.

in love: The phrase in love refers to being tolerant of others “because of love,” or “because you love them.” For example:

...because of your love (NLT)

See love, meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 4:3

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

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4:3a
and with diligence to preserve the unity of the Spirit

- Try hard to maintain/preserve the unity which the Holy Spirit gives
- The Holy Spirit has united us together into one group. Do your best to remain united

4:3b
through the bond of peace.

- by means of being at peace with each other which binds/ties you together.
- by living in peace/harmony which binds/joins/keeps us together.

4:3a–b
and with diligence to preserve the unity of the Spirit through the bond of peace: The basic meaning of this verse is this: the Holy Spirit has united believers into one group, so they must do all they can to maintain this unity by living in peace with each other.

This verse has several difficult phrases that contain abstract nouns. To make it easier to understand, you may have to translate these nouns as verbs. For example:

with diligence: You can restate as:

Do your best (GNT)

Try hard

Use all your strength

to preserve the unity of the Spirit: You can restate this as:

to maintain/preserve the harmony which the Holy Spirit gives

the Holy Spirit has united you all into one group. Continue to be one group

through the bond of peace: This is a metaphor. Peace is compared to a rope or something that binds two objects together. So, the idea here is that peace binds Christians together and keeps them unified the way a rope binds or ties two objects together. You can restate this metaphor as:

Through the peace that ties you together (GW)

by living together in peace which binds/holds us together

by the peace that binds/ties us together like a rope that binds/ties two objects together

Ephesians 4:4

Section 4:1-16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

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4:4-6

In verses 4:4-6, Paul listed some of the things that unite all believers:

- they have become one body/group
- they have received the same Holy Spirit
- they confidently expect to receive the same blessings from God
- they have the same Lord
- they believe the same truths
- they have received the same baptism

Furthermore, there is only one God who is the Father of all people.

Paul used the word "one" six times in 4:4-6 to stress that Christians are united. In your language, it may not be possible to use "one" with things like "faith" and "baptism." This is especially true if you translate these

words as verbs instead of nouns. Think of a natural way to translate these verses so that Paul's emphasis on unity is clear. For example, you could translate "one Spirit" as:

we all have received the same Spirit

In 4:4, Paul uses the pronoun "you." But the things he says in 4:4-6 are true not only for the Ephesians, but also for Paul and all believers. Because of this, some translators use "we^(incl)" in these verses.

4:4a

There is one body and one Spirit,

- We are all part of one body and we have received the same Spirit.
- We are like parts of the same body, and we have the same Holy Spirit dwelling in us.

There is one body: The phrase one body refers to the group of believers called the church. This group of Christians is the body of Christ (1:23). All of us believers are like parts of the same body. So, another way to translate this phrase is a simile. For example:

We are like one body

one Spirit: The phrase one Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit. All believers have the same Holy Spirit living/dwelling in them.

4:4b

just as you were called to one hope when you were called;

- In the same way, God called/chose you to hope/expect the same good things/blessings.
- In the same manner, we are all hoping for the same things/blessings which God promised us when he called/chose us.

just as you were called to one hope: The clause just as you were called to one hope is a comparison. There is one body and one Spirit just as there is one hope. (See General Comment below for ways to translate this.)

you were called: The phrase you were called is passive. If it would be more natural in your language to use an active clause here, you can say:

just as God called you to one hope

called: As in 4:1c, here are some other ways to translate the verb called:

invited

chosen

See how you translated “calling” in 4:1c and called in 1:18b.

one hope: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hope means “to confidently expect and wait for something that we know will happen.” The meaning of the Greek word that is translated as hope is different from the modern English meaning. In modern English, hope is closer to a “wish.”

In many languages hope is easier to understand if translated as a verb rather than a noun. So you may need to say:

you are hoping for/expecting the same good things/blessings

See how you translated hope in 1:18b and 2:12d.

when you were called: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as when you were called is literally “of your calling” (as in the NRSV). This phrase repeats the phrase “you were called” that is found earlier in 4:4b. So some translations combine these two phrases. For example:

just as there is one hope to which God has called you (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate 4:4b:

In the same way you were called to share one hope. (GW)

...and God called you to have one hope. (NCV)

In the same way, when God called/chose you, he chose you to hope/expect the same good things/blessings.

Ephesians 4:5

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained

that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

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4:5a

one Lord, one faith,

- There is one Lord, one faith,
- We all have the same Lord. We all believe the same teaching/doctrine

one Lord: We all have the same Lord. Here one Lord refers to the Lord Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

There is one Lord (GNT)

We have only one Lord (CEV)

one faith: The phrase one faith refers to belief in the same teaching/doctrine about Christ.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Christian doctrine/teachings

set of beliefs/teachings

one way of believing

See faith, Meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

4:5b one baptism;

- and one baptism.
- We all have received the same baptism.
- Each of us have been baptised into that same faith/belief

one baptism: The word baptism refers to a special ritual washing to purify someone. In this context the ritual implied purifying/cleansing from sin. It was an initiation that marked the beginning of that person's life as one of God's pure people.

You should translate baptism in a similar way as you translate "baptize." However, the form of the word or phrase may be different. For example, here are some ways to translate baptism with a descriptive term:

ritual washing

purification/initiation for God

entering the water

General Comment on baptism

- Use a term for a similar ritual that is already used in your culture. You may need to indicate that in this context it has a special connection with God. For example:

God's ceremonial bath

initiation water for God

- Use a term that is already accepted by the local churches. In some areas this term may have been borrowed from the national language or transliterated from Greek or English.

The meaning here is that we all have been baptized with the same baptism. Paul also meant that we all were baptized as a symbol that we are Christians. In the first century, when Paul wrote this letter, baptism had not yet become an issue that Christians argued about. So he was not talking about the method of baptism (sprinkling, immersion or some other method). Baptism was something that all Christians had in common.

Some people think Paul was talking about being baptized by the Holy Spirit here (see 1 Corinthians 12:13), but most people think he was talking about

water baptism. Your translation should be general and should not specify any one kind or mode of baptism.

Ephesians 4:6

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

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4:6a one God and Father of all,

- And there is one God who is the Father of all believers,
- We all worship the same God who is the Father of us^(incl) all.

one God and Father of all: The words God and Father refer to the same Person. You can say:

There is only one God, and he is the Father of all of us.

We all worship the same God who is the Father of us all.

all: There are at least three ways to understand the word all.

1. It means all believers.
2. It means all people whether believers or not. For example:

there is one God and Father of all people (GNT)

1. It means all things or all creation. For example:

There is one God and Father of everything. (NCV)

Many versions say only all, and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. If you want to make the all explicit, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), which many commentaries support. It is true that God is the God of all people, and he is over all people. However, because Paul is speaking of the unity of the church in these verses, he probably means all Christians, whether Jew or Gentile. So you could translate all as:

all of us

all his people

4:6b

who is over all and through all and in all.

- And he is the ruler over everyone, works through everyone and is in everyone.
- He is/rules over us^(incl) all, he works through us all, and he lives in us all.

who is over all: The phrase who is over all means that God rules over all his people. He owns us all. For example:

of all people (GNT)

through all: The phrase through all means that God does his work through all his people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

works through all (GNT)

he works by using all of us (CEV)

in all: The phrase in all means that God lives/dwells in all his people by his Spirit. For example:

and he lives in all of us (CEV)

Ephesians 4:7

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Unity of the body of Christ

Christ's gifts to the church

Live in unity, using God's gifting to strengthen believers

Paul urges the Ephesians to live a life of unity in Christ

Believers in Christ should live in unity, strengthening each other

Paragraph 4:7–16

In 4:4–6 Paul talked about the things that unite Christians. These are things that we have in common. But in 4:7 he talked about special abilities that some Christians have and that others do not have. We all have the same Spirit, we all worship the same Lord, and so on. But to each of us, Christ has given different special abilities.

4:7a

Now to each one of us grace has been given

- ¶ But each of us has received a special gift of grace
- ¶ But Christ has given to each one of us different special abilities to do his work.

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now marks a contrast and a transition. In 4:4–6 Paul talked about what Christians have in common. In this paragraph he talked about special abilities that Christ

gives to individual believers. Indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

However (NLT)

And yet

Although we are united in these ways yet

to each one of us grace: Here the word grace means “the ability which Christ gives to do a special task.” Some of these tasks are described in 4:11. It does not mean “mercy.”

Here are some other ways to translate the word grace:

special gift (GNT)

favor (GW)

generous gift/enabling

gracious empowering

In some languages it is translated as:

power to do a work

See grace, Meaning 3 in the Glossary for more information.

has been given: The phrase has been given is passive. Christ is the one who has given to us these gifts/abilities.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he has given each one of us a special gift (NLT)

Christ gave each of us a gracious gift/ability

4:7b

according to the measure of the gift of Christ.

- as Christ has distributed it.
- He decided how to divide/distribute these abilities.

according to the measure of the gift of Christ: The words according to the measure means “to measure out,” “to distribute,” or “to divide.” Christ decides

which gift each Christian should receive. He does not give the same abilities to every Christian.

Here are some other ways to translate the words according to the measure:

as...divided (CEV)

as...measured out (GW)

as...distributed

Ephesians 4:8

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

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In 4:4–6 Paul talked about the things that unite Christians. These are things that we have in common. But in 4:7 he talked about special abilities that some Christians have and that others do not have. We all have the same Spirit, we all worship the same Lord, and so on. But to each of us, Christ has given different special abilities.

4:8

Paul used a quotation from Psalm 68:18 although the wording is a little different. He used this quotation to support what he had just said about Christ giving gifts. In this psalm, the writer described a Jewish king who had defeated his enemies and returned in victory. In a parade to celebrate his victory, he went up the hill to Mount Zion in Jerusalem. During the parade, he forced some of the enemy soldiers he had captured to follow along behind him and implied in this passage is that from the plunder he gave gifts to his followers/soldiers.

4:8a**This is why it says:**

- This is why the Scriptures say:
- It is as they/someone wrote in the Book of God:

This is why: The Greek word that the BSB translated This is why indicates that Paul used the quote in 4:8b-c to support what he has just said in 4:7.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

This is supported by

Therefore (RSV)

As (CEV)

it says: The pronoun it here refers to the Scriptures. In some languages it is not natural to say that a book says. So you may want to translate this:

we read words in God's Book like this

they/someone wrote in the Book of God"

4:8b**"When He ascended on high,**

- "When he went up to a high place,
- "After he defeated his enemies, he went up to a high place,

When He ascended on high: Psalm 68 describes how the victorious king went up Mount Zion (a hill in Jerusalem) followed by the enemies he had captured. Paul saw this as a picture of Christ ascending to heaven. Just as the king won a victory and then went up to a high place, so also Christ won a victory (over sin and death) and then went up to a high place (God's right side in heaven).

Since this is a quotation from the Psalms, you should translate on high in 4:8b in a general way. In the Psalm, on high refers to Mount Zion, so do not translate it "to heaven" here. Also, the pronoun He in this quotation should not be translated "Christ" because Psalm 68 does not mention the word "Christ."

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When He went up to a high place

If He ascended going to a high place (Uma back translation)

4:8c**He led captives away,**

- he took with him the enemies he had conquered,
- and forced his enemies to walk behind him as captives,

He led captives away: The phrase He led captives away means that the king brought many prisoners along with him.

captives: The word captives refers to enemies the king had captured in a battle. These enemies then became prisoners of the king.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he led a crowd of captives (NLT)

he led away many prisoners (CEV)

He brought along behind him many prisoners

4:8d**and gave gifts to men."**

- and he gave/distributed various gifts to his people."
- then he presented to his people good things

and gave gifts to men: The verb gave here is different from the verb in the psalm which is "received gifts," but the translator must of course translate what Paul wrote in this verse. The word gifts here refers to material gifts, so you should not translate it "special abilities," but rather something general like:

good things

blessingsIn Psalm 68:18, the Hebrew says "you received gifts from men." The victorious king received many material gifts and rewards, not to

mention the valuable things he had taken from the enemy during the battle. He received all these things, and then he shared them with his soldiers and other people of his country. He received these gifts in order to share them with his people. Paul changes the words from “you received gifts from men” to “he gave gifts to men.” In this way, the words better describe what Paul says about Christ giving us gifts (special abilities)

to men: In the context of this quotation, to men refers to the king’s followers. It does not refer to his enemies in 4:8c. It should be clear in your translation that the reference is not to his enemies here. For example:

and gave gifts to his people (NLT)

Ephesians 4:9

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

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Believers in Christ should live in unity, strengthening each other

Paragraph 4:7–16

In 4:4–6 Paul talked about the things that unite Christians. These are things that we have in common. But in

4:7 he talked about special abilities that some Christians have and that others do not have. We all have the same Spirit, we all worship the same Lord, and so on. But to each of us, Christ has given different special abilities.

4:9–10

Paul proved that this quotation from the Psalms applies to Christ, since Christ is the only one who descended from heaven before he ascended.

General Comment on 4:9–10

Some English versions put these verses in (parentheses) to show that this is background information given by Paul. If you are able to do this in your language and it would be natural to do so, you will want to consider following the example of those versions. If not, following the example of the BSB, which does not use parentheses.

4:9a

What does “He ascended” mean,

- (When the Book says: “He went up to a high place,” what does this mean?
- (When it says that “he ascended,” this means that

What does “He ascended” mean: This is a rhetorical question. So Paul is not asking the question so he can get an answer. He asked this question in order to introduce a new aspect of his teaching to his readers. He then explained how Psalm 68:18 applied to Christ.

ascended: The word ascended means “went up.”

There are two ways to translate this question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Now, what does “he went up” mean? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

Notice that it says “he ascended (NLT)

The words “he ascended” mean...

Translate this in a way that is most natural in your language.

4:9b

except that He also descended to the lower parts of the earth?

- These words mean that Christ had already come down to this earth below.

- previously he had come down to a low place; that is, to this earth.

except that He also descended: Here, the words except that have the meaning of “it could only mean that.” The RSV and ESV translate except that as:

but that

He also descended: Beginning here, Paul talked about Christ and how the words of the quotation in 4:8 are like Christ. So the pronoun He refers to Christ, and you can translate it that way if necessary. To make it clear that Christ descended before he ascended, the GNT says:

first came down (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate the word descended:

came down (NCV)

had gone down (GW)

to the lower parts of the earth: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as to the lower parts of the earth may refer to:

1. the earth below in contrast to the highest heaven. This refers to where Christ was when he became a human. For example:

This clearly means that Christ also descended to our lowly world (NLT) (BSB, NIV, REB, JBP, NLT, ESV, NET, NCV)

1. Hades. This refers to where Christ was after he died. According to some interpretations of 1 Peter 3:18 and 1 Peter 4:6, Christ descended into Hades after his death. For example:

...it means that Christ had been deep in the earth. (CEV) (GNT, RSV, NASB, NJB, KJV, CEV, GW)

If possible, translate in a way in which either interpretation could be understood. If you must choose one interpretation, choose interpretation (1). You may also want to include a footnote that gives the other interpretation.

Ephesians 4:10

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

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Paragraph 4:7–16

In 4:4–6 Paul talked about the things that unite Christians. These are things that we have in common. But in 4:7 he talked about special abilities that some Christians have and that others do not have. We all have the same Spirit, we all worship the same Lord, and so on. But to each of us, Christ has given different special abilities.

4:10a

He who descended

- The person who came down to this earth
- So Jesus came down on the earth.

He who descended: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as He who descended is literally “the one having descended himself.” The pronoun He refers to Christ. It is an emphatic form. Try to translate this clause in a way that shows this emphasis.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

And the same one who descended (NLT)

So the one who came down (GNT)

descended: See how you translated descended in 4:9b.

4:10b

is the very One who ascended above all the heavens,

- is the same person who then went up higher than the sky,
- He is the same one/person who then rose to a place above/beyond the sky.

is the very One who ascended: The very One means “the same one.”

ascended: The verb ascended means “to go up.” It has the opposite meaning of “descended” in 4:9b and 4:10a.

above all the heavens: The word heavens here refers to the sky. It contrasts with “earthly regions” in 4:9b. Paul is using figurative language to say that Jesus is superior to any created being. Be careful not to translate heavens in a way that sounds as if Christ were in a higher place than God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

is the same one who went into the highest heaven (CEV)

is the same One who went up above all the sky (NCV)

4:10c

in order to fill all things.

- so that he would fill the whole world/universe.)
- He did this so that he could be everywhere.)

in order to fill all things: Most commentators believe that this refers to Christ being present everywhere in the universe.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

to fill the whole universe with his presence (GNT)

so that he might fill the entire universe with himself (NLT)

Ephesians 4:11

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

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Paragraph 4:7–16

In 4:4–6 Paul talked about the things that unite Christians. These are things that we have in common. But in 4:7 he talked about special abilities that some Christians have and that others do not have. We all have the same Spirit, we all worship the same Lord, and so on. But to each of us, Christ has given different special abilities.

4:11a

And it was He who gave some to be apostles,

- It was he who gave some people to the church to be apostles,
- It was Christ who appointed/chose some people to be his ambassadors.

In this verse Paul resumes the thoughts he was expressing in 4:7–8.

And it was He who gave some to be apostles: In this clause, Paul continues his thought in 4:8 of giving gifts to men. According to Paul, Christ gave the church

these apostles as a gift to benefit the church. So it was Christ who chose or appointed them to their different positions.

apostles: The Greek word that the BSB translates as apostles is literally “sent ones.” See how you translated apostles in 2:20a and 3:5c. See apostle in the Glossary for more information.

General Comment on 4:11–12

Some English versions have made explicit Paul’s reference to “gifts to men” in 4:8d to Christ’s giving officers to the church in 4:11. For example:

¹¹Now these are the gifts Christ gave to the church: the apostles, the prophets, the evangelists, and the pastors and teachers (NLT)

¹¹He also gave apostles, prophets, missionaries, as well as pastors and teachers as gifts [to his church] (GW)

¹¹It was he who “gave gifts to people”; he appointed some to be apostles, others to be prophets, others to be evangelists, others to be pastors and teachers. (GNT)

You may want to follow one of these examples in your translation.

4:11b

some to be prophets, some to be evangelists,

- some people to be prophets, some people to preach the gospel;
- He chose others to speak God’s messages, others to proclaim the good news,

some to be prophets: The word prophets refers to people to whom God gave a special spiritual gift. This gift enabled the person to speak a message from God. See how you translated prophets in 2:20a and 3:5c. See prophet in the Glossary for more information.

some to be evangelists: The word evangelists refers to people who preach the good news. See evangelist in the Glossary if you want more information. Another way to translate evangelists is:

people who preach the good news

some to go and tell the Good News (NCV)

4:11c

and some to be pastors and teachers,

- and he gave some people the power to care for the believers and teach them.
- and others to care for the believers and instruct them about God’s Word.

some to be pastors and teachers: The word pastors literally means “shepherds.” Here, it refers to people who look after and care for the believers.

pastors: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pastors literally means shepherds, that is, people who take care of sheep. Here it is used figuratively to refer to leaders of the church who care for their fellow believers.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

leaders who care for other believers

spiritual overseers

leaders who oversee their congregations

teachers: The word teachers means spiritual teachers, or people who teach God’s truth. They are not school teachers.

The word teachers does not mean a completely separate group of people from “pastors.” Paul linked “pastors” and teachers together because they do similar jobs. You could translate “pastors and teachers” as:

people who care for the believers and teach them

See both pastor and teacher in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 4:12

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

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Paragraph 4:7–16

In 4:4–6 Paul talked about the things that unite Christians. These are things that we have in common. But in 4:7 he talked about special abilities that some Christians have and that others do not have. We all have the same Spirit, we all worship the same Lord, and so on. But to each of us, Christ has given different special abilities.

4:12

This verse explains the purpose of Christ giving some of his people these special abilities that Paul mentioned in 4:11. The purpose is to give the ability to all God's people to work for him, so that they all may grow and become stronger in their faith.

4:12a

to equip the saints for works of ministry

- He did this so that these people would prepare God's people to serve him,
- He gave people these abilities so that they could make the rest of God's people ready to work for him.

to equip: The phrase to equip means to “make able and adequate” to a task. Paul intended that they would be up to the task and fit to serve God's people.

Here is another way to translate this:

to equip God's people to do his work (NLT)

the saints: A literal English translation of the Greek is “holy ones.” It means “people set apart for God.” This Greek word refers to every believer.

See how you translated the saints in 3:8a. See Holy, Meaning 1, special use in the Glossary for more information.

for works of ministry: The phrase works of ministry means “to work serving God.” Notice that Paul did not say that the apostles, prophets, evangelists and pastors are the ones who are equipped to work for God. He says that the apostles and others are to prepare “the saints” to work for God. All of God's people are to work for him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the work of serving (NCV)

would learn to serve (CEV)

4:12b

and to build up the body of Christ,

- so that believers, who are the body of Christ, may grow strong.
- He did it so that all of God's people will become stronger in their faith and more mature.

and to build up the body of Christ: This clause begins with and to. It tells why Christ appointed some people to be apostles, prophets, evangelists and pastors and teachers (4:11). He appointed people to these positions so that they could prepare all of God's people to work for him (4:12a).

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase and to:

for (REB)

He did that so

build up the body of Christ: The body of Christ is a metaphor that refers to all Christians. To build up the body of Christ means to cause all Christians to become strong in their relationship with Christ (the head of the body) and with each other (other members of the body). If it is not clear what the body of Christ refers to, you can make it explicit. For example:

and build up the church, the body of Christ (NLT)

build up: The Greek word that the BSB translates as build up is a verb meaning “to construct (a house).” He uses the same word in 2:22a and 4:16b. Paul is using the word in a figurative sense that means “cause to grow strong” or “make complete and mature.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and his body would grow strong (CEV)

make the body of Christ stronger (NCV)

cause the assembly of Christians/believers to be more mature

Ephesians 4:13

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

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Paragraph 4:7–16

In 4:4–6 Paul talked about the things that unite Christians. These are things that we have in common. But in 4:7 he talked about special abilities that some Christians have and that others do not have. We all have the same Spirit, we all worship the same Lord, and so on. But to each of us, Christ has given different special abilities.

4:13a–d

In the Greek text, 4:13 contains three phrases each of which start with the same preposition *eis*, "to":

- to become unified...

- to become mature...
- to become perfect like Christ...

Commentators connect these phrases in many ways. The two main interpretations are:

1. all three phrases are separate goals. For example:

^{13a}This is to continue

^{13b} until all of us are united in our faith and in our knowledge about God's Son,

^{13c} until we become mature,

^{13d} until we measure up to Christ, who is the standard. (GW) (RSV, NASB, CEV, GW)

1. the first two phrases are separate goals, and the third phrase further describes the second. For example:

^{13a}This work must continue

^{13b} until we are all joined together in the same faith and in the same knowledge of the Son of God.

^{13c} We must become like a mature person, ^{13d} growing until we become like Christ and have his perfection. (NCV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The three goals for the church are that they shall:

1. be united in their faith and knowledge of Christ (4:13b),
2. become mature believers (4:13c) and
3. become completely like Christ (4:13d).

4:13a

until we all

- The goal is for all of us
- This will continue so that we all

until: The word until here means that this is the goal of what Paul said in 4:11–12. Christ gave special abilities to some believers (4:11) in order to prepare all believers to work for him (4:12a) and to make us all united (4:12b). This will continue until we all become united (4:13b), mature (4:13c) and like Christ (4:13d).

we all: The words we all refer to all of us who are believers.

4:13b**reach unity in the faith and in the knowledge of the Son of God,**

- to become united/one by means of the faith about Christ and in our knowledge of the Son of God,
- become joined as one in the faith/teaching about Christ and by knowing Christ, the Son of God

reach unity in the faith and in the knowledge of the Son of God: Here, faith and knowledge are the means of our coming to unity. We become united because we believe in the Son of God and know him. In some languages, it will be clearer to translate these three abstract nouns (unity, faith, knowledge) as verbs. These are discussed below.

reach unity in the faith: Here, reach unity means “to come together like one,” “to become joined together as one” or “to become united.”

the faith: Here the faith refers to a general belief or trust in something or someone. There are two main interpretations.

1. This refers to belief in the true Christian teachings. If you follow this interpretation, you could say:

by believing in the truth/teaching about Christ and knowing the Son of God

1. This refers to belief in the Son of God. Some commentators say that “Son of God” is the object of both “knowledge” and faith. If you follow this interpretation, you could say:

by believing in the Son of God and knowing him

In 4:5a, Paul listed “one faith” and its meaning was “belief in the true Christian teachings.” The context suggested that the faith has the same meaning here. So, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

are united by our faith and by our understanding of the Son of God. (CEV)

are all joined together in the same faith and in the same knowledge of the Son of God. (NCV)

the Son of God: The phrase the Son of God is a title for Jesus. This title was often used to refer to a savior who would be a descendant of King David. God would send this savior to rescue his people. This person was often referred to as the “Messiah” or “Christ.”

The title the Son of God also indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. The relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. The Son of God existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In areas where people do not understand the title the Son of God in this way, you may want to include a footnote that explains the correct meaning. Here is a suggested footnote:

This title refers to Jesus. It indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It does not mean that God the Father had a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. Mary became pregnant with Jesus in a miraculous way by the Holy Spirit of God.

In some languages, it is natural to speak of a son as a “child,” without specifying male or female. If that is true in your language, you may use a more general term, such as:

the Child of GodA translation of the title “the Son of God” must include a familial term such as “son” or “child.” Translations such as “the man who is God,” “the divine man,” or “the God man” are not acceptable, since they do not retain familial language. Examples of acceptable translation options include “the Son who comes from God,” and “the divine/unique/eternal Son of God.”

Other verses will usually make clear that Jesus was a male child. If you use a phrase such as “the male child of God,” be sure that it does not imply that God had another child who was female.

4:13c**as we mature**

- to become mature believers,
- until we become fully grown/developed believers

as we mature: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as as we mature is literally “to a mature man.”

The second goal of the church is to mature. Here, this refers to becoming fully grown, fully developed, like adults in our faith (in contrast to children in 4:14). The meaning is “mature as Christians.” For example:

mature in the Lord (NLT)

4:13d

to the full measure of the stature of Christ.

- and to become completely like Christ, who is perfect.
- and until we become completely mature/perfect, just like Christ is.

to the full measure of the stature of Christ: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as to the full measure of the stature of Christ is literally “at the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ.” It means “to become exactly like Christ, who is perfect.”

Paul is using a metaphor here, comparing the physical maturity of children to the spiritual maturity of Christians. Just as a child grows up until he becomes an adult like his parents, so we Christians are to grow up in our faith until we are like Christ.

In some languages people may not understand the meaning of the metaphor. If that is true in your language, consider translating the meaning directly. For example:

and become completely mature, just as Christ is

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

measuring up to the full and complete standard of Christ (NLT)

until we measure up to Christ, who is the standard (GW)

grow up and be strong the way Christ is strong

Ephesians 4:14

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks

so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Unity of the body of Christ

Christ’s gifts to the church

Live in unity, using God’s gifting to strengthen believers

Paul urges the Ephesians to live a life of unity in Christ

Believers in Christ should live in unity, strengthening each other

Paragraph 4:7–16

In 4:4–6 Paul talked about the things that unite Christians. These are things that we have in common. But in 4:7 he talked about special abilities that some Christians have and that others do not have. We all have the same Spirit, we all worship the same Lord, and so on. But to each of us, Christ has given different special abilities.

4:14

This verse describes immature Christians. They are like children who are easily influenced by false teachers. Paul compared such Christians to a boat blown about on the sea during a storm. The false teachers who try to influence believers are cunning and deceitful.

4:14a

Then we will no longer be infants,

- In order that we will no longer be like infants.
- So that we will no longer be immature like children.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then is sometimes translated as:

in order that (RSV)

This conjunction introduces another purpose of 4:11–12a. Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural for introducing a purpose in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

In order that

So that

The purpose is that

If we do that, then...

we will no longer be infants: The clause we will no longer be infants is a metaphor. It is a continuation of the figure of speech that Paul used in 4:13. It means “immature,” which is the opposite of “mature” in 4:13b. For example:

we will no longer be immature like children (NLT)

Another way to translate this is as a simile:

we will no longer be like children

4:14b

tossed about by the waves

- We will no longer be tossed around by the waves.
- The waves will no longer toss us back and forth.
- who are easily led astray, like a small boat

4:14c

and carried around by every wind of teaching

- We will no longer be blown around by every wind of doctrine.
- The new/false teachings/ideas like wind will no longer blow us here and there.
- that is sent in different directions by the waves and wind.

4:14b–c

tossed about by the waves and carried around by every wind of teaching: There are at least two issues you must consider as you translate 4:14b–c.

Issue 1—passives:

There are several passives in 4:14b–c. If it would be more natural in your language to use active clauses here, you could say:

The waves will no longer toss us about, and every wind of teaching will no longer carry us around.

Issue 2—metaphor:

4:14b–c contains another metaphor. Here Paul compared Christians to boats in the water. The NCV makes this explicit when it says:

We will not be tossed about like a ship that the waves carry one way and then another. (NCV)

The waves and wind easily push boats off course. In the same way, cunning men easily deceive weak Christians and “push” them away from true doctrine.

In translating this metaphor, you have several possibilities:

- You may want to translate this as a simile:

We will no longer be like boats that the waves toss back and forth and the wind blows here and there.

- You may want to translate the direct meaning of the metaphor. If you live in a place where boats and travelling on the water are unknown, people who read your translation may be confused by this figure of speech. If that is true, you may need to translate the meaning with no figure of speech:

^{14c}Cunning men will no longer easily deceive us
^{14b}to believe false teaching.

- Or you may need to use another figure of speech, for example:

We will no longer be like dry leaves that the wind blows around.

by every wind of teaching: The phrase by every wind of teaching means we will no longer be easily deceived “by every type of false teaching.” The word wind is part of the figure of speech that Paul used. The word teaching helps explain the meaning of this figure of speech. Wind easily blows a boat in different directions. In the same way, false teaching easily “blows off course” a weak Christian. That is, it easily causes a weak Christian to leave the truth and follow false teaching.

4:14d

and by the clever cunning of men in their deceitful scheming.

- This means, cunning and tricky people will no longer deceive us with their false teaching.

- We will no longer be influenced by people who use cunning and clever strategies to lead us astray. (GW)

by the clever cunning of men in their deceitful scheming: The phrase by the clever cunning of men in their deceitful scheming is also a passive. If it would be more natural in your language to translate this as an active clause, you could say:

Cunning and crafty men will no longer deceive us with their scheming.

clever cunning of men: The two words clever and cunning may be treated as a doublet. Together they add emphasis. Both words indicate men who “deceive” or who “trick” people. Some versions translate this phrase like this:

deceitful people (GNT)

deceitful scheming: The phrase deceitful scheming refers to working in an underhanded, lying way. For example:

tricks (GNT)

Paul used these words to emphasize his point. The meaning is similar to “clever” and “cunning.”

General Comment on 4:14b–c

The clever and cunning men in 4:14d are the ones who do the false teaching mentioned in 4:14c, so in some languages, it will be more natural to put 4:14d before 4:14b–c. For example:

^{14d}Clever and cunning men will no longer be able to deceive us with their false teaching. ^{14b–c}This teaching tries to toss us back and forth like boats on the waves or like boats blown here and there by the wind.

Ephesians 4:15

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by

false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Unity of the body of Christ

Christ’s gifts to the church

Live in unity, using God’s gifting to strengthen believers

Paul urges the Ephesians to live a life of unity in Christ

Believers in Christ should live in unity, strengthening each other

Paragraph 4:7–16

In 4:4–6 Paul talked about the things that unite Christians. These are things that we have in common. But in 4:7 he talked about special abilities that some Christians have and that others do not have. We all have the same Spirit, we all worship the same Lord, and so on. But to each of us, Christ has given different special abilities.

4:15a

Instead, speaking the truth in love,

- Instead, by speaking the truth in a loving manner,
- Rather, we should speak out the truth about God/Christ in a loving way,

Instead: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Instead indicates a contrast with 4:14. Instead of being like children who are deceived by lies, we need to speak the truth so that we will grow up and become mature.

speaking the truth in love: The clause speaking the truth means that we should tell others the true teaching about Christ. It implies more than speaking true words instead of lies. It implies speaking about Christ.

in love: This means we should speak the truth in a loving manner, or that we should speak the truth and show love to others. See how you translated in love in 4:2b. See love, meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

4:15b

we will in all things grow up into Christ Himself, who is the head.

- we should mature in every way to become like Christ who is the head.
- so that we will become mature and more like Christ in everything we do. He is our head/chief,

we will in all things grow up into Christ Himself:

The phrase in all things here means “in every way.” So, many English versions translate it that way (GNT, RSV, NLT, CEV, NCV, ESV).

grow up into Christ Himself: To grow up into Christ Himself refers to our becoming mature and becoming like Christ in our behavior.

Here is another way to translate these words:

we will grow in every way and be more like Christ (CEV)

“Speaking the truth in love” (4:15a) is the means or way in which we grow up into Christ. Some English versions make this explicit. For example:

Instead, by speaking the truth in a spirit of love, we must grow up in every way to Christ (GNT)

Instead, as we lovingly speak the truth, we will grow up completely in our relationship to Christ (GW)

grow: The form of this verb in Greek shows that Paul wants his readers to grow. For example:

we should grow up into Christ

let us grow up into Christ

we must grow up... (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate this:

let us become more and more like Christ

We must develop into very mature people like he/Christ is

who is the head: Paul used the word head in a metaphorical sense to mean that Christ is our chief or leader.

You may want to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

Christ is the head of his followers.

Christ is the chief of all his people/believers.

See how you translated head in 1:22b.

Ephesians 4:16

Section 4:1–16: Believers are united in Christ

In the previous sections, Paul taught the important truths of the Christian faith. In this section, Paul showed how those truths should affect the way we live. He urged the Ephesian Christians to behave in the way that would keep their unity. He explained in detail the basis of this unity. He also explained that Christ gives believers power to do different tasks so that the church may become strong and mature. Mature believers should no longer be influenced by false teaching. Instead, they will proclaim the truth, and the church, with Christ as its head, will grow as it should and become strong.

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Paragraph 4:7–16

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4:16a

From Him the whole body,

- He/Christ joins together all his people;
- and all of us who believe in him are like his body.

From Him: The pronoun Him refers to Christ in 4:15b.

the whole body: Paul again used the picture of a body to describe the church. Just as the ligaments/muscles hold together the different parts of the body, so it is Christ who holds together his body, which is the church (all believers).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

He makes the whole body (NLT)

The whole body depends on Christ (NCV)

Like the whole body depends on the head so all we believers depend on Christ

See how you translated body in 4:4a and 4:12b.

4:16b

fitted and held together by every supporting ligament,

- so that we are like the ligaments that join together all the parts of the body of a person.
- Just as a person's body is joined together by all its ligaments,

fitted and held together: The phrase fitted and held together refers to the different parts of the body of Christ (members of the church) that work together just as the different parts of a body are held together by its ligaments/muscles. See the note below on "ligament" for more information.

by every supporting ligament: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as by every supporting ligament is literally "through every joint of the supply." A ligament refers to one of the strong bands of tough fibrous tissue that joins bones or holds some part of the body in position. In this context, the word ligament includes all those things that connect the different parts of the body together, that is, joints, tendons and muscles.

Here are some other ways to translate 4:16a:

He makes the whole body fit together perfectly. (NLT)

He makes the whole body fit together and unites it through the support of every joint (GW)

If the people will not understand that this is a metaphor about the group of believers then you may want to translate the meaning directly. Here is an example of how to translate the meaning directly:

He causes all the believers to work together harmoniously as they support each other.

Another option is to put in a footnote. For example:

Paul is continuing to use a metaphor here. He compares the ligaments of a person's body that holds the body together to the individual believers helping and supporting each other by Christ's power. The following is an example of the metaphor with its meaning. "As God causes the whole body to be held together by its ligaments so Christ causes all his believers to work together harmoniously by their support of each other."

4:16c

grows and builds itself up in love through the work of each individual part.

- If each part of the body does its work, then the whole body grows and becomes strong and loves the other parts.
- and, when every part of the body works properly, it grows and becomes strong; in the same way, if each of us does the work Christ has given us, we will grow strong and mature and love each other more.

grows and builds itself up: The phrase grows and builds itself up means "cause to grow large and strong" or "make complete and mature."

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

grows and becomes strong (GNT)

in love: The phrase in love means that the members of the body will grow in their love for each other. This phrase also occurred in 4:15a.

through the work of each individual part: This is a continuation of Paul's comparison between a human body and the church. If all the parts of a person's body function as they should, the body will be healthy and grow. So it is with the church: if all believers use the special gifts God has given them, then the church will become strong. For example:

As each and every part does its job (GW)

General Comment on 4:16c

In your translation it may be better to reorder this clause. You could first explain the figure of speech ("If each part of a body does its work...") and then explain how believers are compared to the body ("In the same

way...”). This has been done in the second meaning line of the Display for 4:16c.

General Comment on 4:16a–c

Here is another way to translate this verse:

He would be like our head, and we would be each of his arms, legs and sinews/ligaments. And if/when we would love each other, we would grow up to be strong and each of us do our own/individual works faithfully.

Ephesians 4:17

Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God’s people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don’t live as pagans but as God’s people

4:17a

So I tell you this, and insist on it in the Lord,

- ¶ So I say to you and warn you in the name of the Lord,
- ¶ Therefore, I speak to you with the authority that the Lord gives me. I strongly advise you

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *So* connects all that Paul has previously taught to the advice that follows. It is similar to 4:1a, where the BSB translates it as “then.” Because God had done so much for the Ephesians, therefore they must not live as they formerly had.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Therefore

On the basis of that

Some versions do not translate the conjunction. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

I tell you this: The words I tell you this show that Paul was emphasising what he said.

this: The word *this* refers to the advice that he is about to give to his readers. It does not refer to that which Paul had already said. If your language would not use the word *this* in such a way, you may need to say something like:

So here is what I want to tell you

So I tell you

insist on it in the Lord: To insist means “to advise, warn, strongly urge.” Paul said that he is speaking in the name of the Lord, that is with the Lord’s authority.

the Lord: Here the word *Lord* refers to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

With the Lord’s authority (NLT)

In the Lord’s name (GNT)

General Comment on 4:17a

One way you can translate 4:17a is like this:

So now listen to these words of mine! With the authority that the Lord gave me, I advise you to...

4:17b

that you must no longer walk as the Gentiles do,

- do not behave any longer like the pagans.
- to stop living/acting like people who do not know God.

that you must no longer walk: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as *walk* refers to our daily actions and our behavior. Some ways to translate this word are:

act

behave

(For other references to “walk,” see notes on 2:2a, 2:10c, 4:1b.)

as the Gentiles do: Here the word *Gentiles* does not mean simply non-Jewish people. Rather, Paul used it to refer to people who do not know God.

Here are some other ways to translate the word Gentiles:

heathen (GNT)

pagan (REB)

Both of these are words that refer to people who do not know God or believe in God. See Gentiles, Meaning 2 in the Glossary.

4:17c
in the futility of their thinking.

- Their thoughts are futile/worthless.
- The things they think about are of no value.

in the futility of their thinking: The phrase in the futility of their thinking means that that which the pagans think is worthless, empty and a waste of time.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

whose thoughts are worthless (GNT)

for they are hopelessly confused (NLT)

Ephesians 4:18

Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God's people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don't live as pagans but as God's people

4:18a
They are darkened in their understanding

- Their understanding of the truth is not clear.
- They cannot clearly understand things about God.

darkened in their understanding: The phrase darkened in their understanding is a figure of speech. It

means that pagans cannot clearly understand things about God.

In some languages there may be other idiomatic ways to say this. For example:

Their minds are clouded

Their hearts are blind to God's truth

4:18b
and alienated from the life of God

- They are far away from the life that God gives.
- They have no part in the new life that God gives,

alienated from the life of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as alienated from also means “excluded” or “separated.” (This word also occurs in 2:12b). The Gentiles are alienated from the life of God. This means they are far away from the life that God gives, or they have no part in it (as in GNT, see below).

the life of God: The life of God is the good, new life that God gives his people. It includes salvation and eternal life.

To state it simply: pagans do not have the new life that God gives to his people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

They have no part in the life that God gives (GNT)

(They) have missed out on the life that comes from God (CEV)

They are excluded from the life that God approves of (GW)

They are outside of God's making us new

4:18c
because of the ignorance that is in them due to the hardness of their hearts.

- because they do not know God and because they are stubborn.
- for they are completely ignorant and they refuse to listen to the truth.

because of the ignorance that is in them: This is a reason that pagans are “alienated from the life of God” (4:18b). They are alienated or separated from the life that God gives them because they are ignorant.

Here they are ignorant because they have decided they do not want to know about God. They refused to listen to anything about the life God gives.

due to the hardness of their hearts: The clause hardness of their hearts is an idiom. It means that the Gentiles, referred to in 4:17b are “stubborn,” or “obstinate.” They do not understand things about God, because they stubbornly refuse to.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

because of their stubbornness

because they refuse to listen

Their heads are like stone; they truly don't listen

There are several ways to connect this clause to the rest of 4:18. The main two interpretations are:

1. It indicates the second reason that the Gentiles are “separated from the life of God” (4:18b). For example:

They have no part in the life that God gives, for they are completely ignorant and stubborn. (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NRSV, REB, GW, NLT)

1. It indicates the reason that they are ignorant. For example:

...because of the ignorance that is in them due to the hardness of their hearts. (NET) (NIV, RSV, NJB, NET, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Ephesians 4:19

Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God's people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don't live as pagans but as God's people

4:19

Commentators and versions differ on how 4:19a and 4:19b are connected to one another. There are two main interpretations:

1. “Having lost all sense of shame” is the reason “they have given themselves over to sensuality.” For example:

Since they no longer have any sense of shame (GW)

(BSB, NIV, NJB, GW, NET, REB, NASB, KJV, CEV)

1. “Having lost all sense of shame” and “they have given themselves over to sensuality” are separate examples connected by the word “and.” For example:

They have lost all feeling of shame, and... (NCV)

(RSV, GNT, NLT, NCV, ESV, JBP)

Since there is strong support for both interpretations, either is acceptable. It is recommended that you consult your national versions and follow their example.

4:19a

Having lost all sense of shame,

- Since/Because they no longer feel shame,
- They no longer feel guilty for doing evil things, so

Having lost all sense of shame: The phrase lost all sense of shame means that when the Gentiles do evil things, they are not ashamed of their actions. These people do evil things day after day, until their hearts (consciences) become “callous” (RSV); that is, they no longer feel ashamed or guilty.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

They no longer have any feelings about what is right (CEV)

They have no sense of shame (NLT)

4:19b

they have given themselves over to sensuality

- they have turned themselves over to doing immoral things
- they allow themselves to do evil/shameful things.

they have given themselves over to sensuality:

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as given themselves over means that “they have turned themselves over” to sensuality, or “they have handed themselves over” to sensuality.

sensuality: The Greek word for sensuality means shameful behavior, impure behavior, immoral ways, debauchery. This is talking mainly about sexual sins, but it may also include other evil behavior, such as getting drunk.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They live for lustful pleasure (NLT)

they do nothing else but shameful deeds

they pass their time behaving in shameful ways

4:19c

for the practice of every kind of impurity,

- resulting in their practice of every kind of immorality,
- They continually do all kinds of immoral acts/behaviours,

for the practice of every kind of impurity: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for the practice of also means “to continually do something” or “satisfy a desire.”

every kind of impurity: The word impurity means sexual immorality. It means almost the same thing as “sensuality” in 4:19b. For example:

They practice every kind of sexual perversion (GW)

4:19d

with a craving for more.

- and they want to do more.
- and they never stop desiring even more of these things.

with a craving for more: The Greek phrase which the BSB translates as craving for more is literally “in greediness.” These people are “greedy for more sin” or they “want to sin more.” Their sinful desires are never satisfied.

Some other ways to say this are:

they do not restrain themselves

they do not hold themselves back from doing all these immoral deeds

They continually seek for more sinful pleasure

Ephesians 4:20

Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God’s people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don’t live as pagans but as God’s people

4:20

But this is not the way you came to know Christ.

- ¶ But that is not what you learned about Christ.
- ¶ But you did not learn to behave like that when you learned about Christ.

But this: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But shows a contrast between two groups of people. In 4:17–19 Paul talked about people who did not know God and the way they acted. Here in 4:20, he said that his readers were not like that. Another way to translate this is:

But you, you did not...

is not the way you came to know Christ: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as is not the way you came to know Christ is literally “did not thus learn Christ,” It means that when the Ephesians learned about Christ, they did not learn to continue to behave as Gentiles.

It is recommended that you follow the example of many English versions that retain the verb “learn.” For example:

That was not what you learned about Christ! (GNT)

But you did not learn about Christ like this (NET)

the way: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the way refers back to 4:17-19, “in the futility of their thinking,” etc. It refers to the way the Gentiles lived. Some versions simply translate this word as “that.” For example:

But that is not what you learned from Christ’s teachings. (GW)

Ephesians 4:21

Section 4:17-32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God’s people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don’t live as pagans but as God’s people

4:21a

Surely you heard of Him and were taught in Him—

- What you have heard about him and what your teachers taught you is surely
- I am sure that when you heard about Christ, you learned

Surely you heard of Him: The clause Surely you heard of Him expresses a strong assumption or a certainty: “I am sure you have heard of him....” This clause is similar to 3:2.

Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus.

and were taught in Him: The phrase taught in Him means “you were taught about him.” It is also a passive. If it would be more natural in your translation to make it active, you can say:

what your teachers taught you about him

4:21b

in keeping with the truth that is in Jesus—

- the true message from Jesus.
- the true teachings about him.

in keeping with the truth that is in Jesus: This clause means “That which they taught you agrees with the true teaching(s) about Jesus.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

just as the truth is in Jesus (NET)

the truth that comes from him (NLT)

Ephesians 4:22

Section 4:17-32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God’s people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don’t live as pagans but as God’s people

4:22-24

In these verses, Paul listed some of the things that the Ephesians were taught. Some English versions repeat the verb “You were taught...” (from 4:21a) at the beginning of 4:22. The BSB does not do this, but continues the sentence on from 4:21b. If, in your translation, you follow the example of those English versions that begin a new sentence here (like the NIV), you may also want to repeat “You were taught...” at the beginning of 4:23.

Here is another way to translate 4:22-24 as a direct command:

(4:22a) Stop behaving like you used to...

(4:24a) Let God make you a new person

4:22a**to put off your former way of life,**

- Your teachers taught you
- This is what you were taught:

4:22b**your old self,**

- to leave/abandon the way you used to behave.
- Stop behaving as you previously did.

4:22a–b

to put off your former way of life, your old self: The phrase your former way of life means “the way you used to live” or “the way you previously behaved when you did not yet know Christ.” The clause your old self is a figure of speech. It means “your former character” or “the behavior you used to do.” This is contrasted with “your new self” in 4:24.

The words put off in 4:22a and “put on” in 4:24 are words usually used to mean take off and put on clothes. A person can take off old, dirty clothes and put on new, clean clothes. In the same way, the Ephesian Christians should “take off” (stop doing) the dirty behavior they used to do, and “put on” (start doing) clean, Christian behavior.

your old self: The phrase your old self refers to “your former/previous character” or “the way you used to behave.” Paul was telling the Ephesians to no longer live the way they did before they became Christians. When a person becomes a Christian, it is as if he becomes a new person (see 2 Corinthians 5:17).

In translating this clause, it may be necessary to translate this figure of speech directly. For example:

change the way you were living (GW)

give up your old way of life (CEV)

4:22c**which is being corrupted by its deceitful desires;**

- Your evil desires deceived you and spoiled/ruined your lives.
- At that time, you desired to do all kinds of evil things. Those things were leading you astray and were destroying your life.

which is being corrupted: The word which refers back to “old self” in 4:22b.

is being corrupted: The word corrupted can mean to “rot away,” “decay,” “ruin” or “destroy.” To say that a person is being corrupted means he is becoming controlled by evil, until finally he is destroyed. He is like

a tree that gets more and more rotten on the inside until it dies and is destroyed.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

being destroyed (GNT)

being ruined

by its deceitful desires: The phrase deceitful desires refers to evil things the Ephesians wanted to do that led them away from the truth/Christ. In many languages it will probably be clearer to translate deceitful and desires as verbs, for example:

You desired to do evil things, and these things deceived you.

Paul meant that the evil desires in people’s hearts caused them to believe the wrong things and follow their own way instead of following God’s way. 4:22c can be translated:

The things you wanted to do were wrong and deceived you, and so they ruined/spoiled your hearts.

General Comment on 4:22a–c

You may want to translate 4:22c as a new sentence. For example:

The way you used to live at that time was ruining your life...

Ephesians 4:23**Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior**

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God’s people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don't live as pagans but as God's people

4:23

to be renewed in the spirit of your minds;

- Your teachers taught you to let God renew your attitudes.
- Now you should let God change/renew the way you think.

If you repeated the clause "You were taught..." at the beginning of 4:22a, you may also want to repeat it at the beginning of 4:23. See, for example:

However, you were taught to have a new attitude.
(GW)

to be renewed: The phrase to be renewed means to let God change you inside and make you into a new person in a spiritual sense. What Paul said here in 4:23 is similar to Romans 12:2 and Colossians 3:10.

in the spirit of your minds: Scholars interpret the phrase that the BSB literally translates as the spirit of your minds in two ways:

1. the phrase refers to one item; that is, the attitude of a person or the way a person thinks. They must allow God to renew their attitudes. For example:

Let the Spirit change your way of thinking (CEV)
(BSB, NIV, RSV, NET, NASB, KJV, GW, ESV, CEV)

1. the phrase refers to two items; that is, the spirit and the mind. They must allow God to renew their spirits and their minds. For example:

Your hearts and minds must be made completely new (GNT) (GNT, REB, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of English versions.

Ephesians 4:24

Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God's people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don't live as pagans but as God's people

4:24a

and to put on the new self, created to be like God

- They also taught you to start behaving/acting like the new people that God made you to be—with a character like his character.
- God has given you a new character that is like his own character. So behave according to this new character.

to put on the new self: The clause put on the new self is a figure of speech. It means to "start behaving like the new person God made you to be (when you became a Christian)." Just like a person puts on new, clean clothes, so we are to start living a new, clean life. This is the same image as "put off your old self" in 4:22a.

You should translate it in a way that is consistent with how you translated 4:22a.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

to become a new person (GW)

make you into a new person (CEV)

created to be like God: This is a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb, you can say:

which God created/made to be like himself

God created your new self to be like himself

4:24b

in true righteousness and holiness.

- Be truly righteous and holy.
- You should be truly upright and pure of sin.

in true righteousness and holiness: There are two issues which you must decide before you translate this part of the verse.

The first issue is how this phrase is connected to 4:24a. The SSA considers this phrase to state the ways in which the new man is to be like God. He is to be truly

righteous and truly holy. A good model to follow is the NCV which says:

^{24a}That new person is made to be like God—^{24b}made to be truly good and holy (NCV)

The second issue to decide is how the word true is connected to righteousness and holiness. A literal English translation of the Greek text is “in righteousness and holiness of the truth.” Scholars differ about how to connect “truth” to righteousness and holiness. Some of the main alternatives are:

1. Truth goes with both righteousness and holiness. For example:

truly righteous and holy (GW) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NLT, GW, NCV)

1. Truth goes with only holiness. For example:

in righteousness and true holiness (KJV) (CEV, KJV)

1. Truth is the source of righteousness and holiness. For example:

in righteousness and holiness that comes from truth (NET) (NET, UBS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English versions.

In many languages it will not be clear to translate the phrase in true righteousness and holiness literally. It may be best to begin a new sentence instead. For example:

Your behavior should be truly righteous and holy.

righteousness and holiness: The words righteousness and holiness are very similar in meaning. The word righteousness means “morally upright,” “straight,” “pleasing to God.” Another way righteousness has been translated is:

upright (GNT)

See righteous in the Glossary for more information.

holiness: The word holiness means “morally clean and pure.” See how you translated “holy” in 2:21b and 3:5c. See holy, Meaning 5 in the Glossary.

Ephesians 4:25

Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God’s people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don’t live as pagans but as God’s people

Paragraph 4:25–28

In this paragraph, Paul gave many commands that talk about specific kinds of behavior that Christians should not do and kinds of behavior that Christians should do.

4:25a

Therefore each of you must put off falsehood

- ¶ Therefore, do not tell lies any more.
- ¶ So, each one of you should stop lying.

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB has translated Therefore connects the previous paragraph (4:20–24) as a basis for the commands in this paragraph. It indicates the following: since we have new lives, as a result or therefore, we must act like it. Some other ways Therefore has been translated include:

So (NLT, NCV)

So then (GW)

then (GNT)

For that reason

Translate the conjunction in a way that is natural in your language.

each of you must put off falsehood: The phrase put off falsehood is a figure of speech. It is the same verb as in 4:22a, “put off your old self.” It means to “stop lying” or “stop telling lies.” If it would not be natural

in your language to use this figure of speech, you may want to translate it directly. For example:

stop telling lies (NLT)

No more lying (GNT)

4:25b

and speak truthfully to his neighbor,

- Tell the truth to one another,
- Each person should speak the truth to his fellow believer,

speak truthfully to his neighbor: In this verse neighbor means “fellow Christian,” because Paul goes on to say that they are all members of one body (see 4:4).

A more general way to translate neighbor is “each other.” For example:

Stop lying and start telling each other the truth.
(CEV)

4:25c

for we are all members of one another.

- because we are like different parts of the same body.
- because we are all members together in the body of Christ. (GNT)

for we are all members of one another: Paul has referred often to this metaphor of believers as members of one another.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

members together in the body of Christ (GNT)

See how you translated this metaphor in 4:4a, 4:12b, 4:16a.

General Comment on 4:25a–c

In some languages, it may be natural to reorder 25a–c. For example:

^{25c}We are Christ’s body, we are like his hands and legs. ^{25a}Therefore, don’t lie to your brothers and sisters, ^{25b}rather speak the truth to them.

Ephesians 4:26

Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged

them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God’s people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don’t live as pagans but as God’s people

Paragraph 4:25–28

In this paragraph, Paul gave many commands that talk about specific kinds of behavior that Christians should not do and kinds of behavior that Christians should do.

4:26a

“Be angry, yet do not sin.”

- If/when you become angry, do not sin.
- If you become angry, do not let your anger lead you into sin. (GNT)

Paul quoted from Psalm 4:4. Several English versions indicate this by using quote marks (as in the BSB), other special formatting, or a footnote. Use the form here that you use for other Old Testament quotations in your translation.

You may also want to add a footnote stating that this is a quotation from Psalm 4:4. For example:

In this verse Paul quotes Psalm 4:4. To indicate this, the BSB has put quotation marks around the part that is quoted.

Be angry: Another way to say Be angry is: “If/when you become angry.” In this verse Paul taught us that we can be angry without sinning. But we need to be careful, because it is easy to sin when we are angry.

yet do not sin: The word sin refers to an offense against God. Sin includes an act, thought, and attitude that is not what God wants or approves of. A person can also offend God by not doing what God wants him to do.

It is helpful to translate sin with a general term that can include any offense against God. Here are some problems to avoid:

1. The term should not imply that only serious crimes like murder or stealing are sins. Other offenses like gossip and greed are also sins.
2. The term should not include accidents or mistakes that are not against God's will.

Some ways to translate sin are:

wrong act

offense against God

evil deed

4:26b

Do not let the sun set upon your anger,

- Before the end of the day you must stop being angry.
- Do not stay angry after sunset.
- Do not be angry for more than a day,

Do not let the sun set upon your anger: Paul is using figurative language here. In his culture, sunset marked the end of a day and the beginning of the next day. So, this sentence means “stop being angry before the end of the day” or “end your anger before you go to bed.”

Paul said that we should not continue being angry for a long time.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

Don't go to bed angry. (GW, CEV)

do not stay angry all day (GNT)

Ephesians 4:27

Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God's people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don't live as pagans but as God's people

Paragraph 4:25–28

In this paragraph, Paul gave many commands that talk about specific kinds of behavior that Christians should not do and kinds of behavior that Christians should do.

4:27

and do not give the devil a foothold.

- Do not give the devil a chance/opportunity to deceive/tempt you through this.
- so that you do not make it easy for Satan to tempt you to sin.

If it is natural in your language, you may want to follow the model of some English versions which connect 4:27 with 4:26 (See 4:26–27 in the NJB, NLT).

Here are some ways to connect these two verses:

²⁶Do not let the sun do down while we are still angry, ²⁷because if we do we will give the devil an opportunity to tempt us to sin.

²⁶Stop being angry before the end of the day, ²⁷so that you do not give the Devil an opportunity....

and do not give the devil a foothold: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as do not give the devil a foothold is literally “do not give the devil a place.” This means “do not give the devil a chance or opportunity to deceive you” or “do not make it easy for the devil to tempt you to do wrong.”

the devil: The devil is the ruler of all evil spirits. The name of the devil is Satan. See devil in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

Don't give the devil any opportunity to work. (GW)

and don't give the devil a chance (CEV)

And don't allow Satan to take advantage of your anger to lead you into sin

Ephesians 4:28

Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (for-

mer) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God's people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don't live as pagans but as God's people

Paragraph 4:25–28

In this paragraph, Paul gave many commands that talk about specific kinds of behavior that Christians should not do and kinds of behavior that Christians should do.

4:28a

He who has been stealing must steal no longer,

- The person who was a thief must not steal anymore,
- If you^(plur) have been a thief, you must stop stealing.

He who has been stealing must steal no longer:

Paul is speaking to the Ephesians who would have been thieves before their conversion to Christianity. Paul is reminding the Ephesians that stealing is not acceptable behavior for Christians.

In the Greek text, this is a direct declarative statement. Some English versions translate it as a conditional statement. If it is more natural in your language, you may want to translate this sentence in a conditional form. For example:

If you are a thief, quit stealing. (NLT)

must steal no longer: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

must stop stealing (NCV)

quit stealing (NLT)

must stop robbing (GNT)

4:28b

but must work, doing good with his own hands,

- but he must work honestly with his own hands,
- Instead, you^(plur) must work honestly for your daily food,

but must: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as but must is literally “but rather.” It is used to show a strong contrast between 4:28a and 4:28b. Translate this phrase in a way that would naturally show a strong contrast in your language.

work...with his own hands: To work...with his own hands is a figure of speech that means “to work for his daily food,” “to work to support himself,” or “to work so he can buy (or make or grow) the things he needs to live.” The thief formerly used his hands to steal, but now he should use his hands to do honest, good, and hard work.

Most people use their hands when they work, for example, farmers and carpenters. But Paul does not mean that former thieves must do only manual work (work with their hands) and no other kind of work.

In some languages, it may not be necessary to explicitly translate the phrase with his own hands. For example:

They should earn an honest living for themselves.
(NCV)

doing good: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as doing good is literally “at (something) good.” Commentators are divided as to what it means in this context. The main two interpretations are:

1. It refers to “honest work.” For example:

doing honest work... (RSV, GNT, ESV, NJB, NCV)

1. It refers to good or useful work. For example:

They should do something good... (BSB, GW, NIV, NLT, NET)

Since both interpretations have good translation and commentary support, either one is acceptable. You may want to follow the interpretation of your national translation.

4:28c

that he may have something to share with the one in need.

- in order to also have something to share with poor people.
- so that you will have enough to give to the people who don't have things.

that he may have something to share with the one in need: The phrase the one in need refers to people who are poor and in need of food and clothing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and then give generously to others in need (NLT)

so you will have something to give to people in need (CEV)

If he does that, he will be able to give to people who don't have things.

Ephesians 4:29

Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God's people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don't live as pagans but as God's people

Paragraph 4:29–32

In this paragraph, Paul gave additional commands about proper Christian behavior for the Ephesians. He lists speaking words that encourage others, being careful not to grieve the Holy Spirit, getting rid of bad behavior, and being kind to others and forgiving others.

4:29a

Let no unwholesome talk come out of your mouths,

- ¶ Do not say harmful words to each other,
- ¶ When you talk, do not use rude/coarse words.

Let no unwholesome talk: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as unwholesome talk is literally “corrupt talk.” It refers to words that hurt other people. It may include things like profanity, talking in rude or coarse ways, insulting people and saying hateful things about people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

foul or abusive language (NLT)

say anything that would hurt another person (GW)

come out of your mouths: The clause come out of your mouths is a figure of speech that simply means that we should not say or speak unwholesome things. This sentence may be unnatural if you translate it literally in your language. Translate this in a natural way in your language. For example:

Do not let harmful talk be on your tongue/lips

Never say profane things

4:29b

but only what is helpful for building up the one in need

- but say words which will help people to grow strong in their hearts/faith.
- Instead, say things which will encourage others.

but: The conjunction but here introduces a contrast. In 4:29a Paul told the Ephesians what they should not do. Here he is telling them what they should do. Translate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

instead

but rather

only what is helpful: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates here as what is helpful is literally “any good (word).”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

good and helpful (NLT)

what is good (GW)

say only what helps other people

for building up the one in need: The phrase for building up means to “encourage” or to “make stronger/mature in their faith.” See how you translated the similar phrase “built up” in 4:12b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to become stronger in their faith

that cause others to trust Christ/God more

that help others to be more mature in their relationship/walk with Christ

that they would stand strong in Christ

4:29c and bringing grace to those who listen.

- Say what they need to hear, so that your words will help them to grow.
- Say things that people need to hear at that time, so you can help the people with whom you are talking.

bringing grace to those who listen: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as bringing grace is literally “give grace.” It means to “do good” or “give help.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

so that your words will be an encouragement to those who hear them (NLT)

so that what you say will do good to those who hear you (GNT)

See grace, Meaning 5 in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 4:30

Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God’s people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don’t live as pagans but as God’s people

Paragraph 4:29–32

In this paragraph, Paul gave additional commands about proper Christian behavior for the Ephesians. He lists speaking words that encourage others, being careful not to grieve the Holy Spirit, getting rid of bad behavior, and being kind to others and forgiving others.

4:30

In 4:30b–c Paul repeated part of a metaphor that he used in 1:13b–14. This metaphor is about the Holy Spirit. In both passages, Paul said that God sealed us with the Holy Spirit. This shows that we belong to God.

In 1:14a Paul also added that the Holy Spirit is like a deposit or guarantee that one day God will redeem us. The idea of a guarantee is not explicit in 4:30, but some translations make it explicit to make the verse more clear. For example:

a guarantee that the Day will come when God will set you free (GNT)

See below under 4:30c for other examples of this.

4:30a

And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God,

- Do not cause the Holy Spirit of God to be sad.
- Take care that you do not cause the Holy Spirit sorrow.

And do not grieve: The word grieve means “to sadden,” “to cause sorrow” or “to cause grief or emotional pain.” Some other ways grieve has been translated include:

make sad (NCV)

bring sorrow to (NLT)

the Holy Spirit of God: See how you translated Holy Spirit 1:13e. Also see Holy, Meaning 3 in the Glossary for more information.

4:30b

in whom you were sealed

- God sealed you with his Holy Spirit
- The Holy Spirit is like a mark which God put on you, to show that you belong to him, and
- God gave you the Holy Spirit. This is like a sign that you belong to him.

in whom you were sealed: The clause in whom you were sealed is passive. If it would be more natural in your language to make it active, you can say: “God sealed you in/with his Holy Spirit.”

sealed: In NT times, a seal was the personal sign of an owner showing that something marked with a person’s seal belonged to him. Here God sealed his people with his Holy Spirit to show that they belong to him.

For the translation of sealed, you may:

- Use a verb or noun in your language that means seal. For example:

tribal mark/sign

mark (put on animals) to show ownership

- Use a simile. If a metaphor is not clear (“God sealed you with the Holy Spirit”), you can say:

When God gave you the Holy Spirit, it was as if he put his seal/mark of ownership on you

- If this figure of speech is confusing, you may have to translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

God gave you the Holy Spirit to show that you belong to him

Paul used this same metaphor to describe the Holy Spirit in 1:13c. You should translate the expression “you were sealed” in 4:30 in a way that is similar to the way you translated it in 1:13c.

4:30c for the day of redemption.

- who guarantees/assures you that one day God will completely redeem you.
- to show that God will make you free when the final day comes. (NCV)
- It also shows that one day God will deliver/free you from sin/evil.

for the day of redemption: The phrase the day of redemption refers to a future time when God will completely redeem or deliver/free Christians from sin and the evil of this world. Here Paul is talking to the Christians in Ephesus.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

he is the guarantee that one day God will completely redeem you

to show that God will make you free when the final day comes (NCV)

a guarantee that the Day will come when God will set you free (GNT)

See how you translated redemption in 1:14b. See redeem in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 4:31

Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God’s people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don’t live as pagans but as God’s people

Paragraph 4:29–32

In this paragraph, Paul gave additional commands about proper Christian behavior for the Ephesians. He lists speaking words that encourage others, being careful not to grieve the Holy Spirit, getting rid of bad behavior, and being kind to others and forgiving others.

4:31a Get rid of all

- Remove from your hearts all
- You must completely stop
- Do not let any

Get rid of all: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Get rid of all is literally “Let all (bitterness, rage, anger) be removed from you.” This is a passive. The BSB and some other translations have changed the passive form to an active form. This active form is a strong way of saying, “Eliminate all...” or “Stop being [bitter, angry...].”

This is a figure of speech similar to “put off” in 4:22a. It is as if the sins of bitterness and anger are physical objects that we can throw away.

Translate this command in a way that is natural in your language. The first two meaning lines of the Display are examples with an active form. The third meaning line is an example of a passive form.

4:31b

bitterness, rage and anger,

- bitter thoughts, rage, anger,
- being bitter/resentful towards other people. Stop being angry and mean.
- bitterness, rage, anger,

bitterness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bitterness means feeling resentful or hatred toward someone or something that happened.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

resentment

very bad feelings against others

hatred

rage and anger: The Greek words the BSB translates as rage and anger are very similar. The word translated as rage refers to a loud outburst of anger. The word translated as anger refers to an inward angry feeling.

Here are some ways to translate these words:

bad temper or anger (NJB)

hot tempers, anger (GW)

angry and mad (CEV)

intense feeling of anger or wrath

4:31c

outcry and slander,

- loud disputing, insulting
- Stop quarrelling with people. Do not insult them.
- harsh words, and slander,

outcry: The Greek word that the BSB translates as outcry refers to a loud shout of grief or anger.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

loud quarrelling (GW)

harsh words (NLT)

loud disputes

slander: The word slander refers to insults, or saying untrue things about people.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

insults (GNT)

cursing (GW)

4:31d

along with every form of malice.

- and all kinds of evil behaviour.
- Do not do any hateful thing at all.
- as well as all types of evil behavior.

along with every form of malice: The Greek word that the BSB translates as malice is a general word covering all kinds of evil or hateful behavior. Some other ways this phrase has been translated include:

all types of evil behavior (NLT)

hateful feelings of any sort (GNT)

General Comment on 4:31b–d

Think about idioms or natural ways to describe these kinds of behavior in your language. For example, “bitterness” may be “having a small liver,” “rage and anger” may be “Do not be angry and have bones in your heart” or “do not let your intestines be all knotted up.”

Ephesians 4:32

Section 4:17–32: We should change our behavior

Paul urged the Christians to stop doing the evil deeds that they used to do before they knew God. He urged them to start doing the good things that people who know Christ should do. He gave examples of old (former) behavior that they must stop doing, for example: lying, theft, anger and slander. Instead they must be kind, tender and forgiving.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Live as God's people (GW)

The old life and the new life (CEV)

Don't live as pagans but as God's people

Paragraph 4:29–32

In this paragraph, Paul gave additional commands about proper Christian behavior for the Ephesians. He lists speaking words that encourage others, being careful not to grieve the Holy Spirit, getting rid of bad behavior, and being kind to others and forgiving others.

4:32

In 4:31, Paul gave examples of bad behaviors Christians should not do. Here in 4:32, he gives good examples of behaviors that Christians should do.

4:32a

Be kind and tenderhearted to one another,

- Be kind to one another and love one another.
- But/Instead do good things to one another, and show mercy.

Be kind: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Be kind means to do good to others, be generous and helpful.

tenderhearted: The word tenderhearted means to show love and mercy to people, to be sympathetic, to feel love and pity for those in pain.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

sympathetic (GW)

tender-hearted (KJV)

caring

4:32b

forgiving each other

- Forgive one another,
- Forgive other people for the harmful things they have done to you,

forgiving each other: The Greek word that the BSB translates as forgiving is more literally “graciously give” or “give generously” toward someone. This word is similar in meaning to the previous words “kind” and “compassionate.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

pardon

erase the guilt of someone

forget/cancel the wrong that person has done

You may need to make explicit what we are to forgive. For example:

forgive other people for the wrong things they have done to you

Also, see the note on “forgiveness of our trespasses” in 1:7b and forgive in the Glossary for more information.

4:32c

just as in Christ God forgave you.

- just as God forgave you because of Christ.
- in the same way as God has forgiven you for your sinful behaviour. He did this because of what Christ did.

just as in Christ God forgave you: The words just as in this context means “generously forgive each other in just the same way that God generously forgave you.”

in Christ: See the note at 1:3b on in Christ for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God forgave you because of that which Christ did for you.

God forgave you by uniting you with Christ.

If necessary, you can translate in Christ as a separate sentence. For example:

Christ made this possible. (UBS handbook)

forgave you: See how you translated “forgiving” in 4:32b. See forgive in the Glossary for more information.

General Comment on 4:32b–c

If it is more natural in your language, you can reverse 4:32b–c like this:

^{32c}God forgave you because of Christ, ^{32b}and so you should forgive each other.

If your language requires stating what is forgiven, you can translate like this:

God forgave your sins because of what Jesus did, so if people do bad behavior to you, you should forgive them too

Ephesians 5:1

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

5:1a

Be imitators of God, therefore,

- ¶ Therefore, imitate God,
- ¶ So in conclusion behave like God,

Be imitators of God: The word “imitate” means “to copy the behavior, appearance, or speech, of another person.” People who are imitators of God are those who “behave in the same way as God.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

try to be like God (GNT, NCV)

do as God does (CEV)

therefore: The conjunction therefore links 4:32 to 5:1 as an expanded conclusion. In 4:32 Paul said that we should be kind, considerate and forgive others just as God has forgiven us. In 5:1, Paul made a conclusion with a more general statement and expanded on it in

the following verses. We should follow God’s example in all our behavior.

In some languages, it will not be natural to translate this conjunction here. Some English versions leave it untranslated.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

In conclusion

5:1b

as beloved children,

- since you are his children whom he loves very much.
- because he is your heavenly father and he loves you very much.

as beloved children: Here Paul figuratively refers to his readers as as beloved children of God. It should be clear in your translation that that the beloved children are God’s rather than Paul’s. Some translations make this explicit. For example:

because you are his dear children (NLT)

since you are the children he loves (GW)

Since you are God’s dear children (GNT)

See love, meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

General Comment on 5:1a–b

If it is more natural in your language to reverse 5:1a–b, you may want to do so. For example:

^{5:1b}Since you are God’s dear children, ^{5:1a}you must try to be like him. (GNT)

Ephesians 5:2

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

5:2a and walk in love,

- Love other people always,
- In your actions every day, always be loving towards other people,

and walk in love: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as walk in love refers to the loving quality of our daily actions. All our actions should be controlled by our love for others.

In many languages it is not natural to say and walk in love. It may also be unnatural to say:

be full of love (LB)

be controlled by love (GNT)

Instead, you may want to translate love as a verb and say:

love one another

Love people

See love, meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information. For other references to “walk,” see notes on 2:2a, 2:10c, 4:1b.

5:2b just as Christ loved us and gave Himself up for us

- just as Christ loves us and died for us.
- in the same way that Christ showed his love for us by dying to save us.

just as: The phrase just as here means “in the same way as.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

following the example of (NLT)

Christ loved us and gave Himself up for us: The two past tense verbs, loved and gave Himself up refer to what Christ did in the past.

Here is another way to translate this sentence:

Christ showed his love for us by dying for us

You may want to translate the verb “love” using the present tense to avoid suggesting that he loved us only in the past. For example:

he loves us

gave Himself up for us: The phrase gave Himself up for us refers to Christ willingly dying on the cross for us. Some other ways this phrase may be translated include:

offered his life for us (CEV)

gave his life for us (GNT)

he died to help/save us

5:2c as a fragrant sacrificial offering to God.

- He gave his life to God as a sweet smelling offering.
- What he did was like a good smelling offering to God which made God happy.

as a fragrant sacrificial offering to God: The phrase as a fragrant sacrificial offering to God is a metaphor. Priests burned sacrifices to God, and the smell of the smoke was fragrant/sweet and pleased God. In the same way, Christ gave himself as a sacrifice to die to redeem mankind, and what he did pleased God.

It may be clearer for your translation to translate this metaphor as a simile. For example:

it was like a fragrant offering to God which pleased him

fragrant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fragrant is literally “sweet-smelling.” It also implies that Christ’s sacrifice on the cross was pleasing to God. One model to follow here is the GNT that has translated fragrant with both meanings:

as a sweet-smelling offering and sacrifice that pleases God (GNT)

sacrificial offering: The words offering and sacrificial are similar in meaning and in this verse can be treated as a doublet. This means that you can translate both words by one term in your language. For example:

He loved us and offered himself as a sacrifice for us, a pleasing aroma to God. (NLT)

General Comment on 5:2a–c

In some languages, it may be natural to change the order of 5:2a–c. For example:

^{5:2b}Just as Christ loved us and gave his body ^{5:2c}as a nice smelling offering to God for us, ^{5:2a}so you are to love people.

Ephesians 5:3

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

5:3a–b

But among you...there must not be even a hint: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as not be even a hint is literally “not even be named.” There are several ways to understand this expression. It can mean:

1. There should not even be a reason for rumors or gossip that the Ephesians committed these sins. In other words, Christians should have such pure behavior that it will never cause non-Christians to even talk about Christians doing these kinds of sins. For example:

don’t let it be said that any of you are immoral (CEV) (BSB, NIV, CEV, UBS, SSA)

1. These sins should not be mentioned by the Ephesians. This means that Christians themselves should not even talk about such sins in their conversation. For example:

don’t even talk about such things (JBP) (GNT, NRSV, REB, GW, ESV, JBP)

1. These sins should not occur among Christians. For example:

Such sins have no place among God’s people. (NLT) (NET, NLT, NCV)

Paul is urging the Ephesians to keep themselves far away from this sort of sinful behavior. Since Paul is himself, discussing and warning the Ephesians against these sins, (2) seems unlikely. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), but (3) is also acceptable.

5:3a

But among you, as is proper among the saints,

- But, because these things are not proper for God’s holy people,
- Now, because it is not right/appropriate for God’s holy people to do these things,

as is proper: The word proper means “suitable.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

right (NCV)

it should be

among the saints: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints is literally “holy ones.” It means “people set apart for God.” This Greek word refers to every believer. It can be translated as:

God’s people

people who belong to God

Many English versions translate this word as saints. All Christians are saints. This word does not refer only to special people that the modern church regards as “saints.”

See how you translated the similar phrase “saints” in 4:12a. And see Holy, Meaning 1, special use in the Glossary, if you want more information.

5:3b

there must not be even a hint of sexual immorality,

- do not give others a reason/cause to say that you^(plur) are sexually immoral,
- do not do anything that would even cause people to talk/gossip about you saying that you are sexually immoral.

sexual immorality: The term sexual immorality refers to all types of sexual behavior that are forbidden in God’s law. It includes adultery and all sexual relations outside of marriage. Another way this phrase has been translated is:

sexual sin (NCV)

5:3c

or of any kind of impurity, or of greed.

- or perverted, or greedy,
- Do not do anything shameful/perverted. Do not be greedy.

impurity: The word impurity is a stronger word for immorality and includes all perverted and unnatural sexual behavior. In the New Testament, this word is often used together with “sexual immorality.” (See Galatians 5:19 and Colossians 3:5.)

In your language, there may not be two different words that mean exactly the same things as “sexual immorality” and impurity. But you can probably find ways to talk about the same things. For example:

adultery and other kinds of sleeping around

taking a woman who is not your wife or other unacceptable actions like that

Try to make your translation clear, but do not use coarse words that are not appropriate to read in public.

greed: The word greed refers to a never-ending desire to get more than you have or deserve. While it is usually associated with material gain, in this context, it could also refer to a strong desire for sexual pleasure.

Your translation of greed should allow for a general understanding of the word.

General Comment on 5:3a–b

In some languages, it will be more natural to reorder parts of 5:3. For example:

^{3a}Since you are holy people, ^{3b}you must not do anything sexually immoral or ^{3c}shameful/perverted, and you must not be greedy. ^{3b}There must not even be a cause for rumors of such behavior ^{3a}among you.

^{3a}But among you ^{3b}there must not be even a hint of sexual immorality, ^{3c}or of any kind of impurity, or of greed, ^{3a}because these are improper for God’s holy people. (NIV)

Ephesians 5:4

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

5:4a–b

Paul said that when Christians talk, they should not use any shameful talk. He uses three terms for shameful talk: obscenity, foolish talk and coarse joking.

5:4a

Nor should there be obscenity,

- Also, you must not talk obscenely/shamefully
- Also, do not say/use obscene/vulgar words,

Nor: The NET translates Nor as “neither.”

should there be obscenity: The word obscenity refers to talking of sexual matters or other taboo subjects in a shameful, crude way.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

obscene stories (NLT)

dirty stories (GW)

5:4b

foolish talk, or crude joking,

- or stupidly or make/tell vulgar jokes.
- meaningless/unwise words or naughty/dirty jokes/stories.

foolish talk: The term foolish talk means saying things that are of no good use. This does not mean talking like a person who has not been to school or who is not intelligent.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

empty talk

flippant talk

disrespectful talk

In the OT, a fool was a person who ignored God or did not believe in God. So foolish talk may mean talking disrespectfully or lightly about serious things, making fun of God and other important things.

or crude joking: The term crude joking means “vulgar jokes,” which usually refers to jokes about sex.

In most languages there are terms for using vulgar and shameful language. You may have expressions like:

saying vulgar words

laughing about things that bring shame

telling stories that are not fit for people’s ears

General Comment on 5:4a–b

In some languages, two terms or even one generic term may be sufficient to express all the ideas in the three terms “obscenity, foolish talking and coarse joking.” For example:

don’t even talk about such things; they are no fit subjects for Christians to talk about (JBP)

5:4c

which are out of character,

- These are not suited for you.
- These things are not right for you. (NCV)

which are out of character: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as out of character means “not right,” or “not fitting.” It is the opposite of “proper” in 5:3a.

5:4d

but rather thanksgiving.

- Instead, give thanks to God. (GW)
- Instead, you should thank God for that which he does for you.

but rather thanksgiving: The clause but rather thanksgiving means “instead, give thanks to God” or “instead of doing those things, thank God for that which he has done for you.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Instead, let there be thankfulness to God. (NLT)

Rather you should give thanks to God. (GNT)

Ephesians 5:5

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

5:5a**For of this you can be sure:**

- You must know that
- You can be confident of this

For of this you can be sure: The clause For of this you can be sure indicates that Paul was emphasizing his words. He wanted his readers to know that what he was about to say was completely true and sure.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- As a statement. For example:

You can be sure of this (NCV)

For you can be confident of this one thing (NET)

- As a command. For example:

Be sure of this (RSV)

5:5b**No immoral, impure, or greedy person**

- no person who is sexually immoral or perverted or who is greedy
- no one who is immoral, indecent, or greedy

No immoral, impure, or greedy person: The three adjectives immoral, impure and greedy are each related to the three nouns in 5:3b and 5:3c, and they have the same meanings.

immoral: An immoral person is someone who practices all types of sexual behaviors (such as adultery) that are forbidden in God's law.

impure: An impure person is someone who practices perverted and unnatural sexual behavior.

greedy person: A greedy person is someone who has a never-ending desire to get more than he has or deserves.

5:5c**(that is, an idolater),**

- (being greedy is like worshipping idols)
- (for greed is a form of idolatry)

The BSB uses parentheses around the clause “that is, an idolater.” (See 5:5c in the Display.) Other versions, such as the NIV, use dashes. The dashes or parentheses show that this clause comes in the middle of the main thought.

In some languages, it is not natural to have a clause like this in the middle of the main sentence. If this is

the case in your language, see the General Comment below after 5:5d for other places to put this clause.

(that is, an idolater): There are two main ways to connect the word idolater to the preceding part of the verse.

1. It is connected only to the word greedy. The GNT clearly shows this interpretation by saying:

for greed is a form of idolatry (GNT) (BSB, GNT, REB, GW, NLT, JBP, NCV)

1. It is connected to all three words immoral, impure and greedy. For example:

Being greedy, indecent, or immoral is just another way of worshipping idols. (CEV) (NET, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as it has the most support among commentators and English versions.

idolater: An idolater is someone who worships idols. A greedy person is like an idolater because riches have become his god. It is as if he worships riches or possessions.

If it is difficult in your language to talk about idols or idolaters together with greed, you can say:

People who desire to get many possessions—we can say that they worship those possessions instead of God.

People who desire to get many possessions have made possessions their lord/boss instead of God.

5:5d**has any inheritance in the kingdom of Christ and of God.**

- will inherit/obtain the good things of the kingdom of Christ and of God.
- will have a share in the things that Christ and God give to those they rule.

has any inheritance in: Here Paul used the Greek word that the BSB translates as inheritance in a figurative sense. Inheritance literally refers to the money or property that someone receives when a relative dies. In its figurative sense, inheritance refers to all the good things that God has promised to give his people. It includes salvation and a future life in heaven. (This word also occurs in 1:14a.)

When Paul said that none of these people “has any inheritance in the kingdom...of God,” he meant that none of them will receive the blessings that God will give his people in his kingdom. These people will have no share in God’s kingdom. They will not be members of it or have a part in it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will never be part of (CEV)

will ever receive a share in (GNT)

the kingdom of Christ and of God: The phrase kingdom of Christ and of God refers to Christ and God’s activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It does not refer to a land or country that they rule over. In the Gospels, it is normally referred to as the “kingdom of God.” It refers to the relationship that he has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the people whom Christ and God rule

You will probably want to translate kingdom of...God here in the same way you translated it in the Gospels, for example in Mark 10:25. (For a discussion of the meaning of kingdom of...God, see kingdom in the Glossary.) The phrase “kingdom of God” is used many times in the NT. But Ephesians 5:5 is the only place in the Bible where the phrase “kingdom of Christ and of God” is used. (But Revelation 11:15 has a similar phrase: “the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ.”) If you translate “kingdom” as a noun, make sure it is clear in your translation that there are not two kingdoms: (the kingdom of Christ and the kingdom of God) but only one kingdom. You can translate it “the kingdom where Christ and God rule,” or “when God and Christ rule.”

General Comment on 5:5a–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder the parts of 5:5. For example:

^{5b}no person who is sexually immoral or shameful/perverted or who is greedy ^{5d}will have a share in the good things of the kingdom of Christ and of God. ^{5c}Being greedy is like worshiping idols.

^{5b}no person who is immoral or who does shameful things ^{5d}will inherit/obtain the things Christ and

God give to those they rule. ^{5b}A person who is greedy ^{5d}will not receive a part either, ^{5c}because he worships those things instead of God.

^{5b}people who commit adultery, have such minds, and greatly desire to have and consume things, ^{5c}false gods are important to them, God is not important to them. ^{5a}Understand this, ^{5d}if people behave like that they will truly never go into God and Christ’s land where they look after people.

Ephesians 5:6

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

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In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

Paragraph 5:6–14

Some English versions begin a new paragraph at 5:6. Others begin a new paragraph at 5:8.

In this paragraph, Paul used the words “darkness” and “light” in a metaphorical sense. These words will be discussed further below.

5:6a

Let no one deceive you with empty words,

- ¶ Do not let anyone deceive you by the foolish words/things they say.
- ¶ Do not let anyone trick you with meaningless words.

Let no one deceive you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deceive means “to trick someone into believing something that is false or bad.” In this

context, Paul meant this: If any people tell you that Christians are permitted to do these sinful things (mentioned in 5:3–5), do not believe them!

Here is another way to translate Let no one deceive you:

Don't be fooled (NLT)

“Do not let anyone make you believe their lies.”

with empty words: The phrase empty words refers to words that are useless, foolish or lies. In this context it refers to excusing the sinful behavior listed by Paul in 5:3–5. Excusing the sinful behavior means saying that it is ok for people to behave in these ways (God won't punish them for it). For example:

excuse these sins (NLT)

General Comment on 5:5a

In some language, it may be necessary to make the phrase “empty words” more clear. For example:

People may behave that way but if people lie and say that God will not punish them for such behavior, don't believe them.

5:6b

for because of such things the wrath of God is coming on the sons of disobedience.

- It is because people do these things that God will punish the people who disobey him.
- God will soon punish the people who disobey him, because they do these kinds of evil things I just mentioned.

for because of such things: The phrase such things refers to the sins listed in 5:3–5. This should be made clear in your translation.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

such things I just mentioned

because of sins like these (GW)

because of these very things (GNT)

Because if people behave in these ways

the wrath of God is coming: the wrath of God means “God shows that he is angry” or “God punishes.” Paul was talking about God doing something, not just feeling angry. (See note on “children of wrath” at 2:3d for more discussion on wrath.)

is coming: When Paul said God's wrath is coming, he probably means it will come soon. For example:

God's anger will come. (GNT)

In many languages you cannot talk about wrath or anger coming. You may have an idiom in your language, such as:

“God will strike them with punishment.”

You may have an idiom like the English:

God's anger falls on them

Or you may need to translate wrath in an active way:

God will punish them

on the sons of disobedience: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as the sons of disobedience refers to people who disobey God. It also refers back to the people described as “immoral, impure, and greedy” in 5:5b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

those who do not obey him (GNT)

the people who do not do what God commands

General Comment on 5:6

In some languages, it may be necessary to make parts of 5:6 explicit. For example:

People may behave in those ways, but if people lie and say that God will not punish them for such behavior, don't believe them. If people are disobedient and behave in such ways, then God will be angry and truly strike them.

Ephesians 5:7

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

Paragraph 5:6–14

Some English versions begin a new paragraph at 5:6. Others begin a new paragraph at 5:8.

In this paragraph, Paul used the words “darkness” and “light” in a metaphorical sense. These words will be discussed further below.

5:7

Therefore do not be partakers with them.

- So, do not join with the people who do those evil things.
- So, do not participate with such people in their disobedient behavior.

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces an appeal on the basis of what Paul said in 5:3–6. It indicates the following: God will punish immoral people, therefore, we must not participate in their evil deeds.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

So (GNT)

For that reason

Many versions do not translate the conjunction in 5:7. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

do not be partakers with them: The clause do not be partakers with them means that they should not join these people when they do evil things.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

So have nothing at all to do with such people.
(GNT)

Don't participate in the things these people do
(NLT)

-or-

do not be part of their group

-or-

If people behave in those ways, then don't be with them.

Ephesians 5:8

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

Paragraph 5:6–14

Some English versions begin a new paragraph at 5:6. Others begin a new paragraph at 5:8.

In this paragraph, Paul used the words “darkness” and “light” in a metaphorical sense. These words will be discussed further below.

5:8a–b

you were once darkness, but now you are light: Paul contrasted the way they once were in the past before they were Christians, with the way they now are, now that they are Christians.

darkness...light: The words darkness and light are metaphors here. Many languages use darkness and light as metaphors. In this context, darkness refers to being disobedient and separated from the will and purposes of God. Here, light represents having true knowledge about the will and purposes of God.

Paul uses this metaphor for several verses here, and often in his writings. You should try to keep the metaphors of light and dark, if possible.

5:8a

For you were once darkness,

- For formerly you were in darkness,
- Because even though your hearts were formerly dark in sin,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the reason that the Ephesians should not be partners with evil people. They should not be partners because they are now in the light.

Some versions do not translate this conjunction. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

you were once darkness: Here are some ways to translate this clause:

You used to be like people living in the dark (CEV)

your hearts were dark

you lived/dwelt in the dark

the darkness of disobedience and sin controlled you

5:8b

but now you are light in the Lord.

- but now you have entered into the light, because you are united with the Lord.
- God has now made your hearts light/bright with truth/goodness because you have become people of the Lord Jesus.

but now you are light: Here are some ways to translate this clause:

now you have light from the Lord (NLT)

now you have entered God’s light of truth and goodness

now God has made your hearts bright with purity and truth

Use expressions that are natural and clear in your language.

in the Lord: The phrase in the Lord means:

since you have become the Lord’s people

in union with the Lord (Jesus)

since you have become united to the Lord

Lord: Here the word Lord refers to Jesus. When Paul used the word Lord in his letters, he almost always meant the Lord Jesus.

5:8c

Walk as children of light,

- So behave like people who are in the light.
- Behave like people who know the truth should behave.

Walk: The Greek verb that the BSB literally translates as Walk means “behave.” See how you translated “walk/live” in 2:2a, 2:10c and 4:1b.)

as children of light: The phrase children of light here contrasts with the “sons of disobedience” in 5:6b. It refers to people who live in the light of God’s truth, that is, “people who behave as God wants.” All believers are children of light: they have turned away from their sins (darkness) and have come to Christ (light). For example:

people who belong to the light (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate “Walk as children of light”:

So act like people of the light (CEV)

So you must live like people who belong to the light (GNT)

Live as children who have light. (GW)

Ephesians 5:9

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

Paragraph 5:6–14

Some English versions begin a new paragraph at 5:6. Others begin a new paragraph at 5:8.

In this paragraph, Paul used the words “darkness” and “light” in a metaphorical sense. These words will be discussed further below.

5:9

for the fruit of the light consists in all goodness, righteousness, and truth.

- Because light produces/makes everything that is good and right and true.
- I say this because if people have the light of the truth, the result is that they behave in good, upright and honest ways.

In some English versions, verse 5:9 is marked by parentheses; that is, it is an extra thought added in between “walk as children of light” (5:8b) and “test and prove what pleases the Lord” (5:10). You could show this by starting the verse:

I say this because....

If you rearranged 5:5c you may want to rearrange this verse in the same way. If not, consider following the example of the BSB and set this verse apart with a comma. Or, you could use parentheses, as some English versions do (see the NIV).

for the fruit of the light: The phrase the fruit of the light contains two metaphors. Paul continues to use the metaphor of “light” introduced in 5:8b–c. Here in 5:9 he is introducing the metaphor of fruit of the light. Light is compared to a plant or a field that produces a harvest (fruit). Just as a plant produces fruit, so also spiritual light produces spiritual fruit: goodness, righteousness and truth.

In some languages, it may be necessary to drop the metaphor of fruit.

So here are some ways to translate this without using the metaphor of fruit:

For this light within you produces only what is good and right and true. (NLT)

-or-If people live in the light, the result is that they behave in good, upright and honest ways.

The light of the truth causes people to do good and upright and true things.

consists in all goodness, righteousness, and truth:

These are the qualities or kinds of behavior that people who are in the light (that is, Christians) should have.

goodness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as goodness means being good, kind and generous. In some languages it may not be natural to use nouns for qualities such as goodness. In that case it may be more natural to use a verb to express this idea. For example:

to do good things

be good

To act kindly

righteousness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as righteousness means being upright, moral, doing things that please God (see 4:24b).

Some other ways righteousness may be translated here include:

honest (CEV)

(everything) that has God's approval (GW)

live a straight life

See righteous in the Glossary for more information.

truth: The word truth in this verse means “to behave in an honest, sincere manner.” It is not referring to something that is true and not false.

General Comment on 5:9

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate all three of these nouns (“goodness,” “righteousness,” and “truth”) in a form that is not a noun. For example:

for the fruit of light is found in all that is good and right and true

The people who walk in the light will bear fruit. They will do good behavior, walk the straight path, and speak the truth.

Ephesians 5:10

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

Paragraph 5:6–14

Some English versions begin a new paragraph at 5:6. Others begin a new paragraph at 5:8.

In this paragraph, Paul used the words “darkness” and “light” in a metaphorical sense. These words will be discussed further below.

5:10

Test and prove what pleases the Lord.

- Try to know/learn the things that please the Lord.
- So determine/discover what the Lord God, wants you^(plur) to do and do it.

Test and prove what pleases the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Test and prove here in this context means that Paul was telling the Ephesians to try to “discern, discover, determine,” what pleases the Lord. For example:

Determine which things please the Lord. (GW)

Here are some other ways to translate Test and prove:

Try to find out

try to learn (GNT)

Discern/discover

what pleases the Lord: This clause means “what the Lord wants you to do.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

what actions and thoughts cause the Lord to be pleased

what makes the Lord happy with us

Lord: Paul probably meant the Lord God here since the phrase “pleasing to the Lord” is often used in the OT when talking about God.

So if you need to specify whether it is the Lord Christ or the Lord God, choose Lord God.

Ephesians 5:11

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

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long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

Paragraph 5:6–14

Some English versions begin a new paragraph at 5:6. Others begin a new paragraph at 5:8.

In this paragraph, Paul used the words “darkness” and “light” in a metaphorical sense. These words will be discussed further below.

5:11a

Have no fellowship with the fruitless deeds of darkness,

- Do not participate in worthless acts that belong to the darkness.
- Do not join in doing the deeds that people do who are in the darkness of sin. The things they do have no value.

Have no fellowship with: The clause Have no fellowship with means “Do not participate in...” or “Take no part in...”

It is also similar in meaning to Paul’s words in 5:7 “do not be partners with” people who do evil. In 5:7, Paul said that the Ephesians should not be included in the group of those who do evil. Here in 5:11, he said that they should not be involved in their deeds.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Do not participate in (NET)

Take no part in (RSV, NLT)

the fruitless deeds of darkness: This clause contains two metaphors and is parallel to “fruit of the light” in 5:9.

fruitless deeds: This refers to worthless, sinful acts. If you dropped the figure of fruit in 5:9, you will probably

also have to drop the figure of fruitless here. However, if possible, try to keep the metaphor of darkness in your translation.

If in your translation you want to make explicit the people who do the deeds, you could say:

Do not join in doing the deeds of people who are in the darkness.

darkness: The word darkness is a metaphor. It refers to being disobedient and separated from the will and purposes of God. See how you translated it in 5:8a and translate it the same way here.

In some languages, it may be natural to change the order of these two clauses. For example:

People who don’t walk in the light don’t bear fruit, stay far away from them

5:11b

but rather expose them.

- Instead, bring these sinful deeds into the open/light.
- Instead, show people that these things/deeds are evil.

but rather: The phrase but rather introduces a contrast between 5:11a and 5:11b. This is the type of negative-positive contrast, “Don’t do...but instead do...” In 5:11a Paul encouraged the Ephesians to not participate in “the fruitless deeds of darkness.” Now he is exhorting them to show others that the “fruitless deeds of darkness” are evil.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

But instead (RSV)

But (NCV)

But, on the contrary (NJB)

Instead

expose them: Here and in 5:13 (where the context is “light”) the Greek verb that the BSB translates as expose means, “bring into the open,” or “bring into the light.” When a person says to someone “What you are doing is evil, it is against God’s teaching,” it is like shining a light on his or her evil deeds, thus “exposing” the fruitless deeds.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

bring them out to the light (GNT)

show that they are wrong (NCV)

make it clear to people that this kind of behavior is wrong

them: The pronoun them refers to “the fruitless deeds of darkness.”

Ephesians 5:12

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

Paragraph 5:6–14

Some English versions begin a new paragraph at 5:6. Others begin a new paragraph at 5:8.

In this paragraph, Paul used the words “darkness” and “light” in a metaphorical sense. These words will be discussed further below.

5:12

For it is shameful even to mention what the disobedient do in secret.

- It is embarrassing even to speak about the secret things/deeds that unbelieving people do.
- If someone even talks about the things/sins that these people do when other people cannot see them, he will feel the shame of these sins.

The GNT translates 5:12 in parentheses:

(¹²It is really too shameful even to talk about the things they do in secret.)

The thought of 5:13 connects directly with 5:11. See how you translated 5:9, which many versions also translate in parentheses. Translate 5:12 in a way that is natural for your language.

For it is shameful even to mention: The clause For it is shameful even to mention means that Christians should feel ashamed or embarrassed to even talk about the evil deeds that non-Christians do.

what the disobedient do: The word disobedient is not in the Greek text. The Greek text literally says, “being done by them” which refers to those people who do evil deeds. The BSB has supplied the word disobedient in order to make the pronoun “them” more explicit.

Another way you could make the pronoun “them” more explicit, is to say:

those people

those unbelieving people

in secret: In the Greek text, this is literally “the hidden/secret things.”

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

the things people do which others cannot see

the things people do when other people cannot see them

Ephesians 5:13

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

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Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

Paragraph 5:6–14

Some English versions begin a new paragraph at 5:6. Others begin a new paragraph at 5:8.

In this paragraph, Paul used the words “darkness” and “light” in a metaphorical sense. These words will be discussed further below.

5:13a

But everything exposed by the light becomes visible,

- When light shines on something, everyone can see what it is like,
- When one brings such things into the light/open, people see what these things are truly like,

But everything exposed by the light becomes visible: This sentence continues to explain the metaphor of light. Paul is also further explaining what he meant by “expose them” in 5:11b.

The meaning of the figure of speech can be explained like this: “When we shine light on something, people can clearly see what it looks like. In the same way, when people do evil deeds in secret and we tell them what God’s Word says, it is as if we are bringing their deeds out into the light. We make them see how evil their deeds are in God’s eyes.”

You should retain this figure of light because Paul used it throughout this section.

everything: The word everything refers to the things done in secret in 5:12.

Here are some other ways to translate 5:13:

And when all things are brought out to the light, then their true nature is clearly revealed (GNT)

But the light will show what these things are really like (CEV)

5:13b

for everything that is illuminated becomes a light itself.

- because when the light reveals/shows something, that thing itself becomes light.
- and whatever is exposed to the light itself becomes light (REB)

The BSB includes this verse part at the end of verse 13 (see also KJV, NASB, RSV). Many other English versions include this verse part at the beginning of verse 14 (see NIV, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NABRE, NET, NRSV). It may be best to follow the numbering system that is used in the major version in your area.

for everything that is illuminated becomes a light itself: Scholars have different views on the meaning of this clause. The meaning depends on whether the Greek verb that the BSB translates as illuminated has a passive or active meaning:

1. The verb has a passive meaning. The clause means that anything that has been revealed (by the light) is light or becomes light. Another way of saying it is: the darkness in things is replaced by the light so the things are transformed into light. The REB has perhaps the clearest translation of this interpretation:

whatever is exposed to the light itself becomes light (REB) (BSB, RSV, GNT, NASB, NJB, REB, NCV, JBP)

1. The verb has an active meaning. The clause means that light reveals/shows what the dark things are really like. This is what light always does. For example:

Light shows up everything (CEV) (NIV, NLT, NET, GW, CEV, ESV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Paul was thinking of the Ephesian Christians who were in darkness, but were now living in God’s light (5:8). When God’s light shines on the hearts of unbelievers, they stop doing their evil deeds. They come to the light and they become “children of light,” too. Here is one way to translate this:

For when the light shines on anything that is dark, that thing does not stay dark but becomes light/bright also.

Ephesians 5:14

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

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In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

Paragraph 5:6–14

Some English versions begin a new paragraph at 5:6. Others begin a new paragraph at 5:8.

In this paragraph, Paul used the words “darkness” and “light” in a metaphorical sense. These words will be discussed further below.

5:14a

So it is said:

- And for this reason it says: (NET)
- That is why people say:

5:14b

“Wake up, O sleeper, rise up from the dead,

- “You^(sing) sleeper, wake up, rise up from death,
- “You^(sing) who are asleep, wake up! Do not remain dead from your sins, become alive!

5:14c

and Christ will shine on you.”

- and the light of Christ will shine on you^(sing).”
- Then Christ will make his light of truth and goodness/righteousness shine in your heart.”

5:14a–c

The words in 5:14b–c are probably from an early Christian hymn. It is not a direct quotation from the OT. Paul quoted these words because they speak about

the same things he has just said: we must expose the evil deeds of people so they will come to the light.

So it is said: This is a passive clause. If you need to translate this with an active verb, you can translate it as “people say.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

This is why people say:

This is the reason there is a song/poem with these words:

And so there is a saying which sounds like this:

In the words that Paul quotes, there are three metaphors for turning to God:

1. waking from sleep,
2. being raised from death,
3. going from darkness into light.

You should try to translate all three of these metaphors as literally as possible. Add only as much of the implicit meaning as is necessary.

Wake up, O sleeper: The clause Wake up, O sleeper is a metaphor. The meaning of this metaphor is: “You are like a person who is asleep, because you are not aware of your sins. Become aware of your sins!”

O sleeper: The word O is not in the Greek text, but the BSB and some other English versions have included it. It is sometimes used in English poetry to add emphasis to what follows it.

He is speaking about someone who isn’t aware of his sin and needs to be forgiven. He is not speaking about someone who is actually asleep.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Get up you sleeping ones!

You who are asleep, wake up!

If people would think that this is speaking of a person who is actually asleep then you may want to add some of the meaning in the text to make the meaning clear. For example:

You who are asleep spiritually, wake up!

You who are like a sleeping person, Get up!

You who are unaware of your sins are like a person who is asleep. Wake up!

rise up from the dead: The clause rise up from the dead is also a metaphor. The meaning of this metaphor is: “You are like a person who is dead, because you are separated from God and do not have the new life that God gives. Come to God and get this new life!” (In 2:1 Paul also used the word “dead” as a metaphor.) He is not speaking to people who are literally dead.

In some languages a literal translation of this metaphor may be difficult to understand.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

You who are like dead people, rise up!

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit the meaning. For example:

You who are separated from God like dead people, rise up and be saved

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

You who are separated from God, be saved

You who do not know God, accept Him!

and Christ will shine on you: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Christ will shine on you is yet another metaphor. Christ is like the sun. The idea is that Christ’s goodness and truth will be given to them (shine on them) giving them new life.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Christ will make his light shine in your heart.

...the light of Christ will shine on you.

Christ will give his light of truth and goodness to you and change you.

and: The Greek word that the BSB translates as and here introduces a result of doing what 14b says.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

If you do these things, then as a result Christ will shine on you.

As a result of doing this Christ will give you his light of truth and goodness

General Comment on 5:14b–c

The person being spoken to in 5:14b–c (“Wake up, O sleeper...”) is an unbeliever. In the Greek, the commands in 5:14b and the “you” in 5:14c are singular, as if one person is being spoken to. But these words are good for all people who are still “in the darkness.” If it is more natural in your language, you can translate these words as plural:

Wake up, O sleepers...Christ will shine on you^(plur).

Ephesians 5:15

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

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In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

Paragraph 5:15–17

In 5:15, 5:17 and 5:18, Paul gives three pairs of commands:

5:15 “walk...not as unwise but as wise”

5:17 “do not be foolish, but understand...”

5:18 “do not get drunk.... Instead, be filled with the Spirit” (RSV).

In each case Paul gives a negative command (something to not do) followed by “but” or “Instead,” then a positive command (something to do). Think how to translate these commands naturally in your language. Here are some possibilities:

- In some languages, it will be better to use a conjunction other than “but” to link the negative and positive commands, for example:

Do not behave like unwise people; instead, behave like wise people.

- In some languages, it is best to use no conjunction at all, for example:

Do not behave like unwise people. Behave like wise people!

- In some languages, it is more natural to put the positive first. For example:

Behave like wise people; do not behave as unwise people.

5:15a

Pay careful attention, then, to how you walk,

- ¶ Therefore, be careful in the way you^(plur) act.
- ¶ So, take care how you^(plur) behave.

Pay careful attention: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Pay careful attention is literally “Therefore look/see carefully,” which is a Greek way of telling them “to pay or give attention to” something. Paul is giving a warning to his audience about how they should live their lives.

then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then is a logical connector that introduces an appeal based on what he has said in the earlier part of chapter 5. This word is not a time word. It can be translated as:

therefore (NET)

so (NCV)

so then (GW)

walk: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as walk means “to behave or live.” See the notes on “walk” in 2:2a, 2:10c, 4:1b and 5:8c.

5:15b

not as unwise but as wise,

- Do not behave like foolish people; instead, behave wisely.
- Behave wisely rather than foolishly.

unwise...wise: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wise refers to the ability to understand what happens and decide on the right action. So unwise has the opposite meaning. Here is another way to translate the word unwise:

foolish people (GW)

Ephesians 5:16

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

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In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

Paragraph 5:15–17

In 5:15, 5:17 and 5:18, Paul gives three pairs of commands:

5:15 “walk...not as unwise but as wise”

5:17 “do not be foolish, but understand...”

5:18 “do not get drunk.... Instead, be filled with the Spirit” (RSV).

In each case Paul gives a negative command (something to not do) followed by “but” or “Instead,” then a positive command (something to do). Think how to translate these commands naturally in your language. Here are some possibilities:

- In some languages, it will be better to use a conjunction other than “but” to link the negative and positive commands, for example:

Do not behave like unwise people; instead, behave like wise people.

- In some languages, it is best to use no conjunction at all, for example:

Do not behave like unwise people. Behave like wise people!

- In some languages, it is more natural to put the positive first. For example:

Behave like wise people; do not behave as unwise people.

5:16a redeeming the time,

- Use every occasion wisely/effectively for good,
- Use every chance you have for doing good, (NCV)

redeeming the time: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as redeeming the time means to “make good use of your time,” or “use your time wisely/effectively.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Make good use of every opportunity (GNT)

Use every chance you have for doing good (NCV)

so make every minute count (CEV)

This clause is the same as Colossians 4:5. Compare your translations of these two passages and use similar wording.

In both passages, Paul advised Christians to use every opportunity or occasion to show and tell the world what a true follower of Christ was.

5:16b because the days are evil.

- because these are evil times. (CEV)
- because people do much evil at this time.

because the days are evil: The clause the days are evil means that “at this time, people do much evil.”

Paul is not saying that the days themselves are evil. People will continue to do many evil deeds.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

these are evil times (CEV)

General Comment on 5:16a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder the parts of 5:16a–b. For example:

^{16b}These are evil times, ^{16a}so make every minute count. (CEV)

Ephesians 5:17

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

Paragraph 5:15–17

In 5:15, 5:17 and 5:18, Paul gives three pairs of commands:

5:15 “walk...not as unwise but as wise”

5:17 “do not be foolish, but understand...”

5:18 “do not get drunk.... Instead, be filled with the Spirit” (RSV).

In each case Paul gives a negative command (something to not do) followed by “but” or “Instead,” then a positive command (something to do). Think how to translate these commands naturally in your language. Here are some possibilities:

- In some languages, it will be better to use a conjunction other than “but” to link the negative and positive commands, for example:

Do not behave like unwise people; instead, behave like wise people.

- In some languages, it is best to use no conjunction at all, for example:

Do not behave like unwise people. Behave like wise people!

- In some languages, it is more natural to put the positive first. For example:

Behave like wise people; do not behave as unwise people.

5:17a

Therefore do not be foolish,

- So do not be foolish people,
- For this reason, do not act unwisely,

Therefore: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces an appeal on the basis of what he just said in 5:15–16. Some English versions do not translate it.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

so (NCV)

For this reason (NET)

Translate this connecting phrase in a way that is natural in your language.

foolish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as foolish here is different from the word translated as “unwise” in 5:15b. Their meanings are very similar. If you do not have two words that mean “foolish” or “unwise,” you can translate foolish here as you translated “unwise” in 5:15b. For example:

thoughtlessly (NLT)

5:17b

but understand what the Lord’s will is.

- instead try to understand/know what the Lord wants you to do.

- rather be wise by trying to find out what the Lord wants you to do and do it.

but: The Greek word that the BSB translates as but indicates a negative, positive contrast between 5:17a and 5:17b. If you need to make this contrast clearer, you could add the words “be wise” to make the contrast with “do not be foolish” more explicit. For example:

^{17a}...do not be foolish, ^{17b}but be wise by understanding what the Lord’s will is. (NET)

understand what the Lord’s will is: Here are some other ways to translate the clause understand what the Lord’s will is:

understand what the Lord wants you to do (NLT)

try to find out what the Lord wants you to do (GNT)

This clause is similar to what Paul said in 5:10.

Lord: As in 5:10, Paul probably meant the Lord God here. So if you need to specify whether it is the Lord Christ or the Lord God, choose Lord God.

Ephesians 5:18

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

5:18a**Do not get drunk on wine,**

- ¶ Do not get drunk with wine,
- ¶ Do not drink so much alcoholic drink that you get drunk,

Do not get drunk on wine: Paul used the word wine here but Paul's main point is that we should not get drunk. His main point is not whether it is wine or beer or something else that we drink that causes us to get drunk. (Note also that Paul did not forbid his readers to drink any wine at all. Wine was a common drink in Paul's time.)

In some languages, it might be better to say:

Do not drink intoxicating drinks to get drunk

don't give your heart to getting drunk

5:18b**which leads to reckless indiscretion.**

- because getting drunk causes people to behave in a wild, uncontrolled way.
- because then you will indulge in shameless immorality.

which leads to reckless indiscretion: Paul is explaining here why believers should not get drunk. The result of continuing to get drunk is uncontrolled behavior and a ruined life.

reckless indiscretion: The word that the BSB translates as reckless indiscretion means "uncontrolled behavior that spoils a person's life." In your translation you can focus either on the "uncontrolled behavior," or on "the ruin" that it causes.

Here are some examples focusing on uncontrolled behavior:

which leads to wild living (GW)

getting drunk makes people act in wild, reckless ways

Some examples focusing on the result of a ruined life:

because that will ruin your life (NLT)

getting drunk will lead you to act in ways that will spoil/ruin your life

5:18c**Instead, be filled with the Spirit.**

- Instead, allow the Holy Spirit to control you.
- But rather, always let the Holy Spirit fill you with his power.

Instead: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Instead shows a contrast between 5:18a-b and 5:18c.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

but (NET)

rather

But rather

Translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

be filled with the Spirit: The word filled is a figure of speech. If a person drinks a lot of wine, it will control him and cause him to behave in unacceptable ways. In the same way, we should let the Holy Spirit "fill" us and control us and tell us what to do. If we let the Holy Spirit control us, our behavior will be pleasing to God.

Here is one way to translate this:

let the Holy Spirit fill and control you (NLT96)

In some languages it may be more natural to say this:

Allow the Holy Spirit to fill you with his power.

In others languages it is better not to use the word "fill" at all, but to translate the meaning:

Let the Holy Spirit control/rule you.

You should translate be filled with the Spirit in a way that is natural in your language.

Ephesians 5:19**Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers**

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already

long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

5:19–21

In 5:18 Paul gave the command “be filled with the Spirit.” In the Greek text, this sentence does not end at 5:18, but continues until 5:21. The BSB and some other versions begin a new sentence here. You must decide whether it is more natural in your language to begin a new sentence here or to translate 5:19a as a continuation of 5:18c. For example:

singing psalms and hymns and spiritual songs among yourselves, and making music to the Lord in your hearts (NLT)

In 5:19–21, Paul lists four kinds of good behavior that we should do when we are “filled” (controlled) by the Holy Spirit. We should:

1. encourage one another with songs,
2. sing to praise the Lord,
3. give thanks and
4. submit to one another.

5:19a

Speak to one another with psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs.

- Sing^(plur) psalms, hymns and other spiritual songs to one another.
- Sing^(plur) to one another songs that David wrote and other songs of praise.

Speak to one another: People normally “sing” psalms, hymns and spiritual songs. They generally do not Speak them. So when Paul said Speak to one another, he could have meant:

1. sing songs to one another. For example:

as you sing psalms and hymns and spiritual songs among yourselves (NRSV, NLT, CEV, NJB, JBP)

1. speak or recite the words of these songs to one another. For example:

by reciting psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs for your own good (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, NASB, REB, KJV, NCV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as this seems to fit the context better and has more commentary support. See also Colossians 3:16 where Paul used the verb “sing” in a similar context.

psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs: Paul here mentioned three types of songs. (Compare this phrase with Colossians 3:16.)

psalms: The word psalms refers to the psalms in the Old Testament. King David wrote most of these songs.

hymns: These hymns were in honor of God and Jesus. The early Christians wrote these songs.

spiritual songs: Scholars are not certain of the meaning of spiritual songs. These songs may have been spontaneous singing inspired by the Holy Spirit.

If you do not have three different terms, use short, descriptive phrases to translate these terms. You could combine two of the terms. For example:

songs of David and other songs praising God

5:19b

Sing and make music in your hearts to the Lord,

- Sing songs and make other music to the Lord with all your^(plur) heart.
- Praise the Lord by singing and making music heartily/enthusiastically.

Sing and make music: The verb Sing obviously means with the voice. So the clause make music may indicate other types of music, for example, playing instruments. However, this clause should remain generic in the translation.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Sing songs and make other music

Singing and making melody (RSV)

in your hearts: There are at least two ways to understand the phrase in your hearts:

1. It means sing with all your hearts, in other words, sing with enthusiasm. For example:

...as you praise the Lord with all your heart. (RSV, NASB, ESV, GW, REB, CEV)

1. It means literally sing in your heart. This would mean singing privately in your own heart without making any sound. For example:

...making music in your hearts for the ears of the Lord! (BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, NET, NLT, JBP, NJB, KJV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This fits the prior clause well, since Paul was writing about public singing.

Ephesians 5:20

Section 5:1–20: Paul described behavior which is fitting for believers

In chapter 5, Paul continued with the subject of Christian behavior, which he had begun in the last section of chapter 4. So it is not necessary to start a new section here. One reason to start a new section here is to help the reader, as the previous section is already long. Some English versions begin a new section at 5:1 (BSB, GNT, NLT, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NASB, NKJV), and some do not (NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, CEV, REB, KJV). You may want to consult your national translation and follow their example.

In this section, Paul exhorted the Christians to imitate God and avoid the sins of the pagan people surrounding them.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Living in the light (GNT, NLT, NCV)

Imitate God (GW)

5:20a

always giving thanks to God the Father for everything

- Always thank^(plur) God our^(incl) Father for everything
- For all that has happened to you, you should always give thanks to God the Father

always giving thanks: The term giving thanks means “to be thankful for” or simply “to thank.”

Here are some other ways to translate always giving thanks:

give thanks every day (REB)

giving thanks...at all times (NRSV)

I thank...every time

to God the Father for everything: In some languages, it is more natural to say “God our Father” rather than God the Father.

for everything: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for everything means everything in general, “for all the things that happen.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for all the things that happen

for whatever happens

5:20b

in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ.

- because of that which our Lord Jesus Christ has done.
- In/by the authority of our Lord Jesus Christ because of what he has done

in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ: There is implied information here. The phrase in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ means “because of what Christ has done.” We are thanking God the Father because of what Christ our Lord has done. It is because of Jesus Christ that we can approach God the Father for all purposes, including giving thanks.

If it is not clear to your audience why Paul is telling the Ephesians to give thanks in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, you may want to consider making this explicit. For example:

because of that which our Lord Jesus Christ has done

in/by the authority of our Lord Jesus Christ because of what he has done

This verse is similar to Colossians 3:17.

General Comment on 5:20a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of 5:20a and 5:20b. For example:

^{20b}In the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, ^{20a}always give thanks for everything to God the Father. (GNT)

Ephesians 5:21**Section 5:21–33: Paul gave advice to husbands and their wives**

In 4:17–5:20, Paul taught the Ephesian Christians to behave differently than pagans (people who do not know God). For the next three sections, Paul taught about how Christians should behave in their relationships in their families and at work. In this first section, he dealt with the duties of wives and husbands. He described the marriage relationship as a picture of the relationship between Christ and the church.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advise to wives and husbands (GW)

How a wife and a husband should live together

Paragraph 5:21–24

Some English versions make verse 5:21 part of the previous section, and begin this section with 5:22. However, since Paul began to talk about a new topic—submitting—in 5:21, other versions make 5:21 the beginning of a new section.

You may want to consult your national version and use it as a model to follow.

5:21**Submit to one another out of reverence for Christ.**

- ¶ Yield to each other, because you^(plur) respect Christ.
- ¶ Put yourselves under one another's authority, because you^(plur) honour Christ.

Submit to one another: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Submit means “to surrender or yield (oneself) to the will or authority of another person.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Place yourselves under each other's authority (GW)

Yield to obey each other (NCV)

accept orders from other people

Some languages have special ways to talk about submitting, for example:

Each of you should be willing to put yourself under the others

Each of you should bow your head to the others

Among God's people you are to be underneath them

out of reverence for Christ: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as out of reverence for Christ is literally “in the fear of Christ.” The BSB and most modern translations use words like “reverence,” “respect,” or “honor,” instead of “fear.” These words are closer to the true meaning in this context.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because you honor Christ

out of respect for Christ (GW)

in order to honor Christ

You are to regard Christ's name highly

Ephesians 5:22**Section 5:21–33: Paul gave advice to husbands and their wives**

In 4:17–5:20, Paul taught the Ephesian Christians to behave differently than pagans (people who do not know God). For the next three sections, Paul taught about how Christians should behave in their relationships in their families and at work. In this first section, he dealt with the duties of wives and husbands. He described the marriage relationship as a picture of the relationship between Christ and the church.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advise to wives and husbands (GW)

How a wife and a husband should live together

Paragraph 5:21–24

Some English versions make verse 5:21 part of the previous section, and begin this section with 5:22. However, since Paul began to talk about a new topic—submitting—in 5:21, other versions make 5:21 the beginning of a new section.

You may want to consult your national version and use it as a model to follow.

5:22**Wives, submit to your husbands as to the Lord.**

- Wives, yield to your husbands like you yield to the Lord.
- Each of you wives, be willing to do what your husband wants in the same way that you are willing to do what the Lord wants.

Wives, submit to your husbands: The words Wives and husbands are plural. But take care that your translation does not sound like some wives have more than one husband. You may want to say:

Wives, each of you must submit to your own husband.

Also, think about how a person speaking your language would speak to a group of people to give advice or teaching like this. Some may use “we husbands^(inclusive)” for this kind of teaching. Others may use “you^(plural),” others “you^(singular)”.

as to the Lord: There are various views as to the meaning of this phrase. The two main views are:

1. It means that the wife should submit to her husband like she submits to the Lord or in the same way as she submits to the Lord. For example:

Wives, place yourselves under your husbands’ authority as you have placed yourselves under the Lord’s authority. (GW) (NLT98, NCV, GW, CEV)

1. It means that when a wife submits to her husband it is as though she is submitting to the Lord. In other words, when a wife obeys her husband, she is obeying the Lord, because this is what the Lord has asked her to do. For example:

Wives, be subject to your husbands as though to the Lord (REB, SSA)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). See 6:5c where Paul used a similar construction.

Ephesians 5:23**Section 5:21–33: Paul gave advice to husbands and their wives**

In 4:17–5:20, Paul taught the Ephesian Christians to behave differently than pagans (people who do not know God). For the next three sections, Paul taught about how Christians should behave in their relationships in their families and at work. In this first section, he dealt with the duties of wives and husbands. He described the marriage relationship as a picture of the relationship between Christ and the church.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul’s advise to wives and husbands (GW)

How a wife and a husband should live together

Paragraph 5:21–24

Some English versions make verse 5:21 part of the previous section, and begin this section with 5:22. However, since Paul began to talk about a new topic—submitting—in 5:21, other versions make 5:21 the beginning of a new section.

You may want to consult your national version and use it as a model to follow.

5:23a**For the husband is the head of the wife**

- For the husband is like the head of his wife,
- Because the husband is the chief/leader of his wife,
- For the husband has authority over his wife,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the reason that wives are to submit to their husbands (5:22). In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder 5:22 and 5:23. For example:

^{23a}The husband is the head of the wife.... That is the reason why ²²wives, submit to your husbands as to the Lord.

the husband is the head of the wife: The word head is a metaphor here, as in other places in Ephesians. This means that the husband is the “leader” or “chief” of the wife, or he has authority over the wife. Some languages use the word head in this sense. For example, the village chief may be called the “head of the village.” But in many languages, it is confusing or means little to say, the husband is the head of the wife. If it will make the meaning clearer in your language, you could translate it:

A husband is like the head, for he has authority over his wife.

It is the husband who has authority over the wife.

The full meaning of the metaphor can be explained like this: “In a human body, the part on top that rules the body is the head. In the same way, the husband is like the head, because he has authority over his wife.” But you will probably not want to make all of this explicit in your translation.

In some languages, you cannot say “the husband” or “the wife,” these words must take a possessive form:

her husband

his wife

a woman’s husband

5:23b

as Christ is the head of the church, His body,

- as Christ is like the head of the church, and the church is like his body.
- as Christ is the chief/leader of the church, and the church is like his body.
- just as Christ has authority over the church. The church belongs to him.

as Christ is the head of the church, His body: There are two comparisons here: Christ is like the head of the church, and the church is like the body of Christ. Just as in our human body the head is the part that is on top and that rules the rest of our body, so also Christ rules over the church, that is, his people.

If the people in your area would not understand this comparison, you can translate it as:

Christ is the leader of the church, which belongs to Him.

This metaphor (Christ is the head, the church is His body) is also found in 1:22–23, 4:12, 4:15–16 and 5:30. You will want to translate it in a similar way in all these places.

the church: The church is the group of all believers in Christ throughout the world. In the New Testament, the word church does not refer to a building. See how you translated church in 1:22b, 3:10a, 3:21b. Also see church in the Glossary for more information.

His body: The phrase His body refers to the church. See how you translated this metaphor in 1:23a and 4:4a, 4:12b, and 4:16a.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

his people are like a body

his people who are united to him like his body is united to his head

those who belong to him

his people/disciples/followers

5:23c

of which He is the Savior.

- And it is he who saves it.
- And Christ is the one who has rescued us, his people from our sins.

of which He is the Savior: The Greek text that the BSB translates as of which He is the Savior is literally “and he-himself is the savior of the body.” This refers to Christ only, and not to husbands. You may want to make this clear in your translation. One way to do this is to make this clause a separate sentence in your translation:

Christ is the Savior

Christ is the one who saves his people

This same Christ rescues his people from their sins

See save, Word 3 in the Glossary for more information.

General Comment on 5:23a–b

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

The husband is the head of his wife as Christ is the head of the church. It is his body, and he is its Savior. (GW)

A husband is the head of his wife, as Christ is the head and the Savior of the church, which is his own body. (CEV)

For a husband is the head of his wife as Christ is the head of the church. He is the Savior of his body, the church. (NLT)

Ephesians 5:24

Section 5:21–33: Paul gave advice to husbands and their wives

In 4:17–5:20, Paul taught the Ephesian Christians to behave differently than pagans (people who do not know God). For the next three sections, Paul taught about how Christians should behave in their relationships in their families and at work. In this first section, he dealt with the duties of wives and husbands. He described the marriage relationship as a picture of the relationship between Christ and the church.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advise to wives and husbands (GW)

How a wife and a husband should live together

Paragraph 5:21–24

Some English versions make verse 5:21 part of the previous section, and begin this section with 5:22. However, since Paul began to talk about a new topic—submitting—in 5:21, other versions make 5:21 the beginning of a new section.

You may want to consult your national version and use it as a model to follow.

5:24a

Now as the church submits to Christ,

- Therefore, just as the church yields to Christ,
- So then, just as the church is under the authority of Christ,

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now is normally translated “but.” Here, however, scholars do not agree about the meaning of this conjunction. There are three possibilities:

1. It indicates that Paul resumed his theme of submitting and marks the connection to that theme. For example:

Now as the church submits to Christ... (BSB, NIV, NJB, probably ESV)

1. It marks a contrast and means “but.” Christ is the savior of the church, (not the husband). But the wife should still submit to her husband. For example:

But as the church submits to Christ, so also wives should submit to their husbands in everything. (NET, NASB, REB)

1. It marks the conclusion of the paragraph on submitting and means “so” or “therefore.” For example:

And so wives must submit themselves completely to their husbands... (GNT) (GNT, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as it best fits the context. But there is strong support for (2) so if your national translation follows (2) you may want to follow their interpretation.

submits: See how you translated submit in 5:21a and 5:22.

5:24b

so also wives should submit to their husbands in everything.

- so also each of you wives should yield to her husband in everything.
- wives should also be under the authority of their husbands in all matters.

submit: See how you translated submit in 5:21a and 5:22. There is a similarity here between how the church submits to Christ (5:24a) and how wives should submit to their husbands (5:24b). Translate in a way that shows this comparison.

General Comment on 5:24a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in this verse. For example:

^{24b}Wives should submit to their husbands in everything ^{24a}as the church submits to Christ. (GNT)

Ephesians 5:25

Section 5:21–33: Paul gave advice to husbands and their wives

In 4:17–5:20, Paul taught the Ephesian Christians to behave differently than pagans (people who do not know God). For the next three sections, Paul taught about how Christians should behave in their relationships in their families and at work. In this first section, he dealt with the duties of wives and husbands. He described the marriage relationship as a picture of the relationship between Christ and the church.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advise to wives and husbands (GW)

How a wife and a husband should live together

Paragraph 5:25–33

In the previous paragraph Paul talked about the duties that a wife has toward her husband. In this paragraph, Paul discusses the duties a husband has toward his wife.

5:25a

Husbands, love your wives,

- ¶ You married men, each of you must love your wife
- ¶ All husbands should love their wives

Husbands, love your wives: Translate this command in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

You married men, each of you should love his wife

See love, meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

Your translation should not suggest that Paul is giving approval of a man having more than one wife.

5:25b

just as Christ loved the church and gave Himself up for her

- just as Christ loves the church and died for it
- in the same way as Christ showed his love for his people, the church, by being willing to die for us^(incl) to save us.

just as Christ loved the church: The Greek words that the BSB translates as just as mean that a husband should love his wife in the same way that Christ loved the church (his people).

loved: The verb loved is in the past tense. But you may want to translate the verb “love” using the present tense “he loves the church” to avoid suggesting that he loved believers only in the past. See love, meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

church: The church is the group of all believers in Christ throughout the world. See how you translated church in 5:23b. See church in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

all his followers

all his people

gave Himself up for her: The verb gave...up means that Christ gave his life for the church, that is, he died for it. See how you translated gave Himself up for (us) in 5:2b.

for her: The pronoun her refers to the church. The Greek pronoun is singular and feminine and it is translated by the English versions as her or “it.” (The BSB uses her here and in 5:26 and 5:27, all referring to the church.)

Since “the church” refers to all people who are believers in Jesus, in many languages it is more natural to use “them” instead of her. For example:

just as Christ loved his group/people and gave himself up for them

In some languages it may be best to use “us^(incl),” so that the readers do not think that Paul was not part of the church:

just as Christ loved us^(incl), his group/people, and gave his life as a sacrifice for us^(incl)

for: the word for means “for the benefit of.” Christ died for the benefit of the church (his people).

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase “for her”:

for your/their good

thinking of

in order to save us^(incl)/you

General Comment on 5:25a–b

In some languages, it is more natural to change the order of 25a–b. For example:

^{25b}As Christ loved his people and died so that they would be in a good state, ^{25a}so you men need to love your wives.

Ephesians 5:26

Section 5:21–33: Paul gave advice to husbands and their wives

In 4:17–5:20, Paul taught the Ephesian Christians to behave differently than pagans (people who do not know God). For the next three sections, Paul taught about how Christians should behave in their relation-

ships in their families and at work. In this first section, he dealt with the duties of wives and husbands. He described the marriage relationship as a picture of the relationship between Christ and the church.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advise to wives and husbands (GW)

How a wife and a husband should live together

Paragraph 5:25–33

In the previous paragraph Paul talked about the duties that a wife has toward her husband. In this paragraph, Paul discusses the duties a husband has toward his wife.

5:26–27

In the Greek, 5:25–27 are one continuous sentence. But it may be clearer to start a new sentence at 5:26, for example:

He did this in order to...

He died in order to....

In 5:26–27, Paul gave two purposes for which Christ gave himself up for the church: Christ did this:

1. in order to make the church holy (5:26a),
2. in order to present the church to himself in a perfect, beautiful condition (5:27).

The second purpose is the ultimate purpose, Christ's long-range goal. He died for us so that in the future when he comes to get us, we will be radiant, holy and blameless.

5:26a

to sanctify her,

- to make it holy.
- He did this in order to make them/us pure/holy.

to sanctify her: The clause to sanctify her is the purpose Christ gave himself for the church (5:25b). Christ gave himself for the church in order to sanctify her.

to sanctify: Some English versions translate the Greek verb here as "to...make holy." The BSB and older English versions translate this verb as sanctify. There are two possible ways to interpret the meaning of the Greek verb here.

1. It means to make holy/pure. For example:

to make her holy (NLT) (BSB, NIV, NRSV, NJB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP)

1. It means "to set apart, to make God's special people." For example:

He did this to dedicate the church to God (GNT) (GNT, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In the NT, sanctify usually means "set apart for the service of God," but here the meaning is "made pure" because of the word "cleansing" which follows. You can translate this:

He did this to make them pure

See holy, Meaning 4 in the Glossary for more information.

5:26b

cleansing her by the washing with water through the word,

- He cleaned the church from sin with God's word and by washing it with water.
- When we heard God's word and believed, he cleaned/washed us from sin with the water of baptism.

cleansing her by the washing with water: The clause cleansing her by the washing with water is a metaphor. Paul meant that Christ "washed away" or removed our sins (cf. 1 John 1:7, 9). It is another way to say Christ made us holy (5:26a). Paul was not referring to Christ literally washing the church or Christians to get the dirt off their bodies.

by the washing with water: Paul said that Christ removed our sins by the washing with water. This probably refers to baptism. Paul may have been comparing baptism to the ceremonial bath taken by a Jewish bride before marriage. Just as a Jewish bride was given a bath before her marriage, so Christ washed away our sins through baptism when we became his bride.

In order to avoid implying that Christ physically washed the church, you may need to include your word for "baptism" in your translation. For example:

...to make her holy and clean, washed by baptism and God's Word (NLT96)

(In the above quote from the NLT96, the word "her" refers to the church.)

through the word: There are two interpretation issues that you need to consider when you translate this phrase:

Issue 1: The meaning of the phrase the word. Here the word means the words that God or Christ spoke. It refers to God's Word, the Christian message. When we heard and believed God's Word, trusted in Christ and were baptized, Christ made us pure and cleansed us from sin.

Issue 2: To which part of the verse is word connected. Two of the main interpretations are:

1. word goes with "cleansed." According to this interpretation, Christ cleansed the church both with water and with the word. For example:

washed by baptism and God's word (NLT) (NLT96, GW, REB)

1. word goes with sanctify/make holy in 5:26a. According to this interpretation, Christ cleansed the church with water, and then he sanctified it by the word. For example:

dedicate the church to God by his word, after making it clean by washing it in water (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as this seems to have the most support among commentaries.

Ephesians 5:27

Section 5:21–33: Paul gave advice to husbands and their wives

In 4:17–5:20, Paul taught the Ephesian Christians to behave differently than pagans (people who do not know God). For the next three sections, Paul taught about how Christians should behave in their relationships in their families and at work. In this first section, he dealt with the duties of wives and husbands. He described the marriage relationship as a picture of the relationship between Christ and the church.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advice to wives and husbands (GW)

How a wife and a husband should live together

Paragraph 5:25–33

In the previous paragraph Paul talked about the duties that a wife has toward her husband. In this paragraph, Paul discusses the duties a husband has toward his wife.

5:27a

and to present her to Himself as a glorious church,

- He did this so that the church will be beautiful when he brings the church to himself like his bride
- He also died for his church/people so that he could make all his people beautiful/perfect and bring them/us all into his presence.

to present her to Himself: This is the second purpose Christ gave himself for the church (5:25b). He gave himself for the church in order to present her to Himself.

The picture of marriage continues. The church is compared to a beautiful bride. In a Jewish wedding, the groom's friend brings the bride to meet the groom at the wedding party. Christ is like the husband or groom, and the church is like his bride. Christ is also like the groom's friend, because he himself will come and take us and bring us to be with himself.

Usually we give something to another person, not to ourselves. But Paul says that Christ died for the church to present her (the church) to himself. Most commentators think that Paul is talking about what will happen when Christ comes back to earth. He will give us (the church) new bodies and set us free from sin and all that is bad. Then he will take us to be with him, and we will be "radiant...holy and blameless."

as a glorious church: The Greek word that the BSB translates as glorious means "beautiful, splendid, radiant." God will give his people wonderful new life.

Here are some other ways to translate glorious:

radiant (NIV)

in all her beauty (GNT)

church: The church refers to the group of all believers in Christ throughout the world. See how you translated church in 5:25b.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

group of all Christ-believers

Christ's people

people who follow Christ

community of Christ-followers

5:27b

without stain or wrinkle or any such blemish,

- who will not have any dirt or wrinkles or spots.
- He did not want dirt, or wrinkles, or any other defects to be in it,
- He did this in order that his people/church will have no faults or sins or any other bad things;

without stain or wrinkle or any such blemish: The words stain, wrinkle, and blemish are figures of speech that represent different kinds of faults and sins. Christ does not want any bad thing to be in his church. He compares his church to a beautiful woman wearing beautiful clean clothes who has no dirt or wrinkles on her clothes and no blemishes (ugly spots) on her skin. That is a comparison of how the church will be: beautiful, perfect, with no sins or faults.

stain: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stain can also be translated as “spot.” It refers to a small dirty area on a cloth, a rug, etc.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

dirty spot

soiled clothes

wrinkle: The word wrinkle refers to a small crease, as in some cloth or one’s skin.

blemish: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as blemish is literally “any such things.” It refers back to “stain” and “wrinkle.” This refers to any defects or imperfections. For example:

any other imperfection (GNT)

If it would not be natural or clear in your translation to translate the terms “stain,” “wrinkle,” and blemish, you may want to translate the meaning directly. For example:

have absolutely no fault/lack

with no evil or sin or any other wrong thing in it (NCV)

nothing evil would be found against them

5:27c

but holy and blameless.

- Rather, it will be pure and without fault.
- but he wanted it to be holy and perfect.
- instead they/we will be pure, and there will be no bad thing in them/us for which he or people could condemn them/us.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here marks a contrast between 5:27b and 5:27c. Translate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

but rather

instead

holy and blameless: These are the same words Paul used to describe believers in 1:4b.

holy: The word holy here means “pure” or “without sin.” We will be holy/pure, because he made us holy/pure. (In Greek the word “sanctify” in 5:26a is related to the word holy here.)

Here are some other ways to translate holy:

pure (GNT)

without sin

See holy, Meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

blameless: The word blameless means that there is nothing bad in a person’s behavior that God (or other people) could accuse the person of doing. Some other ways to translate blameless are:

without fault (NLT, GW, CEV, NCV)

innocent

General Comment on 5:27a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of 5:27b–c. For example:

^{27a}in order to present the church to himself in all its beauty—^{27c}pure and faultless, ^{27b}without spot or wrinkle or any other imperfection (GNT)

Ephesians 5:28

Section 5:21–33: Paul gave advice to husbands and their wives

In 4:17–5:20, Paul taught the Ephesian Christians to behave differently than pagans (people who do not know God). For the next three sections, Paul taught about how Christians should behave in their relationships in their families and at work. In this first section, he dealt with the duties of wives and husbands. He described the marriage relationship as a picture of the relationship between Christ and the church.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advise to wives and husbands (GW)

How a wife and a husband should live together

Paragraph 5:25–33

In the previous paragraph Paul talked about the duties that a wife has toward her husband. In this paragraph, Paul discusses the duties a husband has toward his wife.

5:28a

In the same way, husbands ought to love their wives as their own bodies.

- In the same way that Christ loved the church, a husband should love his wife, as he loves his own body.
- That is how Christ loves the church, so that is also how each man should love his wife. Specifically, he should love her as he loves himself.

In the same way: There is implied information here. The husbands are to love their wives in the same way as Christ loved the church. If this is not clear in the translation you may want to include the implied information. For example:

In the same way that Christ loved the church so a husband should love his wife.”

husbands ought to love their wives: This means that each husband should love his own wife. In areas where there is polygamy, it may be better to use a singular subject instead of a plural. For example:

...each man should love his own wife as he loves his own body.

This fits well with the singular verb (loves himself) that follows in 5:28b.

as their own bodies: These words mean that a husband should love his wife just like he loves his own body. When Paul says that a husband loves his own body, he means that he does things to protect himself from harm. He wants to survive, and so he does what helps him survive and live well. (as mentioned in 5:29a). If it is not natural in your language to talk about loving your body, you can translate this as:

as he loves himself (CEV)

5:28b

He who loves his wife loves himself.

- The man who loves his wife loves himself.
- If a man loves his wife, it is like he loves himself.

He who loves his wife loves himself: There is implied information here. Paul is making a comparison by referring back to the metaphor of 5:23: The husband is the head of his wife just as Christ is the head of the church. Using that metaphor, Paul reminds the Ephesians that a husband is united to his wife in the same way that Christ is united to the church. So, figuratively, the wife is the “body” of her husband just as the church is the “body” of Christ.

In translating this sentence, it may be helpful to show that Paul is making a comparison. For example:

When a man loves his wife, it is like he loves himself too.

Ephesians 5:29

Section 5:21–33: Paul gave advice to husbands and their wives

In 4:17–5:20, Paul taught the Ephesian Christians to behave differently than pagans (people who do not know God). For the next three sections, Paul taught about how Christians should behave in their relationships in their families and at work. In this first section, he dealt with the duties of wives and husbands. He described the marriage relationship as a picture of the relationship between Christ and the church.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advise to wives and husbands (GW)

How a wife and a husband should live together

Paragraph 5:25–33

In the previous paragraph Paul talked about the duties that a wife has toward her husband. In this paragraph, Paul discusses the duties a husband has toward his wife.

5:29a

Indeed, no one ever hated his own body, but he nourishes and cherishes it,

- For no man hates his own body, but he feeds it and takes care of it,
- I say this because none of us hates his own body, but he nourishes and cherishes it

Indeed: The Greek conjunction *that* that BSB has translated as *Indeed* is usually translated as “for” (RSV, NET, ESV). It introduces something that is the basis or reason for the previous statement. What Paul said here in 5:29 was the reason for what he told husbands to do in 5:28.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language for introducing a reason or basis for what he said before.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

I say “as their own bodies” because

The reason I say this is

Because/For we know that

no one: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *no one* refers back to “husbands” in 5:28.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

no man (RSV)

none of us (GNT, CEV)

hated his own body: This is literally “hated his own flesh.” See *flesh*, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

but he nourishes and cherishes it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *cherishes* is literally “cherishes” (RSV, ESV). It is a general term that refers to providing clothing and shelter for himself.

5:29b

just as Christ does the church.

- as Christ cares for the church,
- in the same way that Christ does for the church.

just as Christ does the church: The verb *does* refers to “cares for” in 5:29a. Paul is making a comparison here. A man cares for his own body like Christ cares for the church.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

in the same way that Christ loves and cares for the church

as Christ takes care of his people/followers

church: The church is the group of all believers in Christ throughout the world. See how you translated church in 5:27a. See church in the Glossary for more information.

General Comment on 5:29b

Some English versions end 5:29b with a dash “—.” This is to show that the following verse, 5:30 is a comment inserted by the author. Most versions translate this verse without a dash, as the BSB also does. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

Ephesians 5:30

Section 5:21–33: Paul gave advice to husbands and their wives

In 4:17–5:20, Paul taught the Ephesian Christians to behave differently than pagans (people who do not know God). For the next three sections, Paul taught about how Christians should behave in their relationships in their families and at work. In this first section, he dealt with the duties of wives and husbands. He described the marriage relationship as a picture of the relationship between Christ and the church.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul’s advice to wives and husbands (GW)

How a wife and a husband should live together

Paragraph 5:25–33

In the previous paragraph Paul talked about the duties that a wife has toward her husband. In this paragraph, Paul discusses the duties a husband has toward his wife.

5:30**For we are members of His body.**

- because we are like parts of Christ's body.
- He cares for us because we all belong to him.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* gives the reason why Christ cares for the church. He cares for the church because we are part of his body.

we are members of His body: The phrase we are members of His body is a metaphor. It means that we are united with other believers in the church.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

- As a simile. For example:

We are like the parts of Christ's body.

- In a non-figurative sense. For example:

We all belong to him.

Ephesians 5:31**Section 5:21–33: Paul gave advice to husbands and their wives**

In 4:17–5:20, Paul taught the Ephesian Christians to behave differently than pagans (people who do not know God). For the next three sections, Paul taught about how Christians should behave in their relationships in their families and at work. In this first section, he dealt with the duties of wives and husbands. He described the marriage relationship as a picture of the relationship between Christ and the church.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advise to wives and husbands (GW)

How a wife and a husband should live together

Paragraph 5:25–33

In the previous paragraph Paul talked about the duties that a wife has toward her husband. In this paragraph, Paul discusses the duties a husband has toward his wife.

5:31a**“For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife,**

- “So a man will leave his father and his mother and he will join with his wife,

- As the Book of God says: “And that is why a man will leave his father and his mother and marry a woman,

Verse 5:31a–b is a quotation from Genesis 2:24. It is also quoted in other places in the New Testament: Matt. 19:5, Mark 10:7–8, 1 Cor. 6:16. See how this quotation was translated in these verses and translate it here in a similar way. If you want to make it clear in your translation that this is a quotation, you can say:

As the Book of God says...”

As the scripture says (GNT)

It's written in the Bible like this

For this reason: This is the beginning of a quote from Genesis 2:24 and therefore the phrase *For this reason* refers to the fact that God had made woman from the rib of the man Adam. This does not give a reason for verse 30. If this is not clear in the translation you may want to include the implied information from what happened prior to this in Genesis. For example:

Because the woman was made from man's rib a man will leave his father and mother

a man will leave his father and mother: There are several ways to translate this clause:

- As an indirect command. For example:

So a man should leave his father and mother...

- As a general statement about what usually happens:

This is why a man normally leaves his father and mother...

leave his father and mother: You can translate the phrase his father and mother as “his mother and his father” or “his parents”—whatever is natural in your language.

The phrase leave his father and mother can be translated “leave his parents' house.” These words mean that a man's primary relationship and duty is no longer with his parents, but with his wife. Your translation should not imply that a man should abandon or neglect his parents.

be united to his wife: He will form a close and permanent relationship with his wife. He will live with her and they will become a new family, a new household. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and will be joined to his wife (NET)

and he will live with his wife

5:31b
and the two will become one flesh.”

- and the two of them will become like one body.”
- and the two of them will become as one person.”

the two will become one flesh: The phrase the two will become one flesh means that the husband and wife will become like one person, or like one body. (Jesus uses this same figure in Matthew 19:4–6.) In God’s sight, it is like a husband and wife are no longer two separate people. It is like they are just one person.

Paul was making a very logical comparison: A husband should love his wife like Christ loves the church (5:25). That is, he should love her like he loves his own body (5:28). The church is part of Christ’s body (5:30), and since a husband and wife are one, (5:31), a wife is like part of the husband’s body.

one flesh: Here one flesh means “one person.” In the Greek, it is the same word the BSB translates as “body” in 5:29a. See flesh, Meaning 3 in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 5:32

Section 5:21–33: Paul gave advice to husbands and their wives

In 4:17–5:20, Paul taught the Ephesian Christians to behave differently than pagans (people who do not know God). For the next three sections, Paul taught about how Christians should behave in their relationships in their families and at work. In this first section, he dealt with the duties of wives and husbands. He described the marriage relationship as a picture of the relationship between Christ and the church.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul’s advise to wives and husbands (GW)

How a wife and a husband should live together

Paragraph 5:25–33

In the previous paragraph Paul talked about the duties that a wife has toward her husband. In this paragraph, Paul discusses the duties a husband has toward his wife.

5:32a
This mystery is profound,

- This is a great mystery,
- These words are not easy to understand,

This mystery is profound: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as This mystery is profound is literally “this mystery is great.”

Here is another way to translate this clause:

This is a great mystery (CEV)

This: The pronoun This refers back to 5:31b. The great “mystery” is that “the two will become one flesh.” There are differing views as to which part of the preceding passage the phrase “this mystery” refers. It can refer to: (1) The quote from Genesis, particularly “the two will become one flesh” (5:31b). (2) the relationship between a husband and his wife (5:22–28). (3) the relationship between Christ and the church (5:23–30). (4) the comparison between a husband and a wife and Christ and the church (5:23–30). The Translator’s Notes follows the first interpretation.

mystery: Here the word mystery means “a truth that is not easy to understand or explain.” It is something that God had previously hidden from man but has now revealed to him. See how you translated mystery in 1:9a, 3:4–6 and 3:9a.

Here are some other ways to translate mystery:

secret (GNT)

truth that is difficult to understand

this talk is hidden

profound: The Greek word that the BSB translates as profound is literally “great.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

There is a deep secret truth (GNT)

This is a truth that is very difficult to understand

General Comment on 5:32a

Some English versions end 5:32a with a dash “—.” This is to show that the following verse, 5:32b is a comment inserted by the author. Most other versions translate this verse without a dash, as the BSB also does. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

5:32b

but I am speaking about Christ and the church.

- but I am actually talking about the relationship between Christ and the church.
- yet I understand this Scripture to also be referring to Christ and the church.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but introduces an explanation of another way Paul interprets the quoted passage from Genesis. Some other English versions translate this word as “and.” Still other versions do not translate this conjunction. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

I am speaking about Christ and the church: The quote from Genesis is talking about the relationship between a man and his wife. But Paul interprets the quote to also refer to Christ and the church. Here is one way to translate this:

but I am actually speaking with reference to Christ and the church (NET)

church: The church is the group of all believers in Christ throughout the world. See how you translated church in 5:29b.

Ephesians 5:33

Section 5:21–33: Paul gave advice to husbands and their wives

In 4:17–5:20, Paul taught the Ephesian Christians to behave differently than pagans (people who do not know God). For the next three sections, Paul taught about how Christians should behave in their relationships in their families and at work. In this first section, he dealt with the duties of wives and husbands. He described the marriage relationship as a picture of the relationship between Christ and the church.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul’s advise to wives and husbands (GW)

How a wife and a husband should live together

Paragraph 5:25–33

In the previous paragraph Paul talked about the duties that a wife has toward her husband. In this paragraph, Paul discusses the duties a husband has toward his wife.

5:33a

Nevertheless, each one of you also must love his wife as he loves himself,

- So again, I say that each man must love his wife as he loves himself,
- Nevertheless to summarise, each husband is to love his wife as he loves himself.

Nevertheless: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Nevertheless connects 5:33 with the previous verses. There are two possible ways to understand this connecting word:

1. It indicates that Paul stopped talking about Christ and the church and summarized his advice/commands to husbands and wives. The connecting word means “however,” “nevertheless,” or “in any case.” For example:

To sum up... (NJB)

1. It indicates a contrast. Even though the quote from Genesis in 5:31 has a deeper meaning, it also applies to husbands and wives. For example:

But it applies also to each one of you (REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is possible that both aspects of this connecting word are present, but most commentators follow interpretation (1).

love his wife as he loves himself: See how you translated the similar clause “He who loves his wife loves himself” in 5:28b.

General Comment on 5:33a–b

Note that in 5:33a, Paul summarizes the advice he gave to husbands in 5:25–31. In 5:33b he summarizes the advice he gave to wives in 5:22–24.

5:33b

and the wife must respect her husband.

- and each wife must respect her husband.
- And each wife should esteem/admire her husband.

must respect: The word respect means “admire” or “have high regard” for someone or something.” For example:

should respect (GW)

should think highly of

Ephesians 6:1

Section 6:1–4: Paul gave advice to children and their parents

The first relationship that Paul talked about was the marriage relationship (5:21–33). In this section, Paul talked about another relationship: that of children and parents. Children should obey their parents, and parents should train their children with love and Christian discipline.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advice to children and parents (GW)

Children should obey their parents

6:1–2

In 5:21–24 Paul told Christians to “submit” to one another and told wives to “submit” to their husbands. In 5:33 he told wives to “respect” their husbands. Now in 6:1, he tells children to “obey” and “honor” their parents. These words are similar in meaning. To respect or honor someone means to recognize/consider that person is worthy to love and obey. To submit to a person means to be willing to be under that person's authority, to yield our rights to that person. To obey a person means to do what that person says.

6:1a

Children, obey your parents in the Lord,

- ¶ Children, because you^(plur) are united to the Lord, obey your parents,
- ¶ You^(plur) children, you belong to the Lord Jesus. That is the reason you should obey your parents.

Children: Here the word Children refers to children whose parents are still taking care of them.

obey your parents in the Lord: There are differing views as to the meaning of the phrase in the Lord. Here are two of these views:

1. It means that children should obey their parents “because they (the children) are united to the Lord” or “because they belong to the Lord.” For example:

because you belong to the Lord (NLT) (NLT, CEV GW)

1. It means that children should obey their parents because it is the will of the Lord. For example:

as the Lord wants (NCV) (NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most English versions translate this phrase literally, and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow.

Lord: Here, the word Lord refers to Jesus.

6:1b

for this is right.

- because this is the right thing to do.
- This is the correct behaviour to do.

for: In the Greek 1b begins with a conjunction that the BSB translates as for. This conjunction introduces the basis for his command in 1a.

Here are some other possible ways to introduce this basis:

Because

My reason for this command is that

this is right: The Greek word that the BSB translates as right in this context means “conforming to God's standard, just, right, proper.” The clause “for this is right” may need to be expanded. Some examples are:

for this is the right thing to do

because this is the correct thing that you should do

because this is what you should do

Because this is the right behavior to do

See righteous in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 6:2

Section 6:1–4: Paul gave advice to children and their parents

The first relationship that Paul talked about was the marriage relationship (5:21–33). In this section, Paul talked about another relationship: that of children and parents. Children should obey their parents, and par-

ents should train their children with love and Christian discipline.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advice to children and parents (GW)

Children should obey their parents

6:2a

“Honor your father and mother”

- In the Book of God Moses wrote: “Honour your^(sing) father and mother.”
- As God said in his book: “Respect your^(plur) fathers and mothers.”

“Honor your father and mother”: The command Honor your father and mother is a quote from the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:12 and Deuteronomy 5:16). Most English translations put quote marks around these words, or make some kind of mark to show that it is a quote. You should introduce this quote in a way similar to the quote in 5:31a. For example, you could say:

It is written in God's Book

Honor: The word Honor means to “respect, esteem greatly and act accordingly.” See the note above for 6:1–2 for more information.

your father and mother: In Greek, this command is singular: “Honor your^(sing) father....” This command is not just for one person, of course, but is meant for all people. In Hebrew, all of the commands in the Ten Commandments are singular. This is a common way in the Hebrew language to give commands that are meant for everyone. You should translate this command in a way that is natural in your language.

6:2b

(which is the first commandment with a promise),

- This commandment is the first one to which God added a promise:
- Of all of the commands God gave, this is the first time he commanded something and then made a promise along with it.

(which is the first commandment with a promise):

Here, Paul interrupts his quotation from the Old Testament to add a comment. It is not part of the quotation. The BSB makes this explicit by enclosing 6:2b in paren-

theses. Other versions such as the NIV use dashes to show that this clause is not part of the quotation.

One other way to translate this clause is to put it at the end of 6:3. For example:

^{6:3a-b}that everything may go well for you, and you may have a long life on earth.” ^{6:2b}This is an important commandment with a promise. (GW)

Translate this clause in a way that is natural in your language to show that it is not a part of the quotation.

Paul meant that out of all the commandments that God gave, this is the first time he added a promise to his command. Take care that your translation does not say that the command to honor one's parents is the first commandment in the Ten Commandments. (It is not. It is the fifth commandment.)

General Comment on 6:2–3

It may be clearer to change the order of 6:2a and 6:2b, so that this verse connects better with 6:3 (see 6:2–3 in JBP):

^{2b}The first commandment which the Lord gave and joined a promise to it is this: ^{2a}“Honor your father and mother, ³so that things may be good for you and you may live for a long time.”

Ephesians 6:3

Section 6:1–4: Paul gave advice to children and their parents

The first relationship that Paul talked about was the marriage relationship (5:21–33). In this section, Paul talked about another relationship: that of children and parents. Children should obey their parents, and parents should train their children with love and Christian discipline.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advice to children and parents (GW)

Children should obey their parents

6:3a

“that it may go well with you

- “Do this so that whatever happens to you^(sing) will be good,
- The thing that he promised is this: “If you^(sing) obey your parents, things will go well for you^(sing),

that it may go well with you: This verse continues the Old Testament quotation that started in 6:2a.

Here are some other ways to say that it may go well with you:

that everything that happens to you will be good

that your life may be full of blessings

6:3b

and that you may have a long life on the earth.”

- and so that you^(sing) will live a long time on this earth.”
- and you^(sing) will live a long time.”

and that you may have a long life: The clause that you may have a long life means “that you will live a long time.” For example:

you may live a long time (GNT)

There may be an idiom in your language to express a person living till old age.

on the earth: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as on the earth is literally “in the land.” In the original quotation in Exodus 20:12, “land” refers to Canaan, but here it refers to the earth where we live. In your translation, it may be more natural to leave this implicit. For example:

and you will have a long and happy life (CEV)

Ephesians 6:4

Section 6:1–4: Paul gave advice to children and their parents

The first relationship that Paul talked about was the marriage relationship (5:21–33). In this section, Paul talked about another relationship: that of children and parents. Children should obey their parents, and parents should train their children with love and Christian discipline.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul’s advice to children and parents (GW)

Children should obey their parents

6:4a

Fathers, do not provoke your children to wrath;

- Fathers, do not make your children angry.
- You fathers, do not treat your children in a harsh way which makes them resentful.

Fathers: Some versions, for example the GNT and the NJB, translate this as “parents”, referring to both father and mother. But the Greek word here (pater) is different from the word meaning “parents” in 6:1. Therefore, it is better to translate this Greek word as “fathers” in this verse.

do not provoke your children to wrath: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as provoke...to wrath means “to make angry.” Fathers should not treat their children in a harsh or unjust way that would make them angry or resentful. The tense of the verb in Greek shows that Paul has in mind a continual harsh and critical attitude of a father towards his children, not a sudden outburst of anger.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

do not provoke your children to anger by the way you treat them (NLT)

don’t make your children bitter about life (GW)

6:4b

instead, bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord.

- Instead, raise your children by training and teaching them according to the word of the Lord.
- Rather, as you raise them, train them and teach them in the way the Lord wants.

instead: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as instead is literally “but.” It marks a negative-positive contrast between 6:4a and 6:4b (do not do... but instead do...). Translate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Another way to indicate this negative-positive contrast in English is:

but rather

bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord: The phrase bring them up means “raise children” or “rear children.”

in the discipline: The word discipline refers to the whole process of raising and educating children. Discipline and instruction are part of the training including rules of how to behave.

instruction: The word instruction is similar in meaning to “discipline” but focuses more on the ideas of teaching and warning.

of the Lord: Fathers must teach their children “as the Lord wants,” “in a way which the Lord approves” or “according to the word of the Lord.” For example:

Rather, bring them up with the discipline and instruction approved by the Lord. (NLT96)

This phrase probably does not mean that fathers should teach their children “about the Lord” in this context.

Ephesians 6:5

Section 6:5–9: Paul gave advice to slaves and their masters

The third relationship that Paul talked about is that of slaves and masters. The slave must remember that when he serves his master, he is serving Christ, and he will receive his reward from Christ. The master must remember that the slave’s master in heaven is his own master too.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul’s advice to slaves and masters (GW)

Slaves/Servants should obey their masters

6:5a

Slaves, obey your earthly masters

- ¶ Slaves/servants, obey your masters in this world.
- ¶ Now to you who are servants I say: do what those who own you^(plur) tell you to do.

Slaves: Paul switched from talking to fathers to talking to slaves in Ephesus who were Christians. In the town of Ephesus, slaves were people who worked in the houses of their masters.

In your translation you should use a natural way to show that Paul began talking to a different group of people. For example:

To those who are slaves, I say...

Now you servants....

obey: The word obey means “do what somebody says to do” or “carry out someone’s orders.” For example:

Slaves, you should do what your masters tell you to do.

earthly masters: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as earthly masters is literally “masters according to the flesh.” These are in contrast to the master in heaven (6:9). In Greek, the word for “master” and “Lord” is the same word. Paul told slaves to obey their “masters in the flesh” so they would not mistakenly think he meant “obey the Lord” here. See flesh, Meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

masters: The “master” was the person who had bought and who owned the slave.

Here are some other ways to translate the word masters:

owners

bosses

6:5b

with respect and fear and sincerity of heart,

- Respect^(plur) them and obey/honour them with all of your heart,
- Take care to genuinely respect and honour them. Do not just pretend.

with respect and fear: The words respect and fear are a doublet. Both words mean respect/honor. (Here fear does not mean “to be afraid of.”) You can translate this:

respect them and honor/obey them

really respect them

Perhaps your language has an idiom that describes the attitude a slave should have, for example:

always bow your head to them

sincerity of heart: The phrase sincerity of heart means “honestly,” “with no hidden motives” or “with one heart.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

with a good heart

Or if it is clearer, you can translate it in a negative way. For example:

do not obey them with half a heart

do not just pretend to respect them

be as loyal to them (CEV)

6:5c

just as you would obey Christ.

- as though you were serving Christ. (GNT)
- Obey them like you^(plur) obey Christ.

just as you would obey Christ: This is a comparison. Paul is comparing their service of their masters to their obedience to Christ. He is saying that slaves should obey their masters in the same way that they would obey Christ.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Be as sincere as you are when you obey Christ.
(GW)

be as loyal to them as you are to Christ (CEV)

Ephesians 6:6

Section 6:5–9: Paul gave advice to slaves and their masters

The third relationship that Paul talked about is that of slaves and masters. The slave must remember that when he serves his master, he is serving Christ, and he will receive his reward from Christ. The master must remember that the slave's master in heaven is his own master too.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advice to slaves and masters (GW)

Slaves/Servants should obey their masters

6:6a

And do this not only to please them while they are watching,

- Obey them not only when they are watching you^(plur) so that they will praise you,
- You^(plur) should obey your masters not only when they are watching you or just to gain their approval.

And do this not only to please them: Here are some other ways to translate the phrase to please them:

to please your masters

to gain the approval of your masters

so that your owners will praise you

while they are watching: The clause while they are watching means “when your master is watching you.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Try to please them all the time (NLT)

Don't obey them only while you're being watched
(GW)

Do what your masters say even when they are not around.

6:6b

but as servants of Christ,

- but obey them like slaves of Christ,
- Instead be/act like slaves/servants of Christ

but as servants of Christ: This is a comparison. Paul is comparing slaves of men to slaves of Christ. The point of comparison between a slave of another person and a slave of Christ is that both should obey their masters. So the meaning is: “Obey your earthly masters as servants of Christ obey their heavenly master.”

Here is one way to translate this phrase:

But obey like slaves who belong to Christ... (GW)

6:6c

doing the will of God from your heart.

- doing^(plur) what God wants you to do with all your heart.
- who do what God wants them to do with enthusiasm.

doing the will of God: Another way to say doing the will of God is “doing what God wants.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

following the will of God

do God's wishes (Yakan Back Translation)

do what God says to do

from your heart: The phrase from your heart means “wholeheartedly” or “with enthusiasm.” An English idiom is:

with all your heart (GNT)

If there is an idiom in your language with this meaning you can use it.

It has a similar meaning as the phrase “sincerity of heart,” found in 6:5b.

your: Depending on how you translate this verse, you may have to use different pronouns. For example:

They do what God wants them to do with all their heart.

See the second meaning line in the Display for another example.

Ephesians 6:7

Section 6:5–9: Paul gave advice to slaves and their masters

The third relationship that Paul talked about is that of slaves and masters. The slave must remember that when he serves his master, he is serving Christ, and he will receive his reward from Christ. The master must remember that the slave’s master in heaven is his own master too.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul’s advice to slaves and masters (GW)

Slaves/Servants should obey their masters

6:7a

Serve with good will,

- Do^(plur) your work eagerly,
- Be happy when you^(plur) do your work as a slave/servant.

Serve with good will: The Greek word that the BSB translates as with good will means “enthusiastically” or “cheerfully.” Here, it means slaves should do their work willingly and happily, not just because they have to do it.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

- As an adverb. For example:

Work happily

Work willingly

- As a verb. For example:

Be-happy doing your work

- As an idiom: If your language has an idiom that means to do something with a cheerful willing attitude, you can use that. For example:

Let your heart dance while you do your work

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Work with enthusiasm (NLT)

Do your work as slaves cheerfully (GNT)

Serve eagerly (GW)

6:7b

as to the Lord and not to men,

- as if you were doing it for the Lord and not only for people.
- Do your work for the Lord, not for human beings.

as to the Lord and not to men: The Greek clause that the BSB literally translates as as to the Lord and not to men means that a Christian slave serves the Lord, even when he is doing daily work for his master.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

Consider that you are doing your work for the Lord, not just for people

When you do your work, think this: you are working for the Lord, you are not just working for your master

the Lord: Here Lord refers to Christ (6:5c, 6:6b).

Ephesians 6:8

Section 6:5–9: Paul gave advice to slaves and their masters

The third relationship that Paul talked about is that of slaves and masters. The slave must remember that when he serves his master, he is serving Christ, and he

will receive his reward from Christ. The master must remember that the slave's master in heaven is his own master too.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advice to slaves and masters (GW)

Slaves/Servants should obey their masters

6:8a

because you know that the Lord will reward each one

- Know that the Lord will reward each person
- You can be sure that the Lord will reward you

because you know that the Lord will reward each one: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because you know is literally "knowing." Some English translations translate this "remember" (GNT, NLT, NCV). But it does not mean that Paul's readers had forgotten. Paul was telling them to "keep this in mind, always remember and think about this."

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Be aware of the fact that the Lord will reward each one

You can be sure that the Lord will reward each one

reward: The Greek word that the BSB translates as reward means "cause to experience in return," "cause to experience in proportion to an action," or "be repaid for an action." So in this verse the Lord is giving back a good reward.

Here is another way to translate this word:

the Lord will give good back in return

6:8b

for whatever good he does, whether he is slave or free.

- for the good work that he does, whether he is a slave or he is a free person.
- if you do good deeds, whether you are a slave or not a slave.

for whatever good he does: The phrase whatever good refers to good works or good things or good actions/behaviors he does.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

good work (GNT)

good things (CEV)

good behavior

whether he is slave or free: The words slave and free are opposites. Paul means here that it doesn't matter if a person is a slave or if a person is not a slave (free). Make sure your terms for slave and free have these opposite meanings.

Other languages may not have a precise word for the opposite of slave. If this is the case in your language, you can translate the phrase whether he is slave or free like this:

whether he is a slave or not a slave

Whether he has an owner/master or not

Ephesians 6:9

Section 6:5–9: Paul gave advice to slaves and their masters

The third relationship that Paul talked about is that of slaves and masters. The slave must remember that when he serves his master, he is serving Christ, and he will receive his reward from Christ. The master must remember that the slave's master in heaven is his own master too.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Paul's advice to slaves and masters (GW)

Slaves/Servants should obey their masters

6:9a

And masters, do the same for your slaves.

- Masters, do the same to your slaves.
- And in the same way, you who are masters/bosses, be good to your slaves.
- You owners should treat your slaves in the same way as I have told them to treat you.

And masters: In this verse Paul addressed a new group of people. In some languages, the word for masters may be:

owners

bosses

overseers

do the same for your slaves: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as do the same for your slaves is literally “do the same to them” (as in the RSV). Paul is giving a general principle here. He is saying that masters should treat their slaves with the same kindness and consideration as their slaves are to treat them. For example:

And you slave masters must treat your slaves right, just as I have told them to treat you. (NLT98)

Here is another possible way to translate this:

treat them well also

This does not mean, of course, that masters must obey their slaves in the same way that Paul told slaves to obey their masters in 6:5.

6:9b

Give up your use of threats,

- Do not threaten to punish them,
- Do not say, “I will beat you if you do not do your work.”

Give up your use of threats: The clause Give up your use of threats means “do not say that you will hurt or punish them.” Paul is giving a specific example of how masters should not treat their slaves. An example of threatening is to say in an angry voice: “Get up! Do your work now or I will beat you!” Most languages have a word or phrase for this kind of talk.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

stop using threats (GNT)

Do not say to them, “I will beat you if you do not obey me!”

6:9c

because you know that He who is both their Master and yours is in heaven,

- because you know that they have the same master in heaven as you do,

- Remember that you and they have the same master who is in heaven,

because you know: The clause because you know is exactly the same as “because you know” in 6:8a. Consider if it would be appropriate to translate it in the same way here.

He who is both their Master and yours is in heaven:

This refers to the Lord Jesus. In Greek the word for master is kurios, the same word that is translated “Lord.” If your language has different words for “master” and “Lord”, you may want to translate something like this:

You should always remember that you who are masters and those who are your slaves all have the same big master in heaven; that is, the Lord.

6:9d

and there is no favoritism with Him.

- and he treats everyone alike.
- and he does not treat some people differently from the way he treats other people.

there is no favoritism with Him: The word favoritism means “treat one person better than another.” Paul is saying that the Lord treats slaves and masters in the same way.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Translate this meaning using a negative. For example:

He does not distinguish between people

He does not treat people differently

- Use positive terms. For example:

He treats all people in the same way

he treats everyone alike (NCV)

he judges everyone by one standard (similar to GNT)

- Use an idiom. For example:

God does not look at people’s faces

God is not soft on some people and hard on other people

Choose the translation that is most vivid and accurate in your language.

Ephesians 6:10

Section 6:10–20: Paul told believers how to fight against Satan

In this section, Paul compared the Christian to a soldier fighting in a war. The Christian's enemies are not human, but supernatural. Christians are fighting against the devil and all the powers of evil, and they must use all the weapons that God gives them. Paul described six pieces of equipment that the Roman soldier of that time used (see the picture below), and he compared each one to something spiritual that will help Christians to overcome Satan. Then Paul also reminded Christians to pray at all times. He told them to pray for their fellow believers and to pray for him so that he would be able to proclaim the gospel without fear.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Wear the full armour of God (NCV)

Put on all the armour that God supplies (GW)

Christians should prepare and fight against evil spiritual forces

6:10

Finally, be strong in the Lord and in His mighty power.

- ¶ My last word to you^(plur) is this: Make yourselves strong in the Lord. Get your strength from his great power.
- ¶ In conclusion, I say this to you: get/become spiritually strong from the mighty power of the Lord Jesus.

Finally: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Finally indicates that here Paul began to speak about a different topic. Paul also started to conclude his letter, but he still had some things to say. You should use a word or phrase that indicates that Paul changed topics and started to end his letter.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

A final word (NLT)

In conclusion

My finishing words to you are these:

be strong in the Lord: This is a command, and you should translate it in the form of a command. This refers to spiritual strength, not physical strength. For example:

Get strength from the Lord

Make yourself strong by means of your connection with the Lord

Lord: Here the word Lord refers to Christ.

in His mighty power: We are to get our strength from the Lord.

Here is another way to translate these words:

Let him make you strong with his mighty power

Ephesians 6:11

Section 6:10–20: Paul told believers how to fight against Satan

In this section, Paul compared the Christian to a soldier fighting in a war. The Christian's enemies are not human, but supernatural. Christians are fighting against the devil and all the powers of evil, and they must use all the weapons that God gives them. Paul described six pieces of equipment that the Roman soldier of that time used (see the picture below), and he compared each one to something spiritual that will help Christians to overcome Satan. Then Paul also reminded Christians to pray at all times. He told them to pray for their fellow believers and to pray for him so that he would be able to proclaim the gospel without fear.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Wear the full armour of God (NCV)

Put on all the armour that God supplies (GW)

Christians should prepare and fight against evil spiritual forces

6:11a

Put on the full armor of God,

- Put on all the war clothes which God gives you,
- Just as a soldier puts on all his fighting equipment, so you should use all the things that God has given you,

Put on the full armor of God: This is another command. The word armor is the general term for the protective clothing and equipment a soldier wears and the weapons he carries. In some languages, this may be called:

war stuff

fighting tools

soldier's clothes and weapons

The pieces of armor that Paul mentions in 6:14–17 include the belt, breastplate, shoes and helmet that a soldier puts on, and the shield and the sword that he holds in his hands. So another way to translate this is:

take hold of the things that God has given you to fight the devil

full: The word full here means “complete.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

whole (RSV)

all (GNT)

armor of God: Paul calls this the armor of God, because God is the one who provides the armor.

armor of God is a metaphor. A soldier gets all his special clothing and weapons ready so he can fight. His armor protects him. In the same way we must use all the things that God has given us to protect us, so we can fight against the devil.

6:11b

so that you can make your stand against the devil's schemes.

- so that you^(plur) will be able to resist/refuse the devil's tricks.
- so that when Satan tries to deceive/trick you, you can oppose/resist him.

so that you can make your stand: To make your stand means “to oppose,” “to successfully resist,” or “to fight back and not give in.” When a soldier is fighting

well he does not go backwards or retreat. He stands where he is or moves forward.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

so that you will be able to stand firm (NLT)

so that you will be able to stand up (GNT)

against the devil's schemes: The devil's schemes refers to the devil's/Satan's tricks or tactics. Here Paul talked about the things Satan does to try to make us sin, to make us stop trusting in Jesus and to make us stop serving Jesus. He used the same word in 4:14d (“scheming”).

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

the devil's strategies (GW)

the Devil's evil tricks (GNT)

the devil: The devil is the ruler of all evil spirits. The name of the devil is Satan.

Here are some other ways to translate the devil:

chief of demons

ruler of the evil spirits

Satan

See devil in the Glossary for more information.

General Comment on 6:11b

Some languages might need to translate 6:11b as an “if-then” clause. For example

If you do, then Satan might do his trickery but you will remain standing, you won't fall down.

Ephesians 6:12

Section 6:10–20: Paul told believers how to fight against Satan

In this section, Paul compared the Christian to a soldier fighting in a war. The Christian's enemies are not human, but supernatural. Christians are fighting against the devil and all the powers of evil, and they must use all the weapons that God gives them. Paul described six pieces of equipment that the Roman soldier of that time used (see the picture below), and

he compared each one to something spiritual that will help Christians to overcome Satan. Then Paul also reminded Christians to pray at all times. He told them to pray for their fellow believers and to pray for him so that he would be able to proclaim the gospel without fear.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Wear the full armour of God (NCV)

Put on all the armour that God supplies (GW)

Christians should prepare and fight against evil spiritual forces

6:12a

For our struggle is not against flesh and blood,

- For our fight is not against people on earth,
- For we are not at war against human beings like ourselves,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* here introduces the basis or reason for the previous statement. What Paul said in 6:12 was the basis for what he told the Ephesians in 6:11, “take your stand against the devil’s schemes.” Not all English versions translate this conjunction. Translate *For* in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this in English:

Because

The reason I say this is that

our struggle is not against flesh and blood: In this context, struggle refers to a fight or conflict. Paul was saying that we do fight, but that we are not fighting against other people.

You may want to change the noun struggle into a verb. For example:

we are not fighting against human beings (GNT)

But make sure that your translation is clear: Paul was not saying “we are not fighting...” He said that we do fight, but we don’t fight against ordinary people. For example:

For it is like we are in a battle. But it is not people we are fighting. No, we are fighting...

flesh and blood: The phrase flesh and blood is a figure of speech that refers to human beings or people. See flesh, Meaning 4, in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

people on earth (NCV)

human beings (GNT)

Here is another way to translate all of 6:12a:

The fight we are in, is not a fight with people of the earth, no it’s with...

6:12b–c

against the rulers...the authorities...the powers...the spiritual forces: This list of four terms refers to all ranks of evil spirits that are ruling our world. The list does not refer to earthly rulers. This list is very similar to the list in 1:21a. See how you translated them there.

Also see the notes below for more information on these four terms and for translation advice at the end of this note.

6:12b

but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the powers of this world’s darkness,

- but instead we are fighting against evil spirits and their chiefs who rule this world of darkness/evil,
- but we are at war against the warchiefs of darkness that have power on the earth.

against: Paul repeated the word against four times in this sentence: “against the rulers, against the authorities, against the powers...against the spiritual forces....” This repetition is emphatic. Look for ways to communicate this emphasis in your language. Perhaps you will want to repeat the verb “fight,” for example:

We are fighting the invisible ones who have authority and power. We are fighting the chiefs of darkness that rule in this world. We are fighting all kinds of evil spirits that control the sky.

Or you could repeat the first clause:

We are fighting against the rulers, authorities, powers of this dark world, and the spiritual forces

of evil in the heavens. It is against all these that we are fighting.

rulers...authorities: The first two words Paul used, rulers and authorities, are the same words he used in 1:21a and 3:10b. The words rulers and authorities in this verse refer to all types of evil spirit beings.

powers of this world's darkness: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates of this world's darkness is literally "of this darkness."

There is an interpretation issue here.

1. Most versions translate this phrase so that "dark/darkness" refers to the world. For example:

against mighty powers in this dark world (NLT)

(BSB, NLT, NIV, RSV, NET, GW, NCV, NJB)

1. Another interpretation is the darkness refers to "this age." For example:

this dark age (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow (1) as it is supported by a majority of translations.

The word darkness is a metaphor for evil here, as in 5:8–11. This phrase means "the world-chiefs or powerful spiritual beings who rule this dark (evil) world." See world, Meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

mighty powers in this dark world (NLT)

the powers who govern this world of darkness (GW)

6:12c

and against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly realms.

- and we are fighting against evil powers who live above the earth.
- We oppose all kinds of powerful demons and evil-ones that live in the air/sky.

spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly realms: The phrase spiritual forces of evil is another way of saying evil spirits or demons. These evil spirits are in the heavenly realms.

Here are some other ways to translate spiritual forces of evil:

spiritual powers of evil (NCV)

evil spirits (NLT)

in the heavenly realms: The phrase the heavenly realms refer to the area above the earth where the spirits were thought to live. This does not refer to heaven where God is. The term in the heavenly realms also occurs in 3:10b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

above the earth from the very headquarters of evil (JBP)

In the spiritual world (CEV)

General Comment on 6:12a–c

It is not necessary to find an equivalent term in your language for each of these four terms listed above. It is possible to translate these four terms by one, two or three terms. For example:

Because our enemy is not human but the leader of demons and all his servants and they are all bad/evil; their place is there in the sky. They have supernatural power and some of them have authority and they rule over all people in darkness here in this world.

For we are not fighting against people, but we are fighting against evil supernatural powers that dwell above the earth. These spiritual forces rule over people during these dark days in which we live.

Ephesians 6:13

Section 6:10–20: Paul told believers how to fight against Satan

In this section, Paul compared the Christian to a soldier fighting in a war. The Christian's enemies are not human, but supernatural. Christians are fighting against the devil and all the powers of evil, and they must use all the weapons that God gives them. Paul described six pieces of equipment that the Roman soldier of that time used (see the picture below), and he compared each one to something spiritual that will help Christians to overcome Satan. Then Paul also

reminded Christians to pray at all times. He told them to pray for their fellow believers and to pray for him so that he would be able to proclaim the gospel without fear.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Wear the full armour of God (NCV)

Put on all the armour that God supplies (GW)

Christians should prepare and fight against evil spiritual forces

6:13a

Therefore take up the full armor of God,

- For this reason, put on all the fighting equipment which God gives you^(plur),
- So that is why you should use all the things God has given you, just like a soldier who puts on all his fighting equipment,

Therefore: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Therefore connects 6:12 as a reason for 6:13. We are fighting against spiritual forces (6:12). So, as a result, you should put on the armor of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

For this reason (GW)

That is why (NCV)

take up the full armor of God: Paul repeated here almost the same words he used in 6:11. In 6:11 in the Greek text, Paul used a verb that means, “put on.” Here, he used a different verb that means, “pick up” or “take.” But these verbs mean almost the same thing, and you can translate it here using the same verb that you used in 6:11.

6:13b

so that when the day of evil comes, you will be able to stand your ground,

- so that when evil comes, you^(plur) will be able to resist it.
- in order that when the devil and his evil spirits attack you, you will be able to resist/oppose them.

so that when the day of evil comes: The phrase day of evil is a figure of speech. It refers to a time when suffering, trouble and bad things happen. This is any time that the Christian has to fight against evil. It is

not the final battle between God and the forces of evil. It does not refer to a literal, single day.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

these evil days (GW)

in the time of evil (NLT)

you will be able to stand your ground: The phrase you will be able here does not suggest potential or the possibility of doubt.

stand your ground: The phrase stand your ground is a figure of speech. The verb stand is the same verb as in 6:11b. It means “to oppose,” “to resist,” or “to fight back and not give in.”

Here are some other ways to translate stand your ground:

standing firm (NLT, CEV)

stand strong (NCV)

6:13c

and having done everything, to stand.

- When you^(plur) have done everything, you^(plur) will stand firmly.
- After you have done everything to prepare yourselves for the battle, you will not retreat.

and having done everything: There is an interpretation issue here. There are at least two ways to understand the Greek verb that the BSB translates as having done. It can mean:

1. after accomplishing or doing everything to prepare for battle and resist an attack. For example:

and after you have done everything (NIV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NET, REB, NASB, KJV, NJB)

1. after overcoming, that is, after fighting the whole battle. For example:

And when you have finished the whole fight (NCV) (GNT, NCV, NLT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the normal meaning of the verb and has good commentary support.

everything: Many English versions do not specify what is included in the word everything. Commentators differ as to the exact details of what everything includes. It probably includes all the things a soldier must do before a battle to prepare himself. Perhaps it also includes the things he would do during the battle. If possible, your translation should not be too specific. If you need to make it specific, you can say:

After you have done everything to prepare for battle

to stand: As in 6:11b and 6:13b, to stand means “to oppose,” “to resist,” or “to fight back and not give in.” This phrase is a restatement of the overall goal of putting on the full armor of God. After having done everything necessary to prepare for the battles, at the end of the battles he will be left still standing victorious.

General Comment on 6:13

Here is a way to translate 6:13 using an “if-then” clause:

Therefore, put on/wear all the fight clothes God gives us. If you do, then when the bad time comes, you will stand strong and when the fight is over, you will still be standing strong.

Ephesians 6:14

Section 6:10–20: Paul told believers how to fight against Satan

In this section, Paul compared the Christian to a soldier fighting in a war. The Christian’s enemies are not human, but supernatural. Christians are fighting against the devil and all the powers of evil, and they must use all the weapons that God gives them. Paul described six pieces of equipment that the Roman soldier of that time used (see the picture below), and he compared each one to something spiritual that will help Christians to overcome Satan. Then Paul also reminded Christians to pray at all times. He told them to pray for their fellow believers and to pray for him so that he would be able to proclaim the gospel without fear.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Wear the full armour of God (NCV)

Put on all the armour that God supplies (GW)

Christians should prepare and fight against evil spiritual forces

Paragraph 6:14–20

In this paragraph, Paul used six metaphors to describe the way a Christian should prepare himself to fight against Satan. Paul based these metaphors on the armor a Roman soldier wore. The specific pieces of armor are:

1. belt (6:14b)
2. breastplate (6:14c)
3. shoes (6:15)
4. shield (6:16b–c)
5. helmet (6:17a)
6. sword (6:17b)

In many places in the world, people do not know what breastplates, helmets, shields and other armor of the Roman soldiers looked like. So you may want to put a picture of a Roman soldier in your Bible translation at this place when it is printed.

6:14a

Stand firm then,

- ¶ So prepare yourselves to fight!
- ¶ So get/be ready for the battle.
- ¶ Here is how you^(plur) are to prepare yourselves to resist Satan.

Stand firm then: The clause Stand firm then introduces a list of instructions on how to stand firm. These are his concluding appeals on the basis of what he had said before. So you can translate it as:

So then, take your stand! (GW)

So stand ready (GNT)

Therefore prepare yourselves

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this command as a statement. For example:

Therefore, here is how you are to prepare yourselves to resist Satan.

6:14b

with the belt of truth buckled around your waist,

- Tie^(plur) the belt around your^(plur) waist. The belt is God’s truth.
- Tie^(plur) truth around your waist like a belt.

- God speaks what is true. Live^(plur) according to that. This will serve you^(plur) like a soldier's belt tied around your^(plur) waist.

with the belt of truth buckled around your waist:

A belt was made of pieces of leather. It was probably a wide belt, not just some thin strings of leather. See the belt of a soldier in the picture at Section 6:10–20.

In Paul's time, a soldier used a belt to tie his loose clothing round his waist. He did this so that he could move faster and more freely in battle. A belt also helped to protect the soldier's waist.

The phrase belt of truth is also a metaphor. Paul compared truth to a belt.

One way to fully explain this metaphor is like this: The truth that God gives you is like a Roman soldier's belt. The belt holds up his long clothes so that he is able to run and fight. God's truth supports you in your fight with Satan.

belt of truth buckled: The Greek text is literally "having tied your waist with truth." Notice that the word belt does not occur in Greek.

Some languages may be like Greek and have a verb like "tie" to indicate this action. Other languages will have to translate this as the BSB and supply the word belt. Another simple way to say this is:

the rope to tie your waist

truth: Paul did not specifically say what aspect of truth he was talking about. Scholars interpret this in two ways:

1. "God's truth" or "the truth about God"
2. "tell the truth" or "be truthful"

If you can translate without specifying the type of truth, it is better to do so. If you must make a choice, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

In some languages, the word "true" may be more natural than the word truth. If this is the case in your language, you could say something like:

do what you know to be true

Here are some ways to translate 6:14b:

- Keep the metaphor. Some ways to express the metaphor are:

Take truth and tie your waist with it.

Tie the belt round your waist. The belt is God's truth.

- Make the metaphor a simile. For example:

Fasten truth around your waist like a belt. (GW)

Live according to what is true. This will be like tying a soldier's belt round your waist.

- Give the full meaning of the metaphor. For example:

As a soldier ties a belt round his waist to prepare himself to fight, follow God's truth to prepare yourself to fight against the devil.

6:14c

with the breastplate of righteousness arrayed,

- Put^(plur) on the breastplate. The breastplate is righteousness.
- Believe that Christ made you righteous. This will be like a soldier putting on body armour over his chest to protect himself.

with the breastplate of righteousness arrayed: A breastplate was a piece of armor that a Roman soldier wore on his chest, and sometimes it also extended to cover his back. It protected him from the enemy's swords, arrows and spears. It was made of tough leather or metal. See the breastplate of a soldier in the picture at Section 6:10–20.

This is a metaphor. Paul compared righteousness to a breastplate. One way to fully explain this metaphor is like this: "Just as a breastplate protects a soldier in a battle, so your confidence in the truth of Christ making you righteous will protect you when Satan attacks you."

righteousness: Paul did not specifically say what aspect of righteousness he was talking about. Scholars interpret this in two ways:

1. God's righteousness or God considers a believer as righteous because of Christ. For example:

let God's justice protect you like armor (CEV, NLT, GW)

1. The believer does what is right or the believer has behavior that is righteous/upright. For example:

the protection of right living on your chest (NCV, REB)

If you can translate without specifying the type of righteousness, it is better to do so. Many English versions do this (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT and others). If you must make a choice, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). See righteous in the Glossary.

Here are some ways to translate 6:14c:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Put on Christ's right behavior as your breastplate.

Put on the breastplate. The breastplate is Christ's right behavior.

- Make the metaphor a simile. For example:

Christ behaved righteously for you. Realizing this will be like putting on a breastplate.

- Give the full meaning of the metaphor. For example:

As a soldier puts on a breastplate to protect himself in battle, depend on Christ's righteousness to protect you when the devil attacks.

Ephesians 6:15

Section 6:10–20: Paul told believers how to fight against Satan

In this section, Paul compared the Christian to a soldier fighting in a war. The Christian's enemies are not human, but supernatural. Christians are fighting against the devil and all the powers of evil, and they must use all the weapons that God gives them. Paul described six pieces of equipment that the Roman soldier of that time used (see the picture below), and he compared each one to something spiritual that will help Christians to overcome Satan. Then Paul also reminded Christians to pray at all times. He told them to pray for their fellow believers and to pray for him so that he would be able to proclaim the gospel without fear.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Wear the full armour of God (NCV)

Put on all the armour that God supplies (GW)

Christians should prepare and fight against evil spiritual forces

Paragraph 6:14–20

In this paragraph, Paul used six metaphors to describe the way a Christian should prepare himself to fight against Satan. Paul based these metaphors on the armor a Roman soldier wore. The specific pieces of armor are:

1. belt (6:14b)
2. breastplate (6:14c)
3. shoes (6:15)
4. shield (6:16b–c)
5. helmet (6:17a)
6. sword (6:17b)

In many places in the world, people do not know what breastplates, helmets, shields and other armor of the Roman soldiers looked like. So you may want to put a picture of a Roman soldier in your Bible translation at this place when it is printed.

6:15

and with your feet fitted with the readiness of the gospel of peace.

- Put on the shoes/boots. These shoes represent the peace that comes from the good news and makes you ready for battle.
- Rely on the good news that you have peace with God so that you are prepared to stand strong. This will be like a soldier who gets ready to fight by putting on his boots.

and with your feet fitted with the readiness of the gospel of peace:

This is a metaphor. There are two ways to understand this metaphor:

1. It can be explained like this: "Just like a soldier puts on his shoes/boots to get ready for battle, so you must rely on the good news about peace with God to get ready to fight the evil one." Here is another way to translate this:

For shoes, put on the peace that comes from the Good News so that you will be fully prepared. (NLT) (NIV, NLT, NCV, ESV, REB, NET)

1. It can be explained like this: "Just like a soldier puts on his shoes/boots to get ready for battle, so you must get ready to tell others the good news about peace with God." Here is another way to translate this:

As shoes for your feet put on whatever will make you ready to proclaim the gospel of peace. (NRSV) (NRSV, NJB, GNT, CEV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as it has more commentary support.

with your feet fitted: The phrase with your feet fitted means that “you have put on the shoes.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Put on your war shoes/sandals

having put on your shoes fit for war

with your shoes/sandals fitted appropriately for war

readiness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as readiness refers to being ready, prepared or equipped. Here are some ways to translate this:

equipped by the gospel of peace

made ready by the gospel of peace

made secure by the gospel of peace

gospel of peace: The gospel of peace is the good news that tells how a person can have peace with God. Here, peace probably means having a good relationship with God as in Romans 5:1. See gospel in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

For shoes, put on the peace that comes from the Good News so that you will be fully prepared. (NLT)

On your feet wear the Good News of peace to help you stand strong. (NCV)

let the shoes on your feet be the gospel of peace, to give you firm footing (REB)

Ephesians 6:16

Section 6:10–20: Paul told believers how to fight against Satan

In this section, Paul compared the Christian to a soldier fighting in a war. The Christian's enemies are not human, but supernatural. Christians are fighting against the devil and all the powers of evil, and they must use all the weapons that God gives them. Paul described six pieces of equipment that the Roman soldier of that time used (see the picture below), and he compared each one to something spiritual that will help Christians to overcome Satan. Then Paul also reminded Christians to pray at all times. He told them to pray for their fellow believers and to pray for him so that he would be able to proclaim the gospel without fear.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Wear the full armour of God (NCV)

Put on all the armour that God supplies (GW)

Christians should prepare and fight against evil spiritual forces

Paragraph 6:14–20

In this paragraph, Paul used six metaphors to describe the way a Christian should prepare himself to fight against Satan. Paul based these metaphors on the armor a Roman soldier wore. The specific pieces of armor are:

1. belt (6:14b)
2. breastplate (6:14c)
3. shoes (6:15)
4. shield (6:16b–c)
5. helmet (6:17a)
6. sword (6:17b)

In many places in the world, people do not know what breastplates, helmets, shields and other armor of the Roman soldiers looked like. So you may want to put a picture of a Roman soldier in your Bible translation at this place when it is printed.

6:16a

In addition to all this,

- Another thing is this:
- In addition to all these other things,
- Here is another thing:

In addition to all this: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as In addition to all this is literally “with all (these things).” There is an interpretation issue here. Scholars interpret this phrase in two ways:

1. It means As well as putting on the things I have already mentioned. Paul had already told the Ephesians to put on a belt, breastplate and shoes. Next he told them some other pieces of armor to take. For example:

In addition to all these (GW) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NASB, REB, GW, NLT)

1. It means At all times or always. For example:

At all times (GNT) (GNT, NJB, ESV, NLT96)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the greater number of versions. It also seems to fit the context better.

6:16b

take up the shield of faith,

- take hold of the shield. The shield is faith in God.
- Believe/Trust in God. This will be like holding a shield to protect yourselves.
- just as a soldier carries a shield to protect himself against the arrows the enemy shoots at him, believe firmly in Christ to protect yourselves from being harmed by Satan.

the shield of faith: A shield is a large piece of armor that protected the soldier’s whole body. A soldier held it in one hand out in front of himself to protect himself from his enemies’ weapons.

A shield was made of wooden boards fastened together, covered with cloth and then leather. Before a battle, a soldier would soak his shield in water so that it would not burn when enemies shot flaming arrows at him. See the shield of a soldier in the picture at Section 6:10–20.

This is also a metaphor. Paul compared faith to a shield.

One way to fully explain this metaphor is like this: “Just as a shield protects a soldier in a battle, so if you trust in God, he will protect you when Satan attacks you.”

faith: Here faith means to trust or believe in God. See how you translated faith in 1:15b and 3:12a. See faith, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some ways to translate 6:16b:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Take hold of the shield. The shield is faith in God.

- Make the metaphor a simile. For example:

Have faith in God. This will be like your shield.

Let your faith be like a shield (CEV)

- Give the full meaning of the metaphor. For example:

As a soldier takes hold of a shield to protect himself in battle, if you believe/trust in God it will protect you when Satan attacks.

6:16c

with which you can extinguish all the flaming arrows of the evil one.

- With this shield you^(plur) can put out the arrows of fire which the evil one shoots at you.
- This shield will stop all the burning arrows that Satan shoots at you.

with which you can extinguish all the flaming arrows: As was mentioned in 6:16b, before a battle, soldiers soaked their shields in water. When the enemy shot burning arrows at them, the wet shields put out the flames and the shields did not burn.

If people do not use bows and arrows in your part of the world, this figure of speech may be difficult to explain. If this is the case, you may want to translate this without the metaphor of arrows. One example is:

Your faith will be like a shield that protects you from all the dangerous weapons/things that the evil one throws at you.

all the flaming arrows: In Paul’s time, soldiers dipped the tips of arrows in something like tar. During a battle, they would set the arrows on fire before shooting them.

the evil one: The phrase the evil one refers to Satan, the devil, the ruler of demons. See note on 6:11b.

Here are some other ways to translate 6:16c:

to stop the fiery arrows of the devil (NLT)

for with it you will be able to put out all the burning arrows shot by the Evil One (GNT)

Ephesians 6:17

Section 6:10–20: Paul told believers how to fight against Satan

In this section, Paul compared the Christian to a soldier fighting in a war. The Christian's enemies are not human, but supernatural. Christians are fighting against the devil and all the powers of evil, and they must use all the weapons that God gives them. Paul described six pieces of equipment that the Roman soldier of that time used (see the picture below), and he compared each one to something spiritual that will help Christians to overcome Satan. Then Paul also reminded Christians to pray at all times. He told them to pray for their fellow believers and to pray for him so that he would be able to proclaim the gospel without fear.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Wear the full armour of God (NCV)

Put on all the armour that God supplies (GW)

Christians should prepare and fight against evil spiritual forces

Paragraph 6:14–20

In this paragraph, Paul used six metaphors to describe the way a Christian should prepare himself to fight against Satan. Paul based these metaphors on the armor a Roman soldier wore. The specific pieces of armor are:

1. belt (6:14b)
2. breastplate (6:14c)
3. shoes (6:15)
4. shield (6:16b–c)
5. helmet (6:17a)
6. sword (6:17b)

In many places in the world, people do not know what breastplates, helmets, shields and other armor of the Roman soldiers looked like. So you may want to put a picture of a Roman soldier in your Bible translation at this place when it is printed.

6:17a

And take the helmet of salvation

- Put on the helmet. The helmet is salvation.

- let the fact that God saved you be like a helmet of protection from the devil.

And take: The verb take here implies the meaning “put on” or “wear.”

Some other ways to translate take are:

Put on (NLT)

Accept (GNT)

wear

the helmet of salvation: A helmet is the piece of armor that a soldier wore on his head to protect it. It was made of metal. See the helmet of a soldier in the picture at Section 6:10–20.

This is also a metaphor. Paul compared salvation to a helmet. One way to fully explain this metaphor is like this: “Just as a helmet protects and saves a soldier in a battle, so let the fact that God saved you be like a helmet of protection when Satan attacks you.”

salvation: The word salvation means that God has saved us and will save us from Satan's power. See 1 Thessalonians 5:8 where Paul says that “the hope of salvation” is our helmet. See save, Word 2 in the Glossary for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate 6:17a:

- Keep the metaphor. Some ways to express the metaphor are:

Put on God's salvation as your helmet.

Put on the helmet. The helmet is God's salvation.

- Make the metaphor a simile. For example:

Let God's saving power be like a helmet (CEV)

- Give the full meaning of the metaphor. For example:

As a soldier puts on a helmet to protect his head in battle, let the fact that God saved you be like a helmet of protection from the devil.

6:17b

and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God.

- Take the sword which the Holy Spirit gives. The sword is the word of God.
- Be ready to use God's Word. It is like a sword that the Holy Spirit gives you to oppose evil/Satan.

and the sword of the Spirit: The sword of the Spirit is part of the metaphor and refers to God's powerful word that the Holy Spirit enables you to use. It is like a sword that is used to attack the enemy. It is used as a metaphor and described below.

sword: A sword is a large, long knife which soldiers used in battle. A sword was sharpened on both edges. See the sword of a soldier in the picture at Section 6:10-20.

which is the word of God: Here the word of God refers to the written word of God. It is the Bible or scriptures.

The meaning of this metaphor can be fully described like this: "When Satan attacks you, you must use God's Word (by reading it, quoting it, speaking it). This is like a sword that you can use to fight against Satan."

Here are some ways to translate 6:17b:

- Keep the metaphor. Some ways to express the metaphor are:

Take the sword that the Spirit gives. The sword is the word of God.

- Make the metaphor a simile. For example:

Take the word of God that is like a sword that the Spirit gives.

- Give the full meaning of the metaphor. For example:

As a soldier grasps a sword to defend himself, use God's word to defend yourself. It is from the Holy Spirit.

Ephesians 6:18

Section 6:10-20: Paul told believers how to fight against Satan

In this section, Paul compared the Christian to a soldier fighting in a war. The Christian's enemies are not human, but supernatural. Christians are fighting against the devil and all the powers of evil, and they must use all the weapons that God gives them. Paul described six pieces of equipment that the Roman soldier of that time used (see the picture below), and he compared each one to something spiritual that will help Christians to overcome Satan. Then Paul also

reminded Christians to pray at all times. He told them to pray for their fellow believers and to pray for him so that he would be able to proclaim the gospel without fear.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Wear the full armour of God (NCV)

Put on all the armour that God supplies (GW)

Christians should prepare and fight against evil spiritual forces

Paragraph 6:14-20

In this paragraph, Paul used six metaphors to describe the way a Christian should prepare himself to fight against Satan. Paul based these metaphors on the armor a Roman soldier wore. The specific pieces of armor are:

1. belt (6:14b)
2. breastplate (6:14c)
3. shoes (6:15)
4. shield (6:16b-c)
5. helmet (6:17a)
6. sword (6:17b)

In many places in the world, people do not know what breastplates, helmets, shields and other armor of the Roman soldiers looked like. So you may want to put a picture of a Roman soldier in your Bible translation at this place when it is printed.

6:18-20

In 6:14-17, Paul used six metaphors (belt, breastplate, shoes, shield, helmet, sword) to teach the Ephesian Christians how they should fight against Satan and protect themselves from Satan. In 6:18-20 he added a seventh way to fight Satan: by praying. But he did not use a metaphor to teach about praying.

6:18a

Pray in the Spirit at all times, with every kind of prayer and petition.

- Pray at all times as the Holy Spirit leads you^(plur). When you^(plur) pray, use all kinds of prayers and requests.
- And as you do all these things, pray to God in every way and ask him to help you. Pray on all occasions, as the Holy Spirit leads you.

Pray in the Spirit: The phrase Pray in the Spirit means that we should pray as the Holy Spirit leads or shows

us. It does not mean that we should pray silently. Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

pray by the power of the Spirit (CEV)

Pray...as the Spirit leads (GNT)

at all times: The phrase at all times means “all the time” or “in every situation.” Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Never stop praying (CEV)

Pray...in every situation (GW)

Constantly ask God’s help in prayer (REB)

with every kind of prayer and petition: The phrase with every kind of means to use “all types of” prayers. For example:

Use every kind of prayer and request there is.
(GW)

prayer: The word prayer is a generic term for the many types of prayer that the New Testament mentions: giving thanks to God, asking him for forgiveness and asking him for things.

petition: A petition is a specific type of prayer—it is when a person asks God for something.

If your language would not use nouns for “prayer” and petition, you can say:

pray to God in every way and ask him to help you

asking for everything you need (NCV)

6:18b

To this end, stay alert

- In order to pray like this, be watchful/vigilant,
- For this purpose, do not be inattentive,

To this end, stay alert: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as To this end means “for this purpose.” It refers back to 6:18a about praying in many ways as the Holy Spirit leads. In order to pray as the Holy Spirit leads, a person must be alert.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

For this purpose, be alert

In order to pray like this, pay attention.

stay alert: to the Greek word that the BSB translates as stay alert means to “be watchful,” “pay attention,” or “look for opportunities” to pray. Here is another way to translate this:

always be ready (NCV)

In some languages it may be possible to state this negatively as:

do not be inattentive

do not sleep

6:18c

with all perseverance in your prayers for all the saints.

- and never give up praying for all of God’s people.
- but be persistent in your prayers for all of God’s people.

with all perseverance in your prayers: The Greek clause that the BSB literally translates as with all perseverance in your prayers means that we should be persistent when we pray. We should not give up. This does not mean that we should always pray and never do anything else.

for all the saints: As in 1:1c and 3:18a, the word saints means “people set apart for God.” It does not refer to a special group of “holy people.” All Christians are saints.

Here are some ways to translate the word saints:

God’s people

people belonging to God

See Holy, Meaning 1, special use in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 6:19

Section 6:10–20: Paul told believers how to fight against Satan

In this section, Paul compared the Christian to a soldier fighting in a war. The Christian’s enemies are not human, but supernatural. Christians are fighting

against the devil and all the powers of evil, and they must use all the weapons that God gives them. Paul described six pieces of equipment that the Roman soldier of that time used (see the picture below), and he compared each one to something spiritual that will help Christians to overcome Satan. Then Paul also reminded Christians to pray at all times. He told them to pray for their fellow believers and to pray for him so that he would be able to proclaim the gospel without fear.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Wear the full armour of God (NCV)

Put on all the armour that God supplies (GW)

Christians should prepare and fight against evil spiritual forces

Paragraph 6:14–20

In this paragraph, Paul used six metaphors to describe the way a Christian should prepare himself to fight against Satan. Paul based these metaphors on the armor a Roman soldier wore. The specific pieces of armor are:

1. belt (6:14b)
2. breastplate (6:14c)
3. shoes (6:15)
4. shield (6:16b–c)
5. helmet (6:17a)
6. sword (6:17b)

In many places in the world, people do not know what breastplates, helmets, shields and other armor of the Roman soldiers looked like. So you may want to put a picture of a Roman soldier in your Bible translation at this place when it is printed.

6:19a

Pray also for me, that whenever I open my mouth, words may be given me

- Pray also for me, that when I speak about Christ, I will be given the right words,
- And pray for me too, that God will give me the right words to say when I talk about Christ,

that whenever I open my mouth: The clause that whenever I open my mouth is a figure of speech that means “that each time I talk about Christ.”

words may be given me: This is a passive clause. If your language prefers an active clause you can translate like this:

God will give me the words to say

Here are some other ways to translate these clauses:

Ask God to give me the right words (NLT)

Pray that I will be given the message to speak (CEV)

6:19b

so that I will boldly make known the mystery of the gospel,

- so that without fear I may explain to people the truths which are in the good news.
- so that I may boldly tell people the wonderful truth that God has now revealed to us in the good news.

so that I will boldly make known: To boldly make known means to fully explain something without fear of what might happen afterwards.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will speak boldly (GW)

tell...without fear (NCV)

the mystery of the gospel: The word mystery refers to something hidden or secret which people cannot find out by themselves, but which God reveals to them. See how you translated mystery in 1:9a and 3:9a.

The mystery of the gospel means the “secret that is found in the gospel,” that is, the truth that God has made known to us in the good news. See gospel in the Glossary for more information.

Ephesians 6:20

Section 6:10–20: Paul told believers how to fight against Satan

In this section, Paul compared the Christian to a soldier fighting in a war. The Christian’s enemies are not human, but supernatural. Christians are fighting against the devil and all the powers of evil, and they must use all the weapons that God gives them. Paul described six pieces of equipment that the Roman soldier of that time used (see the picture below), and he compared each one to something spiritual that

will help Christians to overcome Satan. Then Paul also reminded Christians to pray at all times. He told them to pray for their fellow believers and to pray for him so that he would be able to proclaim the gospel without fear.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Wear the full armour of God (NCV)

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Paragraph 6:14–20

In this paragraph, Paul used six metaphors to describe the way a Christian should prepare himself to fight against Satan. Paul based these metaphors on the armor a Roman soldier wore. The specific pieces of armor are:

1. belt (6:14b)
2. breastplate (6:14c)
3. shoes (6:15)
4. shield (6:16b–c)
5. helmet (6:17a)
6. sword (6:17b)

In many places in the world, people do not know what breastplates, helmets, shields and other armor of the Roman soldiers looked like. So you may want to put a picture of a Roman soldier in your Bible translation at this place when it is printed.

6:20a

for which I am an ambassador in chains.

- I am a representative of Christ to explain/tell this good news, and that is the reason that people have put me in prison.
- It is for this gospel that I am Christ's representative even while I am in prison.

for which I am an ambassador: An ambassador is a representative, a spokesman, an important person sent to another country to represent his king or president. In your translation you should make it clear that it is Jesus Christ whom Paul represents. Paul is saying that he is an ambassador of the gospel of Jesus Christ.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

I am a spokesman/representative of Jesus Christ, whom he commissioned to proclaim the good news about him

in chains: The phrase in chains is a figure of speech. When Paul was in prison, his hands and feet were sometimes bound with chains. So in chains means “in prison.”

You can translate in chains as:

even though I am in prison

and that is why I am in prison

Here is the connection between Paul being Christ's ambassador and Paul's being in prison: Jesus chose Paul to be his ambassador to preach the gospel. But people who hated Jesus wanted to stop Paul from preaching the gospel, so they had Paul arrested. That is why Paul was in prison when he wrote this letter to the Ephesians.

Here are some other ways to translate 6:20a:

I was sent to do this work, and that's the reason I am in jail (CEV)

I am in chains now, still preaching this message as God's ambassador. (NLT)

6:20b

Pray that I may proclaim it fearlessly, as I should.

- So pray to God for me that he will give me courage to preach the good news as I should.
- So pray that I will continue to boldly preach God's message as I ought to do.

Pray that I may proclaim it fearlessly: This clause is a summary of Paul's appeal in 6:19. It is repeated to emphasize what he said in 6:19. Translate it in a way that keeps this emphasis.

it: The word it refers to “the mystery of the gospel” in 6:19b.

fearlessly: The word that the BSB translates as fearlessly is similar to the word that the BSB translated as “boldly” in 6:19b. See how you translated that word there.

as I should: In referring to himself as Christ's ambassador, Paul felt it was his duty to boldly represent Christ. That is, boldly tell others the “good news.”

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase as I should:

as I have to (GW)

as I ought to speak (RSV)

Ephesians 6:21

Section 6:21–24: Paul asked God to bless the believers

Before Paul ended his letter, he added some words about a man named Tychicus. Tychicus carried Paul's letter to Ephesus and gave the Ephesian Christians news about Paul. Finally, Paul closed his letter by asking God's blessing on them all. Ephesians 6:21–22 is almost identical to Colossians 4:7–8.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Final Greetings (GNT)

Final greetings from Paul

6:21a

Tychicus, the beloved brother and faithful servant in the Lord,

- ¶ Tychicus is our dear brother. He serves the Lord well/faithfully.
- ¶ Tychicus, our fellow-believer whom we love and who serves the Lord well,

Tychicus: Tychicus is the name of a man.

the beloved brother: The Greek word that the BSB translates as beloved means “one whom I love.”

brother: Since God is the Father of all Christians, all Christians are like brothers and sisters. Therefore, people in the NT frequently use the Greek word for brother when referring to a fellow Christian. You should translate this term literally in your translation if possible. However, in some languages the word brother can only refer to a blood relative. If this is true in your language, you could use a term meaning:

fellow Christian

brother in Christ

fellow believer

dear friend (CEV)

faithful servant in the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as faithful means “reliable, dependable, loyal.”

servant in the Lord: The phrase servant in the Lord means “he serves the Lord” or “person who does the Lord's work.”

Here are some other ways to translate “faithful servant in the Lord”:

he serves the Lord very well

he continues doing work for the Lord

6:21b

will tell you everything, so that you also may know about me and what I am doing.

- He will tell you^(plur) everything that is happening to me, so that you will know about my circumstances and what I am doing.
- will tell you all my news. In that way, you will know about my health and activities.

will tell you everything: The word everything here refers to Paul's living situation when he was writing the letter to the Ephesians. It probably included his living conditions and his personal health. Some other ways everything has been translated include:

all the news about me (GNT)

everything that is happening to me (NCV)

how I am and every work I am doing

Ephesians 6:22

Section 6:21–24: Paul asked God to bless the believers

Before Paul ended his letter, he added some words about a man named Tychicus. Tychicus carried Paul's letter to Ephesus and gave the Ephesian Christians news about Paul. Finally, Paul closed his letter by asking God's blessing on them all. Ephesians 6:21–22 is almost identical to Colossians 4:7–8.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Final Greetings (GNT)

Final greetings from Paul

6:22a

I have sent him to you for this very purpose, that you may know about us,

- That is why I am sending him to you^(plur): so that you may know how we^(excl) are,
- I send him to you with this letter so that he will tell you what is happening to me and my companions,

I have sent him to you: When Paul wrote this letter, Tychicus was with him. They were probably in Rome, and Paul sent him to Ephesus where the people who received this letter were.

sent him: Some languages have a different word for “send things” and “send a person.” If the verb “send” in your language has the idea of forcing someone to go against his will, then you could say:

I am asking him to go to you

I am asking him to go to visit you

for this very purpose: The phrase this very purpose is restated in the following clause, “that you may know how we are.” Paul is restating what he said in 6:21b, but making it more general by including the people who were with him when he wrote the letter.

that you may know about us: As stated above, this clause is similar in meaning to the clause in 6:21b, “that you also may know how about me and what I am doing.” Here, Paul is including those who were with him when he was writing this letter to the Ephesians.

about us: The pronoun us refers to Paul and his companions.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

to tell you how all of us are getting along (GNT)

to let you know how we are doing (NLT)

6:22b

and that he may encourage your hearts.

- and that he may reassure you^(plur).
- and that he may strengthen your hearts.

that he may encourage your hearts: The clause that he may encourage your hearts means that Paul wanted Tychicus to comfort the Ephesian Christians

and to cheer them up so they would not feel sad that Paul was in prison.

Your language may have an idiomatic expression that means encourage. For example:

strengthen your hearts

stand strong in the Lord

General Comment on 6:21–22

In some languages it may be clearer to take the main clause of 6:22a, “I am sending him to you,” and state it at the beginning of 6:21. For example:

^{22a} I have asked Tychicus to go to visit you, ^{21a}so he can tell you all the news, ^{21b}and so you will know how I am and what I am doing. ^{21a}Tychicus is our relative in the faith whom I love, and he faithfully serves the Lord. ^{22a}So, I am sending him so he can tell you what is happening to us here. ^{22b}And in that way he can encourage you.

Ephesians 6:23

Section 6:21–24: Paul asked God to bless the believers

Before Paul ended his letter, he added some words about a man named Tychicus. Tychicus carried Paul’s letter to Ephesus and gave the Ephesian Christians news about Paul. Finally, Paul closed his letter by asking God’s blessing on them all. Ephesians 6:21–22 is almost identical to Colossians 4:7–8.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Final Greetings (GNT)

Final greetings from Paul

6:23–24

Paul’s final words are a blessing or prayer or wish. Paul ended some of his letters with a short blessing, such as “Grace be with you all” (Titus 3:15, see also Colossians 4:18, 1 Thessalonians 5:28, 2 Thessalonians 3:18, 1 Timothy 6:21 and 2 Timothy 4:22). In other letters he has a longer blessing at the end (see Romans 16:25–27, 2 Corinthians 13:14).

6:23

Peace to the brothers and love with faith from God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

- May God our Father and our Lord Jesus Christ give peace to you, the believers. May they cause you to love each other and to continue to believe in Christ.
- I pray that my brothers will have peace, love and faith from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

Peace to the brothers: The word Peace refers to serenity and calm well-being. It can also refer to having a good relationship with God. See how you translated Peace in 1:2 and 6:15.

brothers: The word brothers should be translated so as to include the women believers too, but avoid a long construction. You could say:

all the believers

It is unusual that Paul uses the third person instead of the second person here. That is, he says “Peace to the brothers” instead of “Peace to you.” Some translators prefer to translate this as:

Peace be to you Christian brothers

You may use the second person if the third person is unnatural or would be misleading.

Here are some other ways to translate “Peace to the brothers”:

May God give peace to the brothers

I pray to God and ask him to give peace to the brothers

love with faith: In 1:15 Paul told the Ephesian Christians that he had heard about their “faith in the Lord Jesus” and their “love for all the saints.” Now here at the end of his letter, he prays that they will continue to have love and faith. It may be more natural for you to translate these nouns by verbs. For example:

love each other and continue believing in Christ

See love, meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

faith: Here, the word faith refers to the action of trusting and believing in Jesus Christ. See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

God the Father: See how you translated this phrase in 5:20a.

Lord Jesus Christ: See how you translated this phrase in 5:20b.

Ephesians 6:24

Section 6:21–24: Paul asked God to bless the believers

Before Paul ended his letter, he added some words about a man named Tychicus. Tychicus carried Paul’s letter to Ephesus and gave the Ephesian Christians news about Paul. Finally, Paul closed his letter by asking God’s blessing on them all. Ephesians 6:21–22 is almost identical to Colossians 4:7–8.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Final Greetings (GNT)

Final greetings from Paul

6:24a

Grace to all who love our Lord Jesus Christ

- May God show kindness to all who love our Lord Jesus Christ
- May God be kind to all of you who love our Lord Jesus Christ

Grace: Paul used the word Grace to wish for God’s blessing on people and to wish them well. Grace means that God favors people or that he is kind to people even though they are unable to repay him.

See how you translated Grace in 1:2. See grace, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

to all who love our Lord Jesus Christ: The phrase all who love refers to believers who are continue to love and remain faithful to Jesus Christ.

Lord Jesus Christ: See how you translated this phrase in 6:23.

6:24b

with an undying love.

- with love that does not end.
- with love that never stops.

undying love: The Greek word that the BSB translates as undying love is literally “incorruptible (love).” In this context it means “sincere love” or “love which does not end.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

love that never ends (NCV)

love that goes on forever

General Comment on 6:24a–b

In some languages, it is more natural to change the order of 6:24a–b. For example:

^(24b)you people who continue on loving our^(incl) Lord
Jesus Christ, ^(24a)I want that God would be good
to you